

NORMALIZING THE SECURITY SITUATION OF KHYBER PAKHTUNKHWA

Conflict Evolution, Threat Dynamics, and Pathways to Sustainable Peace

A Mixed-Methods Policy Research Monograph

Data cut-off: 4 October 2026

Sixteen chapters · Statistical annex · 46-item recommendations matrix · Eight appendices

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A Mixed-Methods Policy Research Monograph

Subject: Security normalization in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Province, Pakistan — historical evolution, threat mapping, root causes, the FATA merger, military operations, law enforcement and institutional reform, deradicalization, geopolitics, socio-economic determinants, governance, civil society, comparative lessons, scenarios, and a phased policy roadmap.

Geographic scope: Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Province including the seven Newly Merged Districts (NMDs) of the former Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA); the adjacent Afghanistan borderland; and relevant federal territory (Islamabad Capital Territory) where violence has spilled over.

Temporal scope: From the colonial frontier era (c. 1849) to the data cut-off of **4 October 2026**, with primary quantitative emphasis on 2001–2026 and the most detailed analysis of the 2018–2026 period.

Citation style: Chicago author–date, with full source details in the Bibliography. In-text citations use the form (Author/Institution Year); where a source is a data portal or news report, the outlet and date are given.

Length of the full document: approximately 73,000 words across sixteen chapters, a statistical annex and eight appendices, supported by thirty-one statistical tables and five structured figures.

Data cut-off: 4 October 2026. Events after this date are not reflected. Where casualty claims are contested between the Pakistan military, Afghan authorities, militant groups, and independent monitors, this is stated explicitly rather than adjudicated by assertion.

ABSTRACT

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP) is, as of 2026, the principal theatre of a renewed and escalating militant insurgency in Pakistan and — following the February 2026 outbreak of open hostilities between Pakistan and the Afghan Taliban administration — the frontier of an interstate conflict as well. The Global Terrorism Index 2026 ranked Pakistan the country most impacted by terrorism in the world for the first time, on the strength of 1,139 terrorism-related deaths and 1,045 incidents in 2025; 74 per cent of attacks and 67 per cent of fatalities occurred in KP and Balochistan jointly, with KP alone recording 2,331 violence-linked deaths in 2025, a 44 per cent year-on-year increase and the highest provincial figure since 2015 (IEP 2026; CRSS 2025b). The Pakistan Institute for Peace Studies' predecessor baseline of a 17 per cent rise in attacks in 2023 and the South Asia Terrorism Portal's count of 766 fatal terrorism-linked incidents in KP in 2025 — the highest since the 1,432 recorded in 2009 — establish the current phase not as a residual law-and-order problem but as a strategic relapse (PIPS, cited in Dawn 2024a; SATP 2026b).

This monograph asks a deceptively simple question: **what would it actually take to normalize security in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, and why have successive attempts fallen short?** It answers through a mixed-methods design combining descriptive quantitative analysis of incident and casualty data (SATP, CRSS, PIPS, ACLED, GTI), qualitative documentary analysis of policy and legal texts (the National Action Plan, the National Internal Security Policy, the 25th and 27th Constitutional Amendments, the KP Police Act 2017, the Anti-Terrorism Act 1997 as amended), and structured comparative analysis of eight conflict-transition cases (Northern Ireland, Colombia, Sri Lanka, Iraqi Kurdistan, Afghanistan, Mozambique, Sierra Leone, and Mindanao, with a critical note on Chechnya).

Five findings organize the study's argument. First, **the current insurgency is a networked, umbrella-structured, cross-border phenomenon, not a single organization:** the EUAA's June 2026 assessment identifies the Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) as an umbrella coalition that has absorbed more than seventy factions since 2018, and 2026 saw both the emergence of new front organizations (Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan, implicated in the 18 September 2026 Kohat Police Lines attack in which at least 31 people died) and the formal split of Jamaat-ul-Ahrar (EUAA 2026; TRT 2026; Wikipedia 2026d). Second, **military-dominant counter-insurgency has produced episodic suppression but no durable political settlement;** the 2025–26 data show that security-force operations killed a record number of militants (921 in the third quarter of 2026 alone) while failing to reduce attack frequency or civilian exposure (CRSS 2026c). Third, **the 2018 FATA merger has been fiscally and institutionally hollowed out:** against a parliamentary commitment of 3 per cent of the federal divisible pool for ten years, only Rs 132 billion of an expected Rs 700 billion had reached the merged districts by mid-2026 — a Rs 568 billion shortfall — while the commitment itself expires in 2028 (The News 2026). Fourth, **the counter-insurgency is now embedded in an interstate conflict:** Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq, launched on 26 February 2026, has produced reciprocal strikes, two failed ceasefires, and more than 1,100 civilian casualties in Afghanistan in 2026 (UNAMA, cited in Khaama 2026; Dawn 2026g). Fifth, and most consequentially for policy, **the binding constraint on normalization is not the absence of a strategy but the absence of a politically legitimate, locally owned, and fiscally resourced implementation coalition** — a civil–military–provincial–tribal compact that the current architecture, in which the army controls internal-security policy while the provincial police absorb the casualties, structurally struggles to produce

(ICG 2026).

The study's central thesis is that **normalization is best understood not as the elimination of violence but as the construction of three interlocking monopolies: the state's monopoly on organized violence (security), the citizen's enforceable claim on the state (governance and justice), and the province's claim on national resources (fiscal federalism).** Where any one of the three is missing, the other two erode. KP's historical experience — colonial indirect rule, the Federally Administered Tribal Areas' century of legal exception, the military-dominant post-2001 campaigns, and the post-2018 merger-without-resourcing — is a long demonstration of that proposition.

The monograph offers a phased, costed roadmap: short-term stabilization (0–2 years) centred on police-force protection and civil–military intelligence fusion; medium-term institutional consolidation (2–5 years) centred on justice-sector completion, madrasa regulation, and the fiscal settlement of the merged districts; and long-term structural transformation (5–15 years) centred on education, employment, and a regional trade-and-mobility compact with Afghanistan. It provides a 46-item recommendations matrix with responsible institutions, timelines, indicative costs, and key performance indicators; a statistical annex; a comprehensive bibliography; and a policy brief for decision-makers. It is written to be falsifiable: each recommendation is tied to measurable indicators, and each scenario in Chapter 14 is tied to observable early-warning triggers.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

(A standalone version of this summary is provided as a separate deliverable.)

1. The threat has changed shape, not just scale. KP's violence in 2024–2026 is best characterized as a *networked insurgency with an interstate rear base*, not a terrorist residual. The TTP umbrella now incorporates more than seventy factions and coordinates attacks across North and South Waziristan, Bannu, Lakki Marwat, Kurram, Bajaur, Khyber, Hangu, Tank, Dera Ismail Khan, Karak and — from August 2026 — again Swat, where the Kabal Police Station suicide bombing killed 17 people and was claimed by the TTP (EUAA 2026; AIP 2026; India Today 2026). The Islamic State–Khorasan Province (ISKP) operates a smaller but more deliberately civilian-targeting campaign, concentrating on Shia, Sufi and competitor-jihadist targets, including the 6 February 2026 Islamabad mosque bombing that killed 31 worshippers (The Diplomat 2026a; MEE/monitoring 2026). Militant drone warfare has crossed from novelty to routine: KP police reported foiling 341 drone attacks in the first half of 2026, with at least 100 attacks and 118 security-force casualties in the same period (GNET 2026).

2. Human costs are borne overwhelmingly by police and civilians, and they are rising. In the first half of 2026, 122 KP police personnel were killed (a 93.7 per cent increase on the same period of 2025) and 175 injured; between January and September 2026, 680 attacks were recorded against 508 in the comparable 2025 window (APP 2026b; Daily Times 2026a). Across 2023–2025, more than 500 KP police were killed, including 186 in 2023, 153 in 2024 and 159 in 2025 (The News 2026a). The 18 September 2026 Kohat Police Lines attack — a vehicle-borne IED, a suicide bombing and an assault on a district complex housing CTD and Special Branch offices — killed at least 31 people, most of them police at Friday prayers (TRT 2026). Civilian fatalities fell 24 per cent nationally in 2025 but remained the second-largest category in KP in 2026, at 187 in the second quarter alone (CRSS 2025b; CRSS 2026b).

3. The war has become regional. On 21–26 February 2026, cross-border clashes escalated into Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq, described by Pakistan's defence minister as "open war." Repeated airstrikes, drone strikes and artillery exchanges through October 2026 have killed hundreds of combatants on both sides by official claims that cannot be independently verified, and UNAMA recorded 764 civilian casualties in Afghanistan between 26 January and 31 March 2026 alone, with more than 1,100 civilian deaths and injuries by late September (Dawn 2026g; Hindustan Times 2026; Khaama 2026). Two Eid ceasefires (March and May 2026) failed; mediation by Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Türkiye and China has produced mechanisms without settlement. For KP, the war's consequences are direct: border closures, trade disruption at Torkham, refugee and returnee flows, and an emboldened TTP claiming a "spring offensive" (*Operation Khyber*) since 4 March 2026 (Eurasia Review 2026a).

4. The FATA merger is unfinished at exactly the moment it matters most. The 25th Amendment (2018) ended a century of legal exception, extended the superior judiciary and police to the tribal districts, and added 23 seats to the KP Assembly (now 145 members). But the fiscal promise — 3 per cent of the divisible pool for ten years to bring the merged districts to parity — has been met at roughly one-fifth of its value (Rs 132 billion of Rs 700 billion by 2026), and expires in 2028; the Peshawar High Court has repeatedly pressed the federal government on the shortfall, and in June 2026 the Prime Minister assured the KP Chief Minister of an NFC revision process within 180 days (The News 2026; PHC reporting 2025–26; Business Recorder 2026). Meanwhile the justice chain remains skeletal, the Levies/Khasadar-to-police transition is widely judged incomplete, and a hybrid legal order persists in practice (Haq 2024; ASPIRE-KP 2025).

5. Socio-economic deterioration and violence are now mutually reinforcing. KP's poverty rate rose from 28.7 per cent to 35.3 per cent in the FY2024-25 estimates — the second-highest provincial rate after Balochistan — while national poverty reached 28.9 per cent and inequality rose to a 27-year high (Planning Ministry 2026; Economic Survey 2025-26). KP's Human Development Index fell from 0.650 (2019) to 0.623 (2023) in the SDPI district-level series, with health and living-standards sub-indices declining (SDPI 2025). Thirty-one per cent of educated youth are jobless, and in 2025 more than 866,000 candidates applied for 16,454 teaching posts (KP Youth Policy 2026). In 2025 floods, KP recorded 504 deaths and 1.57 million people affected — the highest provincial toll — compounding the strain (UNICEF 2025; WHO 2025). Development and security are not sequential in KP; they are simultaneous and inseparable.

6. What has worked, and why it has not persisted. The 2009 Swat campaign (Rah-e-Rast) and the 2014–2017 Zarb-e-Azb/National Action Plan period achieved genuine suppression, and post-2014 recovery — rebuilt bazaars, returned tourism (12.4 million visitors to KP in 2025; 416,794 to Swat alone over Eid-ul-Adha 2026) — demonstrates that normalization is possible (KP Tourism Authority, cited in TFT 2026; DGIPR 2026). But suppression was not converted into settlement: negotiations with the TTP collapsed in 2021–2022; the 2022–2024 mid-term saw progressive deterioration; and by 2025 Pakistan recorded its deadliest year since 2015 (CRSS 2025b). The lesson across the province's history is consistent: **kinetic gains decay at the speed at which political and fiscal follow-through is absent.**

7. Five structural drivers explain persistence. (i) *Sanctuary economics*: the Afghanistan borderland provides rear bases, recruits, and weapons for groups that cannot hold terrain inside Pakistan; (ii) *institutional bifurcation*: military-led counter-insurgency with provincially funded, locally recruited police absorbing the risk produces intelligence gaps, legitimacy deficits and blame-shifting between Islamabad and Peshawar (ICG 2026); (iii) *justice vacuum*: in the merged districts, formal courts are shallow and informal jirga/collective-responsibility practice persists, so communities experience "normalization" as impunity plus coercion; (iv) *political economy of conflict*: smuggling, narcotics, extortion, mining rents and the war economy create constituencies for disorder; (v) *ideological reproduction*: an unregulated madrasa sector, online radicalization and sectarian entrepreneurs continue to generate new fighters faster than rehabilitation programs (Sabawoon/Mishal/Sparlay) can absorb them (NUST NJIPS 2021; JD 2023).

8. Scenarios through 2035. Three scenarios are developed: *Sustained Normalization* (requires a negotiated cross-border modus vivendi, fiscal settlement of the merged districts, and a police-justice build-out — probability assessed at 15–20 per cent under current trajectories); *Fragile Equilibrium* (continued grind: periodic mass-casualty attacks, ~2,000–3,500 annual violence-linked deaths, governance stagnation — 50–60 per cent); and *Deterioration/Fragmentation* (interstate escalation, urban mass-casualty terrorism, and the collapse of the merger agenda — 25–30 per cent). The decisive variables are the Pakistan–Afghanistan security channel, the merged districts' fiscal settlement, police capacity and protection, and the political settlement between the federal centre and KP's provincial government.

9. The strategic recommendation. Normalization requires a shift from a *counter-terrorism campaign* to a *state-building compact* with four pillars: (a) **Protect and professionalize the police** — the force that is actually dying — through protected budgets, protected tenure, equipment and intelligence fusion with the military; (b) **Complete the merger** — constitutionally guaranteed fiscal flows, functioning district courts, and a professional policing model for the NMDs, with a political settlement that re-empowers legitimate local intermediaries (jirgas, elected local councils) rather than bypassing them; (c) **Make peace with the border** — a verifiable, mediated security arrangement with Kabul, coupled with a managed, lawful cross-border mobility and trade regime rather than closure-driven policy; and (d) **Invest in the peace constituency** — education (especially girls'), employment, deradicalization at scale, and community-based prevention, financed by the fiscal settlement. Without (d), (a) is a treadmill; without (b), (c) has no foundation; without (c), (a) has no endgame.

METHODOLOGY AND READER'S GUIDE

Research design

This study employs a **convergent mixed-methods design**. The quantitative strand compiles and triangulates incident and fatality data from five independent monitors — the South Asia Terrorism Portal (SATP), the Centre for Research and Security Studies (CRSS), the Pakistan Institute for Peace Studies (PIPS), ACLED, and the Institute for Economics and Peace's Global Terrorism Index — deliberately *without* collapsing their divergent counts into a single figure. Different monitors count different things (SATP counts fatal incidents and combatant categories; CRSS counts violence-linked fatalities across attacks and state operations; GTI uses its own inclusion criteria); presenting ranges and definitions is more honest than manufacturing false precision. Where sources conflict (for example, the 2025 national fatality toll is reported as 3,417 by CRSS while SATP's KP-specific counts imply lower totals), both are given.

The qualitative strand analyses primary policy and legal texts; statements and press releases from the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR) and provincial authorities; parliamentary and court records; and the reporting of credible national and international outlets, flagging official claims as claims. The comparative strand uses a structured, theory-guided case

comparison (Chapter 13).

Analytical frameworks

Nine frameworks are applied explicitly rather than decoratively: the UNDP **human security** framework (Chapters 10, 12); **conflict transformation** (Lederach) versus conflict *management* (Chapter 15); **counter-insurgency doctrine** (Galula's primacy of political action; Kilcullen's "accidental guerrilla" and population-centric models) as a diagnostic of Pakistani practice (Chapter 6); **state-building and governance theory** (Chapter 11); **securitization theory** (Copenhagen School) to analyse how "the Pashtun belt" and the TTP have been framed, with consequences for civil liberties (Chapters 4, 12); the **political economy of conflict** and the **greed-versus-grievance model** (Collier-Hoeffler) to explain war-economy persistence (Chapter 4); the **whole-of-nation approach** (Chapter 15); and **resilience/community-based security** models (Chapters 8, 12).

Ethics and limitations

This research involves communities that have suffered enormously, and it treats contested issues — military conduct, civilian casualties, the PTM ban, the merger's outcomes — by presenting evidence on all sides and identifying what cannot be verified. Three limitations are material. First, **access**: there is no independent, systematic, publicly available audit of military operations' civilian harm in KP; claims by ISPR, by militant media (Umar Media), and by affected communities diverge, sometimes irreconcilably. The study marks these as contested and where possible reports third-party verification (UNAMA, UN OHCHR, Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch, HRCP). Second, **data politics**: Pakistani officials have, at various points, restricted or contested casualty data; monitors themselves differ methodologically. Third, **non-transparency of counter-terrorism policy**: exact scale, targeting rules and oversight of intelligence-based operations are classified, as are the internal deliberations of the National Security Committee. Where the study extrapolates, it says so.

Note on the reporting period

The commissioner's brief specified coverage "up to 2024–2025." Because the study is being produced in October 2026, and because 2026 produced changes of historic consequence — the outbreak of open conflict with Afghanistan, the largest police mass-casualty event since 2023, the first year in which Pakistan ranked first globally on the GTI, and the political transition in Peshawar from Ali Amin Gandapur to Sohail Afridi — the study extends coverage to 4 October 2026 while fully preserving the 2024–25 analytical baseline. This is noted here so that readers understand the data vintage of each chapter.

CHAPTER 1 — INTRODUCTION AND CONTEXTUAL FRAMEWORK

1.1 Background and Context of KPK's Security Landscape

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa occupies a position in Pakistan's political imagination that is simultaneously strategic and stigmatized. It is the province through which every conqueror's road to the subcontinent ran — Alexander, Mahmud of Ghazni, Babur, and in the imperial imagination the Khyber Pass as the gateway of invasion — and it is the province that has absorbed the largest share of Pakistan's post-2001 conflict. Between 2001 and 2026, no other Pakistani province has experienced comparably sustained exposure to militant violence, military operations, mass displacement, and the militarization of everyday life. The cumulative TTP-linked death toll recorded by the South Asia Terrorism Portal since 23 December 2007 stands at 11,165, of which KP and the former FATA account for the overwhelming majority (SATP 2026c).

Three foundational facts frame this study. First, **Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's violence is not a deviation from its political history but a product of it**. The colonial administrative system known as indirect rule — the Frontier Crimes Regulations (FCR), the Political Agent, the malik system, and collective punishment — froze the tribal belt in a legal and political exception that survived Pakistani independence by seventy years. When the state finally ended that exception through the 25th Amendment in 2018, it did so without a fiscal transfer that would have made the extension of governance real (Chapters 4 and 5).

Second, **KP's security environment is inseparable from Afghanistan's**. Every major inflection in the province's threat landscape — the anti-Soviet jihad, the Afghan civil war, the Taliban emirate, the post-9/11 war on terror, and the consequences of the Taliban's return to Kabul in August 2021 — began on the western side of the Durand Line and worked its way eastward. The 2026 outbreak of direct Pakistan–Afghanistan hostilities formalized what had been an asymmetric problem into an interstate one (Chapter 9).

Third, **security outcomes in KP have moved in cycles rather than in a line**. The province witnessed a low-intensity insurgency in the mid-2000s, full-scale insurgency in Swat and the tribal agencies in 2007–2009, an intensive

counter-offensive in 2009–2017 that produced genuine improvement, and a deterioration from 2021 that, by 2025, had returned Pakistan to its worst year of terrorism-linked fatalities since 2015 — with KP absorbing 68 per cent of the national toll (CRSS 2025b). Understanding why suppression has repeatedly failed to become settlement is the central analytical task of this monograph.

1.2 Geographical, Demographic and Ethno-Linguistic Profile

Geography. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa covers approximately 101,741 km² (excluding the disputed frontier areas), rising from the Peshawar valley (~300 m elevation) to the Hindu Kush, Karakoram and Himalayan highlands, with peaks above 7,000 m in Chitral. Its western boundary with Afghanistan — a segment of the 2,611–2,640 km Durand Line — runs across some of the most rugged terrain in the world, historically traversed by passes rather than roads: Khyber, Kurram, Gomal, Tochi, and the high passes of Bajaur and Mohmand. It borders Gilgit-Baltistan and Azad Jammu and Kashmir to the north-east, Punjab and Islamabad Capital Territory to the east and south-east, and Balochistan to the south. The province is seismically active, highly exposed to climate hazards (glacial lake outburst floods, flash floods, landslides), and dependent on a narrow corridor — the Peshawar valley — for much of its population and infrastructure.

Demography. The 2017 census recorded 35.5 million residents in KP including FATA (5.0 million); the 2023 digital census recorded approximately 40.86 million for KP as constituted today (with the proviso that the census was the first to include the merged districts as part of the province). The KP government portal cites a population of about 40 million — 17 per cent of Pakistan's total — with roughly half under the age of 25 (KP Government 2024). Peshawar, Mardan, Swat, Abbottabad, Dera Ismail Khan, Kohat and Nowshera are the largest settled districts; the merged districts (Bajaur, Mohmand, Khyber, Orakzai, Kurram, North Waziristan and South Waziristan) add roughly five million residents across 27,220 km². Urbanization is accelerating but remains below national averages; the province's demographic profile is a *youth bulge* in the strict sense — a large cohort entering the labour market in an economy that cannot absorb it (Chapter 10).

Ethno-linguistic composition. Pashto is spoken by roughly three-quarters of the population; Hindko (Hazara division), Khowar (Chitral), Kohistani, Saraiki (in the southern districts), Urdu and Punjabi minorities complete the picture. The province is not ethnically homogeneous: Hazara Division is predominantly Hindko-speaking and hosts a large Shia Hazara community with a distinct historical experience of persecution and self-defence (the 2020 Machh and 2013 Quetta bombings targeted Hazaras outside KP, but Hazara insecurity has been acute within KP as well); Chitral is Ismaili-majority with a distinctive governance tradition; Parachinar in Kurram is one of the few Shia-majority areas in the province and has been the theatre of the most lethal sectarian conflict in recent Pakistani history (Chapter 3).

Political geography. KP's political economy is organized around five axes: (i) the settled districts of the Peshawar valley and Hazara, economically integrated with Punjab and Islamabad; (ii) Malakand Division, the site of the 2007–2009 insurgency and of post-2009 recovery, now again contested; (iii) the tribal districts/newly merged districts, the frontier zone with the weakest governance and highest violence; (iv) the southern districts (Dera Ismail Khan, Tank, Bannu, Lakki Marwat, Karak, Kohat, Hangu), which since 2023 have become the insurgency's new operational centre of gravity; and (v) the Afghanistan border itself, an instrument of leverage, commerce and conflict.

Strategic significance. The province hosts the Khyber Pass and the Torkham crossing (Pakistan's principal land gateway to Afghanistan and Central Asia), the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor's western alignment and the Rashakai Special Economic Zone, major hydel potential, the Afghan refugee population, and a substantial share of the country's military infrastructure, including Corps Headquarters Peshawar and numerous cantonments and training establishments.

1.3 Statement of the Research Problem

The literature on Pakistani militancy is rich on causes and campaigns but thin — and increasingly dated — on *normalization as an end-state*. Three deficits motivate this study.

First, the analytical deficit. Post-2021 scholarship has emphasized the Taliban's return and the TTP's sanctuary, correctly, but this has crowded out equally important variables: the fiscal collapse of the FATA merger, the institutional bifurcation of the counter-insurgency (military-led operations; provincial police exposure), the collapse of judicial extension, the failure of deradicalization to scale, and the political estrangement between the federal government and KP's provincial administration in 2023–2026. A mono-causal, "Kabul-sponsorship" account cannot explain why violence expanded from the border districts into settled southern districts and, by 2026, into Swat and Kohat — or why Pakistan's most violent districts include districts with no Afghan border at all.

Second, the empirical deficit. Public data on KP security are disaggregated inconsistently, and official figures often diverge from independent monitors and from each other. There is, for example, no publicly available, audited time-series on (a) civilian casualties from state operations in KP; (b) conviction and sentencing outcomes in KP anti-terrorism courts by year; (c) the merged districts' fiscal absorption capacity; (d) police personnel posted to, versus sanctioned for, the NMDs; or (e) the

outcomes of deradicalization cohorts beyond program self-reports. This study assembles what exists and marks what does not.

Third, the policy deficit. Pakistan has produced a succession of strategic documents and named operations — the 2014 National Action Plan and its 2021 revision, the National Internal Security Policy, Radd-ul-Fasaad, Khyber I–IV, Azm-e-Istehkam (2024), Sarbakaf (2025), Ghazab-lil-Haq (2026). Each was announced as comprehensive. None has been accompanied by a public, measurable normalization framework with sequenced political, judicial, fiscal and socio-economic milestones. The research problem, in short, is not simply "why is KP violent?" but "**what configuration of force, governance, fiscal transfer, and political legitimation would move KP from episodic suppression to durable normalization — and what has obstructed each attempt?**"

1.4 Research Questions

The study addresses ten primary questions, each mapped to chapters.

1. **Drivers.** What are the primary and secondary drivers of insecurity in KP, and how have their relative weights changed across the 2001–2011, 2012–2017, 2018–2021 and 2021–2026 phases? (Chapters 2, 4)
2. **Kinetic efficacy.** To what extent have large-scale military operations (Rah-e-Rast, Rah-e-Nijat, Zarb-e-Azb, Radd-ul-Fasaad, Khyber I–IV, Azm-e-Istehkam, Sarbakaf) achieved *sustainable* normalization as distinct from temporary suppression, and what explains the decay of their gains? (Chapter 6)
3. **Merger.** How has the 2018 FATA merger altered security dynamics in the merged districts, and which institutional gaps — fiscal, judicial, policing, political — remain binding? (Chapter 5)
4. **Development–security nexus.** Is the relationship between socio-economic development and security in KP linear, conditional, or reflexive — that is, does development produce security, security produce development, or do they co-produce each other — and what does the evidence from KP's post-2009 districts show? (Chapter 10)
5. **Deradicalization.** How effective are Pakistan's deradicalization and counter-narrative instruments (Sabawoon, Mishal, Sparlay, Rastoon and successors) in the KP context, on what evidence, and with what limitations? (Chapter 8)
6. **Afghanistan.** What is the causal architecture of the Afghanistan factor in KP's security, and what minimal, verifiable cross-border arrangements could reduce the sanctuary dividend without a comprehensive settlement? (Chapter 9)
7. **Governance and rule of law.** Which governance and rule-of-law reforms — apex coordination, local government, judicial extension, police professionalization, anti-terrorism law safeguards — are most strongly associated with reductions in violence in KP's own record? (Chapters 7, 11)
8. **Comparative lessons.** Which transferable lessons from other conflict transitions are applicable to KP, and which are not, given KP's specificity (intra-state but cross-border insurgency; nuclear-armed state; federal structure; no comprehensive peace process)? (Chapter 13)
9. **Society and peace.** What roles do civil society, media, religious institutions, jirgas, women and youth play in sustaining or undermining normalization, and how has the shrinking civic space (including the proscription of the PTM) affected those roles? (Chapter 12)
10. **Futures and economics.** What are the most plausible security futures for KP through 2035, what early-warning indicators distinguish them, and what is the economic cost of insecurity versus the dividend of normalization? (Chapters 14, 15)

Two subsidiary questions run throughout: how do **gender dynamics** affect normalization (Chapters 8, 10, 12); and what is the **cost of insecurity** to KP's economy and public finances (Chapters 10, 15)?

1.5 Significance and Relevance of the Study

The study's significance is both scholarly and policy-relevant.

Scholarly. KP presents a rare configuration in conflict studies: a well-documented, decades-long insurgency in a middle-income, nuclear-armed federal state, in which the state has repeatedly alternated between accommodation, military campaigns, merger-as-integration, and externally-directed diplomacy. It is therefore a natural experiment for testing propositions about counter-insurgency's political primacy, the conditions under which legal integration is substantive rather than formal, and the relationship between cross-border sanctuaries and internal violence. The study contributes an original dataset synthesis and an original analytical framework (the "three monopolies" model advanced in the Abstract and Chapter 16).

Policy. Three audiences are addressed. For Pakistan's federal and provincial governments, the study offers a phased roadmap with financing mechanisms and institutional responsibilities (Chapter 15). For international partners (UN agencies, IFIs, and bilateral donors), it identifies entry points — the merged districts' fiscal settlement, justice-sector completion, education and

deradicalization — where external assistance is plausible and consequential, and it cautions against financing purely kinetic approaches. For regional actors and mediators, it analyses the 2025–2026 Afghan–Pakistan escalation and the design of verification mechanisms (Chapter 9).

Moral and human. The study insists on the human dimension. KP's losses include thousands of police officers, soldiers, tribal elders, religious scholars, journalists, health workers, teachers, and civilians; millions of displaced persons; and communities — Kurram's Shia, Swat's returnees, Tirah's displaced families, Hazara's Shia, women targeted for education — whose suffering is under-recorded. Analysis that abstracts these losses into "security trends" dishonours the evidence itself.

1.6 Scope and Delimitations

Included: the whole of KP, with detailed treatment of the merged districts and, where relevant, spillover into Islamabad and Balochistan; the historical period from the colonial frontier to October 2026; all major threat categories; state and non-state actors; Afghan and Indian regional factors as they bear on KP; domestic and international policy frameworks.

Excluded or de-emphasized: detailed military operational history of Pakistan's eastern border or Kashmir (referenced only where it affects KP's security economy and force allocation); classified counter-terrorism capabilities; and forensic attribution of specific attacks where evidence is not public — the study attributes responsibility only where it is claimed by the group, officially attributed by Pakistani authorities, or independently assessed by credible monitors, and it flags the basis of attribution in each case.

Delimitation note. The study does not attempt a comprehensive account of Balochistan's insurgency (a distinct conflict with distinct actors), except where it intersects with KP's threat landscape through the TTP's expanded footprint, operations in Balochistan attributed to KP-based networks, and Pakistan's national counter-insurgency architecture (azm-e-Istehkam's national framing; NACTA's national coordination).

1.7 Conceptual and Theoretical Framework

The study is theoretically plural but analytically disciplined: each framework is used for the question it can answer, and none is treated as a master key. Figure 1.1 maps frameworks to chapters in narrative form.

(a) Human security (UNDP). The 1994 UNDP formulation (economic, food, health, environmental, personal, community and political security) is used as the *evaluative* standard for normalization, translated into KP terms: freedom from violent death; freedom from displacement; access to livelihood; education; and protection from arbitrary state or non-state coercion. It corrects a persistent distortion in security policy assessment — measuring success by body counts of militants rather than by the security experienced by residents.

(b) Conflict transformation (Lederach). Lederach's distinction between the *presenting problem* (violence) and the *relational substrate* (the patterns of exclusion, domination, and retaliation that regenerate violence) structures Chapter 4's root-cause analysis and Chapter 15's roadmap. Applied to KP: military campaigns address the presenting problem; the relational substrate includes the unresolved Kurram land-and-identity conflict, the exclusion of the tribal belt from fiscal federalism, the Pashtun–state estrangement documented by the ICG (2026), and sectarian securities dilemmas. Transformation requires platforms where these relations can be renegotiated — which is precisely what the current architecture lacks.

(c) Counter-insurgency doctrine (Galula, Kilcullen, Trinquier and their critics). Three propositions are tested against KP's record: Galula's primacy of political over military action ("80 per cent political"); Kilcullen's warning that heavy-handed manoeuvre in peripheral tribal zones creates "accidental guerrillas" by pushing neutral communities into the insurgency; and population-centric doctrine's requirement that protection of civilians be the operational centre of gravity. Chapter 6 assesses Pakistan's operations against these propositions and finds a decisive failure on the first (political purpose), partial success on the second (learning from 2009 civilian-harm episodes), and episodic rather than systematic compliance with the third.

(d) State-building and governance theory. The study adopts a "monopoly of violence plus governance quality" model: security is produced not only by coercion but by legitimate institutions that citizens choose to use — courts that convict, police that respond, tax offices that are not predatory, and local government that allocates. KP's merged districts are the critical case: legal integration without institutional capacity produced what might be called *paper sovereignty* (Chapter 5).

(e) Securitization theory (Copenhagen School). Securitization — the move that lifts an issue from politics into existential "security" framing — explains a great deal of KP's post-2001 history: the framing of the Pashtun belt as a security space produced emergency law, mass detention, curfews and evictions; the framing of the TTP restored "militancy" to the centre of national politics in 2024–2026 and produced Operation Azm-e-Istehkam; and the proscription of the Pashtun Tahafuz Movement in October 2024 under Section 11B of the Anti-Terrorism Act is the clearest illustration of securitization applied

to a *political* movement (Chapter 12).

(f) Political economy of conflict. The war economy — cross-border smuggling, narcotics, illegal mining, extortion, kidnap-for-ransom, and the rents associated with military contracting and border regulation — is analysed as a system with its own beneficiaries. The study resists the reduction of KP's conflict to criminality but tests the proposition that war-economy actors matter more in *duration* than in *initiation*.

(g) Greed versus grievance (Collier–Hoeffler). The model's core insight — that opportunities and lootability can sustain conflicts whose causes are grievances — is applied in Chapter 4 (§4.10) to explain the persistence of a conflict whose drivers have changed over twenty years, and its limits are noted: KP's fighters are not primarily loot-seeking; recruitment narratives are ideological and reactive; and the "greed" mechanism operates chiefly at the level of armed group finance and elite networks, not rank-and-file motivation.

(h) Whole-of-nation approach. Used normatively in Chapter 15: the sequencing of force, regulation, fiscal transfer, service delivery and political inclusion, with explicit coordination mechanisms (and the honest observation that Pakistan has repeatedly announced whole-of-government approaches without whole-of-government budgets).

(i) Resilience and community-based security. The study treats community resilience — peace committees, jirgas, tribal lashkars, women's networks, and local media — as a security *capability*, not a substitute for the state, drawing on the KP record (Chapter 12) and comparative practice (Chapter 13).

1.8 Definitions of Key Terms

Normalization. In this study, the condition in which violence is at levels consistent with ordinary criminality in a comparable society; institutions of coercion (police, courts, prisons) operate as the ordinary providers of security; the population's dominant expectation is that disputes will be resolved by law rather than force; and the state does not require exceptional emergency powers to maintain order. Normalization is a continuum with four thresholds: *suppression* (attacks reduced by force), *consolidation* (reconstruction and return), *institutionalization* (indigenous police/justice capability under civilian authority), and *normalization* (violence legible as crime, politics no longer conducted under existential threat framing). Most analyses of KP conflate the first with the fourth.

Security. Following the human security tradition, security is defined as the condition of being free from chronic threats of violence and coercion, and free from fear of losing life, livelihood, or physical integrity — whether the source is militancy, criminality, or arbitrary state action.

Militancy. Organized, armed, non-state political violence in pursuit of objectives that are framed ideologically (religious, ethno-nationalist, or revolutionary). The term is used descriptively without implying legitimacy.

Insurgency. A contested struggle between a state and non-state actors seeking to control territory, populations, or the state itself, using irregular force and political mobilization. In KP, the TTP's campaign since 2021 approximates insurgency in the border districts (parallel taxation, checkpoints, judicial impositions, and territorial contention) and terrorism in the settled districts.

Terrorism. Deliberate violence (or threat of violence) against non-combatants or symbolic targets, designed to produce psychological effects beyond its immediate victims, in service of political objectives. The study applies the term to attacks by both non-state actors and, where the evidence supports it and international law so defines it, does not shrink from examining state conduct — while noting that "state terrorism" is a contested category in Pakistani law and discourse.

Counter-terrorism (CT) and counter-insurgency (COIN). CT denotes measures against terrorist networks — intelligence, policing, prosecution, disruption, financing; COIN denotes a political-military campaign to defeat an insurgency and restore legitimate governance. Much of Pakistan's policy conflates them, with the effect that strategies designed for CT (targeted raids, arrests, prosecutions) are applied to an insurgency problem (territorial and popular contention), and vice versa.

Deradicalization, disengagement and rehabilitation. *Deradicalization* denotes change in beliefs; *disengagement* denotes change in behaviour (cessation of violence) without necessarily abandoning beliefs; *rehabilitation* denotes the social, psychological and economic restoration of the individual. Programs that achieve only disengagement may reduce violence in the short term while leaving the underlying belief system intact — a crucial distinction for evaluating the KP programs (Chapter 8).

Peacebuilding. Sustained external and internal support to institutions and relationships after violence to prevent relapse — distinct from peacemaking (ending the fighting) and peacekeeping (monitoring).

State-building. The construction of legitimate, effective institutions capable of providing security, justice, revenue and services; distinguished from *state formation* (any process producing a state) and from *regime-building* (strengthening incumbents).

Newly Merged Districts (NMDs) / erstwhile FATA. The seven former tribal agencies (Bajaur, Mohmand, Khyber, Orakzai, Kurram, North Waziristan, South Waziristan) plus six Frontier Regions merged into KP by the 25th Amendment (2018). "Tribal districts" and "merged districts" are used interchangeably in Pakistani discourse; this study prefers NMDs except where historical fidelity requires "FATA."

Alignment structures. Local tribal militias raised by the state or communities — peace committees, lashkars, *chagha* (village defence) groups — used in KP and historically in FATA. Their double-edged nature (effective defence; entrenchment of communal division; exposure to militant reprisal) is analysed in Chapters 3 and 12.

Jirga. The Pashtun assembly-based dispute-resolution institution, ranging from small local jirgas to grand (Loya) jirgas with quasi-judicial functions. Its status and function have been transformed by the merger and by militancy; a central question in Chapter 12 is whether reform can preserve its legitimacy dividend while ending practices — collective punishment, exclusion of women and youth — inconsistent with rights.

Sanctuary and the "sanctuary dividend." The military advantage accruing to an armed group from a protected rear area outside the state's reach (here, Afghan territory plus Pakistan's own historically ungoverned tribal belt). The study refers to the *sanctuary dividend* as the specific increment of capability the TTP derives from Afghan territory, and treats its reduction as a necessary but not sufficient condition for normalization.

Whole-of-nation approach. Pakistan's own official idiom, adopted in policy documents since 2014, for a comprehensive strategy in which "all elements of national power" are applied. The study uses the term critically, noting that the resources committed to its non-military elements have consistently been an order of magnitude smaller than those committed to force (Chapter 11).

Key figures of reference. To avoid ambiguity, the study uses "TTP" for the umbrella and names factions (Hafiz Gul Bahadur Group/HGB, Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan/IMP, Jamaat-ul-Ahrar/JuA, Lashkar-e-Jhangvi) where sources distinguish them; "ISKP" for the Islamic State–Khorasan Province; "PTM" for the Pashtun Tahafuz Movement (proscribed in October 2024); "NACTA" for the National Counter Terrorism Authority; "CTD" for provincial Counter-Terrorism Departments; "ISPR" for the Inter-Services Public Relations; "NMDs" for Newly Merged Districts.

Table 1.1 — Core security indicators, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and comparators (2019–2026)

Indicator	2019	2021	2023	2024	2025	2026 (partial)
Pakistan violence-linked fatalities (CRSS)	~<1,000	~1,000+	1,527	2,555	3,417	3,002 (Q1–Q3)
KP violence-linked fatalities (CRSS)	—	—	—	1,620	2,331	1,342 (Q1 311 + Q2 475 + Q3 556)
KP share of national fatalities	—	—	—	~63%	~68%	~45% (Balochistan surpassed KP in Q3)
Fatal terrorism incidents in KP (SATP)	—	—	—	702	766	—
KP police personnel killed	—	—	186	153	159	122 (H1)
Districts affected (SATP)	—	21 (2021)	22	28	24	—

Sources: CRSS 2024; CRSS 2025b; CRSS 2026a–c; SATP 2026b–c; The News 2026a; APP 2026b. Note: CRSS and SATP use different inclusion criteria; both are presented. National Q1–Q3 2026 total comprises 813 + 774 + 1,415.

Exhibit 1.1 — The "Three Monopolies" Framework (analytical summary)

Monopoly	Content	KP's situation (2026)	Failure mode if absent
On organized violence	State forces durably outperform organized non-state violence; no parallel taxation, checkpoints, or courts	Contested in border districts; TTP checkpoints and extortion reported in several districts (NMDs, Bannu, Lakki Marwat)	Insurgency persists; "suppression" phases recur
On justice/governance	Citizens can access courts, police, and services; rights enforceable against both state and non-state coercion	Skeletal courts in NMDs; hybrid FCR-era practice; low conviction rates; documented abuses	Alienation; private/communal arming; jirga substitution; legitimacy deficit
On national resources (fiscal federalism)	Province/NMDs receive constitutionally-committed, predictable resources enabling security and services	3% NFC commitment ~19% delivered; expires 2028; Rs 568bn shortfall	Institutions cannot pay, post, or equip; development promises discredited

This framework organizes the analysis in Chapters 4, 5, 7, 11 and 15 and the synthesis in Chapter 16.

CHAPTER 2 — HISTORICAL EVOLUTION OF SECURITY CHALLENGES IN KPK

2.1 Pre-Partition Era: The Tribal Frontier and British Colonial Security Architecture

The security architecture that shaped Khyber Pakhtunkhwa until 2018 was designed in the nineteenth century, and its logic — spatial exception, collective responsibility, purchased loyalty, and punitive expedition — outlasted the empire that produced it by seven decades. British consolidation began with the annexation of Punjab (1849) and the gradual extension of control to the frontier, culminating in the demarcation of the Durand Line with Afghanistan in 1893 (ratified in 1894 and formalized in later instruments) — a boundary that Afghanistan has never formally recognized and that structures frontier politics to this day.

Institutions of indirect rule. The apparatus that emerged comprised: (i) the *Political Agent (PA)* in each agency, an executive fusing judicial, administrative and intelligence functions; (ii) the *malik* system — state-recognized tribal intermediaries paid allowances and used as conduits of policy and, when necessary, of punishment; (iii) the *jirga* as the recognized dispute-resolution institution, bound to state purposes through quotas and inducements; (iv) paramilitary forces — *Khasadars* (tribal constabulary) and *Levies* — raised locally, lightly armed, and structurally incapable of confronting organized insurgency; and (v) the **Frontier Crimes Regulations (FCR) of 1901**, which codified collective punishment (including the ruinous "40 FCR" joint-liability clause), barred appeals, and excluded the ordinary criminal law and superior courts from the tribal areas (Ahmed 1983; Haq 2024). Along the settled frontier, the *Sandeman system* exchanged allowances for order; recurrent uprisings — including the Tirah campaign (1897–98), the Mohmand campaigns, and numerous punitive expeditions — established a doctrine of "butcher and bolt": columns would burn villages and withdraw, producing temporary compliance and durable grievance.

The settled districts and the rise of Pashtun nationalism. In the settled districts that became the North-West Frontier Province (NWFP; a Chief Commissioner's province from 1901, given partial representative institutions in 1932 and a Ministry in 1937), a different politics developed. Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan's Khudai Khidmatgar (Red Shirts, founded 1929) fused Pashtun nationalism with a Gandhian non-violence and Congress alignment, winning provincial power in 1937 and presenting an alternative to both the colonial state and the later Pakistani state's approach to the frontier. The 1930 Qissa Khwani bazaar firing (Peshawar), and the Garhi and Ram Bagh shootings of 1930–31, gave the frontier a martyr tradition of its own. The 1947 referendum on NWFP's accession to Pakistan — held under conditions that Congress and the Khudai Khidmatgar boycotted, and excluding a "Pakhtunistan" option — bequeathed an unresolved legitimacy dispute between Pashtun nationalists and the Pakistan state that persists, in altered form, in the Pashtun Tahafuz Movement (Chapter 12).

Analytical significance. Three features of the colonial architecture proved path-dependent. First, *spatial legal dualism* — a governed core and an exception zone — created incentives for armed non-state actors of every kind to locate in the exception. Second, *purchased stability* (allowances, subsidies, and subsidies for intermediaries) created a political economy in which the withdrawal or fluctuation of payments could be destabilizing. Third, *punitive practice* generated cycles of vendetta and provided mobilizing memories for later generations. The colonial frontier was not simply pre-modern disorder; it was a *designed order of managed instability*, and its costs were transferred to post-independence Pakistan intact.

2.2 Post-Independence Period (1947–1979): Governance of the Tribal Belt

Continuity of the exception. Pakistan retained FATA's special status and the FCR practically unchanged. The tribal agencies were administered by federal Political Agents reporting to the Governor and, from the Zulfikar Ali Bhutto era, through the federal law-and-order machinery; the tribal areas had no representation in provincial politics in ordinary terms, no ordinary courts, and no taxation beyond minor revenue arrangements. The Frontier Regions were attached administratively to adjacent settled districts. Paradoxically, this preserved a permissive political space for Afghan-led irredentist claims: Afghanistan's refusal to recognize the Durand Line and the "Pakhtunistan" claim (pressed by Kabul at the United Nations and by proxy in the 1950s–1970s) made the Pashtun belt a theatre of bilateral contest, and the Pakistan People's Party's slogan that Pushtuns would decide their own fate "on the banks of the Indus" as good a summary of the state's strategic approach to the belt (Yusufzai 2019; Ahmad 2010).

Domestic politics and the frontier. NWFP's post-1947 politics fluctuated between Pashtun nationalist mobilizations (the 1948 arrest of Bacha Khan; the Red Shirts' marginalization), religious parties (the Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam, which formed the provincial government in alliance in the 1970s under Mufti Mahmud), and the Pakistan People's Party (which won loyalty through land reform rhetoric and patronage). The 1973 Constitution gave NWFP a full provincial assembly and integrated FATA's representation into the National Assembly by nominated and, later, limited-electoral means. Crucially, the constitution retained the FCR's exclusionary logic (Article 247), preserving the exception zone inside a federal constitution.

Security posture. Through the 1950s–1970s, the frontier was quiet by later standards: the state's principal coercive concerns were cross-border Afghan intrigues, smuggling (a structural frontier activity that financed both elites and bandits), and periodic tribal disputes. Two developments of long-term significance occurred: (i) the emergence of the *khassadar-levies-model* of light frontier policing, which persisted after 2018; and (ii) the expansion of religious education — the Darul Uloom Haqqania at Akora Khattak (founded 1947) and thousands of smaller madrasas — creating an educational infrastructure that, in the 1980s, became a recruitment and ideological conduit (Chapter 4).

Assessment: the long peace and its hidden liabilities. The 1947–1979 period is often romanticized as stability. It was stability purchased by the exclusion of four to five million citizens from rights and courts; by allowances that made tribal politics an auction of loyalties; and by the deliberate non-development of FATA's economy. When the exogenous shock of the Afghan war arrived, the frontier had no institutions capable of absorbing it.

2.3 The Soviet–Afghan War (1979–1989): Jihad Infrastructure and Its Legacy

Pakistan as front-line state. The Soviet intervention in Afghanistan (December 1979) transformed the frontier into the logistical and ideological centre of a multinational jihad. Under General Muhammad Zia-ul-Haq, Pakistan joined the United States, Saudi Arabia and other partners in a program of support to the Afghan resistance. The Inter-Services Intelligence's Afghan Bureau became the managing agency; seven Afghan mujahideen parties based in Peshawar received arms, funding and training support; the CIA's Operation Cyclone supplied weaponry — culminating in the Stinger programme — that entered the region in volumes and types that later armed new conflicts (Coll 2004; Yousaf and Adkin 1992; Riedel 2014). Saudi and Gulf funding financed religious institutions and networks that would re-emerge as Salafi-jihadist infrastructure. Estimates of the US programme's scale range to several billion dollars, alongside matching Saudi contributions.

Effects on KPK. Five consequences are traceable and consequential. (1) *Madrasa expansion*: the number of madrasas in Pakistan expanded dramatically during the 1980s; the KP and FATA belt became the sector's densest habitat, with Afghan and later Pakistani cohorts (Zaman 2002). (2) *Weapons diffusion*: Kalashnikov-pattern rifles, machine guns, RPGs, and later heavier systems entered the tribal economy and never left. (3) *Militant infrastructure*: training camps, logistics networks, and fundraising channels were established in FATA and Malakand, initially for Afghanistan. (4) *Refugee crisis*: Pakistan hosted approximately three million Afghan refugees at the peak, most in KP and FATA; the camps around Peshawar became a parallel society with its own politics, and their economies became entangled with smuggling and with the jihad (Chapters 9 and 10). (5) *Ideological normalization*: jihad as an instrument of state policy in Afghanistan was absorbed into religious and educational institutions in KP, creating a reservoir of legitimacy for later armed projects.

The end of the war and its unfinished business. The Geneva Accords (1988), Soviet withdrawal (1989), and the collapse of the Najibullah government (1992) did not demobilize the infrastructure that had been built. Weapons, cadres, logistics networks, madrasa networks, retired commanders, and a generation socialized into armed politics remained — and were available, as subsequent events showed, for redirection toward Kashmir, toward Afghanistan's civil war, toward sectarian conflict, and eventually toward the Pakistani state itself.

2.4 The Afghan Civil War and the Taliban Rise (1989–2001): Spillover into KPK

From internecine war to the Taliban. The post-1992 Afghan civil war — a five-faction conflict in which Pakistani policy was deeply entangled — devastated Kabul and southern Afghanistan. In 1994–96, the Taliban movement emerged from Kandahar, drawing on madrasa networks in Afghanistan and Pakistan (notably Balochistan and KP) and receiving Pakistani logistical and diplomatic support; by September 1996 it controlled Kabul, and by 2001 it governed most of the country (Rashid 2000; Riedel 2014). For KP and FATA, three spillovers were immediate: fighters and commanders circulated across the border; madrasa recruitment for the Taliban drew heavily on Pakistani Pashtun students; and the so-called "tribals" became the state's instrument of informal foreign policy (Chapter 9).

Sectarianization of the frontier. The 1980s also incubated sectarian organizations: Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (1985, from Jhang in Punjab) and its more militant offshoot Lashkar-e-Jhangvi (1996) organized anti-Shia violence, initially directed at Shia professionals and later at whole communities; Shia militias and Iranian-supported networks proliferated in response. Kurram's Shia-majority Parachinar suffered attacks for decades; the tribal agency became a theatre in which local land disputes, regional sectarian networks, and the Afghan conflict interlocked (The Diplomat 2024; Chapter 3). By the late 1990s, the province had experienced multiple mass-casualty sectarian attacks, and a violent extremist infrastructure existed independent of the Afghan theatre.

Musharraf, the Kashmir jihad, and the pivot. The Kargil episode (1999), the Musharraf coup, and the state's tolerance of Kashmir-focused organizations (Jaish-e-Muhammad, Lashkar-e-Taiba, Harkat-ul-Mujahideen) maintained an ecosystem of armed non-state groups on Pakistani soil. The 9/11 attacks and the US ultimatum forced a strategic pivot: Pakistan joined the war on terror, severed formal support to the Taliban, and permitted the US access that enabled the defeat of the Taliban

regime in late 2001. That decision — and its inconsistent implementation, especially in the tribal belt — set the stage for the insurgency.

Assessment. By 2001, KPK and FATA hosted: Afghan and Pakistani jihadist networks; sectarian organizations with armed wings; madrasa networks with a recruitment function; a weapons economy; and a political culture in which state and non-state armed actors had been entangled for two decades. The 2001–2008 period would convert this infrastructure into an insurgency — but the insurgency's raw materials were all present before 9/11.

2.5 Post-9/11 Era (2001–2008): The War on Terror Comes to KPK

The fragile state–militant equilibrium (2001–2005). Pakistan's initial approach combined cooperation with the United States (arrests of al-Qaeda figures; raids in FATA) with accommodation of the Taliban's remnants and tolerance of Kashmir-focused groups. In FATA, operations were episodic — South Waziristan (2002–2004), Bajaur and Mohmand — and alternated with peace agreements: in Shakai (April 2004) with Nek Muhammad, and subsequently with Baitullah Mehsud (Sararogha, February 2005) and others. These agreements typically traded reduced military pressure and payments for commitments to stop harbouring foreign fighters and attacking the state — commitments that were systematically violated. The pattern — operation, agreement, regroup, violation — became a template later analysed as producing "accidental guerrillas": heavy-handed operations combined with patronage deals discredited cooperating tribal elders, exposed them to reprisal, and made state promises unreliable (Kilcullen 2009).

The emergence of the TTP (2007). In December 2007, an umbrella of militant factions formed the *Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan* under Baitullah Mehsud, with the aim of establishing an Islamic state in Pakistan; its founding coalitions included factions in South and North Waziristan, Bajaur, Mohmand, Khyber, Orakzai, Kurram and the settled districts of Swat, Dir and Shangla (Chapters 3 and 6). The Lal Masjid operation in Islamabad (July 2007) had a catalytic effect: the government's storming of the madrasa-mosque complex triggered retaliation across the province and FATA, and the TTP's cadres expanded through the Malakand Division, where the movement had local roots.

Swat: from movement to insurgency. Swat's insurgency grew from the neo-Taliban campaign of Maulana Fazlullah, who from 2007 used FM radio ("Mullah Radio") to promote a moral-reform program that moved from sermons on music and education to beheadings, attacks on barber shops, bans on girls' schooling (including the January 2009 destruction of schools and the shooting of Malala Yousafzai in October 2012, after the military campaign began), and the destruction of shrines. The *Tehrik-i-Nifaz-i-Shariat-i-Muhammadi* (TNSM), led by Sufi Muhammad, pressed for the imposition of Sharia; the February 2009 "Nizam-e-Adl Regulation" conceded Sharia-based courts in Malakand, but the arrangement collapsed within weeks as the militants expanded into Buner, Dir and Shangla — the "Buner" crisis that triggered the April–May 2009 offensive.

Bajaur and the first big counter-offensive. In August 2008, the military launched a major operation in Bajaur (Operation Sherdil), which killed hundreds of militants by official claims, displaced hundreds of thousands, and became a rehearsal for the 2009 campaigns. By 2008–09 the province had suffered mass-casualty suicide bombings (the Islamabad Marriott in September 2008; attacks on Pakistani security establishments), and the ANP-led provincial government (2008) faced an existential security crisis, losing in the period many of its senior figures to targeted killings.

The IDP crisis and the 2009 turn. Operation Rah-e-Rast (May 2009) in Malakand displaced an estimated 2–2.5 million people in weeks — the largest displacement in Pakistan since 1947 — and produced a nationwide political consensus (a consensual parliamentary resolution) supporting the operation. The military-led campaign, coupled with local resistance to the TTP's violence, broke the Swat insurgency by mid-2009, though sequels — Waziristan's Operation Rah-e-Nijat (October 2009), and rolling operations through 2010–2014 — followed (Chapter 6).

Assessment of 2001–2008. The period demonstrates the costs of a strategy that alternated between accommodating armed groups and mounting episodic operations. The state's inability to hold cleared terrain, its reliance on unreliable patronage, and its tolerance of sanctuary infrastructure in Afghanistan (from which the Afghan Taliban and, later, the TTP operated) meant that each campaign's gains were reversible. The most important positive development was the emergence of broad public opposition to the TTP within KP — an anti-militant political constituency that later made possible both the 2009 operations and the Swat recovery (Chapters 6 and 12).

2.6 The Peak of Militancy (2008–2014): TTP, Swat Insurgency and the Darkest Years

The war's geography. In the years after 2009 the TTP and its allies — including Lashkar-e-Jhangvi in sectarian violence and factions in Orakzai, Kurram and Khyber — carried out high-tempo campaigns: the 2010 attacks on Ahmadi mosques in Lahore and the Data Darbar shrine; the June 2011 attack on the Mehran naval base in Karachi; the August 2012 Kamra airbase attack (Chapter 6); the 2013 attacks on Christian targets in Peshawar (All Saints Church) and on ANP leaders (Bashir Ahmad Bilour, 2012) and tribal elders; and, the terminal event of the period, the December 2014 Army Public School attack

in Peshawar, in which 132 schoolchildren and approximately 149 people were killed.

Drone war and its consequences. US drone strikes in the tribal areas peaked in 2008–2013, with several hundred strikes and hundreds to thousands of claimed deaths (estimates vary widely). The strikes degraded TTP and al-Qaeda leadership (Baitullah Mehsud was killed in 2009; Hakimullah Mehsud in November 2013), but they also generated intense anti-American mobilizations (notably the PTM's pre-history in the Waziristan protests of 2014), created civilian-harm grievances, and at times provided openings for TTP narratives of victimhood. The 2015 killing of Fazlullah's successor lineages and the 2016 killing of Mullah Akhtar Mansour in Balochistan also reshaped the Afghan Taliban's leadership.

Sectarian and anti-minority violence. The period 2008–2014 also saw sectarian and anti-minority violence at scale: Shia processions (the Ashura attacks), the Parachinar attacks, Hazara victimization, and the Kurram conflict, in which approximately 2,000 people died between 2007 and 2011 before the 2011 jirga-brokered truce (Chapter 3). For KP's Shia communities, security became a permanent emergency — visible in the fortified bazaars of Parachinar and Hangu.

Contestation and the emergence of the 2014–2017 turnaround. By 2013–2014, the cost of inaction had become politically unsustainable: the Peshawar APS attack produced a national trauma and a political consensus. The government's 2014 National Action Plan (NAP, twenty points; revised in 2021 to fourteen points) married military operations with judicial, financial, media and madrasa measures. Zarb-e-Azb (June 2014 — July 2017) in North Waziristan displaced about one million people, dismantled militant infrastructure and, by official claims, killed some 3,500 militants; the follow-on Khyber I–IV operations in the Khyber agency and operations elsewhere continued the campaign; Operation Radd-ul-Fasaad (2017) declared a nationwide consolidation campaign. Militant violence fell substantially: by 2018–2020, Pakistan recorded its lowest terrorism fatalities in over a decade (Chapter 6).

2.7 Military Operations and Their Aftermath (2014–2020)

The 2014–2017 campaign. Zarb-e-Azb was qualitatively different from prior operations: it was (i) pre-announced and population-warned, (ii) sustained over years rather than weeks, (iii) accompanied by security-force sweeps across the country, and (iv) executed with an explicit *hard* centre of gravity — physically clearing militant infrastructure and denying it space — rather than a hearts-and-minds emphasis. Its successes were real: the TTP lost its principal territorial base, leadership attrition accelerated, and the incidence of mass-casualty attacks declined. Its limitations are equally documented: the recovery and reconstruction phase was slow and incomplete; the displacement (about one million people from North Waziristan alone) and its economic disruption generated grievances; and the campaign's extension into the border control regime (the fencing of the Durand Line from 2017, largely completed by 2021) shut down licit mobility along a border on which border communities' livelihoods depended (Chapter 9).

The NAP era and institutional reforms. The 2014 NAP's twenty points included military courts (established by the 21st Amendment, initially for two years and extended repeatedly), prosecution of terrorism cases, countering hate speech and financing, madrasa regulation, and NACTA's strengthening. Implementation was uneven: kinetic provisions were pursued energetically; madrasa registration was resisted by religious parties; counter-financing made progress (FATF compliance and the 2018–2022 process were consequential); and judicial reform lagged, producing what critics described as a correctional default: mass detention with low conviction rates (Chapter 7).

Political economy of the post-2014 recovery. The post-2014 period saw genuine reconstruction in Swat and parts of Malakand: roads (including the Swat expressway), rebuilt bazaars, restored tourism, and school reconstruction. Its unevenness — the contrast between Malakand's recovery and the tribal districts' continued deprivation — would become politically explosive after 2018, when the merger promised to close the gap (Chapter 5).

2.8 The Current Phase (2020–2026): Resurgence, FATA Merger and Emerging Dynamics

The Afghan withdrawal and the TTP revival (2020–2022). The Doha agreement (February 2020) and the US withdrawal (August 2021) transformed the TTP's operating environment. With the Afghan Taliban in power and TTP leadership hosted in Afghanistan, Pakistani officials negotiated — with Afghan Taliban hosting/mediation — a short-lived ceasefire (November–December 2021); it collapsed, and formal talks ended in November 2022. From 2022 onward, TTP attacks resumed an upward trajectory; by 2023, attacks had risen 17 per cent year-on-year (306 attacks, 23 suicide bombings) and major attacks included the January 2023 Police Lines mosque bombing in Peshawar (over 100 killed, 86 of them police) and the July 2023 Bajaur bombing. The TTP publicly declared its campaign against the Pakistani state in 2023 and escalated.

The merger moment (2018–2026). The 25th Amendment (May 2018) merged FATA into KP, extending the provincial assembly, formal courts, and police; adding 23 seats to a 145-member assembly; and committing — through parliamentary resolutions — 3 per cent of the divisible pool for ten years to bring the merged districts to parity. Implementation, however, was slow; the fiscal commitment was met at a fraction of its value (Chapter 5); and the security environment in the merged districts deteriorated as the TTP re-established presence. By 2025–2026 the merged districts and adjoining southern settled

districts were the epicentre of violence — 40 per cent of all TTP violence since 2021 occurred in the seven NMDs, and nearly 60 per cent of TTP violence occurred in the south of the province (ACLED 2025).

State response, 2024–2026. Azm-e-Istehkam (June 2024) was announced as a reinvigorated national counter-terrorism campaign with kinetic and diplomatic components; it faced immediate opposition from the KP government (PTI), JUI-F, ANP, PTI-affiliated and PTM circles, and questions about resourcing and political consensus. Operation Sarbakaf (July 2025) targeted TTP hideouts in Bajaur's Lowi Mamund tehsil and displaced an estimated 100,000 people (Arab News/Paradigm Shift 2025). The October 2025 escalation between Pakistan and Afghanistan produced a Qatari/Turkish-brokered Doha ceasefire and an Istanbul monitoring mechanism (November 2025) that failed to hold. On 21–26 February 2026, cross-border clashes escalated into Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq, and on 4 March 2026 the TTP announced its spring offensive (Operation Khyber). In 2026, KP recorded its highest first-half police losses on record (122 killed), the deadliest single police-complex attack since 2023 (Kohat, 18 September 2026), and continuing expansion of operations into districts previously quiet (Swat, Kohat, Karak) (Chapters 3 and 6).

Political transitions and the provincial state. KP's provincial government changed hands in October 2025 when Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur resigned on the instructions of Imran Khan and Sohail Afridi (from Khyber District) was elected on 13 October 2025. The new Chief Minister adopted a posture critical of federal policy — opposing military operations in KP, blaming federal "flawed policies" for the resurgence, and demanding the release of withheld war-on-terror dues and constitutional payments (Wikipedia 2026e; Business Recorder 2026). The federal–provincial estrangement over counter-terrorism strategy is, per the International Crisis Group's 2026 analysis, itself a strategic variable: it degrades intelligence coordination between the army-led campaign and the provincial police (ICG 2026).

2.9 Lessons from History: Patterns, Cycles and Recurring Failures

Seven historical patterns are analytically load-bearing.

1. The system of exception transfers costs forward. Colonial indirect rule, FATA's continuation of the FCR, and the post-2001 doctrine of "military-first" governance created a legal and institutional vacuum that armed actors filled. Each attempt to end the exception — the 2018 merger; the extension of courts; the creation of NMD policing — has been undermined by under-resourcing and by the simultaneous requirement to fight a war in the same space.

2. Sanctuaries set the clock. The A–Z of KP's militancy — the anti-Soviet infrastructure, the Afghan Taliban's Peshawar-based parties, al-Qaeda's post-2001 sanctuary in FATA, the TTP's post-2021 sanctuary in Afghanistan — is a history of sanctuary creation and denial. No campaign has produced durable quiet while a sanctuary remained (Chapter 9).

3. Suppression decays without political and fiscal follow-through. Every kinetic success — Swat 2009, Waziristan 2014–17 — has decayed within five to seven years in the absence of completed governance, justice and economic transition. This is the central empirical regularity that Chapter 6 tests and Chapter 15 operationalizes.

4. Negotiations without verification and enforcement become force multipliers for the stronger party's opponent. The 2004–2008 agreements, the 2021–22 talks, and repeated local *aman* (peace) deals with militant factions were entered without effective monitoring, and each collapse strengthened the militants' position. Treating talks as a tactical pause rather than a strategic instrument has discredited negotiation as an option.

5. Displacement is a security variable, not merely a humanitarian one. The 2009 Swat displacement, Zarb-e-Azb's million-person displacement from North Waziristan, Sarbakaf's 100,000 in Bajaur, the Tirah displacement of 2025–2026 (33,800 families registered by January 2026), and the Kurram crisis have each produced: (i) humanitarian emergencies; (ii) grievance narratives about compensation and return; (iii) a population vulnerable to militant recruitment through hardship and humiliation. Repetition of large-scale operations without pre-positioned recovery financing has converted each military gain into a longer-term political liability.

6. The intra-Pashtun politics of the frontier is decisive. Where communities resisted militancy — the Malakand lashkars in 2009, Swat's Pashoon movement and protest traditions, anti-militant jirgas in Bajaur and Mohmand — violence fell. Where state policy alienated cooperative communities — through collective punishment, closure of civic space, or the proscription of political movements (the PTM ban of October 2024) — it narrowed the anti-militant coalition (Chapters 4 and 12).

7. Federal–provincial estrangement is a weapon for insurgents. When Karachi (or Islamabad) and Peshawar are at odds — over funding, over operations, over refugees — the counter-insurgency is fragmented and the state's messaging is split. From 2023 to 2026 this divergence has widened: the KP government publicly opposed Azm-e-Istehkam and Sarbakaf-style operations; the federal government and military argued for decisive force; and the police, provincially controlled, absorbed the casualties (ICG 2026; Dawn 2024a).

Taken together, these patterns yield the study's historical thesis: **the province's violence is best explained not as a series of discrete campaigns but as an equilibrium — periodically disturbed by force, repeatedly restored by the failure to**

build the three monopolies.***Exhibit 2.1 — Timeline of major inflection points (1849–2026)***

Period	Dominant dynamic	Security outcome
1849–1901	Colonial annexation; punitive expeditions; Durand Line (1893)	Managed instability; FCR (1901) codifies exception
1901–1947	NWFP as Chief Commissioner's province; Khudai Khidmatgar	Constitutional politics vs. frontier coercion
1947–1979	FCR continuity; Afghan irredentism; quiet frontier	Low violence; structural neglect; madrasa growth
1979–1989	Anti-Soviet jihad; US–Saudi–ISI program	Militant infrastructure, weapons, refugees, ideological normalization
1989–2001	Afghan civil war; Taliban rise; sectarianization	Spillover; sectarian armed groups; Kashmir jihad
2001–2007	War on terror; episodic operations; peace deals	Fragile equilibrium; TTP formed (Dec 2007)
2007–2009	Insurgency peak in Swat/Malakand and FATA	2–2.5m displaced; Rah-e-Rast (2009)
2009–2014	Rolling operations; drone campaign; APS attack (Dec 2014)	High attrition; national consensus → NAP
2014–2018	Zarb-e-Azb; NAP; fencing begins; merger (2018)	Violence declines to decade lows
2018–2021	Merger implementation; Kabul falls (Aug 2021)	Divergence: formal integration vs. security deterioration
2022–2024	TTP campaign resumes; talks collapse; Azm-e-Istehkam; PTM ban	Violence climbs sharply (2,555 deaths in 2024)
2025	Sarbakaf; Kurram crisis; Oct clashes with Afghanistan; 27th Amendment	Deadliest year in a decade (3,417 deaths nationally)
2026 (to 4 Oct)	Ghazab-lil-Haq; TTP Operation Khyber; Swat/Kohat attacks	Interstate conflict + insurgency; 1,342 KP deaths in Q1–Q3

CHAPTER 3 — MAPPING THE THREAT LANDSCAPE

3.1 Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP): Structure, Ideology, Strategy and Current Operational Status

Genesis and evolution. The TTP was formed in December 2007 as an umbrella of Pakistani militant factions under Baitullah Mehsud (killed 2009), succeeded by Hakimullah Mehsud (killed 2013), Maulana Fazlullah (killed 2018) and—since 2018—Noor Wali Mehsud. Its stated objective is the establishment of an Islamic system in Pakistan through armed struggle and the expulsion of what it characterizes as foreign domination of the Pakistani state (Yusufzai 2019; SATP 2026c). Across four leadership eras, the organisation's operating doctrine has evolved from the Mehsud-era emphasis on suicide bombing and mass-casualty urban attacks to the Fazlullah period's mix of guerrilla warfare and sectarian targeting, to the Noor Wali era's deliberate "insurgency doctrine" — territorial infiltration, parallel governance (taxes, courts, checkpoints), targeting of security forces, and selective use of spectacular attacks to shape national politics (Basit 2024; EUAA 2026).

Organizational structure and coalition dynamics. The EUAA's June 2026 country assessment concluded that the TTP has functioned since 2018 as an *umbrella coalition* rather than a monolithic organisation, incorporating more than seventy factions, including returning Afghan Taliban-aligned factions, Pakistani al-Qaeda affiliates, and groups from Pashtun- and Baloch-majority areas (EUAA 2026). This distinguishes the TTP from ISKP. In practice the umbrella has three tiers: (i) *core* Mehsud-faction structures in South and North Waziristan, with a leadership shura and a media apparatus (Umar Media/Umar Studio); (ii) *affiliated factions* with local autonomy, notably the **Hafiz Gul Bahadur Group (HGB)** in North Waziristan (previously a state-aligned "good Taliban" militia until 2014, now a leading anti-state actor), the **Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan (IMP)** — implicated in the Kohat Police Lines attack of 18 September 2026 — **Jamaat-ul-Ahrar (JuA)**, which announced a formal split from the TTP in July 2026, **Lashkar-e-Islam** in Khyber, and various Mohmand, Bajaur, Orakzai, Kurram and Swat-based factions; and (iii) *franchise/network* relationships with facilitators, sleeper cells and financial conduits (TRT 2026; Wikipedia 2026d; NSBRI 2026).

Strength. Strength estimates vary widely and should be treated as order-of-magnitude: The Diplomat reported estimates in February 2026 of approximately 3,000 ISKP fighters, 5,000–7,000 TTP, and 400–1,500 al-Qaeda personnel in Afghanistan (The Diplomat 2026a). Former KP Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur claimed in December 2024 that 22,000–24,000 TTP members were in Afghanistan with 16,000–18,000 fighters inside Pakistan (Eurasia Review 2026a) — a figure that should be read as a political statement about a threat rather than a census. Officials cited by Geo News in September 2025 estimated "over 8,000 TTP terrorists present in KP, setting up checkpoints" (ACLED 2025). What is not in dispute: the TTP has regenerated the *capacity* to mount company-sized attacks on static positions (the 26 October 2025 Haidar Kandao camp attack in Tirah, Orakzai — 21 security personnel killed per GTI 2026), sustained attack rates exceeding 300 claimed operations monthly in 2026, and a geographically widening footprint.

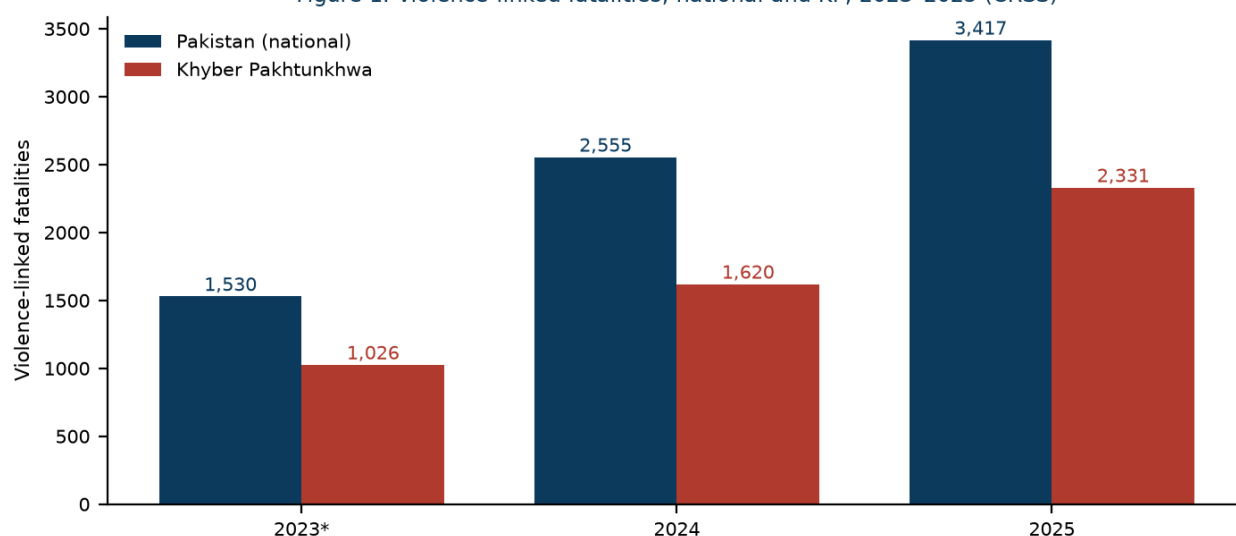
Ideology and strategy. The TTP's ideology is Deobandi-jihadist in lineage but programmatically Pakistani-national: its war aims combine (a) forced renegotiation of Pakistan's relationship with the United States and its allies; (b) imposition of Sharia; (c) revenge for operations and detentions (a theme it has elevated into an explicit demand for the release of prisoners and reversal of the 2018 merger as recompense for fatalities); and (d) the deterritorialization of the tribal belt from the Pakistani state's structures (Basit 2024; SATP 2026c). Strategically, since 2022 the TTP has pursued a *dual-track* campaign: insurgency in the border districts and settled south (parallel taxation, "courts", road tolls, night letters, targeted killings of officials, police and anti-militant notables); and terror in urban centres to demonstrate reach and extract political costs (Peshawar, Islamabad periphery, Karachi — where a trained suicide bomber was arrested in June 2026). On 4 March 2026 the group announced its annual spring offensive under the name *Operation Khyber* (Ghazwa-e-Khyber), following the conclusion of its *Al-Khandaq* campaign, directing attacks at military outposts, police, and security-force personnel (Eurasia Review 2026a).

Capabilities and tactical repertoire. TTP attacks in 2025–2026 have included: vehicle-borne IEDs (Lakki Marwat, May 2026: 9 killed, 33 injured; Kohat, September 2026); suicide bombings (Swat/Kabal, August 2026: 17 killed); coordinated small-arms assaults on checkposts, police stations and military camps; sniper and "laser" attacks; ambushes of convoys; targeted assassinations (including of police, tribal elders, peace-committee members, polio workers, and civil officials); kidnapping for ransom and hostage-taking; bank robbery (PKR 80 million in one 2026 incident); and — the most consequential new capability — drone warfare. KP police reported foiling 341 drone attacks in the first half of 2026, with at least 100 attacks in the province, 29 security personnel killed and 89 injured; at least 13 of KP's 40 districts have experienced drone attacks, and targets have shifted from border convoys to urban police installations, including coordinated quadcopter attacks on three police facilities in Karak on 14 August 2026 (GNET 2026). Pakistan has responded with anti-drone systems, nets and electronic countermeasures.

Finance. TTP financing combines: extortion and "taxation" in areas of influence (documented in Swat in 2025 and in the NMDs); kidnapping for ransom; bank robberies and vehicle thefts; Zakat/ushr collection under coercion; donations through a diaspora and jihadi fundraising networks; and rent extraction from minerals, timber, and construction (Chapters 4, 11). Counter-financing under the NAP and FATF-related reforms degraded formal channels (thousands of accounts frozen; charities proscribed), but the group's shift to cash-intensive, locally-taxed underground economies has offset much of that gain.

Assessment. The TTP is best understood today as an *insurgent coalition with a sanctuary, an increasingly capable technological appetite, and a political-strategic logic of attrition* rather than as a purely terrorist network. Its ability to impose parallel governance — reported checkpoints in parts of the NMDs and south, and coercive taxation — is the most troubling indicator, because parallel governance is precisely what distinguishes insurgency from terrorism in the KP case. The 2026 countervailing factor is internal competition: the JuA split and TTP-ISKP clashes (Orakzai, March 2026) suggest that the umbrella's growth has costs, and the state's counter-terrorism strategy may be able to exploit fissures it has not yet systematically targeted.

Figure 1. Violence-linked fatalities, national and KP, 2023–2025 (CRSS)



*2023 national figure derived from reported annual percentage change; KP 2023 estimate.

Figure 1. Violence-linked fatalities, national and KP, 2023–2025. Sources: CRSS annual reports; 2023 national figure derived from reported annual change (see Statistical Annex, Table A.1).

Figure 2. Provincial fatalities by quarter, 2026: Balochistan overtakes KP in Q3 (CRSS)

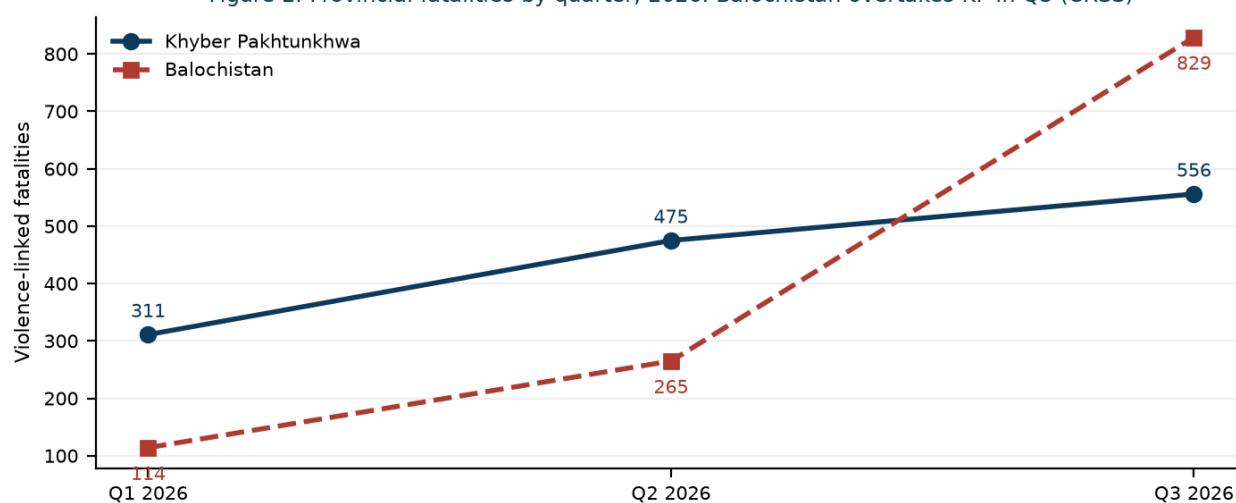


Figure 2. Provincial fatalities by quarter, 2026. Source: CRSS quarterly reports Q1–Q3 2026 (see Statistical Annex, Table A.1).

3.2 ISIS-Khorasan Province (ISKP): Presence, Activities and Threat Level in KPK

Presence and strength. ISKP, the Islamic State's "Khorasan Province," established its presence in Afghanistan's eastern provinces (Nangarhar, Kunar) from 2014–15 and, after its territorial defeat in Afghanistan, has operated as a decentralized

network. Estimates of its strength in the Afghanistan–Pakistan space hover around 2,000–4,000 fighters, with 3,000 a commonly cited figure (The Diplomat 2026a). In Pakistan, ISKP operates through cells — analyst Abdul Sayed's tally found ISKP claimed 19 attacks in Pakistan in 2021 (against the TTP's 257), but the pattern has shifted since: ISKP's campaign has been small in volume, high in lethality, and concentrated in KP. In 2023, ISKP claimed 26 attacks in Pakistan, *all* in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (18 in Bajaur, 7 in Peshawar, 1 in Hangu), causing hundreds of casualties (Wikipedia 2026c). In 2025, ISKP's most significant KP attack was the suicide bombing at the Darul Uloom Haqqania in Akora Khattak, Nowshera (28 February 2025), which killed at least eight people including the seminary's head, Maulana Hamid-ul-Haq Haqqani.

The 2026 escalation. The most consequential ISKP operation of the current phase was the 6 February 2026 suicide bombing at a Shia mosque/imambargah in Islamabad, which killed 31 worshippers and injured dozens more. Pakistan attributed the attack to ISKP and used it — alongside a security-convoys attack in Bannu and Ramadan-period attacks in Bajaur and Bannu — to justify the 22 February 2026 airstrikes inside Afghanistan against alleged TTP and ISKP camps, which in turn escalated into Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq (The Diplomat 2026a; Karmactive 2026; Wikipedia 2026a). ISKP activity in KP continued through 2026, including fighting with TTP factions (the killing of an ISKP commander and three associates in Orakzai's Ghaljo Narai area on 4 March 2026), targeted attacks on Pakistani intelligence personnel and peace-committee members, and attacks on Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam figures (SATP 2026a; Daniel Garofalo Monitoring 2026). One monitoring service observed that in August 2026 *all six* officially recorded Islamic State attacks worldwide occurred in KP — a striking concentration that analysts attribute to the group's regional contraction into the Pakistan–Afghanistan ecosystem.

Target profile and rivalry. ISKP's targeting logic differs from the TTP's in three ways. First, it deliberately selects *soft and sectarian targets* — Shia congregations, Sufi shrines, minority communities, and rival jihadists — where the TTP has increasingly restricted its attacks to security forces and state affiliates (Sayed, cited in RFE/RL). Second, ISKP attacks serve a *competition function*: demonstrating that the TTP is insufficiently "pure." Third, ISKP's anti-Shia campaign intersects with local sectarian entrepreneurs — an overlap that complicates attribution in Kurram, where the most lethal incidents since 2024 have involved both sectarian militias and jihadist franchises.

Assessment. ISKP is the most lethal *per attack* actor in KP, and its presence in Afghanistan makes it, like the TTP, difficult to eliminate from Pakistani territory alone. But its limited manpower, its hostility to the Afghan Taliban and the TTP alike, and its small attack volume mean it is best understood as a *strategic spoiler* — a group whose capacity to trigger interstate crises (as in February 2026) far exceeds its military weight. Policy that treats ISKP and the TTP as a single phenomenon risks both analytical error and strategic overreach; policy that ignores their competition misses an exploitable fault line.

3.3 Sectarian Militant Organizations: Lashkar-e-Jhangvi, Sipah-e-Sahaba and Others

Organizational landscape. Sectarian militancy in Pakistan's Deobandi–Shia conflict axis was institutionalized in the 1980s–1990s: Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (SSP, 1985) as a political-religious movement; Lashkar-e-Jhangvi (LeJ, 1996) as its armed vanguard; and a host of allied and splinter formations (Lashkar-e-Jhangvi Al-Alami, the anti-Shia networks in the Hazara belt, and the militant wings of Deobandi madrasa networks). Both SSP and LeJ were formally proscribed between 2002 and 2004; both persisted as networks and as franchises within the TTP and ISKP. LeJ's historical signature was targeted assassination of Shia professionals — doctors, lawyers, businessmen, and officials — and mass-casualty attacks on Shia gatherings; its factional descendants have been implicated in attacks on the Hazara community, including the 2013 Quetta and 2019–2021 Hazara killings, and in the wave of attacks on Parachinar since 2005 (Chapter 2).

The Kurram conflict as the contemporary sectarian frontline. Kurram district — with the Shia-majority town of Parachinar and a sectarian geography driven by land disputes, tribal alignments and cross-border links to Khost, Paktia and Nangarhar — has been the most lethal sectarian battlefield in Pakistan in recent years. The July 2024 land-dispute clashes between the Maleekhel (Shia-majority) and Madgi Kalay (Sunni-majority) tribes killed ~46–50 people; the 21 November 2024 attack on two Shia convoys (40+ vehicles under police escort) killed at least 40–43 people including women and children, triggering retaliatory clashes that in total killed between 97 (provincial figure) and 133 (independent counts) in weeks, and 200+ over 2024 (Al Jazeera 2024; The Diplomat 2024; Independent 2024; Directus, cited in Social News 2026). Following three weeks of jirga negotiations in Kohat, a 14-point agreement was signed on 1–2 January 2025: permanent ceasefire; surrender of heavy weapons; demolition of bunkers; a ban on private armed displays; a Rs 10 million collective fine for violations; the barring of proscribed sectarian organisations from opening offices; and commitments regarding the safety of government employees and the protection of women and non-combatants (Dawn 2025a; The Nation 2025a). A further one-year *Aman Teega* (peace pact) between Bushahra, Dandar, Taida, Malikhel, Ahmadzai, Mirbakhil, Shakh Daulat and related tribes was signed at a grand jirga in Parachinar in May 2025, with Army and administration representation (Tribune 2025c).

Despite these accords, the Thal–Parachinar Road — the district's lifeline — remained subject to prolonged closure, and by early 2026 a three-month closure produced what analysts described as siege conditions: shortages of food, fuel, medicine and emergency care; an estimated 200+ cumulative deaths; and the displacement of border-area populations (Directus, cited in

Social News 2026). Kurram remained one of the four districts accounting for 63 per cent of all KP violence incidents in the second quarter of 2026 (CRSS 2026b).

The Shia militia dimension and external actors. Because sectarian violence is reciprocal, armed Shia mobilizations matter analytically. Reports have attributed elements of the November 2024 retaliation to fighters associated with the Zainebiyoun Brigade, a Pakistani Shia militia historically recruited to fight in Syria (The Diplomat 2024). Sectarian conflict in Kurram thus includes an external patronage dimension for both sides: Iranian-linked networks on one side; Deobandi-jihadist and possibly ISKP networks on the other. This is the clearest example in KP of the regional proxy dimension operating at the sub-district level.

Assessment. Sectarian militancy in KP has four features that make it structurally dangerous. First, it is *self-reproducing*: each attack spawns vendettas, displacement, and arming. Second, it is *territorially specific*, which concentrates harm (the Shia of Parachinar; the Hazara and Shia of Hangu/Kohat; Ahmadi and Christian minorities in urban centres). Third, it is *networked across conflicts*: LeJ factions, ISKP, and TTP units trade personnel and expertise. Fourth, *legal remedies have failed*: the 14-point accord and Aman Teega are necessary but not sufficient; their enforcement depends on the police and courts that the district lacks. Kurram is where the argument for sequenced state-building — justice before sustained force; infrastructure before elections — is most clearly demonstrated.

3.4 Criminal Networks: Extortion, Kidnapping, Narcotics and Arms Trafficking

Extortion and racketeering. Extortion is the TTP's most accessible revenue stream and a leading source of civilian grievance. Documented patterns include: (a) night letters and telephone demands to businesses, landowners and contractors across the NMDs, Swat, Dir, Bajaur and settled districts (AIP 2026; NSBRRI 2026); (b) the "protection tax" collected from markets, transport, and mining and construction sites; (c) coercion of teachers, health workers and government staff; and (d) demands on the families of serving police and military personnel (a pattern that both generates revenue and forces cooperation). In 2025, Swat residents reported systematic extortion calls preceding the 2026 attack cycle; the presence of an extortion economy is now widely treated as the leading indicator of resurgence in a district.

Kidnapping for ransom (KFR) and abductions. KFR has re-emerged as a significant practice, often in hybrid criminal-militant form. Notable cases include the abduction of officials of the Pakistan Atomic Energy Commission from a mining project (per GTI 2026), multiple police and civilian abductions in the NMDs (including the reported capture of 196 security personnel per TTP's own 2025 claims), and the capture of security personnel in Swat and Bannu. KFR cases against traders and prominent families in the NMDs and southern districts provide liquidity and create communal fear; police data indicate that kidnappings, like all violent crime, have risen alongside militancy.

Narcotics. Pakistan's role as a transit corridor for Afghan opiates was historically concentrated in FATA, where poppy cultivation itself existed in parts of the tribal belt until the 2000s; since then, poppy cultivation has collapsed in Pakistan while transit trade and precursor trafficking have expanded with Afghanistan's poppy economy (which after the 2022 Taliban-imposed ban declined substantially, only to be partially replaced, per UNODC reporting, by methamphetamine and synthetic production). For KP, the relevant harms are: (a) transit corridors through Khyber, Kurram, Bajaur, Mohmand and Balochistan links; (b) local consumption (heroin and methamphetamine use, increasingly among youth and long-term IDPs); (c) financing for armed groups through "taxation" of trafficking; and (d) corruption of law enforcement at points of passage. Official statistics show rising anti-narcotics enforcement in KP in 2025–26, but the structural conditions are unchanged.

Arms trafficking and the weaponization of the border. The most consequential material supply shock of the current phase has been the availability of weapons — including NATO-pattern small arms, night-vision equipment, precision rifles and drone components — that entered Afghanistan after August 2021. Pakistani officials (including the ISPR's Director-General, Lieutenant-General Ahmed Sharif Chaudhry) have asserted that more than USD 7 billion of military equipment was abandoned in Afghanistan and that captured US-made weapons have been recovered in operations against the TTP (Eurasia Review 2026a). Independent verification is limited, but the presence of modern optics, night-fighting equipment and anti-personnel mines in TTP operations is documented in seizure reports and prosecutions (for example, the November 2024 Mohmand case in which five anti-personnel mines, three grenades and small arms were seized from a TTP cell, per the Peshawar ATC judgment of October 2026). Arms are further diffused through smuggling routes into Punjab and Sindh for criminal markets, and through the same routes used for narcotics and contraband.

The political economy of smuggling and "undocumented trade." The Afghanistan–Pakistan frontier hosts an enormous informal economy: fuel smuggling (in which the decanting of Iranian and Afghan petroleum products distorts provincial markets), the transit of goods under the cross-border "Transit Trade Agreement" framework (long used to launder dutiable cargo), currency exchange (the Kabul/Hawala networks), and the smuggling of electronic goods, tyres, vehicles and livestock. Official estimates of the illegal economy vary; the KP government's own assessments and federal enforcement campaigns (including 2025–26 crackdowns on the Landi Kotal/Torkham smuggling networks and the creation of

anti-smuggling task forces) suggest the scale is in the tens of billions of rupees annually. The security significance is twofold: smuggling provides revenue and logistics to armed groups; and crackdowns damage the livelihoods of border communities whose economic survival depends on the same routes — a trade-off that policy has not resolved and that recurrently features in local grievances (Chapter 4).

Assessment. Criminal and militant economies in KP are *convergent but not identical*. The state's interest in suppressing militancy and in suppressing smuggling sometimes align (both fund the TTP) and sometimes conflict (smuggling suppression alienates border communities; corruption networks within the state protect them). A serious normalization strategy must therefore treat the border economy explicitly: neither pure suppression (which has failed repeatedly and generated grievances) nor tolerance (which finances insurgency), but a regulated, tariff-integrated, employment-substituting transition.

3.5 Cross-Border Militant Movements and Afghan-Origin Threats

The border's physical and political geography. The Pakistan–Afghanistan boundary (2,611–2,640 km by varying counts) includes approximately 1,000+ km facing KP and the NMDs. Since 2017, Pakistan has fenced the border (largely completing the KP-facing portion by 2021–2023) and established crossing points and terminals (Torkham, Ghulam Khan, Angoor Adda), while Afghanistan has consistently refused to recognize the boundary. The fence has changed the character of infiltration — from open cross-border movement to a mix of covert crossing, smuggling tunnels, and firing over the fence — but it has not stopped it: infiltration of armed groups remains documented, including at Datta Khel (North Waziristan) and Kurram's Arandu and Nari sectors, and the Pakistani military reported foiling multiple attempts in 2026 (Wikipedia 2026a).

Sanctuary and rear basing. The 2026 Pakistan–Afghanistan conflict made explicit what analysts had argued since 2022: TTP fighters and commanders operate from Afghan territory (Kunar, Nangarhar, Khost, Paktika, Paktia, Logar and beyond), with reported camps and infrastructure; Pakistan's airstrikes beginning February 2026 targeted alleged TTP and ISKP camps and facilities in Kabul, Kandahar, Paktia, Khost, Nangarhar, Kunar and other provinces (The Diplomat 2026a; Wikipedia 2026a). The UN Security Council's Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team's 37th report (February 2026) reportedly found an increase in TTP attacks on Pakistan from Afghanistan (Eurasia Review 2026a). Estimates of the TTP's presence in Afghanistan (thousands of fighters; the 2024 claim of 22,000–24,000 is the upper bound of political estimates) indicate the scale of the sanctuary problem.

The cross-border population and mobility regime. The border zone's population includes: (a) resident tribal communities on both sides of the line who have kinship across it; (b) approximately 1.5–3 million Afghans historically resident in Pakistan, with the largest concentrations in KP; (c) traders and labourers dependent on legal and informal crossings; (d) documented and undocumented Afghan refugees — including, among them, persons of security concern. Since 2023, Pakistan's Illegal Foreigners Repatriation Plan has driven both mass inward pressure on Afghanistan (146,000+ deported in 2026 alone; the KP government's phased plan for ~20,000 in Peshawar city; camp closures in Bannu) and a hardening of border policy that in July 2026 moved to arrest without a valid visa (HRW 2026; Dawn 2026e; Tribune 2026). The security implications are double-edged: the policy plausibly reduces the pool in which militants hide, but it also creates a coercive environment in which "militant" and "Afghan" are conflated; it degrades inter-communal trust; and it generates its own radicalization pressures (Chapter 9).

Assessment. The cross-border threat is best modelled as a *stack of four channels*: (1) sanctuary (safe areas for leadership and training); (2) infiltration and exfiltration (movement of fighters and matériel); (3) supply (weapons, munitions, narcotics, drone components); and (4) the population channel (refugees, returnees, and mixed migration). A normalization strategy should specify which channel it is attempting to close, with what instrument (military, border management, diplomacy, refugee policy), at what cost to the border economy and to bilateral relations. Most past policy has conflated the four — with the result that actions against the population channel have been substituted for progress on the sanctuary channel, the channel that matters most to the insurgency's persistence.

3.6 Lone-Wolf Attacks and Self-Radicalized Actors

Evidence and pattern. Pakistani counter-terrorism practice has become increasingly attentive to small-cell and self-radicalized attackers. Prosecution records from 2025–2026 illustrate the profile: in the ATC Islamabad case of August 2026, three men from Malakand, the former Khyber Agency and Karak were convicted of possessing TNT/nitroglycerine explosives, a firearm, TTP flags and propaganda, along with hand-drawn maps of sensitive installations and forged police identity cards — but were acquitted on terrorism charges for want of proof of intent (The Nation 2026a). Other examples include the 2025–26 cases of suspects trained via online networks and directed by handlers abroad; the police arrests of trained suicide bombers (for example, one caught in Karachi in June 2026 after CTD intelligence developed through cyber-monitoring); and the recurring discovery of IED-making materials in urban homes.

Why the category matters. Lone-wolf and small-cell attacks are the hardest to disrupt through area operations: they do not require camps, sanctuaries or large logistics. They require inspiration, technical instruction (now available online), weapons precursors (obtainable through criminal markets), and a target of opportunity. Their rise is a direct function of two KP realities: the proliferation of radicalizing content online, and the survival of a "reserve" of ideologically motivated individuals across generations of conflict.

Assessment. Pakistan's counter-measures have focused on targeting and surveillance (cyber units, forensics, CTD) and, residually, on deradicalization. The evidence suggests that the growth of this category is outpacing both. The policy gap is preventative: schools, mental health services, employment, and community-level referral mechanisms are the instruments with the best track record in comparable settings and the weakest presence in KP's toolkit (Chapters 8, 15).

3.7 Cyber Radicalization and Online Recruitment

The ecosystem. Online radicalization in KP operates across three layers: (1) *propaganda production* in Pashto, Urdu and Arabic — TTP media (Umar Media/Studio), ISKP's multilingual units (al-Azaim Foundation and successors), and allied channels distributing battlefield footage, sermons, and "nasheed" content; (2) *distribution and network maintenance* via encrypted platforms (Telegram, WhatsApp, Signal, and invite-only forums), and via normal social media with evasive techniques; and (3) *recruitment funnels* converting consumers into facilitators — technical guidance (IED construction, drone modification), travel facilitation, and money movement.

Pakistani counter-measures. Under the NAP's provisions against terrorist media, Pakistani authorities blocked over 1.3 million URLs for incitement, extremism and hate speech by 2023 (Pakistan Connect 2025). PECA (Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act, 2016, amended 2025) provides a legal basis for prosecutions of online incitement; the KP CTD operates cyber investigation capacity; and the federal government has repeatedly suspended or restricted platforms during crises. Global platform policies and takedowns have removed major channels (including ISKP's main outlets), but the ecosystem regenerates quickly through mirroring and new platforms.

Assessment. Two problems dominate. First, *measurement*: no publicly available, reliable KP-specific baseline for online radicalization exists; blocked-URL counts are output measures, not outcome measures. Second, *legal and rights calibration*: the same legal instruments (PECA, ATA provisions, and the proposed/expanded cybersecurity framework) are used against both genuinely inciting content and legitimate political speech, including that of journalists and activists. This weakens the credibility of counter-radicalization with the very audiences whose trust matters. A defensible policy approach would separate (a) incitement to violence — regulated through transparent, reviewed takedown processes with appeal rights — from (b) dissent, and would invest in Pashto- and Urdu-language counter-narratives produced and promoted by credible local voices rather than state-aligned outlets (Chapter 8).

3.8 Threat Assessment Matrix: District-by-District Analysis of KPK

Method note. District-level classification below draws on incident and fatality data from SATP, CRSS, ACLED and EUAA district analyses, cross-checked against attitudinal evidence. Two cautions apply: (i) official district data are incomplete for 2026 (KP police report 680 attacks for Jan–Sept 2026 across the province; the district distribution of these is not fully public); and (ii) *attacks thwarted* are not uniformly reported, so a quiet district may reflect police success rather than absence of threat. The classification is therefore a synthesis with confidence levels noted.

Patterns. Three structural findings emerge from the district record. First, **the geography of violence has shifted south and east**: whereas the 2008–2015 violence was concentrated in Swat/Malakand and the northern tribal agencies (Bajaur, Mohmand, Khyber), by 2023–2026 the "new" epicentre is the southern belt — North and South Waziristan, Bannu, Lakki Marwat, Kurram, Hangu, Tank, Kohat, Karak and Dera Ismail Khan — with 63 per cent of all KP incidents in Q2 2026 occurring in just Bannu, Lakki Marwat, Kurram and Bajaur (CRSS 2026b). Second, **the districts with the highest violence are not necessarily those with the most militancy, but those with the most unresolved governance issues**: the NMDs and Kurram combine post-merger institutional voids with sectarian and land conflicts. Third, **peripheral districts with no Afghan border (Swat 2026; Kohat 2026; Karak 2026) are being drawn back into violence** through a combination of TTP expansion, factional competition (post-split JuA activity), and demonstrations of reach — a warning that cordon-based containment strategies will be outpaced.

Tier	Districts	Dominant threat	Trend (2024→2026)	Confidence
Tier 1 – Critical	North Waziristan, South Waziristan, Bannu, Lakki Marwat, Kurram, Bannu-adjacent FR areas, Khyber (Tirah/Bara), Bajaur	TTP/HGB/IMP insurgency; sectarian conflict (Kurram); displacement; IEDs & drones	Deteriorating then stabilizing at high level; Bannu/Lakki Marwat/Kurram drive Q2 2026	High
Tier 2 – High	Tank, D.I. Khan, Hangu, Kohat, Karak, Mohmand, Orakzai	TTP infiltration; suicide/VBIED (Kohat 2026); targeted police attacks	Deteriorating sharply (Kohat Police Lines attack; Karak drone attacks)	High

Tier	Districts	Dominant threat	Trend (2024→2026)	Confidence
Tier 3 – Elevated	Peshawar, Mardan, Charsadda, Nowshera, Swat, Lower Dir, Upper Dir, Shangla, Malakand, Swabi	Urban terrorism; targeted killings; extortion; sectarian/Haqqania-type attacks	Mixed: Peshawar stable-ish (4–5% of incidents), Swat worsening (Kabul attack 2026)	Medium-High
Tier 4 – Moderate	Abbottabad, Mansehra, Haripur, Battagram, Torghar, Upper Chitral, Lower Chitral, Buner, Chitral	Spillover; tourism-security nexus; localized incidents	Generally stable; climate hazard dominant vulnerability	Medium

Sectoral risk overlays. (i) *Education and women's schooling*: attacks on schools and threats to girls' education in Swat, Bajaur, Kurram, Mohmand and Khyber, with extended school closures documented in Kurram, Bajaur, Khyber, Mohmand and North Waziristan (EUAA 2026). (ii) *Polio campaigns*: repeated attacks on vaccination teams and escorts (police killed guarding polio workers in Khyber, February 2025), with the campaign doubling as a measure of state reach. (iii) *Airport and aviation focus*: historical concentration on Peshawar and Islamabad (Bacha Khan International Airport was attacked in 2014; the 2024–26 period has seen continued aviation-security concern). (iv) *Chinese and CPEC assets*: repeated attacks on Chinese nationals (the March 2024 Shangla attack killed five Chinese engineers; subsequent attacks in 2024–26 in various provinces) sustain Beijing's security concerns and raise the political cost of insecurity (Chapter 9).

3.9 Emerging and Non-Traditional Security Threats

Climate security. KP is among Pakistan's most climate-exposed regions: the 2022 floods (in which KP was the hardest-hit province), the 2025 monsoon (504 KP deaths, 1.57 million people affected, ~100,000 displaced, Buner and Swat among the worst-hit districts), and a 2026 monsoon season forecast at 22–26 per cent above the previous season's rainfall, with accelerated glacial melt across Pakistan's 7,000+ glaciers raising glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF) risk (UNICEF 2025; WHO 2025; Watchers 2026). Climate hazards interact with security in four ways: (a) disaster-driven displacement creates recruitment and trafficking vulnerability; (b) relief distribution becomes a site of political contestation and capture; (c) the destruction of schools, roads and health facilities erodes state presence precisely where normalization depends on it; and (d) water scarcity — in the Peshawar valley's irrigation systems, in Chitral's mountain streams, and along the Kabul River basin — creates conflict potential over entitlements (Chapter 10).

Water and resource conflict. Beyond climate, KP faces disputes over: canal water and entitlements (notably the Chashma Right Bank Canal project's implications); mining rights in the NMDs, where mineral concessions (in marble, chromite, copper and coal) have generated local contestation and, in some areas, protection rackets; and land disputes — the most common trigger of the Kurram conflict and recurrent in the merged districts and Hazara. Land conflicts are especially important analytically because they convert *governance failures* into *sectarian and tribal violence*.

Pandemic-related instability. COVID-19 (2020–21) simultaneously (a) disrupted schooling (learning loss concentrated among poor and rural students), (b) reduced household income, and (c) weakened border and regulatory enforcement. Its aftermath contributes to the present youth crisis. In a different register, the failure to defeat polio — despite a decades-long campaign— remains a security barometer: attacks on vaccination teams, the killing of police escorts, and community resistance rooted in distrust and conspiracy narratives directly complicate health-security cooperation.

Digital and financial-system threats. State-facilitated biometric and surveillance systems create new vulnerabilities (data protection is weak; surveillance capability may be repurposed against political actors); hawala and crypto-facilitated financing remain hard to monitor; and the coming deployment of AI-based facial recognition in the Safe City project raises questions of oversight and bias (Chapter 7).

Assessment. Non-traditional threats in KP are not side-shows; they are *multipliers* of the same grievances that sustain militancy, and they are the issues on which the state's legitimacy is most visibly tested. A normalization strategy that cannot protect flood victims, deliver vaccination, and adjudicate land cannot win the trust that counter-insurgency requires.

Table 3.1 — Threat actors, capabilities and vulnerabilities (2026)

Actor	Est. strength (order of magnitude)	Primary targets	Key capabilities	Key vulnerabilities
TTP umbrella	5,000–20,000 (wide range of estimates)	Security forces, police, state affiliates, notables	Sustained ops; IEDs; drones; extortion networks; sanctuary	Factional splits (JuA); dependence on Afghanistan; revenue traceability
HGB	Low thousands (est.)	Army/police in N. Waziristan; convoys; anti-militant elders	Local dominance; tribal networks; IEDs	Local tribal opposition; cleared-then-reoccupied areas
IMP	Small (hundreds, est.)	Police complexes; urban targets (Kohat 2026)	Suicide/VBIED; complex assaults	High-profile exposure; intelligence chokepoints
JuA (post-split)	Hundreds (est.)	Security forces; northern districts	IEDs; ambushes; factional rivalry	New organizational phase; competition with TTP

Actor	Est. strength (order of magnitude)	Primary targets	Key capabilities	Key vulnerabilities
ISKP	~2,000–4,000 (in AF/PK space)	Shia, Sufi, minorities, rivals, intelligence	Suicide bombings; sectarian mass casualty	Hostile to Taliban & TTP; limited manpower
LeJ/SSP networks	Not publicly estimable	Shia professionals, congregations	Assassination; IEDs; local cells	Proscribed; leader attrition
Criminal networks	Large, diffuse	Civilians, markets, borders	Smuggling, extortion, KFR, kidnapping	Enforcement pressure; border closure volatility

Table 3.2 — Selected major attacks, October 2025 – September 2026 (verified claims/attributions)

Date	Location	Type	Casualties	Attribution (basis)
26 Oct 2025	Tirah, Orakzai (Haidar Kandao camp)	Armed assault	21 military personnel killed	TTP claimed (GTI 2026)
6 Feb 2026	Islamabad (Shia mosque)	Suicide bombing	31 killed, dozens injured	ISKP (GTI/Diplomat 2026)
17 Feb 2026 (approx.)	Bannu	Attack on security convoy	2 soldiers incl. senior officer killed	Militant (Diplomat 2026a)
7 Mar 2026	Wana, South Waziristan (Rustam Bazaar)	IED	3 police killed; 31 injured	TTP-linked (SATP 2026a)
13 May 2026	Lakki Marwat	VBIED	9 killed (incl. 2 traffic police), 33 injured	TTP claimed (Wikipedia 2026a)
22 Sep 2025 / 2026 cycle	Tirah Valley (Khyber)	Airstrike (state)	≥30 civilians killed (reported)	State operation (Wikipedia 2026d)
2 Aug 2026	Kabal Police Station, Swat	Suicide bombing	17 killed (7 police, 10 civilians), 27 injured	TTP claimed (AIP 2026; Tribune 2026d)
18 Sep 2026	Kohat Police Lines	VBIED + suicide + assault	≥31 killed (16–23 police; 6+ civilians); 100+ injured	IMP (linked to TTP/HGB) claimed (TRT 2026; The Week 2026)

Note: casualty figures for the 2025 Tirah strike and other state operations are contested; the table reports reported figures with attribution noted, not adjudicated.

CHAPTER 4 — ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

Introduction: From Lists to Systems

Root-cause analysis of KP's insecurity too often degenerates into lists: poverty, madrasas, the Afghan war, bad governance, Pashtun marginalization, "foreign hands." Lists are analytically useless because they cannot discriminate among drivers that (a) *create* conflict, (b) *trigger* it, (c) *accelerate* it, and (d) merely *correlate* with it. This chapter advances a four-layer model — **structural conditions, proximate triggers, accelerants, and sustaining mechanisms** — and maps the familiar catalogue of causes into it. The model's analytical payoff appears in the discussion of Kurram, Swat and the NMDs, where the same nominal cause (sectarianism, militancy, tribal conservatism) plays different roles in each layer.

The chapter's central argument is that KP's conflict is best explained by **institutional exclusion operating on an armed, networked periphery, within a geopolitically open borderland**. Grievance provides the *recruitment narrative*; sanctuary and weapons supply the *capability*; war economy and factional politics supply the *duration*; and the absence of a just, resourced, locally legitimate governance offer supplies the *recurrence*.

4.1 Political Marginalization and Governance Deficits

The long exclusion. For seventy years, FATA's residents were excluded from ordinary courts, taxation-as-citizenship, provincial legislation, police protection, and local government. The 25th Amendment ended the legal exclusion; the *practical* exclusion persists in measurable forms: the merged districts have the province's lowest human development indicators (SDPI 2025), the weakest road connectivity, the thinnest health infrastructure, and a judicial presence that remains skeletal (Chapters 5 and 10). Meanwhile, the settled districts of KP have experienced their own variant of exclusion: provincial governments have had limited control over security policy; federal agencies — the military, the Interior Ministry, NACTA — dominate counter-terrorism decision-making; and fiscal autonomy is constrained by the province's dependence on federal transfers and by withheld payments (the war-on-terror dues dispute is a running grievance; CM Afridi publicly cited delays in releasing constitutional dues in 2025–26) (Wikipedia 2026e).

Measuring the governance deficit. Several indicators triangulate. (i) *Local government*: KP held local elections in two phases in 2021–22, but the devolution of powers, funds and functions under the KP Local Government Act has been repeatedly delayed; in the NMDs, local councils remain largely absent, and the promised "transition from Political Agents to Deputy Commissioners" produced an administration with formal authority but no functional capacity to deliver services. (ii) *Justice*: district courts in the NMDs were established belatedly and unevenly; the Peshawar High Court has repeatedly intervened on the non-implementation of merged-district reforms. (iii) *Service delivery*: school closures lasting months in Kurram, Bajaur, Khyber, Mohmand and North Waziristan have been documented; health facilities and their staff are frequently attacked or withdrawn (EUAA 2026). (iv) *Citizen experience*: surveys and journalistic accounts consistently describe a state experienced as predatory (checkpoints, night raids, collective fines) rather than protective — a perception that militants exploit ("the state takes your boys; we give them dignity and a purpose").

The mechanism. Political marginalization does not produce violence directly. It produces *low-cost recruitment, low-information environments, and high legitimacy costs for the state*. Where citizens cannot seek justice, they seek protection; where they cannot seek protection, they accept the protection offered by armed actors, even at a cost. ICG's 2026 report captures the reciprocal dynamic: many KP residents "reject jihadism but also resent the military's heavy-handed tactics," creating a legitimacy space that counter-insurgency cannot enlist and militancy can inhabit (ICG 2026).

4.2 Socio-Economic Deprivation: Poverty, Unemployment and Inequality

The macro trend. KP's poverty rate rose from 28.7 per cent to 35.3 per cent in the FY2024-25 estimates — the second-highest provincial rate after Balochistan's 47 per cent, and well above Punjab's 23.3 per cent (Planning Ministry 2026; Economic Survey 2025-26). National poverty reached 28.9 per cent, and inequality rose to its highest level in 27 years (Gini-equivalent inequality index 32.7 nationally, 29.4 in KP). The drivers identified by the Planning Ministry include IMF-programme fiscal consolidation, energy tariff adjustments, inflation, disaster losses and weak growth — a policy mix that, as the World Bank's provincial estimates also suggest, pressed hardest on the poorer provinces (KP Youth Policy 2026).

Labour market. National unemployment reached 7.1 per cent (5.9 million people) in the FY2024-25 estimates, the highest in 21 years; youth unemployment (15–24) is substantially higher, and KP's educated youth are disproportionately affected: PIDE's March 2025 assessment found 31 per cent of educated youth jobless, with women constituting 51 per cent of the unemployed (KP Youth Policy 2026). The scale of the jobs deficit is illustrated by a single statistic: in mid-2025, 866,000 candidates applied for 16,454 teaching vacancies in KP — more than 52 applicants per post. In the NMDs, the combined effect of displacement, destroyed enterprises, and missing banking and market infrastructure means formal employment is

rare and informal work is fragile.

Inequality and spatial disparity. KP's internal inequality is as important as its position relative to other provinces. The Hazara and Peshawar divisions concentrate industry, services and education; the southern districts and NMDs have lower literacy, worse health outcomes and thinner infrastructure. SDPI's district-level Human Development Index series shows KP's overall HDI falling from 0.650 to 0.623 (2019–2023), with only two districts improving on score while 27 declined (SDPI 2025).

Mechanism and caution. The mechanism connecting deprivation to militancy is *relative*, not absolute: it is the combination of rising expectations, unemployable education, and visible inequality — not merely poverty — that produces the "nothing to lose but dignity to gain" recruitment pool. The caution is equally important: **poverty does not make people violent**. Most poor residents of KP never join armed groups; many resist them. The empirical claim this study supports is narrower and defensible: socio-economic deprivation *lowers the cost* of recruitment and *raises the value* of the material benefits (salary, status, protection) that armed groups can offer, particularly for young men in the NMDs and southern belt.

4.3 Educational Deficiencies and the Madrasa Ecosystem

Formal education. KP's literacy rate stands at 51 per cent (with a wide gender gap — 37 per cent female versus 65 per cent male), below the national 60 per cent and Punjab's 66 per cent (Economic Survey 2024-25; KP Government 2024). The province has the second-highest number of out-of-school children, and learning outcomes are weak even among enrolled students. In the NMDs the disparities are stark: only 37 per cent of girls attend primary school and ~5 per cent reach secondary level (KP Youth Policy 2026). School infrastructure gaps, teacher absenteeism, insecurity-driven closures, and cultural constraints on girls' education interact.

The madrasa ecosystem. Pakistan's madrasa sector is estimated at roughly 30,000–35,000 institutions (with counts varying by registration method), teaching between two and four million students, with the largest concentrations in Punjab, KP and the former FATA. The sector is organized into five umbrella *wafaq* boards (Wafaq-ul-Madaris Al-Arabia — Deobandi; Tanzeem-ul-Madaris — Barelvi; Wafaq-ul-Madaris Al-Salafia — Ahl-e-Hadith; Rabita-tul-Madaris — Shia; and Ittehad Tanzeemat-ul-Madaris — a coordinating body) plus thousands of unaffiliated institutions. In KP and the tribal belt, madrasas have historically performed three functions: (i) free education and boarding for poor families (a genuine welfare function); (ii) ideological formation, including for jihadist networks; and (iii) social mobility where state education is absent or weak.

The regulation saga. Pakistan's attempts to regulate the sector have a specific and illuminating history: the 2019 agreement under which madrasas registered with the Ministry of Education (with roughly 18,000 registering) was reversed in October 2024, when the JUI-F secured legislation (the Societies Registration (Amendment) Act) allowing madrasas to register as charitable societies under a colonial-era law with minimal oversight of curricula, funding or foreign students (NYT 2025; Adaamir 2024). President Zardari raised international-compliance concerns (FATF); the government proposed re-registration under the education ministry; and the Ittehad Tanzeemat-e-Madaris has demanded gazette notification of the 2024 law. In early 2026, Punjab reached an agreement with the wafaq boards on *online* registration with the provincial charity commission — a model KP has not replicated at scale (The Nation 2026b). The practical result: after two decades of declared intent, a substantial share of madrasas in KP operate outside effective oversight of funding, curricula or foreign students.

Assessment. The evidence does not support the crude claim that madrasas are terrorist nurseries. It supports three more precise claims: (a) a subset of madrasas has historically provided recruitment, ideological socialization and logistics for armed groups (the Haqqania and Kandahar-circle lineages being the best-known examples, as well as the TNSM network in Malakand); (b) unregulated madrasas receiving foreign funding and enrolling foreign students present specific risks (Chapter 9); and (c) the *opportunity cost* of an education system that produces neither employable skills nor critical literacy is a structural driver of vulnerability to radicalization, regardless of institution type. Regulation without financing and quality reform will remain a paper exercise; conversely, a serious reform offer — curriculum modernization plus teacher training plus a transition path for graduates plus facility funding — is one of the highest-leverage interventions available (Chapters 8, 15).

4.4 Tribal Social Structures, Honour Codes and Conflict Resolution Traditions

Social organization. Pashtun social structure in the frontier belt — *qawm* (descent-and-solidarity group), *jirga* (assembly), *melmastia* (hospitality), *nanawatai* (asylum/refuge-seeking), *badal* (reciprocal justice/vendetta), *ghairat* (honour), *tor* (customary law applied through the jirga) — supplied both the governance system that the colonial state chose to work through and the conflict-resolution system that communities relied on when the state was absent (Ahmed 1983; Barth 1959; Banerjee 2000).

The double-edged legacies. These institutions are neither inherently violent nor inherently peaceful; they are conflict-management technologies with known pathologies. On the constructive side: jirgas have repeatedly ended violent cycles (the 2011 Kurram truce after ~2,000 deaths; the 2025 14-point agreement; Bajaur's tribal jirgas disavowing shelter to militants in 2025; the Tirah tribal committees negotiating return corridors). On the destructive side: (a) customary *riwaj* (custom) has been used to legitimize collective punishment, forced marriage and the exclusion of women from inheritance; (b) the honour/vendetta complex provides escalation structures that sectarian and militant entrepreneurs can *capture* — the Kurram conflict is the paradigmatic case; (c) jirga verdicts cannot be enforced without state backing and therefore fail against armed actors; and (d) the merger's dismantling of the malik system removed intermediaries who, whatever their faults, had brokered between state and society.

The Malik and intermediaries: decline and consequences. The malik system — state-supported tribal notables — was systematically destroyed by the militants between 2005 and 2014 (thousands of maliks and elders were assassinated or driven out; the 2008–2013 period saw the killing of prominent tribal leaders across the NMDs, including attacks on jirga meetings that killed dozens) and then sidelined by the merger's abolition of the Political Agent's patronage structures. The result is an *intermediary vacuum*: old intermediaries discredited or dead; elected local representatives (where they exist) without fiscal or police authority; and new "peace committee" figures who are vulnerable and often unelected. The vacuum is filled by the militants' own intermediaries (the local commanders, "spokesmen", and tax collectors) and by vigilante figures. Rebuilding legitimate intermediaries — through elected local government with real budgets, plus credible, protected elder representation in dispute resolution — is a core requirement of normalization that policy has not yet embraced (Chapter 15).

4.5 Religious Extremism and Ideological Radicalization

Theological-political lineages. KP and the tribal belt host several distinct radical traditions that are often conflated in policy discourse: (i) *Deobandi-jihadist* networks (the Haqqania/Peshawar *jihadi* milieu; TNSM; TTP's ideological core), which draw on a scholarly tradition that has also produced anti-militant clerics; (ii) *Salafi-jihadist* currents (ISKP and its local sympathizers, historically concentrated in Bajaur, Mohmand and parts of Kurram), ideologically hostile to Deobandis and Sufis; (iii) the *TNSM/Barelvi-jihadi* hybrid of Malakand, whose moral-reform program captured Swat's local grievances; (iv) *sectarian anti-Shia* networks (LeJ/SSP lineages), which overlap with both (i) and (ii); and (v) *apolitical Deobandi and Barelvi conservatism*, which supplies the ecosystem of seminaries, mosques, and moral policing in which radicalization incubates — often without active support for violence.

What actually radicalizes? The KP evidence suggests a *pathway model* with four interacting elements: (a) *grievance narratives* (state violence, humiliation at checkpoints, drone casualties, prison abuse, anti-Muslim foreign policy); (b) *identity and honour* (defence of community, protection of honour, revenge for kin); (c) *network recruitment* (family, madrasa classmates, village commanders, online contacts); and (d) *material incentives* (wages, status, protection, escape from unemployment). Radicalization is socially embedded: recruits generally join networks they already trust. Preventing terrorism therefore depends as much on disrupting *networks* and offering *alternatives* as on defeating ideas in the abstract.

The state's own role. Pakistan's religious policy has been contradictory: it has used religious discourse for state legitimization (laws on blasphemy, the constitutional declaration of Islam as the state religion, and the state's historic sponsorship of jihad in Afghanistan and Kashmir) while periodically attempting to roll back extremism. Critics, including within Pakistani scholarly and human rights communities, argue this inconsistency — employing extremists tactically, then fighting them later — produced the Frankenstein dynamic repeatedly invoked in the literature. This study treats that critique as a *hypothesis about incentives*, supported by specific historical episodes (Kashmir-focused groups' differential treatment; the 2004–2008 deals; Hafiz Gul Bahadur's earlier status as a state-aligned militia), while noting that it does not fully explain the current insurgency's scale and autonomy.

4.6 Historical Grievances and the Legacy of Colonial Frontier Policies

Three colonial legacies are structurally causal.

First, legal dualism. The FCR created two classes of Pakistani citizenship in effect for seven decades. Its structures — collective responsibility, no appeal, punitive demolition, and the Political Agent's fiat — are remembered; the 2024–2026 persistence of FCR-style practices (reported detentions under "40 FCR" joint-liability logic) shows the legacy is not merely memory (Haq 2024; GRR Journal 2024).

Second, the Durand Line's non-recognition. Afghanistan's refusal to accept the boundary (and successive Afghan governments' support, at least rhetorically, for Pashtun self-determination) supplied both a diplomatic irritant and a sanctuary framework. Pakistan's counter-moves — strategic depth, support to Afghan Islamists, and cross-border intervention — embedded KP in the conflict dynamics of a neighbouring state (Chapter 9).

Third, the "good tribal" bargains. Purchased loyalties (allowances, local militias, and tolerance of smuggling) created a frontier political economy whose collapse — when allowances were suspended or when the state tried to disarm militias after 2001 — destabilized precisely the actors the state had relied on. The trajectory of Hafiz Gul Bahadur (from a state-tolerated North Waziristan commander to a principal insurgent) illustrates the pattern of client-to-antagonist conversion.

4.7 Geopolitical Exploitation: Proxy Wars and External Interference

The layers of geopolitics. (i) *The Afghan layer:* the sanctuary granted to the TTP by factions within the Afghan Taliban (and the Taliban's denial of control); the ISKP sanctuary in Afghanistan; and the period 2021–2026 in which Pakistan's leverage over Kabul collapsed (Chapters 2, 9). (ii) *The India layer:* Pakistan's longstanding allegation that India's intelligence services support Baloch and (occasionally) TTP-linked militancy; India's denial; the issue recurs in Pakistani crisis discourse (and was invoked during the 2025 escalation). Independent verification is rare, and this study treats the claim as an allegation contested by the party accused rather than an established fact. (iii) *The Iran layer:* Iranian interests in Shia protection in Kurram and its regional competition with Pakistan over Afghanistan; Zainebiyoun-linked networks in the border belt. (iv) *The China layer:* CPEC's security risk premium; Chinese pressure on Pakistan (and, conversely, Chinese mediation between Islamabad and Kabul in 2026); Chinese interest in mineral development in the NMDs. (v) *The US/global layer:* residual counter-terrorism interests, the post-withdrawal loss of intelligence and ISR support that Pakistan had enjoyed during the Zarb-e-Azb era, the Afghanistan-specific visa and resettlement pipeline, and FATF-linked regulatory pressure.

Mechanism: opportunity, not instruction. The analytically defensible position is that geopolitics chiefly supplies *opportunity structures* — sanctuaries, weapons, funding, diplomatic cover — rather than directly *commanding* KP's conflict. Pakistan's own history of using non-state actors in Afghanistan and Kashmir establishes that the instrument has been used by multiple states in the region; the current insurgency is supplied, however, by a genuinely autonomous domestic-ideological core and by the Afghan sanctuary, not solely by foreign instruction.

4.8 Weak State Writ and Institutional Fragility

The composite problem. A state's ability to provide security depends on the interaction of force, intelligence, justice, revenue and legitimacy. In KP each element is deficient in a distinct way: force is concentrated in the military with police overloaded; intelligence is fragmented (military intelligence; ISI; IB; CTD; district police; Special Branch) and the KP CTD suffers resource and personnel gaps (19 per cent vacancy in sanctioned posts in 2026; equipment shortfalls acknowledged even in official data); justice is slow (ATCs are clogged; 2,273 anti-terror cases pending as of November 2024; 657 death sentences awarded between 2019 and 2022 with no executions during that period, per the NAP review literature); revenue is hostage to federal transfers; and legitimacy is contested by both the PTM-aligned rights movement and religious-political parties (Chapters 7, 11).

Policing the periphery: the NMD's unresolved model. The absorption of the Khasadar and Levies forces into the KP Police (2019 legislation; a force of roughly 28,000 personnel split between ~15,600 Levies and ~12,000–15,000 Khasadars, with figures reported variously) produced an institution with three incompatible inheritances: the Levies' light border-policing doctrine; the Khasadar's communal, unpaid, and locally embedded model; and the KP Police's urban-focused, standardized force structure. The result is documented: inadequate training and equipment; personnel "posted" to the NMDs from the settled districts who are unaccountable to local communities; and local officers without the authority or protection to act. This is the single most specific institutional gap in KP's security architecture (Chapter 7).

The civil-military disconnect. ICG's 2026 report (94 interviews, Sept 2025–Feb 2026) documents that the military conducts counter-insurgency with limited coordination with provincial police; that army commanders shape internal-security policy while the police bear the losses; and that provincial authorities have criticized both the conduct of operations and the withheld resources (ICG 2026; Dawn 2024a). This disconnect is not an accident of personalities; it is structural — the provincial police depend on the province for budget and on the centre for strategy, with no joint command-and-accountability mechanism.

4.9 Ungoverned Spaces and Geographic Terrain

The terrain issue. KP's mountainous border zones — Tirah's high pastures, the Shawal and Razmak ranges, the Bajaur and Mohmand hills, and the Kurram's passes — are not "uninhabited"; they are *thinly governed and seasonally transited*. Militants use escarpment sanctuaries, caves, seasonal pasture routes and cross-border valleys; state forces face mobility, visibility and communications constraints; and the climate (snow, fog) determines the tempo of violence (winter lulls; spring escalations — hence the TTP's "spring offensive" framing).

Ungoverned space is relational. It is more useful to think in terms of a *governance gradient* than a binary. In KP, space grades from fully governed (Peshawar's urban core) to partially governed (southern settled districts, where state presence is

contested at night) to thinly governed (Tirah's upper valleys, south Waziristan's border strips) to non-governed (sanctuary pockets in Afghanistan). Policy must therefore specify the mechanism by which each gradient segment is to be moved — and must not assume that "clearing" a district translates into a governance outcome (Chapter 6).

4.10 The Drug Economy and War-Economy Dynamics

Structure of the war economy. KP's conflict economy has six revenue streams: (i) smuggling and trade diversion (fuel, consumer goods, vehicles, livestock, currency); (ii) extortion and "taxation" of commerce and transport; (iii) narcotics transit and local retail (with links to the broader Afghan opiate and synthetic-drug economy); (iv) mining and natural resource rents (marble, chromite, coal, antimony, and sand/gravel), including illegal mining and the coercion of contractors; (v) kidnapping for ransom and, occasionally, hostage-taking; and (vi) "project rents" — the capture of public works contracts, employment and NGO/government projects in conflict districts. A seventh, less-discussed stream is the revenue from *security contracting itself*: private armed escorts for transport, mining, and development work, and informal taxation by militias and police checkpoints alike.

Greed, grievance and the war economy's true role. The Collier–Hoeffler framework helps explain why the conflict has lasted, not why it began. KP's insurgency did not arise from lootable resources, and its fighters were not principally profit-seekers. But once armed actors are established, the war economy: (a) funds operations more reliably than donations; (b) generates private constituencies for conflict (smugglers, contractors, checkpoint officials, militia commanders) whose interests exist independently of ideology; (c) corrupts the state institutions and private actors with which it interacts (documented in multiple cases of police and customs complicity in smuggling routes); and (d) makes *peace* costly for specific actors — a fact any settlement must confront by providing transition pathways (Chapter 15).

The state's smuggling crackdowns. The 2025–26 anti-smuggling drives (and the creation of provincial and federal task forces; the curbs on "non-customs paid" vehicles and fuel) coincided with — and were partly justified by — the TTP's reliance on smuggling rents. But they also deepened the economic crisis of the border communities, including the tens of thousands who depend on the trade. Normalization policy must be explicit about this trade-off: convert the border economy rather than merely repress it (border markets, legal crossings, tariff-based trade, and employment substitution).

4.11 Identity Politics, Pashtun Nationalism and the PTM Movement

The Pashtun question. Pashtun political identity has been mobilized in three distinct registers since 1947: the *nationalist* register (Pakhtunistan, the ANP and allied parties); the *religious-political* register (JUI-F and Deobandi political networks); and, since 2014, the *rights/human-rights* register of the Pashtun Tahafuz Movement (PTM), which began as the Mahsud Tahafuz Movement (May 2014) demanding de-mining and compensation after Waziristan's operations, and grew into a national movement after its 2018 renaming. The PTM's demands are specific and documented: de-mining; freedom of movement and removal of checkpoints; accountability for extrajudicial killings and enforced disappearances; a truth and reconciliation process; and the release of detainees (PTM 2018; ICG 2022; Aaj 2024).

The ban and its consequences. On 6 October 2024 — days before a scheduled "Pashtun National Jirga" — the federal government proscribed the PTM under Section 11B of the Anti-Terrorism Act, citing "activities prejudicial to peace and security," "anti-national narratives," and "anarchy" (The News 2024; The Hindu 2024; Business Recorder 2024). The KP government then froze its activities; Section 144 was imposed to block a Khyber district gathering; and clashes between police and PTM supporters followed (October 2024). Since then, human rights organizations have documented continuing restrictions on Pashtun civil society, including detentions of PTM-affiliated activists without charge (HRW/Amnesty/HRCF reporting, cited in Countercurrents 2026). Simultaneously, the movement's leadership has faced repeated prosecutions (Ali Wazir, Manzoor Pashteen) and bans on entry (Balochistan's 90-day prohibition in August 2024).

Analytical assessment. The PTM ban is a case study in the counterproductive dynamics of securitization. The movement has, in fact, been non-violent (its signature tactic is the sit-in and the "peace march" preceded by a peace jirga), and its demands — de-mining, accountability for disappearances, safe mobility — overlap with the practical requirements of any normalization strategy. By criminalizing it under the anti-terrorism law, the state: (i) removed a channel for non-violent grievance articulation precisely as the insurgency escalated; (ii) conflated peaceful critics with armed actors, weakening the state's claim to distinguish between them; (iii) alienated parts of the anti-militant constituency whose cooperation the counter-insurgency needs; and (iv) shifted the movement's surviving activism to informal, less accountable forms. The counter-argument — that the movement's rhetoric is inflammatory, that some figures have made irresponsible statements, and that its mobilization intersects with ethnocentric narratives that the TTP also seeks to exploit — has some basis but does not justify terrorism-law proscription of a non-violent movement.

4.12 Intersectionality of Root Causes: A Systems-Thinking Perspective

The four-layer model. Layering the causes produces the study's diagnostic framework:

(1) Structural conditions (make the system vulnerable; change slowly): legal exceptionalism and its legacy; geographic proximity to a collapsing borderland; the absence of industrial employment and formal education quality; sectarian-Muslim communal geography; low state legitimacy; and Pakistan's own use of non-state actors as strategic instruments. **(2) Proximate triggers** (set episodes in motion): operations and their displacement effects; drone strikes; assassinations of elders; land disputes (Kurram); electoral and representational shocks (FATA's representation and its subsequent disappointment); negotiated truces that fail; and the 2021 Afghan regime change. **(3) Accelerants** (increase the scale and speed of violence): the Afghanistan sanctuary; weapons surplus; drone and IED technology diffusion; the Islamic State's provocation and sectarian competition; factional splits (JuA 2026) and umbrella competition; online radicalization; and fiscal shocks (poverty rising 28.7→35.3 per cent in KP). **(4) Sustaining mechanisms** (keep violence going even when causes persist elsewhere): war economy; weak justice; police–military bifurcation; displaced-person grievance; the intermediary vacuum; and the credibility deficit of state promises (merger funding, compensation, return guarantees).

Intersectionality in practice: three mini-cases. In *Kurram*, a structurally old sectarian-land conflict was triggered by a convoy attack, accelerated by armed-group competition and cross-border sanctuary, and sustained by a weak justice system and closed roads. In *Swat*, structural factors were comparatively benign (high literacy, tourism economy), which is why the 2007–2009 insurgency required the TNSM's ideology plus state collapse of presence; the 2025–26 resurgence is driven primarily by the *accelerants* (sanctuary, factional expansion, technology) rather than by revived local structural causes (NSBRI 2026). In *North Waziristan*, all four layers are active simultaneously, which explains why it has been the single most violent district almost continuously since 2004 — and why a military operation alone (Zarb-e-Azb) could not end violence there without the other layers being addressed.

Policy implication. Interventions targeted at a single layer fail predictably. Kinetic operations address triggers but not sustaining mechanisms; development projects address structural conditions but not triggers; deradicalization addresses accelerants in part; and only the simultaneous treatment of all four layers — sequenced by what each can realistically achieve in what time — produces movement toward the normalization thresholds defined in Chapter 1. This is the analytical foundation of the roadmap in Chapter 15.

Table 4.1 — Root causes by layer and evidence strength

Layer	Factor	Evidence	Analytical weight
Structural	Legal exception legacy (FCR); exclusion	Historical record; KPK's HDI/literacy gap; PHC petitions	High
Structural	Poverty, unemployment, youth bulge	Poverty 35.3% (FY25); 31% educated youth jobless	High (conditional)
Structural	Madrasa/education deficits	~18,000 registered pre-2024; reversal post-2024	Medium-High
Structural	Sectarian communal geography	Kurram; Hangu; Parachinar history	High (localized)
Trigger	State operations & displacement	Swat 2009; NWA 2014; Bajaur 2025; Tirah 2025-26	High
Trigger	Land disputes	Kurram 2024-25 agreements; Hazara land disputes	High (local)
Trigger	Elite/elder assassinations	Systematic targeting of maliks 2005-2014	High
Accelerant	Afghan sanctuary	Unscrutinized; 2026 conflict; UNSC reports	Very High
Accelerant	Weapons & technology (drones)	341 drones foiled H1 2026	High
Accelerant	ISKP sectarian provocation	Feb 2026 Islamabad bombing; Kurram	High
Sustaining	War economy (smuggling, extortion)	Documented TTP taxation; border trade dependence	High
Sustaining	Justice failure	2,273 pending ATC cases (Nov 2024)	High
Sustaining	Civil-military disconnect	ICG 2026 (94 interviews)	High
Sustaining	Intermediary vacuum	Malik system collapse; local government absence	High

CHAPTER 5 — THE FATA MERGER AND ITS SECURITY IMPLICATIONS

5.1 Historical Context of FATA's Special Constitutional Status

The Federally Administered Tribal Areas comprised, on the eve of the merger: seven agencies (Bajaur, Mohmand, Khyber, Orakzai, Kurram, North Waziristan and South Waziristan) and six Frontier Regions (FR Peshawar, FR Kohat, FR Bannu, FR D.I. Khan, FR Lakki Marwat and FR Tank), covering 27,220 km² with a population of approximately five million (2017 census). FATA's constitutional status was *sui generis*: governed directly by the federal executive through the Governor of KP as agent to the President; administered by Political Agents; regulated by the Frontier Crimes Regulations 1901 (Article 247 of the 1973 Constitution preserved the arrangement); represented in the National Assembly and Senate but not in the provincial assembly; and excluded from the jurisdiction of the superior judiciary, from ordinary criminal and civil law, and from the federal taxation and development framework in any normal sense.

The institutions of exception. Four institutions defined FATA's political life. (i) *The Political Agent* — combining executive, judicial, revenue and intelligence functions, accountable to the federal government and largely unaccountable to residents. (ii) *The FCR* — permitting collective punishment (including the notorious "40 FCR" joint-liability clause under which entire communities could be fined, blockaded, or have property seized for individual offences); excluding appeal and lawyers' representation; and empowering the Political Agent to order detention and demolition. (iii) *The maliki system* — the network of state-recognized tribal notables receiving allowances and performing brokerage functions (including raising lashkars and providing intelligence), whose fate under militancy would shape the post-merger order. (iv) *The jirga* — recognized as a dispute-resolution and, in practice, criminal-adjudication mechanism, with the state's authority mediated through it. Alongside these sat the *Khasadar* (paid tribal constabulary, locally recruited, lightly armed) and *Levies* (a more regularized frontier force) — forces of the frontier, not of the ordinary citizen.

Consequences of the exception. Empirical assessments of FATA's condition in 2018 were unambiguous. The region had: the lowest literacy rates in Pakistan (with female literacy in the low single digits in parts of the belt); the worst health indicators (few functioning hospitals; high maternal and infant mortality); the fewest kilometres of paved road per capita; minimal electricity; no banking in most areas; and no systems for property registration, which would later bedevil the merger's land and mineral governance. The FCR also produced specific human rights pathologies documented over decades: arbitrary detention, collective punishment, exclusion of women's rights under customary practice, and, in the post-2001 period, the use of FATA as the primary theatre of war (Chapter 6). It is against this baseline that the merger's promises — and its shortfalls — must be judged.

5.2 The FATA Reforms Committee and the Road to the 25th Amendment

The committee. The FATA Reforms Committee, constituted in 2015 and chaired by the Adviser to the Prime Minister on Foreign Affairs, Sartaj Aziz, was mandated to propose a durable governance solution. Its 2016 report presented options — (a) full merger with KP; (b) maintaining the status quo with reform; (c) creating a separate province/administrative unit; (d) phased integration — and recommended: **full merger with KP**, to be implemented over time; the **discontinuation of the FCR**; the extension of the superior judiciary and of provincial services; a **transitional "FATA Development Authority"**; and — decisively for fiscal politics — a **3 per cent share of the National Finance Commission divisible pool** for ten years to bring the region to parity. The committee reported having consulted in depth with more than 3,000 local elders/jirga representatives, with a clear majority favoring merger (FATA Reforms Committee 2016; Dawn 2016).

Political contestation. The reform process was contested across three axes. First, *within the tribal areas*: some elders opposed merger as the loss of a distinctive identity and of the maliki entitlements; youth and reformist networks (later heavily associated with the PTM) supported it as the end of civic exclusion. Second, *between the centre and KP*: the federal government, having administered FATA directly, would transfer both responsibility and cost to Peshawar; KP's government (then PTI-led) supported merger as a historic expansion of the province's territory and representation. Third, *among political parties*: JUI-F, whose networks were strongest in FATA, contested the terms; ANP and PTI competed for credit; and the Pashtun-nationalist current was itself divided.

The 25th Amendment (May 2018). On the committee's recommendation, Parliament enacted the 25th Constitutional Amendment, merging FATA and the Frontier Regions into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa; repealing Article 247; extending the constitution, the superior courts' jurisdiction and provincial law to the merged districts; providing 23 general seats in the KP Assembly (bringing it to 145, of which 16 are reserved seats and 4 for non-Muslims); and guaranteeing representation in the National Assembly (12 NA seats) — a step that also increased KP's share of national legislative seats. The amendment passed with overwhelming cross-party support — a rarity in Pakistan's fractious politics — and was widely celebrated as the

most significant constitutional reform since the 18th Amendment.

The fiscal promise. Attached to the merger through parliamentary resolutions and committee recommendations was the commitment to allocate 3 per cent of the divisible pool — approximately Rs 90–90+ billion annually by some early estimates, rising as revenues grew, and amounting, by later accounting, to a cumulative expectation of roughly Rs 700 billion over the first seven years (The News 2026). This commitment was framed as the *quid pro quo* for integration: without it, the merged districts would remain the poorest in the federation and merger would be a transfer of legal labels rather than of resources.

5.3 The Merger Process: Legal, Administrative and Security Dimensions

Legal transition. The legal extension required: (i) the replacement of the FCR with the ordinary criminal and civil law of KP; (ii) the creation of district courts and prosecution services in the seven districts; (iii) the extension of the KP Police Act 2017 and the absorption of the Levies and Khasadar forces; (iv) the application of provincial revenue, excise, education, health and local government law; and (v) the dismantling of the Political Agent system in favor of Deputy Commissioners — the administrative emblem of the merger.

Administrative transition. Deputy Commissioners replaced Political Agents; "Tribal District" administrations were established; and provincial departments extended (schools, health, agriculture, forests, roads). In practice, transition occurred on a spectrum: Khyber, Bajaur, Mohmand and Kurram continued to host large military/FC deployments and the writ of civilian authority remained thin; the Frontier Regions were absorbed into adjacent settled districts (Peshawar, Kohat, Bannu, D.I. Khan, Lakki Marwat, Tank), creating a patchwork of district boundaries; and the province's *administrative* capacity to supervise seven new districts was limited by finance and by the security environment.

Security transition. The most consequential and least resolved dimension. In June 2019 the KP government promulgated Levies and Khasadar ordinances (subsequently legislated in September 2019), bringing approximately 28,000 personnel of the two forces under police command: the Levies (about 15,673 personnel against 16,053 sanctioned posts before transition) as an "essential service," and the Khasadars — whose legal basis had been executive orders, not statute — brought under police powers. The KP government committed to recruiting about 6,000 additional police for the merged districts (in phases; the first tranche of several hundred posts proposed in 2019), and to establishing district police structures. The transition, however, produced a hybrid: large numbers of locally recruited, lightly trained personnel integrated into a force whose doctrine, discipline and accountability systems were built for settled districts; command from distant district police officers; and local legitimacy deficits because the "new" police were sometimes seen as the old Khasadars under a new label — or, worse, as outsiders. The 2019 legislation itself passed amid opposition protest and Levies/Khasadar demonstrations outside the assembly, an early indicator that personnel were being managed as a *fiscal and employment* problem rather than a security-capability problem.

Representative transition. The first provincial elections in the merged districts (2019, in the 16 NA/23 PK seats) enfranchised the tribal population in provincial politics for the first time. PTI and independent candidates performed strongly; subsequent 2024 general elections confirmed PTI's organizational dominance in the belt. But representation without fiscal authority or local government produced a "seats without services" outcome: MPs and MPAs could advocate, but the administrative and financial machinery to implement remained absent.

5.4 Governance Challenges Post-Merger: Institutional Vacuum and Capacity Gaps

The vacuum. Independent assessments five to eight years after the merger converge on a set of findings. The GRR Journal's 2024 study of post-merger "administrative chaos" concluded that the transformation had been implemented hastily, without adequate planning or capacity-building; that the promised administrative structures remained incomplete; and that "the merger's promises have not been fulfilled, and the new administrative structure still struggles to gain public trust." The ASPIRE-KP symposium (2025–26) found deficient funding and unpreparedness; the failure to post capable personnel; weak coordination between federal and provincial governments; incomplete devolution to local government; and the resurgence of TTP violence aggravating all of the above (GRR Journal 2024; ASPIRE-KP 2025).

Specific governance deficits.

1. **Local government:** The merger's implicit promise of local self-government for the tribal districts was not implemented at scale; the KP Local Government Act's application to the NMDs is partial, and provincial governments have repeatedly deferred local elections and (where elected) local budgets and functions.
2. **Land and minerals:** FATA's customary land tenure and the absence of cadastral records created a legal vacuum; the province's efforts to regularize mining (marble, chromite, coal) generated disputes over who owns and who benefits — with reports of provincial-federal contestation and of interest from foreign investors, including Chinese and (reportedly) US firms, over critical minerals, amid unresolved ownership rules (ResearchGate/GRR assessments 2025–26).

3. **Civil service capacity:** The merged districts are not attractive postings; allowances are limited; security constraints reduce mobility; and provincial departments have filled only a fraction of sanctioned posts.
4. **Revenue:** With no tax base and limited provincial fiscal space, the districts depend on transfers — which are delayed, contested, and shrinking as a share of need.
5. **Coordination:** The federal government retains significant roles (SAFRON; federal PSDP projects; the FC's security role), while the province holds administrative responsibility — producing the "two masters" problem noted in the literature.

The FCR's afterlife. Perhaps the most damaging finding of the post-merger assessments is that FCR-style practices survived the FCR. Reports documented detentions and punishments under the logic of collective responsibility (the "40 FCR" clause) even after the regulation's repeal; and there are credible accounts of punitive demolitions, curfews, and collective fines. This is not legal formalism: a community that experiences the "new" law as the old exception under a different name learns to distrust the merger itself.

5.5 Security Force Transition: From Frontier Corps to Police and Levies

Structure of forces in the merged districts (2026). Four security actors operate: (1) the **Pakistan Army and Frontier Corps (FC North)**, holding border positions, conducting operations, and providing the *de facto* security backbone; (2) the **KP Police**, with district structures, CTD presence and the absorbed Levies/Khasadar personnel; (3) **local militias/peace committees/lashkars**, partially armed and paid, operating with state encouragement in some districts; and (4) **Federal Constabulary**-type units deployed for specific tasks (protests, campaigns, patrols), which suffered 124 killed and 244 injured in 2025 according to the KP CTD's own data.

Capability assessment. Independent and parliamentary assessments identify nine recurring problems: (i) personnel shortfalls against sanctioned strength (with the CTD at roughly 81 per cent of sanctioned posts province-wide in 2026 and the NMD forces worse); (ii) equipment deficits (the official claim that the entire CTD has only nine M4 rifles and eleven night-vision devices — contested, but indicative of the debate over resourcing — was made by a federal coordinator in September 2026); (iii) insufficient training for counter-insurgency roles (police are trained for law-and-order and investigation, not for platoon-level combat); (iv) absence of protected mobility and counter-IED capacity (routine APC losses); (v) delayed salaries/compensation and inadequate life insurance, which undermines morale; (vi) command and control fragmentation (DIGs, DPOs, FC, army sectors); (vii) intelligence-sharing gaps between the military and police (ICG 2026); (viii) the double burden of counter-terrorism and ordinary policing; and (ix) "insider" risk from locally recruited personnel coerced by militants.

The core dilemma. Two models compete. *Model A* (police-led): a well-resourced provincial police, trained, equipped and accountable, assuming primacy in the merged districts with federal paramilitary support at the border — the model implied by the merger's logic and demanded by provincial politicians. *Model B* (military-led): continued army/FC primacy in counter-insurgency, with police relegated to static protection and investigation — the *de facto* status quo (ICG 2026). Each has a coherent rationale; what fails is the *combination* — military primacy without police protection and without a transfer-of-authority pathway. The study's assessment (Chapter 7, Chapter 15) is that a *sequenced Model A*, beginning with protection and intelligence fusion and progressing to police primacy in districts as capability thresholds are met, offers the only pathway consistent with both the merger's promises and counter-insurgency doctrine — but it requires resources currently not committed.

5.6 Judicial System Extension to Merged Districts

What was supposed to happen. The 25th Amendment extended the jurisdiction of the Peshawar High Court and the Supreme Court to the merged districts, abolished the FCR's appellate exclusions, and contemplated the establishment of district courts, prosecution services, and the extension of the KP judicial system.

What happened. The record indicates partial, slow and shallow extension. District and sessions courts were established in the seven districts, but with deficiencies in: physical infrastructure (court buildings, residential accommodation, secure transport); judicial officers (shortfalls, and reluctance to serve in insecure areas); prosecution capacity; police investigation quality (the binding constraint on conviction); legal aid; and family/consumer/anti-corruption jurisdiction. The Anti-Terrorism Act applies, but ATC capacity is province-wide and congested (Chapter 7). Two further complications are specific to the merged districts: (a) the persistence of informal justice (*jirga, riwaj*) both as a service that communities prefer (speed, accessibility, local legitimacy) and as a system that departs from constitutional rights (collective punishment, exclusion of women, coercive enforcement); and (b) the coexistence of *qisas/diyat* and other Islamic-law provisions with statutory law in a context where communities expect the *jirga's* restorative logic. Independent scholarship documents the "skeletal" state of the formal system and the continued functioning of hybrid orders (Haq 2024; GRR Journal 2024).

Why it matters for security. In security terms, the justice gap has three consequences: (i) *impunity* — militants and their facilitators are rarely convicted, so the coercive message of law is weak; (ii) *grievance* — citizens detained under security laws without trial, or fined collectively, feel the state's coercion without its protection; and (iii) *substitution* — communities turn to armed actors or tribal militias for dispute resolution, which entrenches the very structures that sustain conflict (Chapter 4). The Peshawar High Court's sustained attention to merged-district rights litigation (including the NFC shortfall and Sehat Card cases) is one of the few institutional counterweights documented in 2025–26.

5.7 Development and Rehabilitation in Merged Areas

The promise and the balance sheet. At merger, financing for the merged districts was to come through three channels: (i) the **3 per cent divisible-pool commitment** (via the NFC framework), approximately Rs 700 billion cumulatively over the first seven years; (ii) the **Accelerated Implementation Programme (AIP)**; and (iii) annual federal and provincial PSDP allocations. The actual delivery, as documented in a July 2026 account by a former KP finance secretary and in PHC proceedings: **Rs 132 billion delivered against Rs 700 billion expected — a Rs 568 billion shortfall**; no new NFC award since 2010 (the 7th NFC Award predates the merger); a promised National Assembly resolution endorsement (September 2021) of a 3 per cent allocation (which then-CM and others estimated at up to nearly Rs 1 trillion annually in future terms) never implemented; and no provision in the FY2026-27 budget for the roughly Rs 192 billion a year owed. The commitment expires in 2028 (The News 2026; Tribune 2025d; PHC reporting 2025–26).

Consequences for services. The shortfall is directly visible: incomplete health facilities and closures; teacher shortages and school closures (compounded by insecurity-driven closures in Kurram, Bajaur, Khyber, Mohmand and North Waziristan); the suspension of Sehat Card health entitlement coverage for tribal districts at one point (litigated); stalled road and electricity projects; and the inability to fund the ~6,000 new police posts promised. Provincial fiscal stress is compounded by the KP government's claim to withheld federal dues.

The political economy of the shortfall. Two structural causes stand out. First, the **NFC structure**: provincial shares are determined by an award that requires consensus of all provinces, and no province has agreed to fund the merged districts' 3 per cent out of its own share. The commitment therefore functions as an unfunded federal mandate. Second, **budgetary politics**: the federal government's fiscal consolidation under the IMF programme (FY2026-27) constrained discretionary development spending; and in 2026 all provinces reportedly agreed that FBR collection above the previous year's base would accrue to the federation — a formula that further squeezes the merged districts.

Assessment. The fiscal shortfall is the single most damaging failure of the merger, because it converts a promised *peace dividend* into its opposite: a demonstration that state promises are unreliable. It is also the most fixable: the instruments exist (a presidential order under Article 160; a dedicated statutory fund; ring-fenced AIP allocations; a legislated floor for merged-district spending). What is required is political will — and this study treats the fiscal settlement of the merged districts as the central near-term test of normalization seriousness (Chapter 15).

5.8 Community Perceptions and Political Dynamics Post-Merger

Perceptions. The available evidence — academic studies, civil society consultations, and journalistic accounts — indicates a trajectory from *hope* (2018) to *disappointment* (2020–22) to *anger and fear* (2023–26). Survey research in the immediate post-merger period found overwhelming support for merger (one study reported 92 per cent support among educated respondents) alongside pessimism about implementation. Later assessments describe the prevailing view as: legal integration is welcome; economic integration has failed; security has deteriorated; and the state's promises (compensation, jobs, return guarantees) are not credible. ASPIRE-KP's civil-society forum recorded particular frustration with delayed fund disbursement, and the "neglect by the KP government" in ensuring robust governance mechanisms — a criticism that cuts across party lines.

Political dynamics. Three trends are visible. First, PTI's dominance of the merged districts (2019, 2024 elections) gives the belt a distinct political voice — but also places it at the centre of the federal-PTI conflict, with consequences for service delivery and for the tone of security policy. Second, the *malik system*'s collapse left the old patronage politics without an institutional successor; the elected representatives have no local fiscal apparatus; and new intermediary figures (peace-committee chairs, contractors, militia commanders) have emerged in an unregulated fashion. Third, the *youth* cohort (the majority in the NMDs) is simultaneously the most integrationist and the most alienated: it demands rights, mobility, and jobs, and it is the segment most receptive both to rights movements (including the proscribed PTM's earlier mobilizations) and, at the margins, to militancy's offers. The 2026 Tirah displacement episode — 33,800 families registered, return windows negotiated for October 2026, and provincial pushback against federal characterizations of the displacement — illustrates the volatility of the politics of return (Countercurrents 2026; EUAA 2026).

5.9 Cross-Border Security Management Along the Durand Line

The fence and the crossings. Pakistan's border-management program along the KP-facing section of the Durand Line produced: a fence along the great majority of the KP/NMD frontier (largely completed by 2021–23); formal crossing terminals at Torkham, Ghulam Khan and Angoor Adda; and border forts and surveillance systems. The program has documented effects: reduced large-scale infiltration; greater state capacity to detect movement; and increased friction with Afghanistan (whose government rejects the fence and has fired on its construction and on border posts).

Recurrent closure as policy. Border closures — including the prolonged closure of Torkham in 2025 over a border-post dispute, and repeated closures during the 2025–26 hostilities — have become a default instrument. Their costs are borne by border communities: loss of trade and labour income, price spikes, stranded patients and students, and separation of kin. Their security benefits are episodic: the CRSS data showed a measurable decline in attacks after the October 2025 closure, followed by resumption (CRSS 2025b). Closures thus function as a *policy of harm to the population to influence the state*, and their repeated use erodes the border communities' stake in the state.

Assessment. Border management along the Durand Line requires three elements that Pakistan has not yet assembled: (a) *legality and predictability* — a border regime (permits, trade facilities, movement corridors) that is stable and lawful rather than reactive; (b) *intelligence-led interception* rather than blanket closure; and (c) *diplomatic framework* — a modus vivendi with Kabul on border management, acknowledging that Afghanistan's refusal to recognize the line is a durable condition that must be managed, not wished away (Chapter 9).

5.10 Assessment: Has the Merger Contributed to or Complicated Security Normalization?

Verdict. The merger has been *constitutionally successful, administratively partial, fiscally failing and—on security—ambiguous*. Six findings support this assessment.

First, juridical integration is real. Four million-plus citizens gained the protections (in principle), rights and representation they lacked; the superior courts' jurisdiction is a genuine remedy; and the 23-seat provincial allocation altered KP's politics. The merger's counterfactual — the continuation of the FCR under 2026 conditions — is worse.

Second, fiscal non-delivery has converted a promise into a grievance. The Rs 568 billion shortfall is not an accounting detail; it is the difference between an integration narrative and a betrayal narrative in the districts where the insurgency recruits.

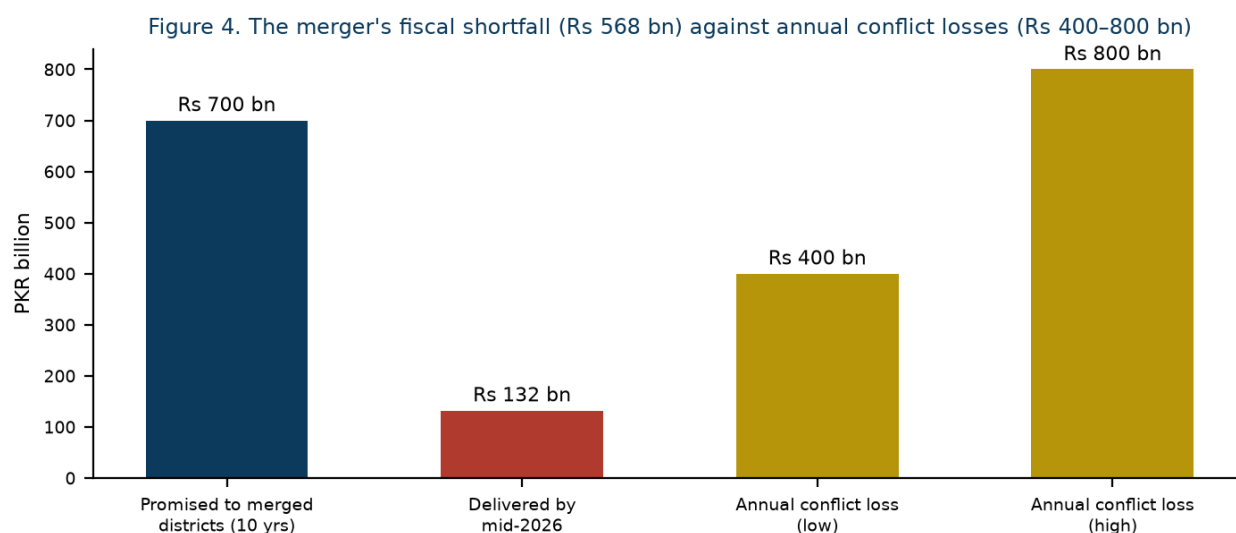


Figure 4. The merger's fiscal shortfall against annual conflict losses. Sources: The News (July 2026); Business Recorder (June 2026); Chapter 10 estimates. See Statistical Annex, Table D.1.

Third, security transition without capability transfer has left the police exposed and unreformed. The merged districts remain *de facto* military-led, while the police absorb casualties without the means to protect themselves — a combination that satisfies neither doctrine nor legitimacy.

Fourth, the justice vacuum has preserved the very practices (collective responsibility, informal enforcement) the merger was meant to end.

Fifth, the merger has complicated the security picture in three specific ways: (i) it created new expectations and new political actors with claims on the state, precisely as violence resurged; (ii) it transferred administrative responsibility without transferring resources; and (iii) it coincided with — and is sometimes blamed for — the TTP's re-infiltration, even

though the causal driver was the Afghan sanctuary (Chapter 9).

Sixth, and most importantly for policy, the merger remains the correct framework. The failures are failures of implementation, not of the design principle. The alternative — reversion to exception, or partial reversion under security cover — would repeat the historical error that produced the insurgency.

Consequent design requirements (developed in Chapter 15): a statutory, ring-fenced merged districts fund with a mandated floor and audit; completion of district court and prosecution capacity with a reform of informal justice that preserves legitimacy; a staged police-capability transfer with protection-first sequencing; local government with budgets; land and mineral regularization with benefit-sharing; and a public, measurable *Normalization Compact* against which progress is reported annually.

CHAPTER 6 — MILITARY OPERATIONS AND COUNTER-TERRORISM CAMPAIGNS

6.1 Overview of Major Military Operations in KPK and FATA (Comprehensive Timeline)

Pakistan's counter-insurgency in KP and the tribal areas has been conducted through an unusually large number of named operations — a fact of analytical significance in itself, since each name implies a distinct campaign and each has often been followed by another within a few years. The following timeline distinguishes *major manoeuvre operations* (division-scale, sustained, displacing populations) from *sector operations* (brigade/battalion-scale, district-specific) and from *standing campaigns* (national frameworks under which operations and intelligence-based raids continue).

Operation	Period	Area	Stated objective	Displacement (est.)
Al Mizan	2002–2006	Waziristan	Clear foreign fighters; dismantle al-Qaeda infrastructure	Localized
Zalzala	2008	South Waziristan (Mehsud areas)	Pressurize Baitullah Mehsud	Tens of thousands
Sherdil	Aug 2008 onward	Bajaur	Break militant control of Bajaur	~200,000–300,000
Rah-e-Haq I & II	Nov 2007; 2008	Swat/Malakand	Clear TNSM/TTP presence	Hundreds of thousands
Rah-e-Rast	May–Jun 2009	Swat, Buner, Dir, Shangla	Defeat insurgency; restore state authority	2–2.5 million
Rah-e-Nijat	Oct–Dec 2009	South Waziristan	Destroy TTP's main base	~300,000+
Brekhnna	2011–12	Mohmand	Clear border sanctuaries	Tens of thousands
Khyber I–III	2014–15	Khyber (Bara, Tirah)	Clear LEI/TTP infrastructure	Hundreds of thousands
Zarb-e-Azb	Jun 2014–Jul 2017	North Waziristan (later others)	Eliminate militant sanctuaries across FATA	~1 million
Khyber IV	Jul–Aug 2017	Rajgal Valley (Khyber)	Seal high-altitude crossing routes	Localized
Radd-ul-Fasaad	Feb 2017–present	Nationwide	Consolidate; dismantle residual networks	Localized
Azm-e-Istehkām	Jun 2024–present	Nationwide (KP/Balochistan focus)	"Reinvigorated" CT campaign; kinetic + diplomatic	Anti-displacement framing
Sarbakaf	Jul–Aug 2025	Bajaur (Lowi Mamund)	Clear re-established TTP presence	~100,000 (relief agencies)
Ghazab-lil-Haq	Feb 2026–present	Afghanistan (cross-border)	Punish/coerce Afghan Taliban over TTP sanctuary	Cross-border refugee flows

Sources: ISPR statements as reported (Dawn, The News, Tribune 2008–2026); Wikipedia operational summaries (2026a, 2026d); Paradigm Shift 2025; CRSS 2025b; UN/OCHA displacement figures as cited.

Analytical observation. The timeline reveals a repeating structural pattern: operations are launched when violence becomes politically intolerable; they achieve temporary clearing; the state consolidates with *some* development spending; violence returns within 4–8 years; and a new operation is named. The pattern is not evidence that force fails, but that force *alone* is a depreciating asset.

6.2 Operation Rah-e-Haq (Swat, 2007–2009): Objectives, Execution and Outcomes

Context. The Swat insurgency developed from the TNSM's moral-reform campaign (2007) into an armed movement controlling much of the valley by 2008, with Maulana Fazlullah's FM broadcasts, attacks on barber shops and music shops, the destruction or closure of hundreds of schools (with a documented campaign against girls' education), beheadings of opponents, and attacks on police. Two earlier operations (Rah-e-Haq I in November 2007 and a follow-on in 2008) failed to restore state control: the forces were too few, the political will fluctuated, and each operation was followed by negotiation — including the February 2009 Nizam-e-Adl Regulation, which conceded Sharia-based adjudication in Malakand in return for peace, and collapsed within weeks as militants expanded into Buner and Dir.

Significance. Rah-e-Haq's failure is instructive for three reasons. First, it demonstrated that *partial operations followed by concessions* signal weakness and accelerate mobilization — the militants' expansion after the February 2009 deal was rapid. Second, it established the pattern of "operation–peace deal–collapse" that recurs in KP's history (Chapter 2). Third, it created the political conditions — the flight of 2 million people, the Buner crisis, the collapse of public tolerance for the TTP — that made a decisive operation possible in May 2009.

6.3 Operation Rah-e-Rast (Swat, 2009): The Liberation of Swat Valley

Execution. Launched in early May 2009 after the collapse of the Nizam-e-Adl arrangement, Rah-e-Rast employed approximately 20,000+ troops (with FC and police support) using artillery, helicopter gunships and airstrikes; the operation cleared Mingora (the valley's capital) within two weeks and continued for months into the valley's periphery and adjoining districts. Approximately 2–2.5 million people fled — the largest displacement in Pakistan since 1947 — into camps in Mardan, Swabi, Charsadda and Peshawar, and into host communities.

Outcomes (assessed). *Military:* the operation broke the TNSM/TTP's territorial control; Swat's insurgency as an organized force was defeated, and many commanders fled to Afghanistan (Kunar/Nuristan), where they remained. *Political:* the operation was accompanied by a consensus parliamentary resolution and was broadly popular in KP — a critical legitimacy asset that enabled subsequent operations. *Human cost:* hundreds of civilians were killed; displacement produced a humanitarian crisis; and there were credible reports of extrajudicial killings and disappearances. *Reconstruction:* the Malakand recovery, though slow at first, eventually produced rebuilt bazaars, roads, and a remarkable restoration of tourism (Chapter 10), and the "Swat model" became internationally studied as a case of counter-insurgency that combined force with governance, albeit imperfectly.

Assessment against doctrine. Rah-e-Rast came closest of any Pakistani operation to population-centric counter-insurgency (Kilcullen 2009; the Walden case study of the campaign finds that governance was deliberately integrated with military action). Its weaknesses were in the *sequencing* of the post-conflict phase: compensation and reconstruction lagged by years; the displaced returned to destroyed infrastructure; and the state did not build institutions capable of preventing re-infiltration across the thirteen years that followed — a failure made manifest in August 2026, when a TTP suicide bomber killed 17 people at a police station in Swat's Kabal area and militants re-entered the valley (Chapter 3).

6.4 Operation Rah-e-Nijat (South Waziristan, 2009): Strategy and Impact

Execution. Following the Swat operation, the army turned to South Waziristan, launching Rah-e-Nijat in mid-October 2009 with roughly 28,000 troops against the Mehsud heartland, supported by FC and air power. The operation dislodged the TTP's central leadership structure from its base area (Baitullah Mehsud had been killed in August 2009; Hakimullah Mehsud relocated), destroyed infrastructure, and displaced several hundred thousand people (Bannu, D.I. Khan and Tank hosting most).

Impact and limits. The military achieved clearing but not holding, in the doctrinal sense: TTP units dispersed into North Waziristan, Orakzai, Kurram, Khyber and Afghanistan; and the pattern of "clear, withdraw, re-infiltrate" was set. The operation also began the construction of the "military-first" model in the tribal areas: FC and army presence in populated areas; curfews and checkpoints; and a dependent local economy — a model whose legitimacy costs would compound over time (ICG 2026).

6.5 Operation Zarb-e-Azb (North Waziristan, 2014): The Game-Changer?

Execution. Launched in June 2014 after the collapse of the peace process with the TTP and the Karachi airport attack, Zarb-e-Azb targeted North Waziristan's sanctuaries — including the Haqqani network's space (a point of significant US–Pakistan friction, since the operation had been demanded for years and its timing was partly a response to US pressure and to the collapse of negotiations) and those of the TTP and foreign fighters. The operation was notable for: pre-operation warnings to civilians; an announced displacement and de-radicalization plan; sustained duration (formally concluded in July 2017 but effectively continuous); and the scale of forces committed.

Outcomes. By official accounts, more than 3,500 militants were killed and hundreds of hideouts destroyed; approximately one million people were displaced (many to Bannu's camps); and the TTP's ability to organize mass-casualty attacks from North Waziristan was substantially degraded. Violence across Pakistan fell markedly in 2015–2018, with 2018–2020 producing the lowest terrorism tolls in over a decade, coinciding with the National Action Plan's instruments (military courts, intelligence operations, counter-financing) and Radd-ul-Fasaad. Militarily, Zarb-e-Azb plus Khyber I–IV was the most consequential campaign in Pakistan's counter-insurgency history.

Limits and critiques. Five are documented. First, the operation *pushed* rather than *captured* much of the adversary: many TTP and allied fighters crossed into Afghanistan (Kunar, Nangarhar, Khost), where a sanctuary was available, a fact of decisive importance after 2021 (Chapter 9). Second, *the presence of the Haqqani network* was not decisively addressed, sustaining the argument that Pakistan's counter-terrorism remained selective. Third, *displacement and reconstruction* were poorly sequenced: TDP returns began in 2015 but housing and compensation continued for years; many never fully recovered. Fourth, *the de-radicalization provision* (the promised centres) was never implemented at scale. Fifth, *the operation had no political component*: no negotiations, no political settlement, no institution-building plan for the districts after clearance — precisely the gap Galula's theory identifies as fatal to counter-insurgency.

Was it a game-changer? For a period of roughly six years (2015–2021), yes: Pakistan experienced its lowest violence in a decade. But the sustainability test — do the gains hold when pressure is released? — was failed: within four years of the American withdrawal, Pakistan had returned to 2015-level violence, with KP absorbing the majority of it. Zarb-e-Azb changed the *scale* of the threat, not its *structure*.

6.6 Operation Radd-ul-Fasaad (2017–Present): Consolidation and Nationwide Approach

Design. Launched on 22 February 2017, Radd-ul-Fasaad ("elimination of discord") was announced as a countrywide operation to consolidate Zarb-e-Azb's gains and eliminate the residual terrorist infrastructure, with an explicit "whole-of-nation" framing: military operations, intelligence-based operations, police and Rangers actions, counter-financing, and a call for public cooperation. Unlike previous campaigns, Radd-ul-Fasaad was not a manoeuvre operation with a defined area and timeline but a standing framework under which operations and IBOs continue.

Outcomes and critiques. The framework's first years coincided with declining violence. However, from 2021 onward the campaign's limits became visible: it had no capacity to address the sanctuary in Afghanistan, no political mechanism for the FATA merger's fiscal delivery, and no answer to the provincial-federal estrangement that followed the 2022 political crisis. Independent assessments conclude that Radd-ul-Fasaad's document-based "whole-of-nation" design was implemented as a *security-forces-first* program, with negligible investment in the soft components (rehabilitation, education, political inclusion) — the mirror image of its design intention.

6.7 Intelligence-Based Operations (IBOs): Precision Strikes and Targeted Operations

What they are. IBOs are small-unit, intelligence-driven raids and strikes against specific individuals, cells and infrastructure, conducted by the military (including special forces and aviation), the FC, and provincial CTDs, often in coordination. Since 2017 they have been the dominant modality of counter-terrorism, and in 2025–26 they constitute the bulk of operational reporting: dozens of engagements per month across the NMDs and southern districts, killing hundreds of militants annually (CRSS data record 392 security operations in 2025 killing 2,060 "outlaws" — the highest since 2015, and 80 operations in Q2 2026 alone killing 453).

Strengths. IBOs: (a) minimize displacement relative to manoeuvre operations; (b) exploit human and technical intelligence; (c) generate a continuous attrition pressure against commanders; and (d) are politically less costly than announced operations.

Weaknesses. (a) *Attrition without endgame:* as 2026 data confirm, killing hundreds of militants per quarter has not reduced attack frequency; the CTD recorded 137 attacks in 2025 despite 320 retaliatory operations and a 50 per cent increase in registered cases; and the third quarter of 2026 saw militant fatalities rise 103 per cent while civilian and security-force deaths rose as well (CRSS 2026c). (b) *Human rights risk:* IBOs conducted with incomplete verification of identity and without judicial process have been associated with civilian casualties, including airstrikes (notably the reported 22 September 2025 Tirah Valley airstrike that killed 30+ civilians, including women and children, and the 13 August 2025 Bajaur mortar incident that killed a woman and her two children). (c) *Local intelligence degradation:* each civilian-harm incident reduces the flow of local intelligence, which IBOs depend upon — a self-limiting dynamic. (d) *Recruitment:* killed militants' funerals and grievances become recruitment events, especially where compensation is absent.

Assessment. IBOs are a necessary instrument, not a strategy. Their effectiveness is conditional on (i) high-fidelity intelligence; (ii) avoidance of civilian harm (both for ethics and for effectiveness); (iii) follow-through in investigation/prosecution; and (iv) political accompaniment. Pakistan's IBO record in 2025–26 satisfies (i) partially, (ii) unevenly, (iii) weakly and (iv) not at all.

6.8 Assessment of Military Effectiveness: Kinetic Success versus Political and Social Outcomes

A seven-criteria framework. The study assesses operations against criteria drawn from counter-insurgency theory and evaluation practice: (1) *Violence reduction* (immediate); (2) *Durability* (measured after 3–5 years); (3) *Territorial control transfer* (to civilian/police authority); (4) *Displacement and recovery*; (5) *Civilian harm and legitimacy*; (6) *Political settlement* (a settlement that addresses the conflict's participants); (7) *Institutional legacy* (security, justice, governance capacity).

Operation	Violence ↓	Durability	Transfer	Recovery	Legitimacy	Political settlement	Institutional legacy
Sherdil (2008)	Partial	Low	No	Poor	Mixed	No	Limited
Rah-e-Rast (2009)	High	Medium (13 yrs)	Partial	Medium–high (Swat's recovery)	Medium	No	Some (police, tourism)

Operation	Violence ↓	Durability	Transfer	Recovery	Legitimacy	Political settlement	Institutional legacy
Rah-e-Nijat (2009)	Medium	Low	Low	Poor	Low–medium	No	Limited
Khyber I–III (2014–15)	High	Low–medium	Low	Poor	Medium	No	Limited
Zarb-e-Azb (2014–17)	High	Medium (6 yrs)	Partial	Medium	Medium	No	Limited–medium
Radd-ul-Fasaad (2017–)	Medium	Low	Partial	n/a	Medium	No	Limited
Sarbakaf (2025)	Local	Not yet assessable	Low	Poor	Low (protests)	No	Negative (grievance)
Azm-e-Istehkam (2024–)	Mixed	Not yet assessable	Low	n/a	Low (KP opposition)	No	Unknown
Ghazab-lil-Haq (2026–)	Negative (retaliation)	n/a	n/a	n/a	Contested	No	Interstate escalation

Findings. First, *the correlation between immediate violence reduction and durability is weak*: the operations with the largest immediate effects (Zarb-e-Azb; Rah-e-Nijat) decayed within a half-decade; the one with the best durability (Rah-e-Rast) benefited from an accompanying governance effort and was anyway overtaken by cross-border re-infiltration. Second, *no operation produced a political settlement* — a striking uniformity that reflects the absence of a negotiating framework with the insurgency that is compatible with the state's constitutional order. Third, *civilian harm and legitimacy were inversely related to outcome quality*. Fourth, *no operation transferred security primacy to a capable civilian institution*, meaning that military gains had no custodian.

Doctrinal reading. Against Galula: Pakistan's campaigns inverted the political-military ratio, treating politics as an announcement rather than a process. Against Kilcullen: the "accidental guerrilla" mechanism — operations converting neutrals into enemies — is visible in the Kurram convoy attack aftermath, Sarbakaf's protests, and the post-2018 deterioration in local intelligence in parts of the NMDs. Against Trinquier: Pakistan has repeatedly practiced a "warfare of reprisal" (collective fines, curfews, demolitions) whose costs fall on the civilians the campaign is meant to protect.

6.9 Civilian Casualties, Human Rights Concerns and Accountability

Data problem. There is no independent, systematic casualty-tracking mechanism for state operations in KP. Available estimates are partial and contested, including: (a) the *South Asia Terrorism Portal's* civilian fatality counts for terrorism (not state operations); (b) *Amnesty International's* statements (June 2025) criticizing rising drone strikes in KP and the failure to protect civilians; (c) *UNAMA's* Afghanistan-side counts for cross-border strikes (764 civilian casualties between 26 January and 31 March 2026; more than 1,100 civilian deaths/injuries by September 2026, including at least 10 killed where most were children in the 1 October 2026 Kunar/Helmand strikes); (d) *Human Rights Watch, Amnesty and HRCP* documentation of enforced disappearances, extrajudicial killings, and restrictions on civil society in KP, including PTM-affiliated activists held without charge in 2025–26; (e) specific incidents documented by local and international media: the 13 August 2025 Bajaur mortar strike (three civilians killed), the 22 September 2025 Tirah airstrike (30+ civilians reported killed), the killing of civilians in the Orakzai/Arandu operations, and allegations surrounding several IBOs. The *absence* of an official casualty registry is itself a policy finding: accountability mechanisms cannot function without data.

Legal and normative issues raised by documented practice. These include: collective punishment (fines on villages; "40 FCR" style measures) contrary to international humanitarian law and Pakistan's own constitutional guarantees post-merger; demolitions of homes and businesses (the November 2025 Surkhab camp demolitions in Balochistan illustrate the practice); prolonged detention without charge; trial of civilians by military courts (the 21st Amendment's military courts and the continuing use of FGCMs for protest-related offences, including against KP residents for the May 2023 episodes, with documented complaints that defendants received no charge sheets or verdict documents and were convicted after appeal deadlines — matters litigated in the Peshawar High Court in 2025); and restrictions on movement and protest. The 27th Amendment (November 2025) further insulated military decision-making from judicial scrutiny (Chapter 11), which will make independent accountability harder.

The strategic cost of unaccountability. Counter-insurgency's most valuable non-lethal currency is intelligence from the population. Accountability failures — and their perception — are therefore not merely normative lapses; they are *operational losses*. This is the empirical content of the ICG's finding that KP residents "reject jihadism but resent the military's heavy-handed tactics" (ICG 2026).

6.10 The Civil–Military Relations Dynamic in Counter-Terrorism

The division of labour (de facto). The military (Army and FC) leads internal-security strategy in the provinces most affected — the National Security Committee, the Army GHQ, corps commands, and the ISPR set policy and conduct operations; the provinces fund police; and the police implement static protection, investigations and casualties. ICG's 2026 report documents three pathologies: (i) *coordination deficits* between military operations and police, including intelligence-sharing gaps that cost lives; (ii) *political externalities*: provincial governments, particularly after 2022, have opposed operations (Azm-e-Istehkam; Sarbakaf), creating a public rift while the police absorb the risk; and (iii) *narrative competition*: federal/military communiqués frame the problem as externally sponsored militancy requiring more force, while provincial statements frame it as the failure of federal policy and the withholding of resources (Wikipedia 2026e; Dawn 2024a; PARADIGM Shift 2025).

Constitutional dimension. The 27th Amendment (passed 11–13 November 2025) formalized a stronger executive-military role: the Chief of Army Staff became Chief of Defence Forces with command over all services, a new National Strategic Command was created, and the top military leadership received lifelong immunity from prosecution, while the Supreme Court's constitutional jurisdiction was transferred to a new executive-appointed Federal Constitutional Court and the Judicial Commission of Pakistan was restructured to give the executive a decisive role (Al Jazeera 2025b; Himal Southasian 2025; TFT 2025). For counter-terrorism governance, the immediate consequences are: (a) reduced judicial oversight of security policy and of military courts; (b) fewer institutional channels for provincial or parliamentary input; and (c) greater reliance on *internal* military accountability mechanisms for operational conduct.

Assessment. Pakistan's counter-terrorism model conflates *command* with *accountability*. A defensible alternative — used by many counter-insurgency campaigns, including in contexts of federalism — is a *joint, published, accountable framework*: a provincial-federal security committee with a legislative mandate, civilian primacy over policing and investigations, military primacy at the border and in manoeuvre, fused intelligence, and public annual reporting (Chapters 7, 15). The current model produces neither civilian ownership nor military accountability, and its legitimacy cost grows with each mass-casualty attack on the police.

6.11 Post-Operation Stabilization: Successes and Failures

Successes. (i) *Swat/Malakand recovery*: infrastructure rebuilding (roads, the Swat Expressway), the restoration of tourism, and the return of schools — the single clearest instance of post-operation normalization in Pakistan. (ii) *Market and transport recovery* in parts of Bajaur, Mohmand and Kurram (interrupted repeatedly by violence). (iii) *Police expansion* with new posts and facilities, the Elite Force and Rapid Response Force, and the Safe City project (Chapter 7). (iv) *Return and rehabilitation programs* in the NMDs (TDP returns from 2015; AIP projects; Sehat Card coverage where funded). (v) *Economic reconnection*: the Peshawar–Torkham corridor's eventual reopening, and CPEC-related infrastructure (Rashakai SEZ).

Failures. (i) *Compensation*: documented delays in payments to the displaced and injured across multiple episodes (Tirah's return package of Rs 10m/killed and Rs 2.5m/injured was reported delayed into 2026; earlier programs were similarly slow). (ii) *De-radicalization at scale*: promised centres and programs were never resourced adequately (Chapter 8). (iii) *Justice and prosecution*: no post-operation justice process; few prosecutions relative to detentions or to incidents. (iv) *Local governance*: local government in the NMDs remains unimplemented in any meaningful fiscal sense. (v) *Institutionalization*: no transition of cleared areas to effective civilian policing; FC/army presence persists indefinitely. (vi) *Political settlement*: none attempted, beyond episodic deals with individual commanders and tribal jirgas.

The stabilization gap. The recurring failure is not the absence of programs but their *architecture*: Pakistan's model finances development through federal programs administered provincially, with no mechanism tying infrastructure and services to the security transition or to local political accountability. International practice suggests a different model: a single stabilization agency with a defined mandate, budget and reporting line; sequenced security-transfer milestones; and community-level accountability (Chapter 13).

6.12 The Question of Sustainability: Can Military Gains Hold Without Political Solutions?

The empirical answer from KP's own record is contained in the operations table above: in every case, gains decayed. The mechanism is now well understood analytically: military operations (a) destroy or displace armed structures but (b) do not resolve the recruitment pool, the sanctuary, the war economy, the justice vacuum, or the political grievance; and (c) they create new grievances through displacement, harm and coercion. When external pressure (ISAF/US presence in Afghanistan; Pakistani force concentrations in FATA) that constrained militancy is removed, the surviving structures regenerate.

Five conditions for sustainability, derived from KP's comparative record:

1. **Denial of sanctuary or a durable cross-border modus vivendi.** Without it, operations in a territorial corner of a networked insurgency merely relocate the conflict.

2. **Transfer of security responsibility to a capable, protected, professionally accountable civilian force**, with a realistic timeline and resourcing (the police problem).
3. **A justice dividend** — visible prosecutions of those who commit atrocities, and relief for those wrongly detained — as the most credible demonstration that the state has ended the conflict.
4. **A fiscal and political settlement with the periphery** (the merger's completion; local government; land and mineral regularization) that changes the terms of the state's relationship with the border belt.
5. **A peace constituency strategy**: education, employment, and protection of the moderates, women, and community leaders who form the social base of normalization.

The unanswered question. Can a military-led campaign *deliver* these conditions? The comparative evidence (Chapters 13) suggests that militaries can deliver conditions 1 and partly 2, but that conditions 3–5 require civilian institutions that KP currently lacks and that the 27th Amendment's centralization of authority may further weaken. The strategic implication is uncomfortable but unavoidable: **without a political process, kinetic operations will continue to produce temporary suppression at rising human and financial cost** — which is precisely the pattern the 2026 data record, with the highest quarterly militant fatality count (921) coexisting with rising civilian and security-force losses.

CHAPTER 7 — LAW ENFORCEMENT, POLICING AND INSTITUTIONAL REFORM

7.1 Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Police: Historical Evolution, Structure and Current Strength

Evolution. The KP Police descends from the colonial frontier constabulary and the Punjab Police model of 1861; it operated for 156 years under the Police Act 1861 (and, in the NMDs, under the extraordinary Levies/Khasadar regime) before the **KP Police Act 2017** provided a modern statutory framework (see §7.2). The force has been reshaped by three shocks: the post-2001 insurgency, which transformed it from a law-and-order force into a counter-insurgency light infantry in all but name; the 2014 Army Public School attack and the National Action Plan, which expanded its counter-terrorism mandate and budgets; and the post-2018 merger, which added seven districts and absorbed 28,000 tribal personnel.

Structure and strength. The KP Police is headed by an Inspector-General (IGP) and organized into regional commands (RPOs) and districts (DPOs), with specialized units including: the **Counter-Terrorism Department (CTD)**; the **Special Branch** (intelligence); the **Elite Force** (roughly 6,000 personnel trained for high-risk operations); the **Frontier Reserve Force (FRF)** (~10,000); the **KP Bureau of Investigation (KPBI)** (~3,000, investigation); the **Tourism Police**; traffic and constabulary units; and the capital-city command in Peshawar (~8,000). Total strength: official statements place the force at approximately 70,000–90,000 personnel (the KP government reported a ratio of one police officer per 291 citizens in 2026); provincial officials have cited ~130,000 sanctioned posts in public debate, indicating a significant vacancy margin. The force's budget for FY2025-26 was reported at **Rs 170 billion — 8.7 per cent of the provincial budget**, up 37 per cent over two years (an additional Rs 46 billion), with ~Rs 17 billion for security development and ~Rs 18 billion for salaries; the government announced plans to raise the allocation to 12 per cent (Tribune 2026a). These figures mark KP as the province devoting the largest *share* of budget to policing — a reflection of need, and a long-standing political claim in Peshawar that the federal government should reimburse the cost of a "front-line province."

The dual mandate problem. A force trained and deployed to fight a militant insurgency struggles to deliver ordinary policing: investigation, prosecution support, dispute response, and protection of the vulnerable. This study's assessment is that KP Police has effectively been converted into a paramilitary constabulary with a policing appendage — an inversion with two consequences: ordinary crime (including extortion, land-grabbing, and organized crime) grows with impunity, and public trust in police as *police* erodes, which in turn reduces cooperation with counter-terrorism.

7.2 The KP Police Reforms (2013–2023): Achievements and Shortcomings

The reform decade. The most consequential reform period followed the 2013 provincial elections, when the PTI-led government appointed a reformist IGP (Nasir Khan Durrani) and pursued a package that included: merit-based recruitment and training reform; new training infrastructure; the establishment of **Public Safety Commissions** and **Complaint Authorities**; the **Dispute Resolution Councils (DRCs)**; welfare and housing improvements; the creation of the **Elite Force** and **Rapid Response Force**; the strengthening of the CTD; and — decisively — the **KP Police Act 2017**, which: (i) gave the IGP a fixed three-year tenure (removable only through defined processes); (ii) established provincial and district public safety commissions to oversee police performance; (iii) created complaint mechanisms against police misconduct; (iv) formalized the police's duties, powers and accountability; and (v) introduced planning and professional standards provisions.

Achievements. Independent commentary and comparative assessments generally credit the reforms with: depoliticizing senior appointments (partially); improving training quality and facility standards; expanding the CTD; introducing community-facing mechanisms (DRCs, complaint cells); professionalizing public communications; and producing a cadre of trained officers whose performance in operations (including the 2026 Kohat clearance, where Elite Force and CTD teams retook the complex) exceeded earlier standards.

Shortcomings. Six are documented. (i) *Implementation gap*: the Public Safety Commissions have functioned unevenly or not at all in several districts; commission membership and activity have been politically contested. (ii) *Command turnover and politicization disputes*: the fixed-tenure provision has been eroded in practice, with frequent IGP changes and provincial-federal friction over appointments and postings; the PML-N's September 2026 "white paper" alleged political influence in police postings and counter-terrorism preparedness failures. (iii) *Resourcing gaps*: despite budget increases, the force remains short of protected mobility, counter-IED equipment, night-vision devices, forensics, and — critically — investigation capacity. (iv) *Welfare deficits*: the shuhada (martyr) compensation and family-support regimes, though improved, have been criticized as slow and uneven. (v) *Investigation quality*: the KPBI's creation notwithstanding, prosecution success remains constrained by weak crime-scene management, forensics, and witness protection. (vi) *NMD integration*: the reform design treated the merged districts as an extension of the settled-district model rather than as a distinct policing environment (see §7.5).

Assessment. The KP Police Act 2017 remains the legal foundation of any future reform and is, by regional standards, a progressive instrument. Its fate illustrates a general lesson: *legal reform without fiscal guarantees, personnel protection and political insulation produces partial implementation*. The 2020s' reform debate has therefore shifted from statute to capacity and protection — with the 2025–26 casualty data making the case unanswerable.

7.3 Counter-Terrorism Department (CTD): Capabilities, Operations and Performance

Origins and mandate. KP's CTD was established in 2010 (following the February 2010 attacks in Peshawar that killed dozens), initially as a specialized investigation and operations unit, with a network of police stations, intelligence wings and interrogation capacity. Under the NAP and subsequent reforms it received expanded budgets, personnel and technology.

Documented performance (2025–26). The CTD's own December 2025 statistics and independent reporting record: attacks on police rising from **327 (2024) to 510 (2025)**; **137 terrorist attacks in 2025** (against 147 in 2024) despite a **50 per cent rise in registered terrorism cases (1,058 → 1,588)**; **320 retaliatory operations** in response to 158 attacks; the arrest of **25 high-value terrorists** with bounties on their heads; and 124 Federal Constabulary personnel killed with 244 injured. In 2026, the CTD has been central to responses to the Swat and Kohat attacks, the disruption of drone networks (including the foiling of 341 drone attacks in H1), and multiple IBOs.

Capability assessment. The CTD's strengths are: dedicated personnel with operational experience; a functioning intelligence wing with informant networks; integration with IBO planning; and the legal authority (ATA, 1997) to detain, interrogate and prosecute. Its weaknesses, documented by official data and independent criticism, are: (i) *personnel shortfall* (3,844 sanctioned posts against 3,113 deployed — a 19 per cent gap; 638 field-operator recruitments incomplete as of mid-2026); (ii) *equipment shortfalls* (Rs 7.77 billion approved for equipment against Rs 7.05 billion released by June 2026; the claim that the entire province has only nine M4 rifles and eleven night-vision devices, advanced by a federal coordinator in September 2026, marked the low estimate of a contested but revealing debate); (iii) *investigation and prosecution quality* (conviction rates remain low; cases collapse on evidentiary grounds); (iv) *fragmentation* with the military intelligence architecture (Chapter 6); and (v) *human rights risk* — allegations of extrajudicial actions, of torture during interrogation, and of detention without charge have been documented by HRCP and international organizations.

7.4 Rapid Response Force and Elite Force: Specialized Units Assessment

The **Elite Force** (est. 2014, ~6,000 personnel) and the **Rapid Response Force / Frontier Reserve Force** constitute KP's specialized tactical capability, trained (in significant part) by the military and equipped with limited armoured and heavy weapons. Their performance in complex attacks — most visibly the September 2026 Kohat Police Lines clearance, conducted by Elite Force commandos and CTD teams with military QRF support — demonstrates genuine capability. Their limitations: (i) coverage breadth (specialized units cannot garrison the province; most police stations remain vulnerable to platoon-strength assault); (ii) dependence on military support for sustained combat; (iii) counter-IED and anti-drone capability gaps exposed by 2026 attacks (the Karak quadcopter attacks targeted three police facilities); and (iv) force protection deficits at static sites (APCs and checkpoints remain the most common casualties). A capability audit — never published — would be the logical precondition of investment decisions, but no such public audit exists.

7.5 Levies and Khasadar Forces in Merged Districts: Integration and Challenges

The transition. As detailed in Chapter 5, the Levies (~15,673 personnel) and Khasadar forces were brought under KP Police command by ordinances/legislation in 2019, with a combined strength of approximately 28,000. The transition's problems fall into four categories.

First, doctrinal mismatch. Levies were border constabulary; Khasadars were a communal guard force with minimal training; KP Police are a settled-district force governed by the Police Act. Integrating the first two into the third without designing a *purpose-built NMD policing model* produced a hybrid: local personnel without police powers' confidence; settled-district officers without local knowledge; and neither with the equipment or training to confront TTP units.

Second, personnel issues. Khasadars' regularization, pensions, and grade fitment generated grievances and protests; many personnel remain uncertain of their status years after the merger. The number of new police posts created (~3,550 province-wide, including NMDs; with promises of 6,000+ initially) remains inadequate to the threat.

Third, local legitimacy. In parts of the NMDs, police are viewed as (a) predators (checkpoint extortion), (b) outsiders (settled-district officers), or (c) collaborators with historical abuses. Where communities trust their local force — as in some Bajaur and Kurram pockets — they provide intelligence and refuse shelter to militants; where they do not, they withhold both.

Fourth, vulnerability. Locally recruited officers are susceptible to coercion (threats to families), bribery, and — in some cases — ideological sympathy, particularly where recruitment standards were relaxed to meet quotas.

The model question. Three options exist for NMD policing: (i) continue the hybrid; (ii) build a *constabulary-style NMD force* with community-embedded units, tribal recruitment with vetting, dedicated training, and provincial oversight; or (iii) return policing functions to FC/paramilitary control (rejected by the merger's logic and by provincial politics). This study recommends option (ii) within the KP Police framework — a "NMD Wing" with its own doctrine, training, equipment and community-accountability mechanisms (Chapter 15).

7.6 Intelligence Infrastructure at the Provincial Level

Actors. Provincial intelligence has five components: (i) the KP **Special Branch** (district-level political and security intelligence); (ii) the **CTD intelligence wing** (counter-terrorist targeting); (iii) **district police** informant networks (the most embedded and the most fragile); (iv) federal agencies (IB, ISI, MI) operating in the province; and (v) *military intelligence* via FC/army formations. Coordination occurs through: the **Provincial Apex Committee** (chaired by the Chief Minister, with the Corps Commander); district intelligence coordination committees (the Sarbakaf curfew notification explicitly referenced the district intelligence coordination committee's recommendation); and national-level mechanisms (the National Security Committee; the National Intelligence Coordination Committee established in 2022 per ISPR statements, and NACTA's coordination role).

Fusion or fragmentation? The evidence indicates partial fusion: IBO targeting has improved (IBO volume and precision increased markedly in 2025–26), but the *Kohat Police Lines attack* (September 2026) — a complex, multi-phase operation against a facility housing CTD and Special Branch offices — suggests either intelligence failure, force-protection failure, or both. Structural fragmentation persists: police intelligence is not systematically shared with the FC/army in real time, and vice versa, as ICG (2026) documented across 94 interviews. The provincial police's intelligence priorities (local crime, political intelligence) also compete with counter-terrorism demands.

Recommendations preview. A joint provincial-federal *Counter-Terrorism Fusion Centre* with legal basis (provincial legislation or a federal-provincial MoU), common databases, protective intelligence for police installations, and a clear protocol for local intelligence protection would address the documented gap. The alternative — building parallel provincial intelligence capacity to rival federal agencies — is both unaffordable and politically impossible (Chapter 15).

7.7 Prosecution and Judicial Challenges: Anti-Terrorism Courts and Conviction Rates

Structure. The Anti-Terrorism Act 1997 (as amended, including 2013's post-APS reforms and later amendments) establishes Anti-Terrorism Courts (ATCs) with special procedures: trials in camera, no adjournments beyond limited periods, and the admissibility of certain confessions. KP has a limited number of ATCs relative to its caseload, plus juvenile courts acting under ATA provisions in some cases.

Performance data. Nationally, the NAP review literature records: **657 death sentences awarded between 2019 and 2022 with no executions in that period; 2,273 anti-terror cases pending as of November 2024**; and recurrent concerns about acquittals due to poor investigation. In KP, the case-level record suggests: (i) successful prosecutions are possible (the October 2026 Peshawar ATC conviction of five accused, including a juvenile, for a 2024 Mohmand CTD case, with five-year sentences and fines, and the declaration of five others as absconders); (ii) the charge-to-conviction pipeline is weak (evidentiary failures, witness intimidation, forensic gaps, and the collapse of cases where digital evidence's admissibility is not properly established — a limitation explicitly noted in the Islamabad ATC judgment of August 2026, where defendants were acquitted of terrorism charges for want of proof of intent notwithstanding explosives recoveries); and (iii) appeal delays undermine deterrence.

Structural problems. Six are identified: (a) investigation quality — police lack forensic capacity, crime-scene protocols, and trained investigators (the KPBI's creation was meant to address this, but capacity remains thin); (b) witness protection — no functioning program, so witnesses recant or refuse; (c) judge security and case volume — ATC judges are exposed and overburdened; (d) the *alternative of military courts* — which, while producing convictions, weakens the civilian system's development, raises fair-trial questions, and removes cases from public scrutiny (with documented complaints that defendants received no charge sheets or verdict copies, litigated in the PHC in 2025); (e) *legal-aid scarcity*; and (f) *preventive detention practice* (detention without charge as a substitute for prosecution) which is both legally dubious and counterproductive.

Post-27th Amendment environment. The 27th Amendment's restructuring (the Federal Constitutional Court; reduced Supreme Court constitutional jurisdiction; executive dominance of the Judicial Commission) has implications for the *appeal architecture* of terrorism convictions and for judicial oversight of security agencies. Whether this strengthens or weakens counter-terrorism's legitimacy in KP is a live question; the early evidence — two Supreme Court justices resigning in protest and warning of the judiciary's subordination — suggests the change is being read by informed publics as a politicization of justice (Al Jazeera 2025b; Himal Southasian 2025).

7.8 Community Policing and Police–Public Trust

Instruments. KP has deployed a distinctive set of community-facing mechanisms: **Dispute Resolution Councils (DRCs)**, composed of local notables and retired officials, which mediate civil and criminal disputes outside the courts (KP's DRC network has been widely cited, including in international policing literature, as one of Pakistan's most successful community-policing experiments); **Public Safety Commissions** at provincial and district levels; **peace committees** in the NMDs (often encouraged and partially funded by the military); **Terrorism-Free District/Community** initiatives; and school and youth outreach.

Performance and constraints. The DRCs do real work — resolving thousands of disputes, reducing court backlogs, and generating goodwill. But they operate at the margins of the security problem: they cannot adjudicate terrorism, sectarian conflict, or land disputes involving armed actors. Peace committees in the NMDs have been both effective (intelligence, refusing shelter, negotiations with militants) and vulnerable (members assassinated; accused of militia abuses). Two structural constraints limit all community engagement: (i) *the coercion-first environment* — curfews, raids and collective measures undermine the trust that community policing requires; and (ii) *the trust deficit* — documented in the resentment of heavy-handed tactics (ICG 2026) and reinforced by the 2024 PTM ban and accusations of disappearances.

Assessment. Community policing in KP is undervalued and under-resourced relative to its potential. Comparative evidence indicates that police legitimacy is a force multiplier for intelligence and public cooperation (the primary currency of counter-terrorism). A normalization strategy should therefore treat police-community relations as a strategic capability — funded, measured and protected — rather than as public relations (Chapter 15).

7.9 Police Martyrdom and Morale: The Human Cost

The numbers. KP Police has lost **more than 2,000 personnel** since 2006 (contrasting with 369 killed between 1970 and 2006). Recent years: **186 (2023), 153 (2024), 159 (2025); 122 killed and 175 injured in the first half of 2026 alone (+93.7 per cent and +108.3 per cent respectively); attacks on police rose 48 per cent in 2025 (536 attacks) and 33.9 per cent in Jan–Sep 2026 (680 attacks); more than 500 police killed since 2023.** The single deadliest attack was the **30 January 2023 Peshawar Police Lines mosque suicide bombing** (over 100 killed, including ~86 police), while the **September 2026 Kohat attack** was the deadliest assault on a police complex since then. Most recent casualties have occurred in Peshawar, D.I. Khan, Bannu and Lakki Marwat (Chapter 3).

Morale and welfare. Documented morale factors include: compensation delays and adequacy (the provincial shuhada package has been increased repeatedly but processing is slow); the practice of posting personnel to high-risk NMD locations without family accommodation or rotational relief; equipment deficits (the night-vision and rifle claims); and the perception, widely held within the force and articulated by provincial leaders, that the burden of a national counter-insurgency is being borne by a provincial force without commensurate federal financing or operational authority.

Strategic significance. A force suffering a casualty rate of this magnitude faces predictable pathologies: risk aversion (static, defensive postures that concede mobility to militants); corruption (survival and welfare-driven); attrition and recruitment difficulties; and intelligence passivity. Each undermines the counter-insurgency. The 2026 escalation in police casualties is thus not merely a human tragedy; it is a *capability crisis* — and one reason the province's police-focused demands (equipment, federal reimbursement, joint command) are, in security terms, well founded.

7.10 Technology Integration: Safe City Projects, CCTV, Biometrics and Data Analytics

The Peshawar Safe City Project. Conceived in 2008 and inaugurated only on 3–5 March 2026 (after 18 years), the project cost **Rs 2.23 billion** for Phase I: **711 surveillance cameras at 133 key and sensitive locations**; an AI-enabled command-and-control centre integrating surveillance, emergency response and traffic management; facial recognition and automated alerts to patrol units; e-challan capability for traffic offences; a private wireless network; **smart surveillance vehicles, drones, anti-drone systems and 68 panic buttons**; and integration with BRT corridor, Red Zone and other camera networks. Projects in **D.I. Khan, Bannu and Lakki Marwat are nearing completion**, with rollout planned for divisional headquarters and merged districts (post-June 2026), Phase II (~Rs 5 billion) covering **Mardan, Kohat, Nowshera, Swat and Abbottabad**, and a planned extension to six southern districts (D.I. Khan, Bannu, Lakki Marwat, North Waziristan, Tank, Karak). The provincial government intends to legislate a **Safe City Authority** to regulate and integrate surveillance infrastructure.

Other technology. Biometric verification (NADRA-linked SIM and identity systems); vehicle registration/ANPR; the police's digital reporting systems (the KP "Digital Transformation Policy and Roadmap 2030" approved in 2026 includes cybersecurity and e-governance); CTD cyber units; and military surveillance/anti-drone capability along the border.

Assessment. Technology is necessary but not sufficient, for four reasons. First, *coverage*: 711 cameras in a city of ~4 million facing attacks in its periphery and rural districts cannot substitute for human intelligence and patrol capability; Peshawar itself accounts for only ~4–5 per cent of provincial incidents, while the violence is rural and southern. Second, *effectiveness evidence*: there is no published evaluation of Safe City's contribution to interdiction or deterrence. Third, *rights and oversight*: facial recognition without data-protection law, oversight mechanisms, or redress creates a substantial liberty risk that could itself become a source of grievance; and the Safe City Authority, if it concentrates surveillance in executive hands, would compound the 27th Amendment's centralization. Fourth, *protection*: the technology does not protect checkpoints, patrols and static sites where police are dying. A balanced capability portfolio — counter-IED, protected mobility, night-vision, drones/counter-drones, and communications — matters more than an urban camera network for the current threat profile.

7.11 Comparative Analysis: KP Police versus Punjab and Sindh

Budgets and scale. Punjab fields the largest provincial force (with substantially more personnel than KP) and has invested heavily in urban policing technology (the Punjab Safe Cities Authority in Lahore, operational since 2016, was the first and largest such system). Sindh concentrates resources on Karachi, with a large CTD and significant federal/paramilitary support. KP's distinct position is that it spends the largest *budget share* on policing (8.7 per cent, rising to a projected 12 per cent) while facing the highest per-capita casualty rates.

Reform trajectories. Comparative scholarship identifies the KP Police Act 2017 as the most ambitious provincial policing statute in Pakistan (fixed IGP tenure; public safety commissions; complaint mechanisms). Punjab has retained a structure closer to the Police Order 2002 model, with reforms largely executive-driven. Sindh's reform experience has been shaped by urban political competition and by the concentration of its CTD in Karachi.

Counter-terrorism specialization. Punjab's CTD (established in 2017) operates in a lower-threat environment but with better infrastructure; Sindh's CTD is larger and more urban-focused; KP's CTD operates under sustained attack, with the documented deficits of \$7.3. The **federal dimension** is the crucial asymmetry: Punjab and Sindh's security challenges are not framed as an interstate frontier problem, and they do not carry the burden of the frontier's refugee, closure and border-management externalities.

Lessons. Three comparative lessons for KP: (i) *urban technology is not a substitute for rural protection* (Punjab's Safe Cities model does not map onto KP's threat geography); (ii) *statutory reform matters most when it protects tenure, budget and oversight* — KP's Act should be defended, not diluted; and (iii) *federal fiscal rebalancing* is the only way to finance a "front-line province" burden: no provincial budget can simultaneously pay for counter-insurgency and development.

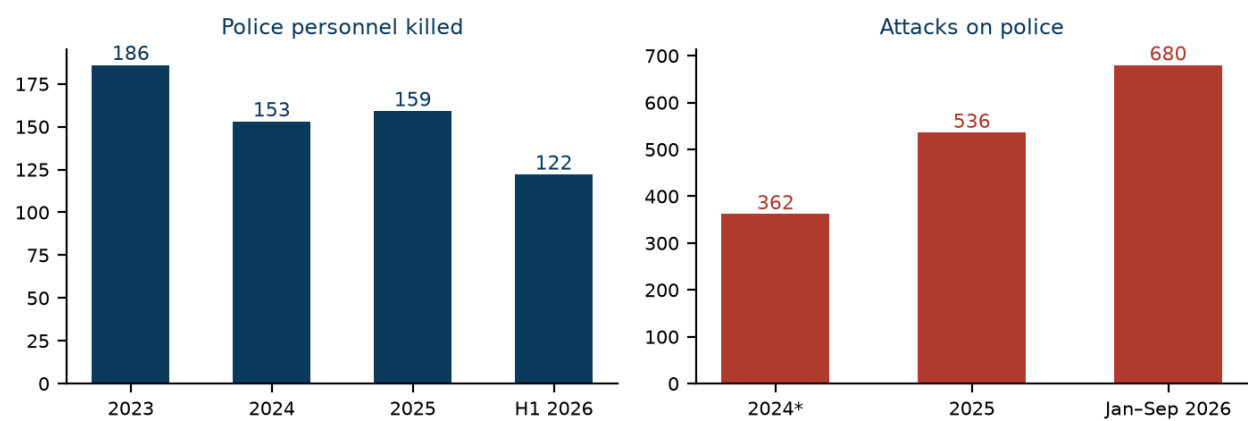
7.12 Recommendations for Deep Institutional Reform

Ten recommendations are advanced here and integrated into the Chapter 15 roadmap:

1. **Adopt a published Five-Year KP Police Protection and Capability Plan** with audited baselines: personnel (against sanctioned strength), protected mobility, counter-IED, night-vision, medical evacuation, and communications; published quarterly to the KP Assembly's relevant committee.
2. **Create a dedicated NMD Policing Wing** with its own doctrine, training academy (in the merged districts), recruitment-and-vetting standards, community-accountability mechanisms, and a staged transfer of primacy from FC/army formations against explicit capability milestones.
3. **Legislate and fund a Police Protection Fund** for shuhada families and injured personnel: guaranteed, timed, transparent compensation; education and employment support for dependents; and a public annual report.
4. **Reinvigorate the Public Safety Commissions** with mandated annual reports, published district performance data (attacks, casualties, complaints, convictions), and civil-society membership criteria insulated from partisan capture.
5. **Establish a Joint Counter-Terrorism Fusion Centre** (military-police-civil, with federal participation) with legal authority, common databases, protection protocols and quarterly public threat summaries.
6. **Rebuild investigation capacity**: a dedicated Counter-Terrorism Investigation Wing with forensics, crime-scene protocols, digital-evidence handling (addressing the admissibility failures documented in 2026 judgments), and a witness-protection law with funded protection units.
7. **Separate the CTD's operational and investigative functions** and professionalize both, with career paths, training exchanges, and a promotions policy tied to case outcomes rather than contacts.
8. **Fund community policing as a capability**: expand and protect DRCs; fund peace committees' welfare and security; and create a police-community liaison cadre (with female officers) in every high-threat district.

- 9. **Adopt a data-protection and surveillance-oversight statute** before the Safe City Authority is created, with independent audit, retention limits, redress mechanisms and transparency reporting.
- 10. **Negotiate a federal security-financing compact:** reimbursement of the provincial security incremental cost (a "frontier burden" transfer), tied to published capability and casualty data — converting the province's fiscal grievance into a transparent, auditable arrangement.

Figure 3. KP police: casualties and attacks, 2023–2026 (official KP data)



*2024 attacks derived from reported +48% change; SATP/CRSS counts differ in scope.

Figure 3. KP police casualties and attacks, 2023–2026. Sources: official KP police data via APP (September 2026); KP CTD (December 2025). See Statistical Annex, Table C.1.

Table 7.1 — KP Police: key indicators (2023–2026)

Indicator	2023	2024	2025	2026 (H1/partial)	Source basis
Police personnel killed	186	153	159	122 (H1)	Official KP data
Police injured	—	—	—	175 (H1)	Official KP data
Attacks on police	—	362 (est. from +48%)	536	680 (Jan–Sep, all attacks)	Official KP/CTD data
Attacks thwarted	—	~177 (est.)	324	—	Official KP data
Registered terrorism cases	—	1,058	1,588	—	KP CTD (Dec 2025)
CTD personnel (sanctioned/deployed)	—	—	—	3,844 / 3,113	PML-N white paper 2026
Police budget (Rs bn / % of provincial budget)	—	~124 (est.)	~170 (8.7%)	Plan: 12%	KP government statements

CHAPTER 8 — DERADICALIZATION, REHABILITATION AND COUNTER-NARRATIVE STRATEGIES

8.1 Understanding Radicalization Pathways in the KP Context

From models to evidence. The global literature on radicalization offers stage models (pre-radicalization, identification, indoctrination, action), social-movement accounts (networks, identity, framing) and structural accounts (relative deprivation, state violence). KP's evidence supports a *relational* model with five empirically observable components:

1. **Exposure and grievance.** The overwhelming majority of KP recruits encountered militancy through family, village, madrasa or workplace networks (not through ideology first). Grievances most frequently cited in interviews and testimonials: deaths or humiliation of relatives in operations; detention and torture; drone strikes; the inability to obtain justice; and material deprivation.
2. **Identity and honour framing.** Recruitment narratives translate private grievances into collective ones (Pashtun honour; defence of Islam; revenge for kin — *badal*).
3. **Network linkage.** Combatants described joining because a relative, teacher, or friend was already involved — the "friend-of-a-friend" mechanism. This is why network disruption and rehabilitation are intertwined; and why surveillance-led prevention fails to address the relational core.
4. **Material incentives.** Income, status, and protection matter, especially for young men in the NMDs and southern belt.
5. **Ideological justification.** Ideology typically consolidates rather than initiates commitment, providing language, rules of conduct, and afterlife promise.

Diversity of pathways. Distinct profiles are documented: child soldiers recruited or handed over by families (the Sabawoon cohort); adolescent volunteers seeking status or acting on peer pressure; adult fighters motivated by revenge or ideology; sectarian recruits drawn through LeJ/SSP or ISKP networks; and, increasingly, self-radicalized online actors (Chapter 3). Programs that do not tailor interventions to profiles will fail at scale.

Gender dimension. Women's roles in KP's conflict are simultaneously under-recognized and analytically important: as victims (targeted violence, widowhood, displacement); as prevention actors (mothers' networks, female teachers and health workers, and women's peace organizations); and, in rare documented cases, as facilitators or recruiters. Ignoring women's roles in either direction produces bad policy — either a protection gap or a security blind spot (Chapter 12).

8.2 Pakistan's Deradicalization Framework: Policy and Institutional Architecture

Policy lineage. Deradicalization entered Pakistan's formal security discourse through the National Action Plan's provisions against extremism and terrorism (including the rehabilitation of willing militants) and the 2021 NAP revision; the National Internal Security Policy and the National Counter-Terrorism Narrative (developed under NACTA) provide the conceptual frame; and the provinces — mandated by NAP to build counter-extremism capacity — established rehabilitation programs. Notably, Pakistan has never adopted a *single national deradicalization policy* with a legal mandate, budget line, standards, and evaluation framework; the practice is a mosaic of military-run, provincial, and NGO programs.

Institutional map.

- **Military-run programs** in Malakand/Swat: **Sabawoon** (juveniles), **Mishal** (adults), **Sparlay** (families of detainees), plus parallel vocational facilities in Swat, Mingora, D.I. Khan and Bajaur; documented predecessors/follow-ons including *Rastoon* and *Pythom*; funding historically from the army with some international support.
- **Provincial programs:** KP's CTD and Home Department manage rehabilitation for detainees and de-radicalization modules in prison settings; the KP government has run (and intermittently funded) vocational training for surrendered militants; the KP cabinet approved reform measures from time to time (including, in 2026, police and digital reforms).
- **Punjab programs:** the Punjab CTD's deradicalization centre (Naway Sehar-type facility) and a pilot program that reported rehabilitating 300 members of proscribed organizations from 15 districts (with a Rs 9.33 million allocation).
- **NACTA:** mandated to coordinate counter-narrative and deradicalization work; has produced the National Narrative document and coordinates counter-financing; capacity has been constrained (its own 2018 report found roughly three-quarters of approved posts unfilled), and it received a new military-appointed head in 2026 (Major-General Faisal Naseer) with a mandate to strengthen coordination (CRSS 2019; TFT 2026).
- **Religious/community instruments:** the **Paigham-e-Pakistan** declaration (January 2018), a fatwa/declaration by a broad assembly of scholars (with 1,800+ signatories claimed) rejecting terrorism and suicide bombing; subsequent anti-militancy statements by wafaq boards; and mosque-level counter-narratives.

- **NGO/CSO programs:** PAIMAN Alumni Trust's mothers' counter-radicalization work; PEAD's peace education; Aware Girls and other women-led organizations; Khwendo Kor and others in KP; with international support (UN Women, EU, USIP, and others) — all chronically under-funded and now constrained by the contracting civic space.

8.3 The Sabawoon Centre: Model, Methodology and Outcomes for Juvenile Militants

Origins and design. Sabawoon ("dawn") was established in Swat in 2009 by the army's humanitarian wing (with a civilian police/psychologist component), in the aftermath of Rah-e-Rast, for *juvenile* detainees who had not committed grave offences and were deemed low-to-medium risk. It became the flagship of Pakistan's rehabilitation effort and is one of the most-studied programs of its kind in South Asia.

Methodology. Four components: (i) *basic education* (literacy, numeracy, and "corrected" religious education including instruction on Islamic pluralism and the illegitimacy of suicide attacks); (ii) *vocational training* (auto mechanics, carpentry, electronics, masonry, poultry/horticulture, computer skills); (iii) *psychological counselling and psychotherapy* (individual and group; addressing trauma and identity); and (iv) *social and family counselling* (family therapy; reintegration planning; monitoring after release). The curriculum explicitly aimed at "de-indoctrination" through engagement with the students' own religious vocabulary and exposure to national/cultural identity markers.

Outcomes. Reported figures: induction of **~226 juveniles across seven batches (2009–2015)**; **~143 reintegrated** after completing programs; officials claim a **99 per cent success rate** with low recidivism; independent academic assessments (NUST's *Journal of Peace and Security*, 2021) found that most reintegrated graduates pursued small businesses, jobs, or further education, while acknowledging **(a) higher-than-claimed risk of recidivism — with 10–15 re-institutionalized on the advice of monitoring teams, and (b) no independent evaluation with access to program data.** A separate journalist-academic field study (2023) could not verify the *Sparlay* centre's existence at all, and documented **difficulties faced by graduates in starting businesses or finding jobs.**

Critical assessment. Sabawoon's design is genuinely strong by international standards — particularly its combination of education, vocational skills, psychosocial care, family work, and post-release monitoring, mirroring the better-regarded international programs (Chapter 8.11). Its weaknesses are equally instructive: (i) *scale* — 226 juveniles over six years is minuscule relative to thousands of detainees and tens of thousands of at-risk youth; (ii) *transparency* — no independent evaluation, no published recidivism study with methodology; (iii) *aftercare deficit* — graduates report no material support, ongoing surveillance, travel restrictions, and community stigmatization; (iv) *the cohort question* — the program's beneficiaries were largely juveniles who surrendered or were lightly implicated, whereas current cohorts include harder cases; and (v) *outcome attribution* — the claimed success may reflect selection (low-risk intake) as much as intervention efficacy.

8.4 The Mishal and Sparlay Centres: Adult Deradicalization Programs

Mishal was designed for *adult* low-risk detainees deemed capable of reintegration, combining religious re-education, vocational training, and psychological support in a residential setting; **Sparlay** was designed for the *families* of detainees (mitigating the secondary radicalization risks and economic pressures that affect combatant households). Documented claims: **Mishal reintegrated approximately 400 individuals**; broader claims place the total number of ex-combatants who passed through the Swat rehabilitation system at **~2,200–2,500**; the KP Provincial Government earmarked funds (Rs 4.4 million in one budget cycle; the de-radicalization pilot received Rs 9.33 million per one account).

Evidence of effectiveness. The published record is thin: program claims are reported by officials; independent studies report graduates' complaints in a consistent pattern — no financial or material start-up support; inability to find jobs; surveillance (graduates described being followed and questioned for travel); a requirement to report to security forces; and community rejection, especially where the community knew the individual's history. The 2023 field study (Journal of Dialogue, Public Knowledge Project) found that *all twelve* graduates interviewed faced difficulties starting enterprises, and reported stigma and monitoring. This is the strongest available independent evidence — and it points to a **reintegration failure** rather than a *re-radicalization* failure: programs may change beliefs, but without economic and social re-entry, the graduates remain a vulnerable population.

Sparlay's fate. The field study's inability to verify Sparlay's existence (despite visiting two centres) suggests either consolidation under other names or quiet discontinuation — a microcosm of the absence of transparency in the sector.

8.5 Madrasa Reform and Regulation: Progress, Resistance and Gaps

The policy record. Pakistan's madrasa regulation efforts have a 25-year lineage: registration drives (2002, 2005), the 2019 framework agreement under which madrasas registered with the Ministry of Education (roughly **18,000 registered**; with commitments to bank accounts, foreign-student regulation, and curriculum goals), and then **reversal**: in October 2024, after

JUI-F pressure, the **Societies Registration (Amendment) Act** allowed madrasas to register under the colonial-era Societies Registration Act as charitable bodies — a framework with minimal oversight of curricula, funding or foreign students. President Zardari objected publicly on FATF-compliance grounds; the government proposed re-registration under the education ministry; the Ittehad Tanzeemat-e-Madaris demanded gazette notification of the 2024 law. Punjab's January 2026 agreement (online registration through the Punjab Charity Commission, negotiated with the wafaq boards) represents a practical alternative model — transparent, consultative, digitized — but it has not been replicated in KP at scale (NYT 2025; Adaamir 2024; The Nation 2026b).

The KP-specific picture. KP hosts one of the densest madrasa networks in Pakistan, including the most politically significant institution (Darul Uloom Haqqania, Akora Khattak, associated with numerous Afghan Taliban leaders, and whose head, Maulana Hamid-ul-Haq Haqqani, was killed in the February 2025 ISKP bombing). Two gaps are salient: (i) *unregistered institutions* — a substantial (though unquantified) share of KP madrasas, especially small village institutions, remain outside any registry; and (ii) *financing* — foreign funding of madrasas was a central FATF-era concern; documentation remains incomplete, and the October 2024 legal change reduced the financial-transparency requirements that the 2019 framework had introduced.

What reform would require. The international and Pakistani evidence converges on five requirements: consultative (not unilateral) design; digitized, low-friction registration; curriculum modernization with religious-authority buy-in; financial transparency (bank accounts, audited sources, foreign student reporting); and *positive* incentives — faculty salaries, facilities, libraries, science labs, and student scholarships — without which regulation is experienced as an assault on the poor's only educational option.

8.6 Counter-Narrative Development: Religious, Cultural and Media-Based Approaches

Instruments. (i) *Religious counter-narratives:* Paigham-e-Pakistan's anti-terror fatwa and its dissemination; wafaq board statements; the Sabawoon curriculum's use of religious reasoning against suicide attacks and for pluralism. (ii) *National Narrative:* NACTA's framework, developed with academic and religious input, positioning the state's struggle against extremism in national and Islamic terms. (iii) *Media and digital:* state counter-terrorism messaging, social-media campaigns, blocking of extremist content (over 1.3 million URLs blocked by 2023); religious programming on state media. (iv) *Cultural counter-narratives:* Pashtun cultural production (poetry, music, TV) reclaiming religious and cultural identity from militant monopolization; memorialization of victims, including the APS tragedy's annual observances.

Effectiveness. Three observations. First, *the state's credibility problem caps counter-narratives:* messaging from institutions perceived as coercive or self-serving is discounted precisely by the audiences at risk. Second, *Pashto-language, locally credible messaging is scarce* — most content is Urdu, urban, and state-framed. Third, *the most effective counter-narrative vehicle is often not messaging at all* but demonstrable state protection and justice — Swat's post-2009 recovery (schools reopened, tourists returned) did more to discredit the TNSM's narrative than any campaign. The policy implication is that counter-narrative work should be *embedded in credible local institutions* (mosques, madrasas, schools, jirgas, radio) rather than centralized in state communications.

8.7 Role of Religious Scholars and Ulema in Countering Extremist Ideology

The anti-militant ulama. A significant body of Pakistani religious opinion has opposed armed militancy: Paigham-e-Pakistan; the Fatwa of the Wafaq-ul-Madaris; statements by Barelvi and Deobandi scholars; and victims' advocacy (the families of APS; the relatives of clerics killed by militants). In KP, the murders of anti-Taliban clerics and tribal elders were systematic in 2005–2014, and the 2025 killing of the Haqqania head — whatever his complex legacy — illustrated that even establishment-aligned clerics are targets.

The limits. (i) *Ambiguity:* some scholars have historically justified jihad in Kashmir/Afghanistan while condemning attacks inside Pakistan — an inconsistent position that militants exploit and that undermines the clarity of the counter-narrative. (ii) *Political instrumentalization:* religious parties (JUI-F most prominently) mediate state-religious relations while maintaining independent positions on operations, madrasa reform and sectarian groups. (iii) *Structural incentives:* madrasa economics — fee-free education and community prestige — create institution-level resistance to curriculum modernization.

Practical recommendation. The state's most credible route to religious counter-narratives runs through *standing, funded partnerships with anti-militant scholars and institutions* — not ad hoc endorsements — including protection for clerics, media platforms for anti-militancy sermons, and inclusion of scholars in deradicalization delivery (as Saudi Arabia and Singapore have done with their credentialed religious authorities).

8.8 Reintegration into Society: Employment, Education and Psychosocial Support

The evidence. As noted, the strongest independent evidence (interviews with twelve graduates, 2023) documents that rehabilitees face: no start-up capital; no job placement; employer reluctance; surveillance and travel restrictions; community stigma; and the psychological burden of untreated trauma. The NUST study found comparatively better outcomes (education continuation, self-employment) for the Sabawoon cohort, with monitoring.

Why reintegration is the decisive phase. Deradicalization literature is consistent: programs succeed or fail at *aftercare*. Individuals who return to unemployment, humiliation and surveillance have strong incentives to rejoin armed networks — not necessarily from renewed belief, but from material and social exclusion. Conversely, employment plus community acceptance (with monitoring that is respectful rather than punitive) is strongly associated with durable disengagement.

Design elements supported by evidence. (i) *Individual reintegration plans* (education, vocational certification, job placement, small-business grants); (ii) *family support* (stipends conditioned on school attendance; the Sparlay concept); (iii) *psychosocial services* (trauma treatment, especially for juveniles; the Sabawoon model); (iv) *protected, time-limited monitoring* with clear exit criteria rather than indefinite surveillance; (v) *community reconciliation* (jirga-mediated acceptance ceremonies; religious endorsement of re-entry); (vi) *employer partnerships* (subsidized apprenticeships; certification); and (vii) *documented release/clearance* so graduates can travel, work and access services without permanent suspicion.

8.9 Women and Youth-Focused Deradicalization Programs

Women. Two distinct program types exist globally and partly in Pakistan: (i) *mothers' programs* (PAIMAN's work with mothers of at-risk and radicalized youth in KP and FATA — among the most cited Pakistani PVE innovations); and (ii) *women's peace networks* (UN Women's Pakistan programme reported engaging **228 Afghan and Pakistani women peace activists** in dialogue processes contributing to cross-border peace discussions, alongside NACTA partnerships on women's leadership in peacebuilding). Women's PVE work benefits from unique access (to households and youth), but is constrained by: security risks, cultural gate-keeping, and funding that is short-term and project-based.

Youth. Youth-focused interventions include: the KP government's skill and employment programs (Youth Impact Challenge grants expanded to Rs 2 billion; the KP Youth Employment Program for IT skills; digital internships); the KP Youth Policy 2026's revision process (which itself documents that female education and employment lag, with only 37 per cent of women literate versus 65 per cent of men and women making up over half of unemployed youth); and the *Peace Education* work of CSOs. The critical gap is *prevention at scale*: school-based critical-thinking curricula, school safety, girls' education protection (from attacks and closures), and mental-health services are all underfunded relative to the risk.

Assessment. Both categories are extremely high-leverage and chronically marginal in Pakistani counter-radicalization spending. The KP Youth Policy's own drafting acknowledges that "youth programmes cannot catch up with demand."

8.10 Community-Based Approaches to Preventing Violent Extremism (PVE)

Practice in KP. A network of Pakistani CSOs operates PVE programs in KP: PAIMAN (mothers' networks, youth dialogues, peace education); PEAD (peace education and community dialogues); Aware Girls (women's empowerment and youth leadership in KP — with its founder subject to travel restrictions and legal harassment in earlier years); Khwendo Kor (women's and girls' development); the Khpal Kor and similar institutions; and district-level peace committees and jirgas (Chapter 12). Government-adjacent efforts include the "Terrorism-Free" district initiatives and, in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa context, peace jirgas and local *aman* committees supported by the administration and army.

What works. The international evidence base on community-based PVE (CVE) points to: locally-led (not externally imposed) programming; credible local voices (religious, tribal, teachers); multi-sector services (education, livelihoods, mental health) rather than messaging alone; addressing state-society grievances as part of prevention; and rigorous evaluation. Pakistan's KP practice aligns with the first three and lacks the fourth and fifth: there are almost no published *outcome evaluations* of Pakistani PVE programs, and civic-space contraction (the PTM ban; restrictions on activists; NOC regimes for NGOs) limits the very actors best positioned to deliver prevention.

Assessment. Community-based PVE in KP is at an inflection point: demand has never been greater (the 2021–26 recruitment environment), the practice is small, and the political space for independent civil society has narrowed. Without a deliberate re-opening of space and sustained financing, the state will be left relying on the least effective prevention instrument — coercion — while the recruitment pipeline continues to refill.

8.11 International Best Practices in Deradicalization

Programme / country	Key design features	Transferable elements for KP
Saudi Arabia — Counseling Programme / Etidal & the Muhammad bin Nayef Center (PRAC)	Credentialed religious authority; family involvement; aftercare with employment and marriage support; deradicalization vs. disengagement distinction	Religious-authority partnership; aftercare contracts (employment, family); clear release status
Singapore — Religious Rehabilitation Group (RRG)	Volunteer scholars, individually tailored religious counselling; community (mosque) ownership; separate aftercare group for families	Islamic-credentialed counselling; mosque-based community ownership; family support group
Denmark — Aarhus model	"SSP" multi-agency approach: police, schools, social services, health; mentoring; exit programs; no criminalization of returnees where legally possible	Multi-agency local teams; mentoring; school and municipal involvement
Nigeria — Operation Safe Corridor (DDR for repentant Boko Haram)	Vocational training, psycho-spiritual counselling, community reintegration, follow-up	Reintegration plus Community Reintegration Committees; documented clearance certificates
Colombia — DDR with FARC (2016)	Individual reintegration plans; income support; transitional justice; truth-telling as social reintegration	Transitional justice link; individual plans; public truth mechanism
Indonesia — deradicalization programs	Government plus religious organizations; individual assessment; family and community	Family-centered programming; religious-organization delivery

Synthesis of design principles. (1) Credible religious authority; (2) individual assessment and tailored plans; (3) family centrality; (4) multi-agency local delivery (police + social services + schools + health); (5) aftercare with real economic content; (6) community acceptance strategies and truth/reconciliation mechanisms where feasible; (7) clear legal status on release; (8) monitoring with exit criteria; and (9) independent evaluation with published results.

8.12 Critical Assessment: Are Pakistan's Deradicalization Programs Working?

What can be established. (a) Pakistan has *models* — the Sabawoon design is sound and internationally recognized; (b) the programs are *small* relative to need (hundreds, not thousands, of beneficiaries, against a recruitment pool of tens of thousands and a caseload of thousands of detainees); (c) the *evidence base is weak* — claims of 99 per cent success rates lack methodological support, and independent research documents reintegration failures and unverifiable claims; (d) *aftercare* is the principal weakness; (e) *geographic coverage* is concentrated in Swat/Malakand, missing the current epicentre (the southern belt and the NMDs), where programs have been initiated only intermittently; (f) *financing* has never been institutionalized in a budget line with accountability; and (g) the legal framework for detention and release of alleged militants creates perverse incentives (indefinite detention vs. premature release without genuine program completion), which deradicalization programs cannot fix from within.

The verdict. Pakistan's deradicalization infrastructure is *promising in design, marginal in scale, unverified in outcome, and misaligned with the current threat geography*. It is not, however, a failure of concept; it is a failure of political commitment and institutional investment. In a counter-insurgency that is demonstrably attrition-limited (Chapter 6), scaling deradicalization, rehabilitation and reentry is not a soft option; it is one of the few instruments that can reduce the enemy's replenishment rate.

Priority recommendations (developed in Chapter 15).

1. Enact a **provincial deradicalization and reintegration statute** establishing a KP Rehabilitation and Reintegration Authority with a legal mandate, defined admission criteria, judicial oversight of detention, published standards, independent evaluation, and a ring-fenced budget.
2. **Relocate and expand capacity to the current threat geography:** centres in Bannu/D.I. Khan and the NMDs (Bajaur, Khyber, North Waziristan), with mobile teams for the southern districts.
3. **Mandate independent evaluation:** a university-led, five-year longitudinal study with published recidivism, employment and psychosocial outcomes (with data-protection safeguards).
4. **Fix aftercare:** grants, apprenticeships, employer partnerships, psychological services, and clear release certification — the single most important determinant of durability.
5. **Employ the families:** expand a Sparlay-type program, with stipends tied to children's schooling and mothers' participation.
6. **Build the counter-narrative base locally:** fund KP-based Pashto-language media, mosque networks, and scholar partnerships; end the conflation of religious conservatism with extremism.
7. **Reform the legal pathway:** create a statutory juvenile-justice and rehabilitation track; end the practice of indefinite preventive detention of juveniles; and link deradicalization completion to judicial release mechanisms.
8. **Reopen civic space for PVE:** a transparent, rights-based NGO registration and NOC regime, and the withdrawal of the PTM proscription in favor of lawful political engagement (Chapter 12).

CHAPTER 9 — GEOPOLITICAL AND CROSS-BORDER DIMENSIONS

9.1 The Afghanistan Factor: Taliban Government, Bilateral Relations and Security Spillover

The structural transformation of 2021. The Taliban's return to Kabul in August 2021 removed the principal external constraint on the TTP — a hostile Afghan government allied to the US-led coalition — and replaced it with an ideological kin government that Pakistan had supported for decades. The TTP's leadership relocated to Afghanistan (Kunar, Nangarhar, Khost, Paktika, Paktia and beyond); its fighters gained freedom of movement, training space, medical care, and access to newly abundant weaponry; and its families gained a sanctuary in which Pakistani pressure could not reach them directly. The International Crisis Group concluded in January 2026 that Pakistan was "the country worst affected by the fall of Kabul" — a striking inversion of Islamabad's expectations (ICG, cited in Wikipedia 2026d).

Bilateral relationship, 2021–2025: from expectation to estrangement. Pakistan's toolkit toward Kabul comprised: diplomatic engagement (repeated delegations, the "Afghan Inter-Ministerial Committee" and special envoys); border closures and trade restrictions (Torkham, Chaman); expulsions of Afghan refugees; and — ultimately — unilateral military action. Each instrument was tried; none produced compliance. The Afghan Taliban's position was consistent: it denies harbouring the TTP and characterizes cross-border attacks as Pakistan's internal problem; it refuses (as a matter of stated principle) to be seen acting against fellow jihadists under foreign pressure; and elements within it — particularly the Haqqani network, whose leaders dominate the Interior Ministry — maintain longstanding ties to the TTP and to Pakistani Taliban factions. Meanwhile, the TTP's own demands (prisoner releases; reversal of merger; compensation for casualties) make any Afghan-mediated deal hard to land.

The escalation ladder to war (October 2025 – February 2026). The sequence is documented: (i) *October 2025*: major cross-border clashes and Pakistani strikes inside Afghanistan, followed by a **Qatari/Turkish-mediated ceasefire (Doha, October 2025)**; (ii) *November 2025: Istanbul talks* produced agreement on a monitoring and verification mechanism — without a political settlement; (iii) *December 2025 – January 2026*: continued (if reduced) cross-border violence; Pakistan's air campaign inside Afghanistan resumed in late 2025 and continued through 2026 (reported strikes in Kabul and the eastern provinces); (iv) *6 February 2026*: the ISKP suicide bombing at an Islamabad imambargah (31 killed) — plus attacks in Bannu and Bajaur during early Ramadan — hardened Islamabad's position; (v) *21–22 February 2026*: cross-border clashes escalated; Pakistan launched airstrikes against alleged TTP/ISKP camps in Afghanistan; (vi) *26 February 2026: Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq* was announced, with the Defence Minister declaring "open war" (Wikipedia 2026a; Dawn 2026g; The Diplomat 2026a; Hindustan Times 2026).

The war (February – October 2026). Both sides deployed air power (Pakistan) and drones, artillery and border assaults (Afghanistan). Contested claims proliferated: Pakistan said it had killed 583 Afghan Taliban personnel, injured 795 and destroyed 242 checkpoints by early March (later figures higher); Afghanistan claimed 55–110 Pakistani soldiers killed and dozens of posts captured; ISPR reported 274 Taliban/terrorists killed for 12 Pakistani troops in the first days (Dawn 2026g; Indian Express 2026; Hindustan Times 2026). Two Eid ceasefires — Eid al-Fitr (19–24 March, at Saudi, Qatari and Turkish request) and a TTP-announced pause over Eid al-Adha (late May) — briefly reduced hostilities; fighting resumed after each. On 24 September 2026, Pakistani strikes hit ten sites in Kandahar, Paktia and Khost; on 1 October 2026 strikes hit Kunar and Helmand, with UNAMA confirming at least 10 civilians killed (mostly children). Cumulatively, UNAMA recorded **764 civilian casualties (372 killed, 392 injured) in Afghanistan between 26 January and 31 March 2026 alone**, and **more than 1,100 civilian deaths and injuries by late September 2026** (UNAMA, cited in Khaama 2026; Dawn 2026g).

Why it matters for KP. The war has four direct effects on the province: (i) *force and attention diversion*: military resources shift to border and cross-border operations; (ii) *militant mobilization*: the TTP exploits the war to frame itself as an anti-state force in a national struggle, and announced its *Operation Khyber* spring offensive on 4 March 2026; (iii) *humanitarian flows*: displacement, return flows and border closures affect KP's border districts; and (iv) *escalation risk*: each cycle of strikes and retaliation hardens both governments' domestic political constraints against de-escalation.

Assessment. The Afghan sanctuary is the single most important *external* variable in KP's security equation, and the 2026 war has demonstrated that force alone cannot close it — Pakistan's airstrikes can punish and disrupt, but they cannot occupy Kunar or compel the Taliban's compliance. Sustained de-escalation would require a *verifiable* arrangement (monitoring, defined commitments on TTP movement/training, incentives such as trade and refugee cooperation), which the Istanbul mechanism attempted and the war destroyed. Rebuilding a credible channel — with regional guarantors — is a strategic necessity, not an act of goodwill.

9.2 The Durand Line: Historical Dispute, Fencing Project and Border Management

The dispute. The Durand Line (demarcated 1893–1896) has never been recognized by any Afghan government as a permanent international boundary. Afghanistan's position — that the line separated Pashtun and Baloch communities without their consent and is therefore void — has persisted through monarchic, republican, communist and Taliban governments. Pakistan's position — that the line is a settled international boundary, whatever its colonial origins — has been consistent since 1947. The dispute has practical consequences: Afghanistan's refusal to accept border posts and fencing as legitimate; periodic firing at construction and at posts; the non-regulation of cross-border movement in Afghan law; and the political costs of any Pakistani concession (which would be framed domestically as capitulation).

Fencing and border management. Pakistan began fencing the Durand Line in 2017 and reported substantial completion (of the KP/NMD-facing sectors and much of the Balochistan frontier) by 2021–2023, coupled with new terminals (Torkham, Ghulam Khan, Angoor Adda and others), border forts, and surveillance systems. Effects: reduced large-scale infiltration and a formalization of crossings; but also: increased friction with Kabul; disruption of traditional cross-border social and economic life (kin mobility, grazing, labour, and trade); and — crucially — a *diversion effect*: infiltration shifted to covert crossings, tunnels, and unfenced or barely monitored stretches, and firing over the fence became a recurring tactic.

Closure as instrument. Since 2021, both sides have repeatedly closed crossings (Torkham in early 2025 over a border-post dispute; Torkham and Ghulam Khan during the 2025 and 2026 hostilities). Closures damage both economies, particularly Afghanistan's (dependent on Pakistani transit) and KP's border districts (trade, transport, labour, and consumer prices).

Assessment. A fenced line without a *border regime* — lawful crossings, permits, trade facilities, dispute mechanisms and a hotline for incidents — is an incomplete solution: it hardens the border's security function while degrading its economic and social functions. The correct objective is not an impermeable seal (unattainable over 2,600 km of mountains) but a *managed border* that denies sanctuary transit while preserving the lawful movement on which border communities depend.

9.3 Afghan Refugees in KPK: Security Implications, Policy Dilemmas and Repatriation

The scale. Afghanistan's displacement crisis and four decades of conflict-related migration produced one of the world's largest protracted refugee situations. Pakistan hosts (by various estimates) 1.5–3.7 million Afghans, including UNHCR-registered Proof of Registration (PoR) holders (~1.3 million), Afghan Citizen Card holders, undocumented migrants, and new arrivals since 2021. **Khyber Pakhtunkhwa hosts the largest share — roughly one-third to one-half of the population of concern**, concentrated in Peshawar, Bannu, Nowshera, Swat, Mardan, Kohat, and camps (Nasir Bagh, Kacha Garhi, Jalozi closure, and others).

The policy trajectory. Phase one (2023–24): the Interior Ministry's **Illegal Foreigners Repatriation Plan (IFRP)** targeted undocumented Afghans from 1 November 2023; hundreds of thousands returned. Phase two (2025): **April 2025** deadlines led to 80,000+ expelled within weeks, with 1.3 million PoR holders (many with decades of residence) told to relocate out of Islamabad/Rawalpindi; UNHCR reported over 910,000 deported since September 2023. Phase three (2026): a **June 2026 review meeting** directed "expedited repatriation/deportation" including visa overstay cases; from **10 July 2026**, any Afghan found without a valid visa was to be arrested immediately; Bannu's camps (Bizan Khel, Ghoriwala, Mamand Khel) were vacated (525 families repatriated in one reported tranche); and KP prepared the "final phase" of repatriation for **~20,000 Afghans in Peshawar city**, with lists compiled by the Special Branch, District Security Branch and police, and Federal Constabulary support (Dawn 2026e; Tribune 2026b; Al Jazeera 2025; HRW 2026; NYT 2025).

Evidence of abuses. Human Rights Watch (April 2026) documented: arrests of Afghans while shopping, at school, or seeking day labour; confiscation of phones and cash; demands for bribes; detention and expulsion of persons at risk in Afghanistan (journalists, human rights defenders, former government officials); the forcible return of at least nine Afghan journalists including some with valid visas (Reporters Without Borders); and the November 2025 Surkhab camp operation in Balochistan in which more than 1,000 people were detained and homes and businesses bulldozed (HRW 2026).

Security arguments and counter-arguments. The security argument: Afghan nationals — including some linked to militant networks, and some in mixed-migration flows that criminals exploit — are present in enormous, poorly documented numbers; identity systems are incomplete; and camps have historically been used as cover (the October 2026 ATC conviction in Peshawar involved an abandoned house in a refugee camp in Mohmand used as a militant safe house). The counter-arguments are equally weighty: (i) the overwhelming majority of Afghans are not combatants, and mass expulsion is a collective measure that violates non-refoulement obligations for at-risk groups and generates profound resentment among the wider Afghan and Pashtun population; (ii) the policy is *substitutionary*: it addresses the population channel (Chapter 3) rather than the sanctuary channel; and (iii) it has been repeatedly shown to correlate with *rising*, not falling, violence in the periods of most intense expulsions.

Assessment. Pakistan has legitimate security, fiscal and demographic interests in a managed Afghan presence. The policy instruments available to serve those interests — registration, biometric documentation, work permits, encampment reform, and case-by-case enforcement against specific threats — are all more effective and lawful than mass arrest-and-expel campaigns. The current trajectory is producing three harms: humanitarian (refoulement); diplomatic (eroding Pakistan's standing and feeding Afghan irredentism); and security (creating grievance, disrupting information flows, and enabling extortion networks within the state apparatus).

9.4 Cross-Border TTP Sanctuaries and the Afghan Taliban's Relationship with the TTP

The relationship's complexity. The Afghan Taliban–TTP relationship is neither sponsorship nor estrangement; it is a set of competing and overlapping interests: (i) *ideological affinity* — shared Deobandi-jihadist lineage, personnel exchanges since the 1990s, and familial ties between borderland communities; (ii) *strategic dependence* — the TTP provided fighters for the Afghan Taliban's war and hosts fighters' families in Afghanistan; (iii) *divergence* — the Afghan Taliban govern a state whose interests now include (a) Pakistani trade, (b) not being attacked, and (c) keeping the TTP from importing Pakistan's war into Afghan politics; (iv) *fragmentation* — the Taliban's internal factions (Kandahar core; Haqqani network; military commissions) differ in their tolerance of the TTP, and some commanders function as intermediaries; and (v) *leverage* — the TTP is useful to Kabul as leverage in negotiations with Pakistan, and dangerous as an autonomous actor.

Practical patterns. Relocation and dispersal: repeated Pakistani requests and Afghan promises have produced some movement (relocations away from the border, shifts between provinces) without dismantling. Mediation attempts: the Afghan Taliban hosted and at times imposed ceasefires (including the November–December 2021 truce) and attempted to broker talks (2021–22). Enforcement: at no point has Kabul moved decisively against TTP infrastructure, and Afghanistan's position publicly treats the TTP as Pakistan's problem.

Options for Pakistan. The realistic set is: (a) *coercive pressure* — cross-border strikes (as in 2026) and economic restrictions — which disrupted but did not dismantle the sanctuary and produced escalation; (b) *conditional engagement* — trading on Afghanistan's dependencies (trade transit, currency, refugees, connectivity) for verifiable actions on specified armed groups; (c) *mediation* — using regional guarantors (China, Qatar, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia) to establish a monitoring mechanism with consequences; and (d) *decoupling* — recognizing that statelessness and fragmentation in Afghanistan mean that even a cooperative Kabul cannot perfectly control the TTP, and building internal defenses (border management, intelligence, deradicalization) accordingly. The study's assessment is that a combination of (b) and (d), with (c) as the process vehicle, is the only durable approach — and that (a) alone has demonstrated a poor cost-benefit record.

9.5 Role of Regional Powers: India, Iran, China, Russia and Central Asian States

India. Pakistan's persistent allegation that Indian intelligence networks support militant activity (principally in Balochistan, and occasionally claimed for KP) remains formally unverified; India denies it. Regardless of the factual dispute, the *strategic dynamic* is real: India–Pakistan tension (the 2019 and 2025 military exchanges, including Operation Sindoor in May 2025) shapes Pakistan's threat perception and force posture; the Taliban's relationship with India (diplomatic and humanitarian engagement post-2021) is read in Islamabad as encirclement; and any Pakistan–India crisis has historically coincided with heightened cross-border pressure in KP and Afghanistan. This study treats Indian involvement in KP's insurgency as *unproven*, while noting that the *perception* of it influences Pakistani policy and that Pakistan's own record of using non-state actors complicates its claims.

Iran. Iran's interests in Afghanistan (water rights, the Helmand basin; Shia and Persian-speaking populations; the Chabahar–India–Central Asia corridor) and its sectarian ties to Pakistan's Shia communities (including in Kurram and Hangu) make it a party to KP's security in ways that are rarely acknowledged. Allegations of Iranian-linked support to Shia militias in Kurram (including Zainebiyoun-linked fighters) and of Iranian involvement in Balochistan are contested; what is documented is Iran's mediation and its hosting of Afghan refugees (returned en masse during 2023–25). Iran's most significant structural impact is the sectarian equilibrium of the borderland: a reciprocal sponsorship dynamic in which each side's sponsorship is cited to justify the other's.

China. China's interests are threefold: CPEC security (including the safety of Chinese nationals — the March 2024 Shangla attack killed five Chinese engineers travelling to a Dasu project in KP, and attacks on Chinese nationals continued in 2024–26); counter-terrorism cooperation (China has supplied drones, surveillance technology and training support, and pressed Pakistan on TTP/ETIM threats); and mediation (China brokered Pakistan–Afghanistan talks in April 2026 and hosted a trilateral process). China also has economic interests in KP: the Rashakai SEZ (with 22 enterprises in progress by 2026, ~Rs 68 billion in planned investment, and ~3,000 expected jobs), the Karakoram Highway realignment, and mineral interest in the merged districts.

Russia and Central Asia. Russia's counter-terrorism concerns (ISKP; Central Asian fighters) have driven pragmatic engagement with the Taliban and with Pakistan; Central Asian states (Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, Kazakhstan) share the ISKP threat and trade interests in a stable Afghanistan (trans-Afghan connectivity: railways, power). Their interest in KP is indirect but real: instability in Pakistan's borderland constrains their trade routes and increases ISKP's reach westward.

9.6 The US Withdrawal from Afghanistan (2021): Impact on KPK Security

Direct effects. (i) *Sanctuary restored:* the withdrawal removed US ISR (intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance) and strike capability that had degraded TTP/AQ leadership after 2001; Pakistan's own later operations operated without that enabler — a factor explicitly noted by analysts contrasting the Zarb-e-Azb environment with the current one (Dawn 2024a). (ii) *Weapons proliferation:* the Afghan National Security Forces' collapse released vast quantities of small arms, night-vision equipment, vehicles and munitions; Pakistan officially estimates USD 7 billion-plus of equipment was abandoned (Eurasia Review 2026a). (iii) *Refugee and migration pressures:* 2021–2022 saw new arrivals and, later, international resettlement pipelines that left thousands stranded in Pakistan when third-country admissions were suspended in 2025. (iv) *Diplomatic vacuum:* no external actor with leverage over the Taliban remains willing to invest in constraining the TTP on Pakistan's behalf, and the US–Pakistan relationship remains transactional (a dynamic visible in the 2026 US statement of support for Pakistan's "right to defend itself" while providing no material support).

Second-order effects. The perception of abandonment in Kabul's neighborhood (including Pakistan's sense that it paid the price for US policy) shaped Pakistan's more unilateral posture in 2025–26; and the lack of international funding for stabilization in the borderlands (contrasting with the AF-PAK era's development dollars) shifted the fiscal burden entirely to Pakistan's own strained budget.

9.7 Intelligence Cooperation and Failures: ISI, NDS/GDI, CIA Dynamics

The triangle. The ISI–CIA relationship (2001–2021) was essential to targeting al-Qaeda and produced the capture of numerous senior figures, but was chronically strained by divergent priorities (Pakistan's focus on India and on Afghanistan's post-settlement order; the US's demands regarding the Haqqani network and sanctuary). The ISI–NDS (Afghan National Directorate of Security) relationship pre-2021 was openly adversarial. Post-2021, the ISI deals with the Taliban's General Directorate of Intelligence (GDI) and military intelligence — counterparts with ideological ties to the adversary (TTP) that Pakistan wants them to act against. The institutional outcome is an intelligence relationship in which Pakistan lacks the leverage that a shared adversary provides.

Documented failures and cooperation. Failures: the TTP leadership's reconstitution post-2021; advance warnings missed for major attacks (including the Kohat Police Lines attack of September 2026, which struck a facility housing CTD and Special Branch offices — suggesting either a critical intelligence gap or a protection failure); and the ISKP's ability to strike inside Islamabad in February 2026. Cooperation: Pakistan's provision (and China's contribution) of intelligence to Kabul regarding ISKP; exchanges with Iran and China; and counter-financing cooperation via NACTA and the FATF context.

Assessment. In the absence of a cooperative Afghan counterpart, intelligence-led operations become the *entire* counter-terrorism strategy — with the self-limiting problems described in Chapter 6 (civilian harm erodes sources; attrition refills ranks). A sustainable approach requires either an intelligence-sharing channel with Kabul (which the 2025 Istanbul mechanism attempted) or a border-management and reconnaissance architecture comprehensive enough to compensate for its absence (which the fence-plus-drone model does not achieve).

9.8 CPEC Security and the Geopolitics of Economic Corridors

CPEC in KP. The China–Pakistan Economic Corridor's western and Hazara alignments pass through KP (Karakoram Highway realignment; the Rashakai SEZ; energy projects; the Swat Expressway's linkage). Estimated investment in KP under CPEC remains modest relative to on-paper commitments; Rashakai's progress (22 enterprises in progress; Rs 68 billion planned investment; the September 2026 inauguration of a mobile-phone manufacturing unit) illustrates both the promise and the slow pace.

Security politics. The security of Chinese nationals (and projects) has become a central domestic political issue and a diplomatic constraint: attacks on Chinese personnel (Dasu in 2021; Shangla in March 2024 killing five engineers; subsequent incidents) have prompted Beijing to demand stronger security guarantees, occasionally linking to demands for joint security arrangements — an unsettling prospect for Pakistani sovereignty. Chinese pressure also contributes to the political economy of operations (analysts have argued the timing of Azm-e-Istehkam reflected, in part, Chinese concerns) and to Pakistan's willingness to escalate against Kabul (Chinese mediation in 2026 notwithstanding).

Assessment. CPEC's security burden in KP is substantial: it requires protection of long linear infrastructure through contested terrain, generates grievance where land acquisition and labour practices are perceived as unfair, and creates

high-value targets. The economic dividend (jobs, connectivity, energy) is real but smaller and slower than promised, and it cannot substitute for the fiscal settlement of the merged districts in producing a peace dividend. Moreover, the geopolitics of corridors means KP's security is now an element of Sino-Pakistani and Sino-Central Asian relations, further reducing Pakistan's freedom of action.

9.9 The Balochistan–KPK Security Nexus

Connections. The two western provinces' insurgencies are distinct (ethno-nationalist and separatist in Balochistan; jihadist and Pashtunist in KP), but they interlock in five ways: (i) *personnel and networks*: TTP factions operate across Balochistan (TTP claimed the Quetta and Ziarat attacks of July 2026, with the BLA claiming the Lasbela attack); the TTP's Baloch reach and BLA's Pashtun recruitment overlap in the border districts; (ii) *logistics*: arms and narcotics routes cross both provinces; (iii) *state response*: Azm-e-Istehkam's national framing, ISPR's aggregated casualty reporting, and the federal claim that "hostile agencies" sponsor both insurgencies; (iv) *politics*: the PTM's Balochistan bans and the Pashtun–Baloch solidarity framing in rights movements; and (v) *data and attention*: in Q3 2026, Balochistan (829 deaths) surpassed KP (556) as Pakistan's most violent region — a shift with national political consequences, including the July 2026 Quetta attacks and the Apex Committee response.

Strategic implication. KP and Balochistan jointly oblige Pakistan's military to fight on two fronts with different adversaries, distinct terrain, and separate political dynamics — a force-allocation reality that has historically produced discontinuous pressure in each province. Resource-constrained strategy should therefore be explicit about acceptable risk in each theatre rather than responding reactively to the latest attack, or the state will continue to oscillate between theatres.

9.10 The Role of International Organizations: UN, NATO, SCO, FATF

United Nations. UN instruments matter to KP through: (i) *Security Council sanctions* (1267 and 1988 regimes; the Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team's assessments, whose 37th report in February 2026 documented increased TTP attacks from Afghanistan); (ii) *UNAMA's civilian-casualty documentation* for the cross-border strikes; (iii) *UN human rights mechanisms* (the High Commissioner's and Special Rapporteur's statements; the Secretary-General's ceasefire appeals during the 2026 war); (iv) *UNHCR and IOM* for refugee and returnee management; and (v) *UN Women and UNODC* for PVE and narcotics programming. The UN's leverage is limited by the absence of enforcement mechanisms in the Afghanistan context and by the politics of the Security Council.

NATO. NATO's role ended with the withdrawal, but its legacy is material (weapons in circulation; the coalition support fund's fiscal dependence; the "Af-Pak" framework's collapse).

SCO. Pakistan's membership (and its hosting of the 2024 SCO summit, during which security was emphasized) provides a platform for counter-terrorism cooperation with China, Russia, and Central Asian states — including the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS). SCO declarations routinely commit members to non-support for terrorism against each other — a commitment relevant to Afghan–Pakistan disputes.

FATF. Pakistan's exit from the FATF grey list (2022) was consequential for its international financial standing and for the seriousness with which it pursued counter-financing and madrasa financial oversight — indeed, FATF compliance pressure was the principal driver of madrasa regulation efforts, and its relaxation (following the 2024 statutory reversal) is a cautionary example of how external pressure can produce both progress and its reversal.

9.11 Geopolitical Scenarios and Their Implications for KPK Security (to 2035)

Scenario A: Regional de-escalation and a verifiable border modus vivendi (low probability, high impact). A Pakistan–Afghanistan agreement (brokered by China/Qatar/Türkiye/Saudi Arabia) with monitoring, prisoner exchanges, and reciprocal limits on cross-border activity; TTP pressure reduced but not eliminated; Pakistan's military returned to internal focus; fiscal space for the merged districts' settlement. Probability: low (15–20 per cent) absent a change in Taliban incentives; consequence for KP: the single largest improvement available.

Scenario B: Managed confrontation (current trajectory). Periodic cross-border strikes and ceasefire cycles; continued insurgency at 2025–26 levels; growing interdependence with China's security interests; gradual erosion of Pakistan's border-region economy and legitimacy. Probability: 45–55 per cent. Consequence: continued high casualties; a slow fiscal and institutional attrition.

Scenario C: Escalatory collapse (interstate war intensifies). Repeated mass-casualty events inside Pakistan (Islamabad/KP) trigger larger strikes; Afghanistan responds with cross-border attacks; border trade collapses; refugee flows reverse; TTP and ISKP both gain from the chaos; the TTP's operational reach expands to central Punjab and Karachi. Probability: 20–25 per cent. Consequence: KP becomes a full war economy with the highest civilian cost in a generation.

Scenario D: Regional realignment (India–Pakistan crisis interlinked). Any major India–Pakistan confrontation pulls Pakistani forces eastward, creates opportunity structures for both TTP and BLA, and produces a two-front crisis. Probability: variable (10–20 per cent for a major crisis). Consequence: severe; force allocation and political attention shift away from KP precisely when it is most fragile.

Scenario E: Taliban internal instability. Factional conflict or succession crisis in Kabul fragments control over TTP sanctuary areas, producing local deals and local chaos — potentially reducing some threats (command fragmentation) while increasing others (uncontrolled zones; ISKP opportunity). Probability: 25–35 per cent over a decade; consequence: unpredictable, possibly regionally serious.

Cross-cutting analysis. In four of the five scenarios, KP's security is determined in large part by decisions taken in Kabul, Islamabad, Beijing, and Doha rather than Peshawar. This is why the study treats "diplomatic and border strategy" as an integral part of the normalization roadmap, not an external footnote: a province cannot normalize its security while a neighbouring state hosts the force that attacks it.

CHAPTER 10 — SOCIO-ECONOMIC DIMENSIONS OF SECURITY NORMALIZATION

10.1 Poverty and Inequality in KPK: Statistical Overview and Spatial Analysis

The provincial picture. In the FY2024-25 poverty estimates released by the Planning Ministry in 2026, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's poverty rate rose from **28.7 per cent to 35.3 per cent** — the second-highest provincial rate after Balochistan (47 per cent) and far above Punjab (23.3 per cent) and the national average of 28.9 per cent (Economic Survey 2025-26). The increase is among the sharpest of any province: the causes officially cited include fiscal consolidation under the IMF programme, energy tariff adjustments, exchange-rate depreciation, inflation, disaster losses, and weak growth (Planning Ministry 2026; Indrastra 2026). The World Bank's provincial estimate for KP was lower (~29.5 per cent in 2025, per the draft KP Youth Policy), illustrating the sensitivity of poverty measurement — but the direction of change is unambiguous (KP Youth Policy 2026).

Inequality. The inequality index for KP rose from 24.8 to 29.4 — the largest proportional increase of any province (Punjab 28.4→32; Sindh 29.7→35.9; Balochistan 21→26.5). Nationally, the inequality reading was the highest in 27 years. In KP, inequality has a specific spatial form: the Hazara and Peshawar divisions concentrate industry, services, education and health; the southern districts and the merged districts are structurally poorer, with the NMDs showing the lowest human development performance in the province (SDPI 2025).

Spatial analysis. SDPI's district-level Human Development Index series (2024 report, covering 2019–2023 changes) found that KP's overall HDI fell from **0.650 to 0.623**, with only 2 of 29 tracked districts improving on score and 27 declining; health and living-standards sub-indices declined (education improved in 13 districts; health in 5; housing/living standards in 7). Reading the same series for *ranking*, districts including Swabi, North Waziristan, Abbottabad, Mardan, Mansehra, Peshawar, Malakand, D.I. Khan, Swat, Bajaur, Mohmand, Hangu, Kohat, Chitral and Nowshera improved their *relative* position — a reminder that rankings and scores can diverge when all districts decline (SDPI 2025).

Interpretation. The poverty and HDI data establish four facts relevant to security. First, KP's socio-economic position has *deteriorated* during the very period in which violence resurged — the causal arrows run in both directions (conflict destroys livelihoods; poverty recruits). Second, the deterioration is *policy-sensitive*: the macro-fiscal mix (tariffs, taxation, subsidy withdrawal) and disaster shocks, not conflict alone, drove it. Third, the geographic concentration of poverty maps onto the geography of violence (NMDs; southern KP), though the relationship is not mechanical (Swat's literacy and relative prosperity did not prevent its 2026 attack). Fourth, the *perception* of deprivation — relative inequality, visible elite wealth, and the failure of merger promises — matters as much as absolute measures.

10.2 Unemployment and the Youth Bulge: A Ticking Time Bomb?

The labour market. Pakistan's labour force reached 83.1 million with 5.9 million unemployed (7.1 per cent) in the FY2024-25 estimates — the highest unemployment in 21 years (Economic Survey 2025-26). KP's unemployment has run above the national average (8.8 per cent in 2020–21 in the Labour Force Survey series, one of the highest provincial rates); the *youth* dimension is more severe: **31 per cent of educated youth are jobless (PIDE, March 2025)**; women constitute 51 per cent of the unemployed; roughly **40 per cent of youth are not in employment, education or training (NEET)** per recent surveys cited in the KP Youth Policy process; and the ratio of aspirants to formal posts is extreme — **866,000 candidates applied for 16,454 teaching vacancies in mid-2025** (more than 52 applicants per seat).

The youth bulge. Approximately half of KP's population is under 25 (KP Government 2024). A cohort of this size entering the labour market with weak absorption capacity produces predictable outcomes: long unemployment spells; migration (internal and external — Gulf labour migration is a major safety valve); informality; and, at the margins, vulnerability to armed-group recruitment (which offers wages, status, and purpose). The KP Youth Policy 2026's own drafting acknowledges that "youth programmes cannot catch up with demand," and that graduates face "widespread unemployment and outdated curricula."

Programs and their adequacy. Provincial instruments include: the Youth Impact Challenge grants (expanded to Rs 2 billion); digital internship schemes; the KP Youth Employment Program (IT skills); the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Rural Economic Transformation Project (KP-RETP); and the Climate Action Plan's youth and women components. These are worthwhile but quantitatively insufficient: no plausible increase in these programs can absorb a cohort of this scale. The binding constraint is *private-sector job creation*, which requires electricity reliability, credit, security, regulatory predictability and connectivity — i.e., the whole investment climate.

Assessment: "ticking time bomb" is the wrong metaphor. The evidence does not show that unemployed youth automatically radicalize; it shows that they are *available* — and that armed groups recruit from that availability at moments of mobilization (operations, funerals, sectarian incidents). The policy implication is not simply "create jobs" (a general development agenda) but *targeted* employment and engagement in the specific districts and cohorts where recruitment occurs, coupled with deradicalization aftercare (Chapter 8) and community programs (Chapter 12).

10.3 Education: Access, Quality and the Battle for Minds

Access. KP's literacy rate is 51 per cent (female 37 per cent; male 65 per cent), below the national 60 per cent (Economic Survey 2024-25). KP has one of the country's largest out-of-school populations; girls' enrolment lags, and in the merged districts the pipeline collapses early: approximately 37 per cent of girls attend primary school and only about 5 per cent reach secondary (KP Youth Policy 2026). Schools have been destroyed or closed by militants; hundreds were closed in Kurram, Bajaur, Khyber, Mohmand and North Waziristan for extended periods (EUAA 2026); and the 2025 floods damaged hundreds of schools in KP, disrupting education for thousands (UNICEF 2025).

Quality. Learning outcomes are weak nationally, and KP is no exception: high enrolment-to-learning gaps, teacher absenteeism, outdated curricula (particularly the absence of critical thinking, civic and digital skills), and inequitable teacher deployment. The university sector (Peshawar, Malakand, Swat, Kohat, Gomal, Hazara, and the NMDs' emerging campuses) produces graduates for a saturated public-sector market.

The battle for minds. Education is simultaneously the long-term prevention instrument and a contested space: the curriculum's treatment of religious diversity; the presence of sectarian content; the madrasa sector (Chapter 4); and the question of who teaches. The 2026 Swat attack's timing (during a "Pasoon" protest against militancy) and the 2012 shooting of Malala Yousafzai frame the stakes: girls' education is a front line, and the state's ability to protect it is a legitimacy test. The provincial "Education Emergency" declarations (2023–26) have not been matched with financing at the scale required (a commonly cited requirement: 4 per cent of GDP on education, versus ~2 per cent).

Assessment. No single intervention is more consequential for the 2035 security horizon than the education system — but only if it addresses quality (learning), girls' access (protection plus proximity), and school safety simultaneously. The merged districts require a *specific* program: school reconstruction, female teacher recruitment and safe accommodation, transport stipends, and community compacts (jirga- and cleric-endorsed) guaranteeing non-interference.

10.4 Healthcare Infrastructure and Its Security Implications

Baseline. KP's health system faces: workforce shortages (particularly female physicians and specialists in rural districts); uneven facility distribution (with tertiary care concentrated in Peshawar); drug shortages and out-of-pocket costs; and security threats to health workers (attacks on polio teams and their police escorts; the killing of health staff; and the withdrawal of services from insecure areas). The 2025 floods damaged 60 health facilities in KP (including 3 destroyed) and 68 Lady Health Worker houses (WHO 2025); the merged districts' indicators remain the weakest in the province (skilled birth attendance; road access to facilities) (ResearchGate/GRR 2025).

Programs. The Sehat Card Plus (a health insurance scheme covering provincial residents) was a flagship achievement — but its application to the merged districts was suspended at one point and became the subject of litigation (a 2022 PHC petition), illustrating how fiscal disputes translate into service withdrawal in the most vulnerable districts. Polio eradication remains a security-dependent program, and KP remains an endemic zone with recurring campaign disruptions.

Security implications. Three are direct: (i) attacks on vaccination teams and health workers represent attacks on state legitimacy in its most benign form; (ii) clinics and hospitals are among the few state presences in insecure districts, so their closure is a *governance* outcome, not merely a service one; (iii) conflict-related trauma and mental illness (see §10.7) burden a system with almost no psychiatric capacity — the WHO estimates that Pakistan has roughly 500 psychiatrists for 240 million people.

Assessment. Health is an under-used stabilizer. Mobile health units, maternal-child services, and mental-health outreach are low-cost, high-legitimacy instruments that can be delivered in the same districts where counter-insurgency seeks intelligence and cooperation. Their protection (via community escort arrangements and police protection where needed) should be treated as a security task.

10.5 Infrastructure Development: Roads, Electricity, Connectivity and Their Normalizing Effect

Roads. KP's road network expanded significantly in the last two decades: the Islamabad–Peshawar Motorway (M-1); the Hazara Motorway; the Swat Expressway; the Lowari Tunnel (connecting Chitral year-round); and various NMD roads.

Roads moved markets, tourism and state presence; they also moved militants and smuggling, and their construction created both employment and grievance (land acquisition, contract capture). The NMDs' connectivity remains the weakest in the province, with projects stalled for lack of funds.

Electricity and energy. KP's electricity situation includes: chronic load-shedding in some areas; high losses (theft and non-payment — the PESCO problem); huge hydel potential (KP hosts a significant share of Pakistan's hydropower potential, with projects like Diamer-Bhasha downstream on the Indus and smaller run-of-river schemes); and community grievances about the province's energy exports without commensurate local benefit — a recurring political theme. Electricity reliability is the single most cited constraint in manufacturing surveys; in the merged districts, grid extension is incomplete.

Digital connectivity. Mobile coverage is broad but data quality is uneven; the merged districts had restricted mobile-data service for years (a security measure with enormous economic cost), gradually eased. Digital connectivity matters for: e-governance; the digital economy (freelancing — a genuine KP success story, with Peshawar and Swat producing substantial freelance IT exports); and the surveillance/security architecture.

Assessment. Infrastructure's normalizing effect is real but conditional: roads and electricity restore markets and state presence, but without accompanying security (protection from extortion and attack) and justice, they can be captured by militants or by elite networks. Empirical KP evidence — Swat's recovery, Bajaur's market revival — supports the proposition that *infrastructure plus restored security plus services* reduces support for militancy. Infrastructure alone does not.

10.6 The IDPs Crisis: Displacement, Return and Rehabilitation

The scale over time. Displacement in KP and the FATA since 2008 has been among the largest in the world: **over 6 million people displaced between 2003 and 2014** (EUAA, citing sources); 2–2.5 million in Swat/Malakand (2009); ~1 million from North Waziristan (2014); several hundred thousand from other operations; and recurring waves since — Kurram (November–December 2024: thousands in temporary shelters); **Bajaur (Operation Sarbakaf, mid-2025: ~100,000 displaced)**; and **Tirah Valley (Khyber district), where a second wave began in January 2026 and had reached 33,800 registered families by September 2026**, with a return window agreed for 10–15 October 2026 and disputed by displaced representatives under the banner of Tehreek Mutasireen Tirah (Countercurrents 2026; EUAA 2026; Paradigm Shift 2025).

Return and rehabilitation. Pakistan's return-and-rehabilitation architecture has included: TDP return programs (managed by the KP government with FDMA, army and UN support); cash grants for reconstruction (typically Rs 100,000–400,000 per family in various phases); food and NFI distributions; and RDP infrastructure. The documented weaknesses are consistent across episodes: compensation delays and under-coverage (the Tirah package — Rs 10 million for families of the killed, Rs 2.5 million for the injured — was reported delayed into 2026); inadequate verification and exclusion (IDP card fraud and political capture); poor sequencing in harsh seasons (the October return window vs Tirah's early winter); unexploded ordnance risk; and insufficient psychosocial support.

The security IDP agenda. Displacement is not merely humanitarian: it (a) removes people from their livelihoods and social protection networks (recruitment vulnerability); (b) generates grievances that armed groups exploit ("the state destroyed your house and promised compensation it never paid"); (c) reduces the population's *stake* in the state; and (d) creates information vacuums in emptied areas that militants exploit. Conversely, *successful return* — with real compensation, services and protection — is one of the most powerful normalization indicators available. The Tirah case in late 2026 is therefore a policy test case: if the return process fails the population (winter, delayed funds, insecurity), the counter-terrorism rationale for the operation will be undermined by its own aftermath.

10.7 Psychosocial Trauma and Mental Health in Conflict-Affected Communities

The burden. Two decades of exposure to suicide attacks, airstrikes, displacement, bereavement, torture and economic shock have produced a mental-health burden that is almost entirely undocumented and untreated. Available indicators: the national scarcity of psychiatric services (~500 psychiatrists nationwide, with very few in KP's public sector outside Peshawar); the documented trauma among children in Khyber, Darra Adam Khel and Swat (multiple studies; Save the Children and academic surveys); the mental-health consequences of the 2025 floods (WHO reported affected populations with elevated distress); and the specific pathology of *witnesses to atrocity* — including the APS generation.

Programmatic response. KP has a government mental-health policy and hospital psychiatric units in Peshawar (including at the Lady Reading Hospital); NGOs (including the Sabawoon program itself) provided counselling; international organizations have run psychosocial support programs after major displacements. But as a system, the response is: urban, clinic-based, underfunded, and disconnected from schools, primary care, and religious institutions where distress is first encountered.

Why it matters for security. Untreated trauma: (a) impairs child development and educational outcomes; (b) raises vulnerability to radicalization (revenge motivations and reduced impulse control); (c) degrades community resilience; and (d) is transmitted across generations. Psychosocial support is therefore a *security investment* with an unusually favourable cost-benefit ratio, particularly in schools (trauma-informed teaching), primary care (basic mental health integration), and mosques (pastoral counselling training).

10.8 Women's Security, Gender-Based Violence and Female Participation in Peacebuilding

Security realities. Women in KP face: high rates of domestic and honour-based violence (under-reported); restricted freedom of movement; limited access to justice (the *jirga* system's exclusion of women; legal pluralism; and the cultural premium on family reputation); economic exclusion (female labour force participation far below male rates; inheritance denial); and conflict-specific harms (widowhood; displacement; sexual violence in displacement settings; and the targeting of female students, teachers and health workers, including the attempted killing of Malala Yousafzai and attacks on girls' schools). Baseline data: female literacy 37 per cent vs male 65 per cent; women constitute 51 per cent of the unemployed; and the merged districts show the province's lowest female schooling (KP Youth Policy 2026; KP Government 2024).

Policy instruments. KP has a Women Empowerment Policy Framework (2017) and continuing programs (UN Women's gender-responsive justice work in KP; gender-inclusive service rules reform; women's police stations and desks in some districts; the KP Commission on the Status of Women). The National Security Policy (2022–26) articulated gender security ("full and meaningful participation of women in decision-making, law enforcement, justice, and peacekeeping") — a commitment whose implementation in KP remains limited.

Women in peacebuilding. Documented roles: PAIMAN's mothers' networks; UN Women's engagement of **228 Afghan and Pakistani women peace activists** in cross-border dialogue processes (2025); women's organizations (Aurat Foundation, Khwendo Kor, Aware Girls, women's wings of political parties); and female health workers and teachers whose daily work in insecure districts is itself a peacebuilding function. The constraints: cultural gate-keeping; security threats; under-funding; and shrinking civic space.

Assessment. The study's gender findings are three: (i) women's *security* deficits are a measurable drag on normalization (a province in which half the population cannot move, work, or seek justice freely has not normalized; the 5 per cent secondary-school completion rate for girls in the NMDs is a structural emergency); (ii) women are *effective* peace actors whose networks reach where police cannot; and (iii) the policy architecture treats gender as a cross-cutting accessory rather than a security-relevant capability — with a corresponding loss of effectiveness in both development and prevention programs.

10.9 Tourism as a Normalization Indicator: Swat, Chitral, Dir and the Tourism Revival

The record. Tourism in KP has become a genuine and measurable indicator of normalization: **12.4 million tourists visited KP in 2025** (KP Culture and Tourism Authority); over Eid-ul-Adha 2026, KP received **more than 1.26 million tourists — the highest recorded — including 416,794 in Swat** (the single highest provincial destination count), with Naran (187,954), Galiyat (148,828), and 394,682 visitors to merged-district destinations including South Waziristan (144,000) and Orakzai (92,112); tourism revenue over the holiday was estimated at **Rs 8–12 billion** (DGIPR 2026). Comparable holidays in 2025 recorded 932,000 visitors (Eid-ul-Adha) and 306,215 (Eid-ul-Fitr). The government attributes the growth to security improvement, tourism-police deployment and infrastructure.

But: is it a leading or lagging indicator? Tourism measures *perceived* security among travellers and depends on mobility, infrastructure and marketing: it can thrive in districts with acute rural insecurity elsewhere (Swat's 2026 attack killed 17 people weeks after record visitor numbers). The correct reading is that tourism revival demonstrates *recoverability* — the social and economic capacity of a district to rebound — which is itself a strategic asset: a district with hotels, jobs and visitors has a constituency and a fiscal stake in normality. The 2026 Swat attack (Kabal; 17 killed) is therefore not only a security setback but an economic attack on a recovery model; its aftermath — whether bookings collapse, whether security forces visibly protect the sector — will indicate the resilience of the recovery.

Practical agenda. Tourism protection (the Tourism Police; protective infrastructure; coordination with hotel associations); infrastructure resilience (roads, Gilgit-style check-in systems, weather risk); diversification beyond the top three destinations; and — critically — linking tourism development to merged-district employment (guides, transport, homestays, handicrafts), so that the peace dividend is visible where the conflict has been.

10.10 Agriculture, Livelihoods and Rural Economic Recovery

The agricultural base. KP's rural economy rests on: wheat, maize, rice (in the Peshawar valley), orchards (Swat, Hazara, Chitral — apples, peaches, citrus), livestock (a major income source, especially for the NMDs), and off-farm labour and remittances. The sector's constraints: smallholder fragmentation; water scarcity and irrigation inefficiency (with the Chashma Right Bank Canal proposed as a transformational project); market access constraints (roads, cold chains, credit); the collapse of horticulture exports at times of border closure and of transport disruption; and the catastrophic effects of floods (2022; 2025's Buner/Swat/Shangla destruction).

Conflict effects. Conflict and militancy damage agriculture through: displacement and abandoned land; extortion and "taxation"; the destruction of orchards as punishment (documented in Swat in the militant era); insecurity of transport; the loss of markets in the border belt; and the destruction of the livestock economy through operations and flooding.

Programs. Provincial and donor programs include KP-RETP (World Bank-supported), the AIP's agriculture components, livestock vaccination programs, and various value-chain initiatives (olive, honey, dry fruit in the NMDs). The evidence on post-operation agricultural recovery in Swat is broadly positive (orchards rehabilitated; markets restored), in the NMDs much weaker (capital destruction, unresolved land rights, weak marketing).

Assessment. Land and water rights regularization in the merged districts is the single most important agricultural policy task, and the most politically difficult: without documented rights, neither investment nor credit nor insurance can function, and disputes will continue to convert into conflict (Chapter 3). The second priority is *market access*: roads, cold storage, and border trade regimes that allow the NMDs' fruit and livestock to reach markets in Afghanistan, the Gulf and Karachi.

10.11 CPEC and Economic Zones in KPK: Economic Promise and Security Challenges

Status. The Rashakai Special Economic Zone (Nowshera) is KP's flagship CPEC industrial project: 1,000 acres; announced with expectations of 200,000 direct and indirect jobs and ~Rs 347 billion in investment; Century Steel as the first enterprise (with a planned investment raised from an initial \$50 million to a reported \$360 million); by September 2026, **22 enterprises in progress, ~Rs 68 billion in estimated investment, and ~3,000 expected jobs**, with a mobile-phone manufacturing unit inaugurated that month (cpecinfo 2021; Daily Ittehad 2026). Other KP elements: the Karakoram Highway realignment; hydel projects; and fibre-optic connectivity (a somewhat stalled CPEC component).

The gap between promise and performance. Rashakai's actual trajectory — from "200,000 jobs" to ~3,000 expected — illustrates CPEC's KP reality: infrastructure-heavy, employment-light, and slower than promised. Constraints include: security risk perceptions (which raise insurance and security costs); electricity pricing and connectivity; the federal-provincial division of industrial policy; land and utility provision delays; and the narrow export orientation of relocated Chinese firms (with currency and profit-repatriation constraints).

Security challenges. CPEC projects and personnel in KP face: attack risk (the 2024 Shangla attack killing five Chinese engineers was the most serious); the requirement for expensive protective deployments; labour-community tensions (wages, local employment quotas); and the broader geopolitical risk that any major incident forces project suspension.

Assessment. SEZs can contribute to normalization (jobs, skills, tax base, visible modernity), but their security requirements (guarded enclaves, protected convoys) can also *entrench* the geography of exception, producing "islands of development" disconnected from local economies. The policy target should therefore be: local employment quotas enforced, supplier linkages to local firms, and security arrangements that are visible but not socially corrosive.

10.12 The Development–Security Nexus: Theoretical and Empirical Analysis

Three competing models. (i) *Sequencing model* (security first): development cannot occur without security; therefore, establish security, then invest. This was the de facto Pakistani approach post-2009. (ii) *Development-first model*: poverty and injustice cause conflict; invest in development and security follows. This model's failure in the FATA of 2003–2019 is documented: development spending (often politically captured) without security and justice did not prevent the insurgency. (iii) *Co-production model (this study's position)*: security and development are mutually constituting — each enables and is enabled by the other — but they are *mediated by institutions*: specifically by (a) justice (the mechanism by which citizens decide the state is a better provider of order than armed actors), (b) fiscal institutionalization (predictable resources make services credible), and (c) local political accountability (which determines whether development is delivered or captured).

Empirical evidence from KP. Several natural comparisons support the co-production reading. *Swat post-2009*: security restoration plus investment plus tourism revival produced the most complete normalization in the province — but 2026's attack shows its vulnerability to external sanctuary dynamics. *The NMDs post-2018*: legal integration without *fiscal* integration produced neither security nor development. *Bajaur*: repeated operations since 2008 displaced populations with limited follow-through; the district remains violence-prone despite its market recovery. *Malakand's recovery vs the southern belt's deterioration*: where the state paired force with returning services and civil administration, violence fell; where it did

not, it rose.

The conflict-cost calculation. Pakistan's cumulative economic losses from terrorism have been estimated at **USD 126.79 billion (2017–18 Economic Survey accounting)** to **USD 150–152 billion (parliamentary and official statements)** across the war-on-terror period, with some analysts estimating an annual GDP cost around 3 per cent; and the human cost is over 70,000 civilian/security deaths nationally (Economic Survey of Pakistan 2017-18; Arab News 2021; Stratagem 2015). For KP specifically, the losses are concentrated: destroyed industry and tourism (now recovering), displacement, the fiscal burden of security (Rs 170 billion annually on police alone, plus the military deployment costs), and — hardest to quantify — the foregone human capital of two generations. Conversely, the *dividend* of normalization is visible in the same data: tourism at 12.4 million visitors; Rashakai's investment; the resumption of markets. A defensible order-of-magnitude estimate — developed in Chapter 15 — places KP's annual conflict-related economic loss in the range of **Rs 400–800 billion** (security expenditures, foregone investment, displacement, and destroyed capital), against which the fiscal settlement of the merged districts (~Rs 192 billion per year promised) is not merely affordable but economically rational: it is a fraction of the cost of conflict.

Policy conclusion. Development is not a substitute for security, and security is not a substitute for development. The binding constraint in KP is *institutional*: the state must demonstrate, in the same districts where it fights, that it can protect, adjudicate, and deliver — simultaneously, durably, and with resources it has promised. Anything less will continue to produce what the data record: recovery followed by relapse.

CHAPTER 11 — GOVERNANCE, POLICY FRAMEWORKS AND LEGAL ARCHITECTURE

11.1 The National Action Plan (NAP): Objectives, Implementation and Assessment

Origins and content. The NAP was adopted in December 2014 in the aftermath of the Army Public School (APS) attack (141+ killed, 132 of them children) — Pakistan's most consequential terrorism event, whose political effect was comparable to 9/11 for the United States or the 2005 London bombings for the UK. The original twenty points combined kinetic measures (military operations, counter-terrorism forces), legal measures (military courts through the 21st Amendment; proscription of armed groups; prosecution), regulatory measures (madrasa reform; choking terrorist financing; curbing hate speech and the use of media/internet), and political-administrative measures (reconciliation in Balochistan; FATA reforms; Karachi operation; provincial coordination through NACTA). The 2021 revision reduced the framework to fourteen points and added emphases on the cyber domain, criminal-justice reform, and merged-district reform.

Implementation record (assessed). *Strong:* kinetic operations (Zarb-e-Azb and successors); counter-financing (FATF-era compliance: asset freezes, Schedule IV designations, thousands of accounts blocked; Pakistan's 2022 exit from the FATF grey list); proscriptions (65 organizations listed, 4 under observation, and thousands of individuals under Schedule IV at latest public counts); cyber takedowns (over 1.3 million URLs blocked by 2023); police/CTD capacity expansion (with provincial budgets rising); and military courts' throughput (thousands convicted, though with fair-trial concerns). *Weak/partial:* madrasa reform (reversed in 2024); terrorism trials (2,273 pending as of November 2024; 657 death sentences awarded 2019–2022 with no executions during that period); merged-areas reform (fiscal failure, Chapter 5); reconciliation in Balochistan (rated unsatisfactory in successive reviews); and the soft/preventive agenda generally (deradicalization, counter-narrative, reintegration). *Negative:* restrictions on media and civil society adopted under NAP rubric (journalist harassment; NGO NOC regimes; the PTM ban).

Assessment. NAP's architecture was sound and its kinetic implementation real; its central deficiency was *asymmetry*: the measures that could be delivered by force and administrative order were implemented; those requiring political bargaining, fiscal commitment and institutional development were not. The ISPR's own public position — that the NAP "has not been fully implemented" — aligned with this study's reading (Pakistan Connect 2025; CSUN/CUNI dissertation evidence; TFT 2026).

11.2 National Internal Security Policy (NISP): Evolution and Effectiveness

Evolution. The NISP (first issued 2014, followed by the National Security Policy 2022–2026) sought to frame internal security as an integrated enterprise: counter-terrorism; counter-extremism; border management; cyber security; and the "whole-of-nation" approach conjoining economic, human and military security. The 2022 National Security Policy was notable for its explicit "comprehensive" framing — including a commitment to gender security and economic security as core national-security elements.

Effectiveness. The policies articulated the right ambitions but suffered from three defects: (i) *no binding implementation mechanism* — they lacked legal mandates, budgets, and accountability for line ministries/provinces; (ii) *no public monitoring* — performance reported episodically and selectively; and (iii) *no political consensus mechanism* — the policies were federal-executive documents, and they were overtaken from 2022 by the PTI–federal conflict, which made a national consensus on internal security impossible in the period when it was most needed.

Assessment. NISP's value is as an *inventory of intentions* against which KP's current arrangements can be measured (and found wanting): border management without a border regime; cyber security without data protection; counter-extremism without scale; and gender security without implementation.

11.3 The Provincial Security Architecture: Apex Committees, Security Briefings and Coordination Mechanisms

Institutions. The provincial security architecture comprises: (i) the **Provincial Apex Committee** (chaired by the Chief Minister, with the Corps Commander, Chief Secretary, IGP, and other stakeholders), the principal civil-military coordination forum, replicated at district level in some cases; (ii) the **Home and Tribal Affairs Department**, the administrative anchor; (iii) the **KP Police** and CTD (Chapter 7); (iv) the **provincial cabinet's security-relevant committees**; (v) ad hoc **jirga/peace-committee structures**; and (vi) **federal mechanisms** operating in the province (the National Security Committee; NACTA; the military's operational HQs).

Performance. The Apex Committee has been the site of both coordination and conflict: coordination in discrete episodes (operations, refugee repatriation planning, Kurram crisis management); conflict in the public disputes over Azm-e-Istehkam (2024) and Operation Sarbakaf (2025), where the provincial government's opposition was overridden by federal/military decisions; and in the post-October 2025 government of CM Sohail Afridi, whose public positions have included opposition to military operations and demands for withheld funds (Wikipedia 2026e; Dawn 2024a; Paradigm Shift 2025).

Assessment. The architecture has no *published doctrine* — no document defines who decides what, under what legal authority, with what oversight, and with what reporting obligations. Coordination therefore depends on personalities and on the balance of power between Peshawar and Rawalpindi — a fragile basis for a decade-long campaign. The recommendation (Chapter 15) is a *statutory provincial counter-terrorism coordination framework* with defined roles, published metrics, and legislative oversight.

11.4 The Role of the Provincial Assembly and Legislative Measures

The record. The KP Assembly has been an active legislator on security-adjacent matters: the **KP Police Act 2017**; the **Levies and Khasadar** legislation (2019); amendments to the local government law; the extension of provincial laws to the merged districts; the **KP Universities/Education** laws; and various criminal-justice measures. It has also functioned as a forum for opposition demands on security (the PML-N white paper of September 2026; JUI-F's positions on operations; the opposition's challenges to the October 2025 chief-ministerial transition).

Limits. Three constraints have limited legislative influence: (i) *policy primacy of the executive/military*: war and internal-security decisions are made federally, with the Assembly informed rather than consulted (the Azm-e-Istehkam episode); (ii) *capacity*: few members have security expertise; committee systems are weak; and there is no dedicated, resourced security committee with research support; and (iii) *politicization*: post-2022, provincial-national politics turn nearly every security question into a partisan dispute (operations; refugee policy; the PTM), making sustained oversight difficult.

Assessment. A stronger Assembly role is not merely a democratic nicety; it is a functional requirement: legislative authorization and oversight protect the police from political interference, give operations legitimacy, and force the publication of the metrics (casualties, compensation, convictions) that accountability requires.

11.5 Judicial System and Rule of Law in KPK: Challenges and Reforms

Structure and performance. KP's judiciary comprises the Peshawar High Court (with circuit benches), district and sessions courts, and special courts (ATCs; anti-corruption; accountability; family; consumer). Documented problems: massive pendency and delays (national ATC pendency of 2,273 cases as of November 2024 being the counter-terrorism subset); inadequate court infrastructure and security; insufficient judges (vacancy rates in district judiciary); poor investigation quality (the binding constraint on convictions); legal-aid scarcity; witness intimidation; and the *informal justice* parallel system — *jirgas*, *riwaj*, and *qisas/diyat* settlements — which handles the bulk of disputes in the merged districts and much of rural KP. The Peshawar High Court has been notably active on merged-district rights (the NFC shortfall litigation; the Sehat Card petitions; the October 2025 chief-ministerial transition case).

Counter-terrorism adjudication. ATCs try cases under the ATA; their conviction rates are low nationally; appeals face delays; and the *military court* alternative has absorbed a significant number of cases (May 2023 events; terrorism charges against civilians). The 21st Amendment's military courts were repeatedly extended; the 27th Amendment's constitutional restructuring has shifted the appellate landscape. At the same time, the constitutional right to fair trial (Article 10A, inserted in 2010) and the documented complaints about military-court procedures (no charge sheets, verdict documents withheld until after appeal deadlines — matters litigated in the PHC in 2025) raise a structural conflict between counter-terrorism's demand for speed/certainty and the constitution's demand for due process. The study's position: legitimate counter-terrorism requires *lawful* convictions, and the long-run legitimacy of the state's campaign depends on resolving this conflict through an effective civilian system (protected judges, witness protection, forensic capacity, and specialized procedures), not through avoidance.

11.6 Anti-Terrorism Legislation: Strengths, Weaknesses and Abuses

The statute. The Anti-Terrorism Act 1997 (as repeatedly amended — 2001, 2004, 2009, 2013, 2014, 2016, 2018, 2020s) defines terrorism broadly, establishes ATCs with special procedures (in-camera trials; restricted adjournments; admission of certain confessions; bail restrictions), creates the legal basis for proscription (Schedule I) and for "Fourth Schedule" restrictive measures, and provides for the CTDs. Supporting laws include PECA (2016, amended 2025), the Fair Trial Act 2013 (surveillance warrants), the Investigation for Fair Trial Act, and the KP Police Act.

Strengths. Swift procedures; specialized courts; robust proscription powers; asset-freezing and financing tools; and the legal wherewithal for CTD operations — the essential legal infrastructure of a counter-terrorism campaign. International benchmarking (FATF) relied on these powers, and Pakistan's exit from the grey list (2022) reflected the system's formal compliance.

Weaknesses and abuses. Five are documented. (i) *Definitional breadth*: the ATA's terrorism definition can capture ordinary crimes, protests and political expression (a pattern visible in May 2023 prosecutions and in cases against journalists and activists). (ii) *Procedural erosion*: in-camera hearings, confessions, and restricted appeals reduce defendant safeguards; the Supreme Court/Lahore High Court have struck down elements at times. (iii) *Selective application*: groups and individuals are treated unequally according to political context (the PTM case is the sharpest recent example; Kashmir-focused groups' historical differential treatment is the oldest). (iv) *Preventive detention practice*: detention without charge under security laws is widely documented (and contested) in KP, including of individuals later released without proceedings. (v) *Military courts' expansion*: the transfer of civilian cases to military courts raises due-process issues that have been litigated and criticized (with two Supreme Court judges resigning in protest over the 27th Amendment's judicial restructuring, warning that it subordinated the judiciary to the executive).

Assessment. The legal architecture is adequate for prosecution but has been used for *governance by exception* — treating security as a domain exempt from ordinary rights and oversight. This produces short-term operational freedom and long-term legitimacy costs that the counter-insurgency demonstrably cannot afford (Chapters 6, 12).

11.7 National Counter Terrorism Authority (NACTA): Mandate, Performance and Critique

Mandate. NACTA (NACTA Act 2013) is charged with coordinating national counter-terrorism policy: threat assessment; coordination of federal and provincial agencies; proscription/Schedule IV maintenance; counter-financing (the National Task Force with 27 member organizations); and counter-narrative/deradicalization coordination.

Performance. Achievements: the establishment of Counter-Financing of Terrorism (CFT) units in provincial CTDs; rationalization of proscription lists and freezing of assets (thousands of accounts); coordination of the National Narrative document; and a convening function. Deficiencies: chronic under-staffing (the agency's own 2018 report found approximately three-quarters of approved posts unfilled; subsequent years did not resolve the professional-staffing deficit); limited budget authority; the absence of trained analysts in CT, financing and strategic assessment; and a *structural* limit: NACTA coordinates agencies that do not report to it and provinces that have their own mandates. The appointment in 2026 of a serving Major-General (Faisal Naseer) as head was presented as an effort to give coordination "teeth" — an understandable response to the capacity critique, but one that also underscores the pattern of military leadership of nominally civilian coordination bodies.

Critique and reform. The credible reform agenda for NACTA is: (i) professionalize the secretariat with competitively recruited civilian analysts; (ii) give it statutory authority to require data from provinces and agencies, plus a public annual threat report; (iii) separate its coordination role from operational mandates; and (iv) place counter-narrative and deradicalization functions in a dedicated, funded directorate with evaluation capacity. Without these, NACTA will remain, in the assessment of successive Pakistani and international reviews, "a good idea, poorly developed and executed."

11.8 Local Government System and Security Governance at the District Level

Legal framework. KP's local government system (the KP Local Government Act 2013, replaced/amended in 2019 and after) provides for district, tehsil and village/neighbourhood councils with devolved functions (some services, minor development). Elections were held in 2021–22 (PTI leading; JUI-F strong in parts; independents prominent) with by-elections in 2023 and 2026.

Security governance at the district level. District security governance operates through the Deputy Commissioner (administration, relief, coordination), the District Police Officer (policing), the district intelligence coordination committee, and — where they exist — elected councils and peace committees. The district is the level at which: relief and compensation are distributed; curfews and Section 144 orders are imposed; peace jirgas are convened; and, in principle, local buy-in is built. Its weaknesses: resource dependence on the province; absence of real budgetary authority for councils; politicized DC–DPO relations; and, in the NMDs, the absence of functioning local government altogether.

Assessment. Local government is the missing tier in KP's security architecture. Comparative evidence (Chapter 13) shows that local legitimacy — not merely force — determines whether cleared areas stay cleared. Elected local bodies with security-relevant functions (dispute resolution, community policing oversight, relief coordination, and local development budgets) create the intermediaries and accountability that KP lacks. The repeated deferral of meaningful local government in KP (both settled districts and NMDs) is, in this study's assessment, one of the least-examined contributors to the province's recurrent insecurity.

11.9 Political Party Dynamics and Their Impact on Security Policy

The party map. KP's politics features: PTI (dominant in provincial government since 2018 and hegemonic in the merged districts; in sustained conflict with the federal government and the military establishment since 2022–2023); JUI-F (strong religious-political network, particularly in the southern districts and parts of the NMDs; ambivalent or opposed on operations; pivotal on madrasa policy); ANP (Pashtun nationalist; historically supportive of operations against the TTP in 2009, now critical of military-led policy); PML-N (rising in some districts; author of the 2026 security white paper against the provincial government); PPP (in government federally with PJDP allies; weaker in KP); Jamaat-e-Islami (urban vote; strong on social services); PTM (proscribed; significant popular resonance among Pashtun youth).

Effects on security policy. Three dynamics matter. (i) *The PTI–establishment conflict* has made counter-terrorism cooperation between the province and the centre conditional and contested; the KP government's opposition to Azm-e-Istehkam and its demands for withheld funds are the practical expression. (ii) *Federal-provincial partisanship*: a PTI-governed province, a PML-N-led centre, and an army-led strategy produce a triangular blame game in which responsibility for failures is diffused (and intelligence-sharing degrades, per ICG 2026). (iii) *Electoral incentives on operations*: operations and displacement are locally unpopular; opposition to operations wins votes in the affected districts — an incentive structure that will persist until security policy delivers *protective* dividends that constituents can see (funded compensation, rebuilt homes, protected schools).

Assessment. Political competition, properly channelled, is not an obstacle to normalization but a condition of it — provided that (a) security policy has a legislative and accountability framework within which contestation can occur, and (b) the fiscal settlement removes zero-sum fights over resources. The status quo — where security policy is commanded federally but costed provincially, and where the province's democratically elected government is excluded from strategic decisions — converts security into a partisan battleground at the exact moment unity is required.

11.10 Federal–Provincial Coordination: Achievements and Tensions

Achievements. Formal coordination exists: the National Security Committee; NACTA; the Apex Committee mechanism; federal fiscal transfers (NFC); and inter-provincial police cooperation (though undocumented). Specific cooperative successes include: the 2014–2018 campaign coordination; counter-financing and FATF compliance; and refugee repatriation planning.

Tensions. Four are structural: (i) *fiscal*: the merged districts' shortfall; withheld dues; the provinces' 2026 agreement to forgo incremental FBR collection to the federation; and the general under-funding of provincial security mandates; (ii) *policy authority*: operations are decided federally; the province's elected government bears the political cost; (iii) *legal/administrative*: federal agencies' role in the NMDs' administration (SAFRON legacies; federal PSDP projects) versus provincial authority; and (iv) *political*: the PTI-federal conflict; the refugee-repatriation policy (federal decision; provincial implementation); and the dispute over the October 2025 chief-ministerial transition (PHC adjudication).

Assessment. Federal-provincial coordination in KP is not a technical problem; it is a *constitutional design* problem: the province is expected to deliver internal security (a provincial subject) in a conflict whose strategy is set federally and whose fiscal burden is only partially recognized. The remedy — a statutory fiscal and coordination compact with defined responsibilities, guaranteed transfers, and joint public reporting — is discussed in Chapter 15.

11.11 The Role of the National Security Committee and National Security Adviser

The NSC. The National Security Committee (chaired by the Prime Minister; comprising the service chiefs and senior ministers; supported by the National Security Division and an NSA/Adviser on National Security) is Pakistan's apex security policy forum. In KP's security, the NSC's role has included: endorsing Azm-e-Istehkam (2024); authorizing/adjusting the Afghan policy (including the resort to cross-border operations in 2026); and framing the counter-terrorism narrative ("Fitna al-Khawarij" terminology; the "hostile agencies" framing). The NSC publishes little; its decisions are conveyed through ISPR and press releases.

Critique. The NSC's opacity and its military-heavy composition (with the 27th Amendment's CDF reforms further centralizing military authority) limit both civilian and provincial input into decisions that determine KP's fate. Comparative practice suggests two reforms: (i) formal inclusion of provincial chief executives in decisions on operations within their provinces; and (ii) public summaries of decisions and frameworks — not operational detail, but decision-affecting frameworks. Absent both, federal–provincial estrangement is structural, not accidental.

11.12 Policy Coherence and Implementation Gaps: A Critical Assessment

The implementation gap as the master variable. Across every domain examined in this chapter, the pattern is the same: articulate policy; partial implementation; reversal or erosion. The causes are identifiable: (i) *no binding mechanism* (policies without statutes, budgets or reporting); (ii) *fiscal fragility* (programs dependent on discretionary allocations that evaporate under fiscal pressure — the merged districts being the outstanding example); (iii) *political discontinuity* (each government re-announces rather than continues); (iv) *institutional interest conflicts* (madrasa boards versus the state; federal agencies versus the province; cops versus CTD versus military); and (v) *absence of evaluation* (almost no policy in the KP security domain has been independently evaluated; programs survive on claims, not evidence).

Three policy deficits that most urgently need repair. (1) *The fiscal deficit in security policy:* KP fights a national counter-insurgency on provincial resources; the merged districts lack the resources promised at merger. (2) *The accountability deficit:* no reliable public data on operations, casualties, convictions, or program outcomes; no functioning parliamentary oversight of security. (3) *The legitimacy deficit:* policy instruments that criminalize political dissent (PTM; journalists) and collective punishment practices undermine the state's claim to be protecting the very populations it asks to help.

Design principle for the repair. The consistent lesson of this chapter is that KP's governance system is strong on *command* and weak on *legitimacy, accountability and fiscal predictability*. A normalization framework must therefore invert the current bias: fewer operational announcements; more statutory, funded, measurable commitments; and a public, annual normalization report by the provincial and federal governments jointly — with the KP Assembly and the public as its audience.

CHAPTER 12 — ROLE OF CIVIL SOCIETY, MEDIA AND NON-STATE ACTORS

12.1 Civil Society Organizations Working on Peace and Security in KPK

The landscape. KP's peace-oriented civil society comprises five clusters: (i) *PVE and peace-education organizations* (PAIMAN Alumni Trust, PEAD Foundation, Khwendo Kor, Aware Girls, and a network of smaller district-level groups); (ii) *human rights and legal-aid organizations* (the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan's KP chapters; the Legal Aid Society's local partners; women's legal-aid groups); (iii) *media and research organizations* (journalists' safety networks; research groups producing district-level reporting); (iv) *victims' and survivors' groups* (including families of the APS attack; displaced persons' associations such as Tehreek Mutasireen Tirah; and martyrs' family associations); and (v) *community-based and faith-based organizations* (welfare societies, zakat committees, mosque-linked charities, and youth clubs).

Contributions. Documented contributions include: mothers' networks and family-based counselling against radicalization (PAIMAN); peace education in schools and madrasas; psychosocial support for conflict-affected children; practical support to displaced persons; victim documentation (including the documentation of drone-strike and operation casualties); monitoring closed schools and girls' education restrictions; advocacy for de-mining; and the provision of the *evidence base* that policy discussions consume (including the district-level human development series by SDPI and the incident monitoring of civil-society-linked researchers).

Constraints. Five are structural: (i) *funding insecurity* — dependence on short project grants, with periods of abrupt suspension (including the 2018–2020 USAID/development-funding disruptions and the subsequent contraction of international development financing); (ii) *legal-administrative friction* — NOC requirements, registration conditions, and complex reporting mandated for foreign-funded organizations; (iii) *smearing and intimidation* — organizations critical of military conduct or government policy face campaigns, and staff face threats from both militants and (in some documented cases) state actors; (iv) *physical risk* — attacks on NGO offices, and the killing or abduction of aid workers; and (v) *shrinking space* generally (see §12.6).

Assessment. Civil society's comparative advantage in KP is *access* — to women, children, households and displaced communities that neither police nor army can reach — and its comparative weakness is *scale and sustainability*: the sector is small, project-driven, and politically exposed. A normalization strategy that fails to protect and finance it loses its most credible preventers.

12.2 The Jirga System: Traditional Conflict Resolution and Its Modern Relevance

What it is. The jirga is a deliberative assembly for dispute resolution — from small local *marakas* to district and grand jirgas — grounded in Pashtun custom (*riwaj/tor*), with procedures that vary by locality, sect and district. Its strengths are recognized: speed, accessibility, legitimacy, cost, and context-sensitivity; its verdicts often include compensation (*swara*, *nazrana*), restitution and reconciliation, and its proceedings can repair relationships in ways that courts cannot. Its most consequential recent successes are in Kurram (the 2011 truce ending a multi-year conflict that killed ~2,000; the 14-point accord of January 2025; the May 2025 *Aman Teega*), in Swat's de-escalation episodes, in Tirah's return negotiations, and in hundreds of localized feuds.

Its pathologies. Documented critiques: (i) *exclusion* — women and youth are generally excluded from decision-making; (ii) *punitive norms* — verdicts have historically included practices that violate constitutional and human rights (forced marriage/compensation involving women; collective fines); (iii) *enforcement* — jirgas cannot execute decisions against armed actors and depend on state power they often distrust; (iv) *capture* — military, religious and political actors have used grand jirgas for legitimation, and some proceedings become instruments of political theatre; and (v) *legal pluralism* — where jirgas adjudicate criminal matters, they displace the statutory system and the rights it guarantees.

Reform directions. Comparative practice (Chapter 13) and Pakistani proposals converge on: formalizing jirgas as *mediators* rather than *adjudicators* (a role adjacent to the DRC model); mandatory inclusion of women's *nominated representatives* in civil disputes involving women; a prohibition on verdicts violating statutory rights; vetting of members; state support for implementation; and explicit disentanglement from terrorism prosecutions (no jirga amnesty for grave crimes). None of this is easy in the tribal belt, but the alternative — either criminalizing the jirga (destroying legitimacy) or ignoring it (entrenching illegality) — has failed.

12.3 Tribal Elders and Maliks: Declining Influence and Security Implications

The collapse. Between 2004 and 2014, militants systematically targeted tribal notables: hundreds of *maliks* and elders were assassinated (with jirga massacres in the NMDs that killed dozens at a time), driven out, or forced to surrender their positions; the state, meanwhile, progressively suspended allowances and patronage as the Political Agent system wound down and the merger abolished it. Independent accounts describe a *generational erasure* of the intermediary class, with consequences that are still working through the system: absent interlocutors, absent community negotiators, and absent bearers of local memory and customary process.

Who replaced them? Four substitutes have emerged: (i) elected politicians (MPAs/MNAs from the merged districts) whose authority is electoral but not fiscal; (ii) *peace committee* figures (often younger, sometimes armed, and dependent on state security patronage); (iii) *religious* authority (clerics, madrasa heads) whose authority in some districts exceeds that of the state; and (iv) the militants' own "spokesmen" and enforcers — a role that completes the rupture of the old order.

Security implications. The absence of legitimate intermediaries has three effects: (a) *intelligence degradation* (no trusted local interlocutors to talk to); (b) *communication failure* (the state cannot negotiate or de-escalate locally without intermediaries); and (c) *transition risk*: post-operation settlements and return processes depend on local brokers whose legitimacy is contested — as in Tirah's 2026 return negotiations and Kurram's repeated accords, where jirgas succeed temporarily but their enforcement collapses without sustained state and community investment.

Assessment. Rebuilding legitimate intermediary capacity — through elected local government, formalized jirgas, protected elder networks, and women's and youth inclusion — is a precondition for the sustainability of any security gains. This is a *capability-building* task, not a nostalgic one; the old malik system was itself a colonial artifact, and its restoration is neither possible nor desirable.

12.4 The Role of Media: Conflict Reporting, Peace Journalism and Propaganda

The media ecology. KP hosts a dense media landscape: national outlets (Dawn, The News, Express Tribune, Geo, ARY, private TV) with substantial Peshawar bureaus; a vibrant regional press; radio (including Pashto broadcasts with wide rural reach); and a large online ecosystem. Its reports are indispensable to the historical record that this study relies upon.

Practices and pressures. (i) *Courage*: KP journalists have documented operations, displacement, casualties, refugee policy, and militant violence at enormous personal risk — KP and the merged districts have been among the world's most dangerous places for journalists, with dozens killed (including the 2021 killing of Shaheena Shaheen in Khyber and the long roster of casualties documented by press-freedom organizations). (ii) *Pressure*: reporting on military conduct, disappearances, and militant taxation has been restricted by official pressure, access denial, legal threats (PECA and ATA charges against journalists), and physical risk; the PTM ban further limited coverage through political prohibitions on the movement's activities. (iii) *Conflict-insensitive practice*: some coverage amplifies sectarian, ethnic and conspiracy framings; "Afghan" and "terrorist" are often conflated; the reporting of casualty claims by militant media (Umar Media claims of attacks and killing counts, republished widely) amplifies the militants' information objectives; and the construction of a *national security narrative* in some state-aligned outlets reduces space for evidence-based reporting on operations' civilian harm. (iv) *Peace journalism deficits*: solutions-oriented, victim-centred, non-sectarian reporting exists (e.g., reporting on Swat's recovery; the documentation of peace jirgas) but is not systematically supported.

Assessment. Media in KP is simultaneously a security actor (framing threat and policy), a restraint on abuses, and a vulnerability. The policy implications: protect journalists (transparent investigation of attacks on media); decriminalize professional reporting (resolve PECA/ATA misuse); and support peace journalism with training, safety and financing — especially in Pashto and the merged districts where trust deficits are deepest.

12.5 Social Media: Radicalization Tool or Peacebuilding Platform?

The dual character. Social media in KP plays both roles simultaneously. (1) *Radicalization and mobilization*: TTP and ISKP propaganda distribution (Chapters 3, 8); sectarian incitement (Kurram's 2024 escalation included a documented role for sectarian social media content, as the January 2025 agreement's clause on "those fomenting on social media" attests); recruitment through group chats; and — in a different register — the circulation of graphic images of violence that magnify terror's psychological effects. (2) *Peacebuilding and accountability*: social media has been central to peace mobilization (the 2022–23 Pashtun long marches; the Swat and Waziristan protest movements against militancy; village-level mutual-aid networks during floods; and displaced-persons' advocacy such as the Tirah committees). It has also been the principal channel through which the human cost of the conflict is documented and contested — including the #SwatSaniha mobilization after the June 2025 attack.

Policy tension. Pakistan's regulatory posture — platform blocking; PECA prosecutions for online speech; content takedown (1.3 million URLs by 2023) — is broad and insufficiently targeted: it has produced documented prosecutions of journalists and activists for lawful expression while failing to eliminate extremist content, which migrates to new platforms and

channels. The counter-narrative and PVE fields need online presence and credible local voices, not blanket restrictions.

Assessment. No serious normalization strategy can ignore the information domain. The minimal credible framework: (i) targeted, reviewed, appealable removal of *incitement to violence* (with published criteria and transparency reporting); (ii) protection of lawful speech (repeal or reform of PECA's broad speech offences); (iii) support for Pashto/Urdu counter-narrative content produced by local credible voices; and (iv) digital literacy in schools and madrasas.

12.6 The Pashtun Tahafuz Movement (PTM): Demands, Dynamics and Security Discourse

History and demands. The PTM grew out of the Mahsud Tahafuz Movement (May 2014), founded by students to demand de-mining and compensation after operations in Waziristan; renamed in 2018, it became the largest Pashtun civil mobilization in decades through rallies across Pakistan demanding: an end to extrajudicial killings and enforced disappearances; removal of landmines; freedom of movement (checkpoint abuses); the release of the detained; and accountability for the human costs of counter-insurgency — with a rejected demand for a truth and reconciliation framework. Its mobilization capacity was demonstrated in 2018–2019 and again in the 2021–2023 "long marches" after enforced disappearances (the disappearance and killing of Nazimuddin and others).

The ban and its context. The PTM was proscribed in October 2024 under ATA Section 11B (Chapter 4); a prior attempt at legal action (2019) and provincial bans on its leadership predated it. The state's case against the PTM rests on: provocative rhetoric against state institutions; slogans offensive to the military's identity; alleged incitement; and the risk of ethnic polarization in a war zone. The movement and its defenders emphasize its non-violence, its rights-based demands, and the absence of any documented commission of terrorism by its leadership.

Analytical assessment. The PTM is the most important non-violent Pashtun political movement since the Khudai Khidmatgar, and its treatment is the clearest current test of whether Pakistan can distinguish between *militancy* and *dissent*. The ban has (a) removed a non-violent channel for grievance articulation; (b) criminalized significant parts of the Pashtun political spectrum, particularly youth; (c) complicated counter-insurgency's local intelligence and cooperation networks (the movement's supporters include the families whose cooperation the state needs); and (d) been widely read as confirming the movement's core claim (that the state treats Pashtun grievance as security threat). For normalization, the pragmatic question is not whether to accept all the PTM's rhetoric but whether a democratic state can afford to outlaw a non-violent political movement in the middle of a counter-insurgency: the evidence from KP says it cannot.

12.7 Religious Leaders and Institutions: Constructive and Destructive Roles

Constructive roles. Religious institutions in KP perform welfare functions (madrasas educating poor children), social mediation, and moral authority. Anti-militant religious voices have been consequential: the Paigham-e-Pakistan declaration (2018); wafaq board statements; clerics who officiated at the funerals of slain police and condemned terrorist attacks; the anti-polio-vaccine reversal by many clerics after erring in some areas; and the counter-narrative content used in deradicalization (Chapter 8).

Destructive roles. A subset of institutions and leaders has supplied ideological justification, recruits and logistics to armed groups (Chapter 4); the 2019 registration framework and its 2024 reversal illustrate the sector's political leverage; and sectarian clerics have stoked inter-communal conflict (Kurram; Hangu; parts of Peshawar).

The policy choice. The state's relationship with religious authority in KP oscillates between instrumentalization (partners in the counter-narrative) and confrontation (regulation). Neither pure approach has worked. The available evidence suggests a *conditional-partnership* model: fund and credential moderate, anti-militancy institutions; enforce transparency (financing, foreign students, curricula standards) through consultative mechanisms (the Punjab registration model); and hold accountable, through law, the institutions that cross into incitement — while avoiding blanket suspicion of the sector, which produces only defensiveness and non-compliance.

12.8 International NGOs and Development Partners in KPK

Presence. KP has hosted one of Pakistan's largest development-partner footprints: UN agencies (UNDP, UNICEF, UNHCR, WFP, UN Women, IOM, UNODC); IFIs (World Bank, ADB, IFAD); bilateral donors (US and UK historical funding; EU; Germany; Japan; China); and international NGOs (Save the Children, IRC, ACTED, Islamic Relief, and others). Programs have covered: displacement response; livelihood restoration; education; health (polio, nutrition); water and sanitation; governance; and peacebuilding/PVE (with UN Women, USIP and others funding pilot work).

Contributions and limitations. Contributions: humanitarian response at scale; technical assistance in justice and police reform; evidence and monitoring (including casualty documentation and human development data); financing for education and health; and PVE pilot programming. Limitations: (i) *short-termism and projectization* — donor cycles rarely align with a decade-long normalization requirement; (ii) *absorption and access* constraints (security, government NOC requirements);

(iii) *coordination gaps* with provincial priorities and between donors; (iv) *political sensitivities* around monitoring casualties and civil-society support; and (v) the *financing shift*: the global decline of development assistance (and the diversion of funds to other crises) has reduced INGO presence in KP's conflict districts precisely as needs grew.

Assessment. Development partners cannot substitute for the state's role in security and justice; but they hold a comparative advantage in *education, health, livelihood and protection programs* — the soft infrastructure of normalization — and in *independent evaluation*, which KP's security sector almost entirely lacks. Their most valuable contribution would be a coordinated, decade-horizon program focused on the merged districts, conditioned on the government's fiscal delivery.

12.9 Youth Activism and Civic Engagement for Peace

Forms. Documented youth activism includes: the PTM's youth base and its marches; Swat's protest movements (against militancy and against military operations in different periods — including the Pashoon network's organizing, which produced the rally during which the 2 August 2026 Kabal attack occurred); student unions (long banned and only recently partially restored) and campus civic groups; sports and arts movements (cricket in the tribal districts; the recently established literary festivals); the digital freelancers who have made Peshawar and Swat hubs of online work; and village-level volunteer networks during disasters (the flood responses of 2022 and 2025).

Constraints. Youth civic engagement faces: high unemployment; the collapse of student representative institutions; the risks of protest under security laws; distrust of parties; and the lack of funded platforms. Militancy competes for the same cohort with offers of salary, status and purpose.

Assessment. Youth activism is both the primary recruitment pool and the primary peace constituency: the same cohort that militancy targets is the one that fills peace marches, volleyball courts, and freelance training programs. Policy should therefore treat youth engagement as a *security program*: sports and cultural facilities (a cheap, high-visibility intervention); funded internship/training pipelines; protected student organizations; and support for youth-led civil society.

12.10 Women's Organizations and Gender-Inclusive Security

Organizations. KP's women's movement includes: large national organizations with provincial programming (Aurat Foundation, more than four decades active); local providers (Khwendo Kor); women-led PVE groups (Aware Girls under Gulalai Ismail, which faced state pressure and whose leadership relocated); the KP Commission on the Status of Women; women's wings of political parties; and informal networks of female teachers, health workers and madrasa graduates.

Roles in security. Women's organizations have: delivered psychosocial support and family counselling; run peace education and interfaith programs; documented violence against women and girls; advocated on girls' education and school closures; supported displaced women; and engaged in cross-border dialogue (UN Women's 228-participant Afghan–Pakistani women peacebuilder network). The National Security Policy's gender commitment provides a formal basis; implementation is minimal.

Assessment. The evidence from Pakistan and internationally indicates that women's participation strengthens both prevention programs and community-level mediation (particularly in family and youth radicalization cases). In KP, women's participation is constrained by security, convention and funding — yet the female cohort (37 per cent literacy; five per cent secondary completion in the NMDs) is simultaneously the province's most under-utilized peacebuilding asset. The specific recommendations: fund women-led PVE organizations with long-horizon grants; create safe mechanisms (women's councils, female jirga auxiliaries) to participate in dispute resolution; expand female police recruitment and women's desks (Chapter 7); and protect female students and teachers with targeted security measures (routes, escort, secure campuses).

12.11 Private Sector and the Business Community's Role in Normalization

The business voice. KP's business community — chambers of commerce (Peshawar, Swat, D.I. Khan, Mardan), sector associations (marble, hotels, transporters, mining, pharmacy), and the freelancer/digital economy (a growing export sector) — has consistently articulated the costs of insecurity: extortion, KFR, transport disruption, insurance and security costs, and loss of tourism and investment. Business associations have supported relief (flood and displacement response), engaged in peace advocacy, and occasionally brokered locally.

Business as a security actor. Three roles are documented: (a) *employers* — the primary mechanism of reintegration (Chapter 8), though few firms hire ex-combatants, citing risk; (b) *advocates* — chambers have pressed for infrastructure (roads, electricity, border trade reopening) and for the release of held-up funds; (c) *targets and funders* — extortion and protection payments make businesses both victims and, involuntarily, financiers of armed groups (a dilemma most firms cannot resolve individually and which requires collective state action).

Assessment. The private sector's stake in normalization is large but unstructured. The most valuable policy moves are: (i) *public-private security compacts* (joint vetting of threats; coordinated protection of corridors; support for tourism routes with insured security); (ii) *employment incentives* for hiring at-risk youth and rehabilitees (subsidies, certification, assurances); and (iii) *transparency against extortion* (a confidential reporting channel with police protection, breaking the silence that allows extortion networks to operate).

12.12 Building a Culture of Peace: Long-Term Social Transformation

What is meant by "culture of peace" in KP. Not sentimentality, but a set of institutionalized practices and public attitudes: rejection of violence as a political instrument; acceptance of sectarian and ethnic pluralism; education that teaches critical thinking and civic values; commemoration of all victims; and the availability of peaceful channels (courts, elections, unions, media) for the grievances that currently find violent outlets.

What would build it. Seven tested components: (1) *curriculum and teachers* — civic education, critical thinking, anti-sectarian content, teacher training; (2) *memorialization and truth* — public recognition of all victims, including of state operations, with the APS memorialization being a precedent for national unity around victimhood; (3) *the arts and sports* — the most scalable counter-recruitment instruments (music, Pashto literary revival, cricket and football leagues in violence-affected districts); (4) *media pluralism* — peace journalism, local language content, journalists' protection; (5) *religious and tribal institutions* — constructive roles formalized and funded; (6) *youth and women's participation* — as above; and (7) *visible justice* — nothing builds a culture of peace more than seeing perpetrators convicted and victims compensated (Chapter 7).

The counterfactual risk. The alternative to a culture of peace is a culture of endurance: a society in which violence is understood as normal, revenge as honourable, and the state as an unreliable protector. KP has elements of both cultures today; the balance between them over the next decade will determine the durability of whatever security gains are achieved. That balance is not determined by military operations; it is determined by schools, courts, compensation payments, media, and the honesty of public accounting for what has happened.

CHAPTER 13 — COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS AND INTERNATIONAL LESSONS

13.1 Northern Ireland Peace Process: Power-Sharing, Decommissioning and Lessons for KPK

The settlement. The Good Friday/Belfast Agreement (1998) ended three decades of conflict (the "Troubles": ~3,500 deaths) through a three-stranded architecture: power-sharing in a devolved assembly; North–South and East–West institutions; and mutual concessions on prisoners, decommissioning and policing. Violence did not end in 1998 — dissident republicans and loyalists persisted, and the killings of the 2000s (including the 1998 Omagh bombing that killed 29) and the 2011 death of a police officer demonstrated the residual threat — but the political process held. Subsequent agreements (St Andrews 2006; the 2005 IRA decommissioning) consolidated it.

Key mechanisms. (i) *Inclusion of non-violent politics*: Sinn Féin and the loyalist parties were brought into constitutional politics; the state did not defeat the IRA militarily, nor did it demand ideological surrender — it demanded the end of violence and acceptance of the political process. (ii) *Police reform as a peace dividend*: the Patten Commission (1999) produced the most far-reaching police reform in the developed world — renamed service (PSNI), new recruitment quotas, human-rights-based training, an independent ombudsman and Policing Board. This is arguably the single most transferable element to KPK: the recognition that a security force seen as an instrument of one community cannot deliver normalization. (iii) *Prisoner releases and victim-centred legacy bodies*: early releases were traded for violence-ending; but legacy issues (collusion inquiries, victims' pensions, inquests) remain disputed, illustrating how *unresolved truth* can persist for decades. (iv) *Economic dividend and reconstruction*: investment (including EU peace programmes) helped normalize. (iv) *Third-party facilitation*: US, British and Irish governments as guarantors, plus independent monitors.

Counterpoints. Northern Ireland's conditions differ from KP's in crucial ways: the conflict was intra-provincial but within a single developed state; there was no cross-border sanctuary (though arms smuggling existed) and the "Kinahan" organized-crime overlap came later; and the British state's fiscal capacity dwarfed Pakistan's provincial budgets. Its principal relevance is therefore *not* the grand settlement but the three operational doctrines: police reform, inclusive political process, and sequenced prisoner/justice measures with monitoring.

13.2 Colombia's Peace Agreement with FARC: DDR Programs and Transitional Justice

The settlement. The 2016 Havana agreement between the Colombian government and the FARC ended a 52-year conflict (over 220,000 deaths). It comprised: (i) *rural reform* (land restitution, development); (ii) *political participation* (the FARC's transformation into a political party with guaranteed seats); (iii) *drugs policy* (crop substitution, voluntary eradication); (iv) *transitional justice* (the Special Jurisdiction for Peace, JEP; the Truth Commission; reparations); and (v) *DDR* — with around 13,000 combatants demobilized into reintegration zones, individual reintegration plans, income support, and monitoring.

Outcomes and lessons. (i) *DDR can work at scale, but its survival depends on security guarantees*: hundreds of former combatants were assassinated after demobilization (over 400 documented in the years following), and dissident factions (with coca-related interests) re-armed; the lesson for KP is precise: reintegration without protection (from former enemies, criminal groups and rogue state agents) fails. (ii) *Politics as the DDR's endpoint*: the FARC's conversion into a political party was contested domestically but provided a non-violent outlet for membership. (iii) *Partial implementation is corrosive*: delays in land reform and security guarantees drive dissidence and erode the public's faith in the agreement. (iv) *Justice with participation*: the JEP's mix of restorative and retributive sanctions is a model for contexts where blanket amnesty is politically impossible (as in KP, where victims' families would reject impunity) — but it requires enormous institutional investment and years of patience.

13.3 Sri Lanka's Post-LTTE Normalization: Military Victory and Political Reconciliation

The case. Sri Lanka's military defeat of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) in 2009 ended a 26-year civil war and eliminated the world's most effective insurgency's territorial control. The government's approach to post-war normalization combined: massive military presence in the north/east; infrastructure and economic development (especially in Colombo and the east); a Lessons Learnt and Reconciliation Commission (2011); and minimal political devolution. Reconciliation stalled; militarization persisted; the recommendations of accountability mechanisms were largely unimplemented; the 2019 Easter Sunday bombings (retaliatory-Islamic State-linked) and the 2022 economic collapse showed how the absence of a political settlement leaves structural vulnerabilities.

Lessons for KP. (i) *Military victory is not normalization*: Sri Lanka defeated the LTTE but did not end Tamil grievances; the absence of devolution and truth-telling produced a long-term legitimacy deficit that proved internationally costly. (ii) *Development without political settlement buys quiet for a while*. (iii) *The counterfactual of a "hard security" model* is that it can suppress insurgency but cannot produce durable peace — a warning equally applicable to any strategy of pure coercion in KP. Transposed to the province: even a successful campaign against the TTP would not automatically normalize Swat, the NMDs, or Kurram.

13.4 Iraqi Kurdistan's Security Transition: Peshmerga, Governance and Economic Development

The case. The Kurdistan Region of Iraq (KRI) built a functioning autonomous administration after 1991 (Safe Haven; no-fly zone), with its own Peshmerga forces, two-party system (KDP/PUK), and — from 2003 — substantial oil revenues. It has been more stable than central Iraq but faces: internal party-based security fragmentation (duplicated Peshmerga structures under KDP and PUK control); fiscal dependence on Baghdad transfers and oil; the 2017 independence referendum's disastrous aftermath (loss of Kirkuk; economic crisis); the ISIL war (2014–2017), in which Peshmerga fought; and long-standing governance deficits (corruption, delayed elections, patronage).

Lessons for KP. (i) *Autonomy/devolution can stabilize if it is fiscally real*: the KRI's stability rests on revenue-sharing (which it fought over) — an echo of the merged districts' fiscal shortfall. (ii) *Security-sector fragmentation along party lines entrenches instability*: the KDP–PUK duplication is a warning for any provincial force built on patronage — and for the NMD policing model (Chapter 7). (iii) *Internal political unity is a security precondition*: the KRI's biggest vulnerabilities were internal (2017 referendum; the 2013–15 budget standoff), not military — an analogy to the federal–provincial estrangement over KP's security (Chapter 11). (iv) *Oil/dependable rent economies are not a substitute for institutionalized statebuilding*.

13.5 Afghanistan's Ongoing Challenges: Lessons in What Not to Do

The record, 2001–2026. Afghanistan's post-2001 experience offers negative lessons unmatched in the contemporary record: (i) *DDR without a political settlement*: the Afghanistan Peace and Reintegration Programme (APRP) and earlier DDR efforts demobilized tens of thousands of combatants superficially while warlord networks — and their militias — retained power, ensuring that demobilization did not reduce armed politics (some DDR beneficiaries rejoined the Taliban). (ii) *Counter-insurgency dependent on foreign forces*: the ANSF collapsed within weeks of the allied withdrawal (August 2021), demonstrating that security forces built on external funding, airlift and logistics collapse when the patron leaves. (iii) *Corruption and parallel governance*: the Kabul government's legitimacy deficit — warlord capture, electoral fraud, and predatory local administration — handed the Taliban their strongest recruiting argument ("we deliver justice, they sell it"). (iv) *Sanctuary myopia*: the alliance's toleration of Taliban sanctuaries in Pakistan (2005–2021) and Pakistan's toleration of TTP sanctuaries in Afghanistan (2021–2026) show both how sanctuaries extend conflicts and how each side's short-term calculus lengthens the war. (v) *The peace process's design failure*: the US–Taliban Doha agreement (2020) excluded the Afghan government and traded withdrawal for promises rather than verification, producing the collapse of the government before any negotiated settlement.

Lessons for KP. The Afghan record is the study's principal caution against five fallacies: that security forces can be *rented* rather than built; that *reintegration* without politics and economics works; that *corruption* is a side-issue in counter-insurgency; that *sanctuaries* can be tolerated with impunity; and that *peace processes* designed to satisfy external actors will hold.

13.6 Mozambique and Sierra Leone: African Models of Post-Conflict Recovery

Mozambique (1992 Rome General Peace Accords). The accords between Frelimo and Renamo ended a 16-year civil war; UN-supported DDR demobilized ~90,000 combatants; multiparty elections (1994) brought Renamo into politics; and sustained growth followed. The success factors: a genuine mutual hurting stalemate; effective third-party mediation (the Sant'Egidio community, with UN and Italian). The cautionary suffix: Renamo's return to armed conflict (2012–2016) after protracted exclusion and electoral disputes in 2013–16, and the Cabo Delgado insurgency (from 2017) that revealed how a resource-rich periphery with weak governance can become a new conflict frontier. The KP relevance: demobilization success does not immunize against future insurgency if political exclusion and peripheral governance persist.

Sierra Leone (1999 Lomé → 2002 end). The rebel RUF's terror campaign (amputations, child soldiering) ended through a combination of British military intervention (2000), UN peacekeeping, DDR of ~70,000 combatants, a Truth and Reconciliation Commission, and a Special Court (which tried Charles Taylor and others) — a case demonstrating that hybrid justice (truth commission + court) with sustained external involvement can consolidate peace. The KP applicability is limited by scale and geopolitics but the *model* — local truth-telling plus selective judicial accountability — is relevant to Kurram,

Swat and the NMDs, where impunity is pervasive and grievance accumulates.

13.7 The Philippines' Mindanao Peace Process: Autonomous Governance and Security

The case. The Mindanao conflict between the Philippine state and Moro insurgencies produced two settlements: with the Moro National Liberation Front (1996) and the far more consequential 2014 Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro with the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF), institutionalized through the Bangsamoro Organic Law (2018) and the establishment of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region (BARMM, 2019). Key mechanisms: (i) *asymmetric autonomy* with a regional parliamentary government, fiscal arrangements (block grants, tax powers) and specified competences; (ii) *phased decommissioning* of the MILF's 40,000-strong force — with donors providing transition payments — implemented in stages that continued after 2019; (iii) *third-party monitoring* (the International Monitoring Team, IMT, with Malaysian, Indonesian, Japanese and other participation; the Independent Decommissioning Body; the Third-Party Monitoring Team reporting publicly); (iv) *militia normalization* (dealing with private armed groups); and (v) *economic development* (roads, social services).

Outcomes and lessons. Progress has been real (violence declined among the main groups; BARMM has governed since 2019) but partial: residual jihadist groups (BIFF, IS-linked factions) exploited the transition; clan politics and electoral violence persist; the 2022 elections tested the transition; and the normalization annexes (decommissioning, disbanding private armies, policing) lagged implementation. **KP relevance** — the closest structural analogy available: (i) *autonomy with real fiscal transfers* is the analogue of the merged-district settlement: promised transfers that are not delivered undermine the political class the settlement creates; (ii) *third-party monitoring with public reporting* — an approach entirely absent from KP's merger implementation — creates accountability and confidence; (iii) *phased, funded decommissioning of armed groups* is the analogue of a future TTP disengagement process, should one ever be possible; and (iv) the residual-jihadist problem (BIFF/ISKP-analogue) persists in every post-settlement environment, requiring sustained counter-terrorism even after a political settlement.

13.8 Chechnya/Dagestan: Russia's Counter-Insurgency Model (Critical Assessment)

The model. Russia's North Caucasus campaigns (two wars in Chechnya: 1994–96, 1999–2009; continuous operations in Dagestan and Ingushetia) produced a form of stabilization that combined: overwhelming force (massive artillery and air campaigns; "cleansing" operations — documented mass abuses); "Chechenization"/"Kadyrovization" — transferring security to a local strongman, Ramzan Kadyrov, with a large militia/police apparatus funded from Moscow; extreme coercion plus selective social subsidy; and the suppression of all independent political activity, media and civil society. The measured outcome: open insurgency in Chechnya was largely defeated; extremist violence shifted to Dagestan/Ingushetia in the late 2000s and declined substantially by the 2010s — while producing: thousands killed and displaced; mass human-rights abuses (documented by Memorial and others, including "disappearances," torture, and persecution of LGBT individuals); a repressive, personality-based regional regime; and export of violence (the 2013 Boston Marathon bombing by Chechen-linked brothers; ISKP recruitment from the Caucasus).

Critical assessment and relevance. The Chechen case demonstrates that *militarily effective* counter-insurgency is achievable through extreme coercion — and that its costs include the destruction of the rule of law, the corruption of the state, exported violence, and the impossibility of measuring "success" against anything but the absence of armed self-reporting. It is not a transferable model for Pakistan for three reasons: (i) Pakistan is not an authoritarian federation able to impose a Kadyrov-type equilibrium without dismantling its own constitutional order (though the 27th Amendment's centralization moves in that direction); (ii) the Chechen analogue would require a monolithic local enforcer with consolidated power — which no single faction in KP possesses; (iii) the model leaves the recruitment narrative intact and merely suppresses its expression, producing periodic recurrence. Its *one* legitimate lesson: local security forces with local legitimacy (however manufactured) outperform foreign ones — but only if "local legitimacy" is built through consent, not terror.

Dagestan's specifics are arguably more relevant to KP: a region with a mixed ethnic composition, a Salafi-jihadist insurgency operating from rural and mountainous sanctuaries, an ethnic and governance mix, and an insurgency that was ultimately suppressed by a combination of special operations, amnesties, and co-opted religious authorities — with recurring resurgences whenever the co-optation or coercion lapsed.

13.9 Comparative Framework: Key Variables for Successful Security Normalization

Variable	Evidence from cases	KP position (2026)
1. Political settlement	NI, Colombia, Mindanao, Mozambique (1992) succeeded where settlements created non-violent outlets; Sri Lanka, Chechnya & Afghanistan failed without them	Absent — no settlement; TTP excluded from politics; PTM banned

Variable	Evidence from cases	KP position (2026)
2. DDR/reintegration	Colombia & Mindanao: effective with financing, security guarantees, political integration; Afghanistan: failed without politics; Cabo Delgado: reconstruction ≠ reconciliation	Nascent/marginal (Chapters 8)
3. Police & justice reform	NI: the single most consequential reform; Colombia: rural justice gaps drove dissidence	KP Act 2017 progressive; implementation partial; NMD policing unresolved
4. Economic dividend & reconstruction	NI/Mindanao: consequential; Sierra Leone: partial; Mozambique (Cabo Delgado): insufficient	Swat recovered; NMDs' fiscal shortfall catastrophic
5. Sanctuary management	Afghanistan/Pakistan: sanctuary prolongs; Colombia: neighbours cooperated	Acute (Afghanistan); unresolved
6. Inclusion & local legitimacy	Mindanao autonomy, NI inclusion, KRI devolution vs Sri Lanka/Chechnya exclusion	NMD local government absent; PTM/PTM-aligned youth excluded
7. Transitional justice/victims	Sierra Leone (TRC+SC); Colombia (JEP); NI (legacy unresolved → 25+ years of dispute)	Absent; impunity widespread; no victims' process
8. Third-party guarantees & monitoring	Mindanao (IMT/TPMT); NI (guarantors); Mozambique (Sant'Egidio)	Episodic (Qatar/Türkiye/China mediation) without institution
9. Time horizon	All successful cases: 10–25+ years of sustained attention	Policy horizon is election-cycle; no long-horizon framework
10. State coherence	KRI fragmentation, Afghan corruption: internal incoherence lethal; NI required London–Dublin–Belfast alignment	Federal–provincial estrangement is acute

Synthesis. Across cases, no variable is sufficient alone, and the *sequencing varies* — but the recurring pattern is: a *political framework* (settlement, autonomy, or inclusion) + *security-sector reform* + *economic dividend* + *legitimacy mechanisms* (justice/truth) delivered over a decade or more, with third-party monitoring. Where any element is missing, normalization stalls even when violence declines.

13.10 Transferable Lessons and Contextual Adaptations for KPK

Lessons that transfer directly.

- 1. Police reform is the load-bearing wall** (Northern Ireland). KP cannot normalize while its police are simultaneously victims, occupiers and ineffective — the Patten-style agenda (rights-based training, community accountability, representative recruitment, independent oversight, professional investigations) applies with modifications to the KP Police Act 2017 framework and the NMD policing question.
- 2. Reintegration must be protected and financed** (Colombia, Mindanao): ex-combatants who are killed, excluded or impoverished become the next insurgency. KP's deradicalization programs need security guarantees, employment, and community acceptance.
- 3. Third-party monitoring creates accountability** (Mindanao): an independent monitoring body with public reporting — for the merged districts' fiscal commitments and for any security arrangement with Afghanistan — would address the implementation-gap pattern that defines KP's policy history.
- 4. Fiscal delivery is the political class's lifeblood** (Mindanao/BARMM, KRI): promised transfers not delivered discredit the settlement's local champions; KP's Rs 568 billion shortfall is precisely this failure.
- 5. Justice must be visible, but need not be retributive-only** (Sierra Leone, Colombia): hybrid approaches (local truth processes; selective accountability; reparations) can substitute where full trials are impossible — relevant to Kurram and to state-abuse victims.
- 6. The security sector cannot be a rented service** (Afghanistan): the police and courts must be built as indigenous institutions with public legitimacy, not as donor-funded expeditionary capacity.

Lessons requiring adaptation (not transfer).

- 1. Peace agreements with insurgents** (NI, Mindanao): KP's TTP is not a political movement with negotiable demands comparable to the IRA or MILF; any negotiation must deal with a coalition whose factions split (JuA 2026) and whose sponsorship base is external — so the *negotiation design* must be decentralized, conditional, verified, and staged (cessation → confidence-building → disengagement → reintegration), and must not repeat the failed pattern of unverified deals (2004–2008; 2021–22).
- 2. Autonomy as a solution:** KP's challenge is not secession but integration; the Mindanao analogy is *fiscal devolution and local self-government*, not sovereignty.
- 3. International intervention:** no external force will provide security in KP; the "third party" roles are monitoring, mediation, financing and evaluation — and those are available.

The synthesis for policy. KP's optimal pathway is a *hybrid* of the Northern Ireland (police/justice/inclusion), Mindanao (fiscal autonomy and monitoring), Colombia (reintegration and transitional justice), and Sierra Leone (truth plus selective accountability) models, adapted to the conditions of an entrenched, sanctuary-supported insurgency within a nuclear-armed federal state. Chapter 15 translates this into an implementable roadmap; Chapter 14 establishes its strategic context.

CHAPTER 14 — SCENARIOS, PROJECTIONS AND RISK ASSESSMENT

Methodological Note on Scenario Construction

The scenario method used here is *driver-based* rather than forecasting: rather than extrapolating trend lines, the analysis identifies the four variables with the greatest demonstrated causal weight on KP's security trajectory (established in Chapters 3–11) — (i) the Afghanistan security channel; (ii) the federal–provincial security compact; (iii) the merged districts' fiscal settlement and governance build-out; and (iv) the police protection and capability trajectory — and constructs alternative futures from their interactions. Probabilities are *subjective assessments* derived from historical base rates (KP's record of relapse; the failure rate of ceasefires; the repeat of operation cycles) and from current trend evidence (2026 data). They are offered to discipline thinking, not to claim precision.

14.1 Scenario 1: Optimistic Trajectory — Sustained Normalization and Peace Consolidation

Probability: 15–20 per cent over 2026–2035 (under current leadership and resource conditions).

Narrative. In this scenario, a conjunction of three favourable developments occurs within 24–36 months. First, the Pakistan–Afghanistan channel stabilizes: a mediated arrangement (Chinese/Qatari/Turkish/Saudi facilitation) establishes a monitoring mechanism with reciprocal commitments — TTP relocations away from the border, verified curbs on cross-border movement, prisoner exchanges, and trade/mobility normalization (Chapters 9, 15). The TTP's sanctuary dividend erodes gradually, and its operational tempo declines as leadership losses (already significant: 921 militants killed in Q3 2026 alone) accumulate without replacement from safe rear areas. Second, the fiscal settlement of the merged districts is delivered: following the Prime Minister's June 2026 assurance, the NFC revision process (or a presidential order under Article 160) creates a statutory, ring-fenced transfer of the promised 3 per cent (or an equivalent quantified package), and the 2028 expiry of the original commitment is pre-empted by a successor framework. The merged districts immediately see payrolls funded, ~6,000 promised police posts created, courts staffed, and road/health/school projects resumed. Third, the federal–provincial compact is repaired through a statutory coordination framework and a security-financing arrangement that eschews political blame games; the police receive protection equipment, counter-drone and counter-IED capability, and the casualty rate declines from the 2026 peak.

Outcome indicators by 2030. KP violence-linked fatalities fall below 500/year (vs 2,331 in 2025); police killed fall to double digits annually; attacks on the NMDs decline 60 per cent-plus; tourism exceeds 20 million provincial visitors; Rashakai and the NMDs' mineral sector generate visible employment; the merged districts' fiscal absorption reaches 80 per cent of allocated funds; and a functioning district judiciary is reported in all seven NMDs.

Requisites (each necessary). A verifiable Afghanistan arrangement; fiscal settlement legislated; leadership continuity across at least two electoral cycles; sustained external (donor) financing for reintegration and education; internal TTP fragmentation exploited; and no major India–Pakistan crisis.

Assessment. This scenario's low probability is a function of the number of independent conditions, not of their impossibility. Notably, its *most* contingent element is the fiscal settlement — the one item requiring no adversary's consent. That asymmetry is the strongest argument in the study for prioritizing it.

14.2 Scenario 2: Status Quo — Fragile Equilibrium with Periodic Violence

Probability: 50–60 per cent — the central case.

Narrative. Hostilities with Afghanistan oscillate between episodes of relative calm (ceasefires, mediation cycles) and strikes-and-retaliation cycles; the TTP retains its sanctuary and enough capacity to sustain 300–600 attacks per month across KP, with periodic spectacular attacks (a Kohat- or Swat-scale event every 6–18 months, an Islamabad-scale event every 1–3 years). The police continue to absorb losses (100–150 killed annually) with incremental equipment and technology improvements; IBOs continue to kill several hundred militants annually; the merged districts' fiscal shortfall is partially addressed (piecemeal releases; political bargaining) but not structurally resolved; local government remains stalled; and economic recovery proceeds unevenly (tourism resilient; investment cautious).

Outcome indicators. Annual KP violence-linked fatalities steady in the 1,400–2,500 band; deaths among security forces 300–500 annually; attacks on the police 600–900 annually; displacement episodes of 20,000–100,000 people recurring in the frontier districts; education and health indicators stagnant; radicalization pipelines partially replaced by ongoing recruitment.

Why this is the central case. It requires no change in any party's behaviour — it is the continuation of observable trends (2024–2026), smoothed. It is "fragile" because the equilibrium can tip (Scenario 3) on any of several shocks, and it is "equilibrium" because none of the core drivers is self-correcting: the sanctuary persists, the fiscal shortfall persists, and the police protection deficit persists.

14.3 Scenario 3: Deterioration — Resurgence of Militancy and State-Erosion Risk

Probability: 25–30 per cent by 2035 (with sub-scenarios below).

Narrative components (each independently plausible). (a) *Interstate escalation trap*: repeated mass-casualty attacks inside Pakistan trigger larger strikes on Afghanistan; Kabul retaliates with sustained border fire and drone attacks; Torkham and Ghulam Khan close for months; cross-border trade collapses; border populations (already displaced 33,800 families in Tirah alone) radicalize further; and the TTP's Operation Khyber framing gains traction (Chapters 3, 9). (b) *Urban mass-casualty terrorism*: an ISKP or TTP attack on a soft urban target in Peshawar or Islamabad (a mosque, hospital, market, or school) produces political panic, curfews, and possibly a nationwide crackdown that compounds alienation. (c) *Police collapse dynamic*: if police casualties continue at 2026 rates (+93.7 per cent H1/2025→H1/2026), recruitment, retention and morale degrade to the point where static posts are abandoned and rural policing collapses in parts of the south — handing some districts to TTP's parallel governance (taxation, courts), a threshold-crossing event that would make the NMDs resemble pre-2009 Swat. (d) *Escalation in sectarian conflict*: a Kurram-scale or larger incident (a major attack on a Shia procession, or a Hazara massacre) ignites sustained sectarian warfare; the state's capacity is diverted; and both Iran-linked and ISKP-linked escalatory pressures intensify. (e) *Two-front stress*: an India–Pakistan crisis (e.g., a repeat of 2019 or 2025-style exchanges) draws forces eastward, creating space for TTP/BLA operations in the west.

Outcome indicators. Annual KP fatalities exceed 3,500; the TTP holds "no-go" pockets by night in ≥ 3 districts; parallel taxation is routinized in ≥ 5 NMD districts; police recruitment shortfalls exceed 20 per cent; provincial revenue-strapped government fails to pay salaries on time; provincial elections (or their postponement) become a legitimacy crisis.

Assessment. The constituent risks are not hypothetical; several have already occurred in partial form (the 2026 war; the Kohat attack; Tirah displacement; Kurram's siege-like closure). What distinguishes Scenario 3 from the status quo is *threshold crossing*: the transition from episodic violence to durable loss of state control in parts of the province — which would require not a new set of causes but the removal of the current counterweights (police presence, tribal resistance, intelligence penetration, international attention).

14.4 Key Variables and Tipping Points

Variable	Direction that improves security	Tipping point (negative)
Afghanistan channel	Mediated, verifiable arrangement; TTP relocation pressures	Sustained border war; sanctuary consolidation; TTP leadership freed from restraint
Federal–provincial compact	Statutory coordination; security financing; unified narrative	Continued estrangement; provincial refusal to support operations; federal exclusion of Peshawar
Merged districts' fiscal settlement	3% floor legislated (or equivalent); transfers on schedule; local government funded	Expiry in 2028 without successor; further withholding; visible elite capture
Police protection & capability	Protected mobility, counter-IED, counter-drone; casualty decline; tenure stability	Casualty rates above H1 2026 (122/6 months); mass resignations; collapse of static posts
Justice & prison system	Convictions in visible cases; witness protection; ATC throughput	High-profile acquittals/escapes; military-court overuse eroding legitimacy
PTM and civic space	Legal political space; release of activists; protest normalization	Further proscriptions; mass arrests of young Pashtun activists
Sectarian flashpoints (Kurram)	Enforced peace agreement; reopened roads; disarmament	Mass-casualty sectarian attack; sustained road closure
Economy & employment	Growth, exports (tourism, IT, minerals), youth employment	Fiscal crisis; rupee shock; loss of remittances (Gulf)
External finance	Donor support for reintegration/education	Global aid contraction; CPEC pause after a major attack
Elite cohesion	Cross-party consensus on security framework	Contested election/postponement; imposition of emergency governance

Figure 5. KP security scenarios to 2035 (Chapter 14 assessments)

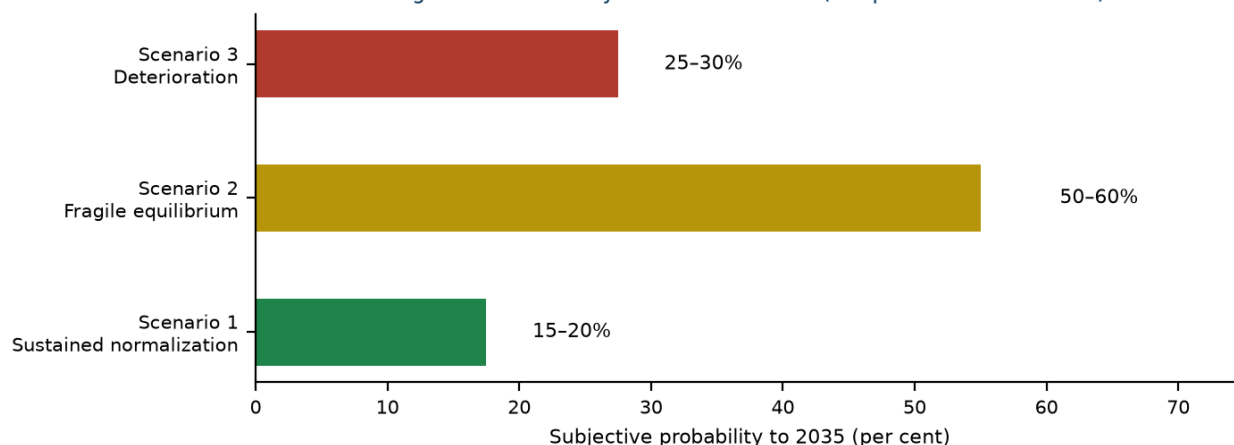


Figure 5. Subjective probability assessments for the three KP security scenarios to 2035 (Chapter 14). These are analytic judgements, not forecasts; Chapter 9's five geopolitical scenarios describe the external environment within which these outcomes would unfold.

14.5 Risk Assessment Matrix: Political, Security, Economic, Social and External Risks

Risk	Likelihood (to 2035)	Impact	Composite	Mitigation lever
Mass-casualty urban terror attack	High	High	Critical	Intelligence fusion; protection of soft targets; deradicalization
Sustained border war with Afghanistan	Medium-High	Very High	Critical	Mediation; verification mechanism; border regime
Police force attrition/collapse in south KP	Medium	Very High	Critical	Protection package; federal financing; recruitment in situ
Sectarian mass-casualty escalation (Kurram/Parachinar)	Medium	Very High	Critical	Enforced accords; road security; disarmament; justice
Fiscal failure of the merger (post-2028)	Medium-High	High	High	Statutory fund; presidential order; donor conditionality
ISKP expansion in KP	Medium	High	High	Targeted CT; border control; sectarian de-escalation
PTM-related unrest/martyr narratives	Medium-High	Medium	High	Lift proscription; lawful political space; dialogue
Climate disaster (mega-flood/GLOF)	High (recurring)	High	High	Preparedness; resilient infrastructure; relief accountability
CPEC/Chinese national attack (major)	Medium	High	High	Protection; local employment; political de-risking
Two-front crisis (India)	Medium	Very High	High	Strategic restraint; crisis management
Youth radicalization acceleration	High (structural)	Medium-High	High	Education; employment; PVE at scale
Economy/fiscal shock (IMF-linked)	Medium-High	Medium	Medium-High	Fiscal stability; provincial revenue reform

14.6 Early Warning Indicators for Security Deterioration

A functional early-warning system (currently absent) would track, quarterly: (1) attack frequency and fatality trends by district, disaggregated by actor and target type; (2) police casualties and attacks, and *thwarted* attacks, by district; (3) TTP taxation/"checkpoint" reports by district; (4) drone-attack attempts and counter-drone successes; (5) compensation-payment arrears and displaced-return rates; (6) school closures and girl-enrolment by district; (7) conviction rates and pending cases in ATCs; (8) TTP/ISKP propaganda volume and recruitment narratives (media monitoring); (9) cross-border trade volumes and border-post closure days; (10) local-government budget flows (or their absence); (11) police recruitment/retention rates; and (12) sectoral indicators of state presence (health facilities functional; courts sitting; teachers present). Thresholds on several indicators (e.g., a district where TTP taxation is reported for two consecutive quarters; three consecutive months of rising police attacks; failure to pay compensation within 180 days) would trip escalation of the response — from development acceleration to security surge.

14.7 The Role of Climate Change and Environmental Degradation in Future Security

The risk profile. KP faces: accelerated glacial melt (Pakistan has 7,000+ glaciers, mostly in KP and Gilgit-Baltistan); increased monsoon intensity (the NDMA forecast 22–26 per cent above-normal rainfall for 2026); GLOF risk in Chitral, Swat, Dir and Gilgit-Baltistan's border areas; flash flooding (the 2025 disaster: 504 KP deaths, 1.57 million affected, ~100,000 displaced, 437 schools affected, 60 health facilities damaged); landslides; and prolonged drought cycles in the southern districts. These are *security-relevant* through five channels: (i) displacement (recruitment, trafficking, and lost

livelihoods); (ii) the destruction of state infrastructure precisely in contested districts; (iii) relief distribution becoming a site of capture and conflict (flood relief in KP has been politically contested); (iv) water conflict (canals, entitlements, and the trans-boundary Kabul River); and (v) economic contraction (agriculture losses driving rural poverty, which is already increasing).

Scenario relevance. Climate shocks in Scenario 2 are recurrent stress; in Scenario 3 they are accelerants. Policy must integrate climate resilience into the security framework: flood-resilient roads and schools (double-purpose: state presence and disaster protection), upstream GLOF early warning, and relief distribution through transparent, community-audited mechanisms (avoiding the patronage capture that feeds grievance).

14.8 Demographic Trends and Their Security Implications (Youth Bulge, Urbanization)

Trends. KP's population (~40 million) is growing at roughly 2 per cent-plus annually, with about half under 25. Urbanization is accelerating: Peshawar's metropolitan area, Mardan, Swat, Abbottabad and D.I. Khan are growing, driven by rural-to-urban migration, displacement, and conflict. The combined effect by 2035: a labour force expanding by ~400,000–600,000 people per year against formal job creation that in recent years has been a fraction of that figure.

Security implications. (i) *Urbanization of violence*: as cities grow, so does the target set for terrorism (markets, transport, mosques, government offices) — the pattern already visible in Peshawar, and threatened in the Kohat/Swat episodes. (ii) *Informal settlements*: rapid urbanization produces unplanned peripheral settlements (the natural habitat for anonymity, criminality and radicalization networks). (iii) *The youth bulge*: a cohort with weak job prospects and strong connectivity will generate recruitment pressure and mobilization potential for both militant and protest movements — the PTM's peak mobilization (2018–2020) was demographically driven. (iv) *Elderly/veteran problem*: decades of conflict produce a large cohort of injured, traumatized and disarmed men needing reintegration.

Policy implication. Any normalization plan that does not include an explicit *urban and youth strategy* (housing, transport, skills, sports/culture, and urban policing) will be overwhelmed by demography. Conversely, urbanization can be an advantage: services are cheaper to deliver in dense settlements, and city governance — if empowered — can be a laboratory for accountable security provision.

14.9 Technology, AI and the Future of Security Management in KPK

Applications now arriving. (i) *Surveillance*: the Peshawar Safe City system (711 AI cameras, facial recognition; D.I. Khan, Bannu, Lakki Marwat in progress) plus mobile surveillance vehicles, drones and anti-drone systems. (ii) *Biometrics and identity*: NADRA-linked verification, SIM registration, border-crossing biometrics. (iii) *Military technologies*: anti-drone electronic warfare; night-vision and precision optics; ISR drones. (iv) *Data analytics*: police data systems; the provincial "Digital Transformation Policy 2030." (v) *Militant technologies*: quadcopter IED delivery (341 attacks foiled in H1 2026), commercial drones, encrypted communications, online propaganda.

Emerging risks and opportunities. *Opportunities*: predictive policing (with safeguards); automated threat alerts at checkpoints; rapid forensic identification; counter-drone systems; digital payment tracking (anti-financing); and e-governance improving service delivery and reducing corruption contact points. *Risks*: (i) *rights and oversight* — facial recognition without data protection (there is no Pakistani data-protection law of general application) becomes a tool of political surveillance; the Safe City Authority, if executive-controlled, would compound the 27th Amendment's centralization; (ii) *technological overconfidence* — cameras cannot solve a rural insurgency in which the state lacks presence, intelligence and legitimacy; (iii) *the adversary adapts* — drone/dark-web/AI-enabled propaganda will evolve faster than procurement cycles; and (iv) *digital exclusion* — merged-district connectivity gaps mean the digital dividend accrues unevenly, deepening the core-periphery gap.

Policy direction. (a) Legislate data protection and surveillance oversight *before* expanding the Safe City network; (b) treat counter-drone capability as a frontline police protection requirement (the Karak attack pattern); (c) invest in counter-propaganda AI tools only within a rights framework with published rules; and (d) prioritize *investigative* technology (forensics, digital evidence chain of custody) over mass surveillance — the former is what converts detentions into convictions, the latter is what produces grievance.

14.10 Strategic Foresight: KPK Security in 2035

Three 2035 snapshots, corresponding to the scenarios above:

2035-A (Normalization, ~18 per cent). KP is a middle-income provincial economy with functioning district courts in the NMDs, a professionalized police force with an NMD wing, a legislated merged-districts fund delivering on schedule, 20 million annual tourists, a minerals sector with community benefit-sharing, and a border regime with Afghanistan managed through monitoring agreements. Violence is at criminal levels (200–400 fatalities/year), and the FATA merger is regarded

regionally as a success model. This future requires the fiscal settlement and a border détente — nothing else.

2035-B (Fragile Equilibrium, ~55 per cent). KP has absorbed another decade of violence: cumulative 200,000+ displaced, tens of thousands dead, a police force hollowed by casualties, an economy that grows slowly while the merged districts remain the poorest in Pakistan, periodic border wars with Afghanistan, and a political system in which security remains the dominant issue. Tourism continues; the province holds; but its institutions remain below the level required to break with the past.

2035-C (Deterioration, ~27 per cent). The eastward shift of the insurgency continues to the settled districts; the TTP exercises parallel governance in some NMD pockets; sectarian conflict has erupted at scale in at least one district; the state's response has produced further centralization and repression; a PTI-era political crisis has hardened Pashtun alienation; and Pakistan ranks among the world's most terrorism-affected countries for a decade running. This future's seeds are visible in 2026's data — a 93.7 per cent increase in police fatalities, a Rs 568 billion fiscal betrayal, and an interstate war with no exit.

Foresight conclusion. The difference between these futures is not primarily the number of militants Pakistan kills; it is the delivery of three state commitments that are entirely within Pakistan's control: money for the merged districts; protection for the police; and a lawful political channel for Pashtun grievance. The external variable — the Afghan sanctuary — can be mitigated or worsened by diplomacy, but it cannot be waited out. **KP's 2035 hinges on whether Peshawar and Islamabad treat the province as a constitutional partner or as a war zone with a budget.**

CHAPTER 15 — A PHASED ROADMAP FOR NORMALIZATION: IMPLEMENTATION, MONITORING AND FINANCING

15.1 Purpose, Design Principles and the Logic of Sequencing

Purpose. This chapter converts the study's findings into an implementable agenda. Its objective is not to end all violence — no plan can — but to move the province from Scenario 2 (fragile equilibrium) toward Scenario 1 (sustained normalization) and to make a transition to Scenario 3 (deterioration) less likely. The roadmap is deliberately long-horizon: 15 years, in three phases (0–2, 2–5, 5–15 years), because the evidence in Chapters 13–14 shows that normalization is generational, not annual.

Design principles.

1. **Security and legitimacy together.** Operations that kill militants without building the institutions that replace them (courts, police, local government) reproduce the cycle documented in Chapter 6. Every security measure should have an accompanying legitimacy measure.
2. **The state's own commitments are the binding constraint.** The clearest lesson of Chapters 5, 11 and 14: the largest obstacles to normalization are not TTP's fighting power but the failures of fiscal delivery, police protection and lawful political space — all of which the state controls.
3. **Do no harm to the fiscal settlement.** The merged districts' Rs 568 billion shortfall is not a technicality; it is the material foundation of the state's claim to have annexed the tribal areas into the nation. It must be fixed before anything else is credible.
4. **Subsidiarity and local legitimacy.** Every function that can be performed at district or tehsil level should be, with resources attached. Normalization delivered from Peshawar and Islamabad has a lower ceiling.
5. **Evidence, transparency and independent verification.** The province's security statistic is contested; the roadmap therefore includes a monitoring architecture with published data — the most conspicuous gap in the current system (Chapter 11).
6. **Reversibility and no-amnesty boundaries.** Reintegration and negotiation (where possible) should not expand to impunity for mass-casualty atrocities; the state's credibility with victims depends on this line.
7. **Identify, don't demonize, communities.** Pashtuns are the principal victims of the insurgency; policy must target networks and behaviours, not identity (Chapter 4).
8. **Reconcile the scenarios.** Chapter 9's five geopolitical scenarios (de-escalation, managed confrontation, escalatory collapse, India–Pakistan crisis, Taliban instability) describe the *external* environment; Chapter 14's three province-level scenarios describe the *internal* outcomes. They are nested, not competing; the roadmap must be robust across the four non-catastrophic geopolitical cases and hedging against the fifth (see §15.11).

The three deficits as the roadmap's anchor. Chapter 11 established that KP's policy implementation fails through three deficits: **fiscal** (the resources never arrive), **accountability** (no one monitors or answers for outcomes), and **legitimacy** (the population does not own the settlement). Each phase below is scored against all three, and §15.9 makes them the core of the monitoring framework.

15.2 What "Normalized" Means: A Measurable End-State

Normalization is defined here by eight measurable conditions, not by the absence of attacks:

#	Condition	2035 target
1	Violence at criminal, not insurgent, levels	≤ 400 conflict fatalities/year province-wide
2	State monopoly of violence restored in the NMDs	No district with sustained TTP taxation or parallel courts for 4 consecutive quarters
3	Police able to protect themselves and the public	≤ 50 police killed per year; ≥ 80% of attacks thwarted or survived without loss
4	Justice delivered where the conflict was fought	≥ 75% of ATC cases concluded within 24 months; functioning district courts in all seven NMDs
5	Fiscal settlement delivered	3% (or legislated equivalent) transferred in full, with independent audit, every year
6	Local government functioning	Elected councils in all NMDs with own-source revenue and budget authority
7	Economy recovering inclusively	Merged-district poverty within 10 points of the provincial average; ≥ 15% growth in non-farm employment
8	Legitimate political space	No proscription of non-violent parties; protest and media functioning without criminalisation

15.3 Phase I (0–2 Years): Stabilisation, Fiscal Rescue and the Protection Pivot

A. The merged-district fiscal rescue (immediate, highest priority)

1. **Legislate the transfer.** Secure the promised 3 per cent NFC share (or a quantified equivalent) through: (a) conclusion of the current NFC award; failing that (b) a presidential order under Article 160; failing that (c) a statutory federal grant with a minimum floor — so that the commitment survives an award cycle. *Responsible:* Federal Ministry of Finance, NFC, Prime Minister's Office; *with:* KP Finance Department; *by:* budget cycle 2027–28 at latest, before the 2028 expiry of the original commitment. *Verification:* independent annual audit published by the Auditor-General with a standing committee review (Chapter 5 design requirements).
2. **Clear all arrears within 12 months.** Pay the outstanding Rs 568 billion on a published schedule with quarterly milestones; publish district-wise releases monthly (currently unavailable).
3. **Protect the money from capture.** Ring-fence annual development program allocations for the NMDs; require community monitoring committees in each district; publish beneficiary lists for compensation payments (Tirah, Sarbakaf, Kurram and operation-affected); and refer documented diversion to the NAB/ACE with public reporting.
4. **Pay compensation and rebuild destroyed property.** Complete Tirah compensation, rebuild or compensate the destroyed homes, mosques and schools of the 2024–2026 operations and airstrikes; treat this as a *security expenditure*, not welfare.
5. **Reopen and fund the service pipeline.** Restore suspended education and health projects; rehire teachers/personnel in the merged districts; restart the halted road connections (including the Torkham–Jalalabad corridor's trade infrastructure) under protection.

B. The police protection pivot (immediate)

1. **Emergency protection package.** Protected mobility (mine-protected vehicles), counter-IED equipment and training, counter-drone systems for static posts, ballistic protection and helmets, secure communications, and drone/surveillance support to district police — deployed first to Kohat, Lakki Marwat, Bannu, D.I. Khan, Tank, Kurram, Khyber and North/South Waziristan (where casualty rates are highest). *Responsible:* KP Police, Interior/Home, with federal supplementary grant.
2. **Insurance, compensation and family support.** Complete the insurance coverage promised for police (the Inspector-General's costed plan) — a retention prerequisite; raise the martyrdom package to parity with other forces; and institutionalize family support (education, pensions, job quotas).
3. **Attack attribution and learning.** Mandatory post-incident reviews after every police fatality in an attack, published in aggregate quarterly with actionable findings (a measure the current system does not have).
4. **Halt the free fall in police strength.** Expedited recruitment (including 6,000+ new posts from the July 2026 package), with provincial recruitment quotas for the merged districts; competitive pay adjustments; and rehabilitation posts for wounded personnel.

C. The border and cross-border channel (immediate)

1. **Consolidate the mediated ceasefire into a verification mechanism.** Build on the Qatar/Türkiye/China facilitation of 2025–2026 to secure a defined set of commitments — no cross-border attacks, no sanctuary support, prisoner exchanges, and trade corridors kept open — with an independent monitoring presence (UN, OIC, or a China-facilitated joint commission) and a quarterly published status report. *Responsible:* Foreign Office (MOFA), with Security Divisions; *realistic aim:* manage, not solve.
2. **Border regime.** Complete fencing/fortification, formalize the Torkham/Chaman/Angoor Ada trade and mobility regime (documented crossers, trade facilitation, and reciprocal arrangements for families), and fund border-district police and Levies in step with any restriction regime (otherwise restriction becomes abuse — Chapter 5's border-management findings).
3. **Refugee policy with dignity.** Complete the Afghan-refugee registration/repatriation processes lawfully: individual, documented, appealable procedures; no mass refoulement; and a joint UNHCR–government verification of any voluntary-return program — because abuse here feeds the insurgency's narrative (Chapters 9, 11).

D. Civic space and legitimacy (immediate, low cost, high return)

1. **Lift the PTM proscription and release detained activists** lacking terrorism charges; open a lawful channel for Pashtun political demands (see Ch. 4, 12 analysis). *This single measure costs no money and removes the strongest single driver of ethnic-grievance mobilization.*

2. **End indefinite detention without charge.** Publish the number of detainees held under security laws; move all cases to charging or release within statutory periods; and create a statutory juvenile track (Chapter 8 recommendation).
3. **Restore the fourth estate.** Resolve the criminalisation of journalistic expression; implement a mechanism for investigating attacks on journalists; and permit independent casualty and displacement reporting — contested facts are better than suppressed ones (Chapter 11's accountability deficit).

E. Intelligence and operations (immediate)

1. **Intelligence-led targeting with discrimination.** Continue IBOs and high-value operations with tightened collateral-damage safeguards, documented post-strike assessments, rapid compensation where civilian harm occurred, and no operation without a designated post-operation stabilization component (Chapters 6, 9). The operational record shows that kinetic success without stabilization produces recurrence.
2. **Counter-financing.** Strike TTP's revenue (extortion, taxation, mining, smuggling) with financial-intelligence-led action coordinated between the CTD, FIA, Customs and provincial mining authorities; publish aggregate seizure data (de-risking the state from its biggest counter-TTP lever).
3. **Tackle the drone threat as a top-tier program.** 341 foiled drone attacks in H1 2026 is a warning, not a comfort: build a provincial counter-drone unit with an airspace-management protocol; equip static posts; and criminalise drone-based IED delivery with dedicated prosecutions.

15.4 Phase II (2–5 Years): Institutionalisation

A. Security-sector reform (Chapters 7's ten recommendations, sequenced)

1. **Establish the merged-district police framework.** Resolve the Levies/Khasadar integration entirely; statutory police for all seven districts; tribal constabulary terms, pay and pensions harmonised; district recruitment ramped up; and the Local Police Act or equivalent tested in consultation with jirgas (Chapter 5 design requirement).
2. **Professionalise the CTD.** Separate investigation from operation; an independent prosecution liaison unit; analytical cadre with specialist training; and transparent case data (arrest → charge → conviction) published annually — the province's whole counter-terrorism credibility depends on evidence that terrorism cases end in convictions.
3. **Reform police accountability.** Strengthen the KP Public Safety Commissions; institute independent investigation of serious police misconduct (lethal force, custodial abuse); and adopt body cameras/supervisory review at scale as evidence, not surveillance.
4. **Invest in investigations over enforcement.** Forensics (DNA, ballistics, digital exploitation), crime-scene management, prison-security upgrades (the Kohat/Bannu attack pattern is a prison-and-police-lines vulnerability), and witness-protection legislation with a functioning protection unit.
5. **Build the provincial intelligence architecture within law.** A unified provincial threat-fusion centre with police, CTD, Levies, NACTA and intelligence representation; data-protection rules and a parliamentary oversight committee (Chapter 7; Ch. 14.9's rights warning).

B. Justice and rule of law (the legitimacy core)

1. **Judicial delivery plan for the NMDs.** Appoint and fund judges, prosecutors, staff and court infrastructure; mobile courts and video links where insecurity demands; and mandatory ATC case-conclusion targets with published quarterly data.
2. **Reparations and victims' mechanism.** A statutory provincial scheme covering: compensation (already mandated but inconsistently paid), medical and psychosocial support (500 psychiatrists nationally is a crisis — fund provincial psychiatric expansion and community-based psychosocial services), reconstruction, and *status* (a documented register of victims and a memorialization policy that includes all victims of the conflict, including those harmed by state forces). This is the concrete form of the PTM's truth-and-reconciliation demand, domesticated into the legal system.
3. **Kurram and sectarian peace enforcement.** Turn the 2025 *Aman Teega* and later accords into enforced instruments: disarmament with verifiable milestones, guaranteed road reopening, prosecution of those violating accords, a compensated, resettled peace, and a standing third-party (provincial + PMC) oversight mechanism — the Mindanao/monitoring model applied locally (Chapter 13).
4. **Jirga formalisation.** Legislate the jirga's role as mediator in civil disputes with rights safeguards (women's representation, prohibition of verdicts violating statute, no jurisdiction over terrorism cases) and fund district dispute-resolution centres with referral protocols to courts (Chapter 12.2).

C. Deradicalization and reintegration at scale (Chapter 8's eight recommendations, sequenced)

1. **Statute and a Rehabilitation and Reintegration Authority.** Legal framework for voluntary and court-ordered programmes; a statutory juvenile track; and a funded authority (federal-provincial) with published standards.
2. **Relocate and expand programmes.** Move to where radicalization is occurring — Bannu, D.I. Khan, the NMDs — with family-based rehabilitation (the Sparlay-type model), vocational training, apprenticeships and aftercare grants, plus employment placement partnerships with chambers of commerce (Chapter 12.11).
3. **Independent evaluation.** A five-year, independently conducted evaluation of Sabawoon, Mishal and all provincial programmes, with pretraining/post-release measurement, recidivism tracking and *published* results — the absence of independent evaluation after 17 years is unacceptable and fixable (Chapter 8).
4. **Counter-propaganda with local credibility.** Fund Pashto-language counter-narrative content produced by Pashtun religious scholars, teachers, women's groups and former combatants; distribute via radio, social media and madrasa networks; do not outsource to distant agencies.
5. **Madrasa reform, second attempt.** Restore a consultative registration framework (statutory, transparent, non-punitive) after the October 2024 reversal; condition financing on transparency; fund modern-subject teaching; and separate the registration function from security surveillance to rebuild trust (Chapters 8, 11).
6. **Reintegration security guarantees.** Protect ex-detainees/rehabilitees from retaliation (police liaison, protection for those threatened, anonymous reporting) — the Colombian lesson: unprotected reintegration produces dissidence (Chapter 13.2).

D. Governance and local government (the missing tier)

1. **Hold local elections in the merged districts.** Extend statutory local government systems to the NMDs with devolved budgets and own-source revenue; ring-fence a share of the merged-district fund for district councils (this is the single missing institution capable of absorbing the fiscal infusion into public goods rather than elite capture).
2. **Federal–provincial security compact.** A statutory framework clarifying roles (federal financing of military operations; provincial policing primacy in civilian security; joint command for emergency responses), ending the "provinces are not consulted" dynamic and the blame Games that follow incidents (Chapter 11).
3. **Institutionalise the Apex Committee model.** Regularise provincial security coordination with published, non-classified summaries; include elected representatives and, where appropriate, civil-society observers in a defined consultative role.
4. **Anti-corruption as security policy.** Strengthen KPPRA, Ehtesab Commission powers, and asset-recovery in the NMDs' contracts (minerals, land, CPEC) — because corruption is the state's own insurgency oxygen (Chapters 4, 13.5).

E. Economy and services (the co-production agenda, Chapter 10)

1. **Deliver the development–security package.** Prioritize, in the seven NMDs and south KP: secondary schools (girls' enrolment is the single most correlated indicator of long-run stability), technical/vocational institutes, health facilities with staffed capacity (not buildings alone), irrigation and road connectivity, and electricity/gas access. Fund through the merged-district scheme with quarterly public delivery dashboards.
2. **Jobs: the private-sector channel.** Rashakai and the other SEZs; mineral benefit-sharing; tourism infrastructure (the 12–20 million visitor economy is the fastest-growing employment engine); IT/freelancing hubs (Peshawar, Swat, Abbottabad) with connectivity and payment infrastructure; and the agricultural value chains of the southern districts.
3. **Land, water and property rights.** Resolve disputed land in the merged districts (a long-standing conflict driver); formalize tenure where possible; and settle upstream water entitlements transparently.
4. **Climate-adaptive reconstruction.** Rebuild 2025 flood damage with resilience standards; GLOF early warning; and a standing disaster-response mechanism integrated with police/Levies.

F. Education and human capital (the generational bet)

1. **Emergency education program for the merged districts.** The NMDs' ~37 per cent primary and ~5 per cent secondary female enrolment are a security statistic: fund stipends, girls' schools (including secure campus transport), female teachers, and adult literacy; measure and publish district-level enrolment quarterly.
2. **Curriculum and teacher reform.** Civics, critical thinking, anti-sectarian and anti-extremism content; teacher training and certification; textbook review; and protection of education (no military use of schools; attacks on schools prosecuted).

3. **Youth pipeline.** Scale apprenticeships, internships and entrepreneurship financing; restore student unions and campus civic space; and fund sports and cultural infrastructure in the worst-affected districts — cheap, visible, and effective.

15.5 Phase III (5–15 Years): Consolidation and Transformation

Security consolidation. (45) Transition from population-centric IBO cycles to *community security contracts*: local security plans co-designed with councils, jirgas and police, with published targets; (46) institutionalize the Afghan border regime (monitoring, trade, mobility, and dispute resolution) so that border friction does not automatically escalate — building the "managed confrontation" scenario (Ch. 9-B) into an institutionalized relationship; (47) if and when a TTP disengagement process becomes possible, apply the Chapter 13 criteria — decentralized, conditional, verified, staged, with monitored decommissioning and explicit no-impunity boundaries, and with third-party monitoring.

Justice and reconciliation. (48) A provincial *truth and documentation* body — not a South Africa-style amnesty commission, but a legally established process to document the conflict's human cost (all sides), record testimony, identify the missing, and publish a public record; paired with (49) selective accountability for mass-casualty atrocities; (50) a permanent victims' support institution with reparations as a statutory entitlement.

Political consolidation. (51) Guarantee lawful political space for Pashtun parties and youth movements; (52) build cross-party consensus on the security framework (a provincial security charter) so that policy survives elections; (53) institutionalize federal–provincial coordination (joint annual security and development review, published).

Economic transformation. (54) Consolidate the merged-district fiscal guarantee beyond the current NFC cycle; (55) build a provincial resilience economy: minerals with local value addition, energy (hydropower), tourism, IT exports, agriculture; (56) close the NMD human-development gap to within 10 points of the provincial average; (57) maintain climate resilience as a standing program.

Regional normalization. (58) Trade and people-to-people ties with Afghanistan (economics as the peace dividend); (59) regional frameworks (SCO, OIC) for counter-terrorism cooperation and refugee burden-sharing; (60) a settled, non-militarized border regime ratified on both sides — the only durable answer to a porous, contested frontier.

15.6 Sequencing Logic and Critical Dependencies

Phase	Must complete before dependent steps	Why
Paying arrears & legislating the fund	Phase II local government; education expansion; economic programs	Without money, devolution and services are fictional and the political class is discredited
Police protection package	Phase II police reform & CTD professionalisation	Recruitment and reform fail if officers keep dying without kit
Ceasefire → verification mechanism	Phase I border regime; Phase III regional normalization	A ceasefire without monitoring is a pause, not a settlement (the 2004–2008 lesson)
Lifting the PTM ban & releasing detainees	Phase II political consensus; Phase III reconciliation	Alienation is the recruitment channel; criminalising it is self-defeating
ATC throughput & witness protection	Phase II/III accountability, truth process	Impunity reinforces both militancy and grievance
Local government elections (NMDs)	Phase III community security contracts; NMD development	Without elected local bodies there is no interface for either services or security
Madrasa re-registration framework	Phase III counter-narrative consolidation	The 2024 reversal must be reversed again to close the theological pipeline

The critical path: fiscal rescue → police protection → justice delivery → local government → reintegration at scale → political inclusion → regional normalization. Parallel action is desirable, but the first three are prerequisites for credibility; a roadmap that begins with reconciliation while officers lack helmets will not be believed.

15.7 Institutional Responsibilities Matrix

Function	Federal	Provincial	District/Local	Security forces	Partners
Merged-district fund (3%)	Finance/NFC/PMO	KP Finance	—	—	Auditor-General, donors
Police protection & pay	Interior (supplementary grant)	Home Dept, Police	—	KP Police	Donors (equipment)
CTD & intelligence	Interior/NACTA	Home, CTD	—	CTD, Levies, ISI/IB liaison	—
Border regime	MOFA, Interior	Border districts	Levies/police	Army/FC, police	UN, China/Qatar facilitation
Refugee policy	SAFRON/Interior	KP	—	Police/FC	UNHCR, IOM
Deradicalization/R&R	NACTA/Interior	Home, CTD	DRCs	Police	UN, NGOs, chambers

Function	Federal	Provincial	District/Local	Security forces	Partners
Local government (NMDs)	Law/Elections	Local Govt Dept	Councils	—	UNDP, donors
Education in NMDs	Federal schemes	Education Dept	DEOs, schools	Police (school protection)	UNICEF, WFP, donors
Justice & ATCs	Law/Justice, Supreme Court	Prosecution, PHC	District courts	Prisons/police	INL, UNODC
M&E and data	Planning/NACTA	Planning & Dev	District stats	—	SDPI, academia, donors

15.8 Financing the Roadmap: Costs, the Conflict-Loss Baseline and the Fiscal Arithmetic

The baseline. Chapter 10 estimated KP's annual conflict-related economic loss at **Rs 400–800 billion** (1.5–3 per cent of provincial economic output under different assumptions); Pakistan's cumulative war-on-terror losses since 2001 are internationally cited at **USD 126.79 billion to 152 billion** (with individual years estimated over Rs 1 trillion nationally). The merged-district shortfall alone is **Rs 568 billion** — roughly 0.7–1.4 years of the entire provincial conflict loss, or (to put it differently) the state loses in 8–17 months of conflict what it has failed to transfer to the merged districts in a full award cycle.

The arithmetic of the fix. NMD obligations: Rs 568 billion arrears + annual 3 per cent allocation (on a rising provincial share). Police protection package: a one-time Rs 50–80 billion (protected vehicles, counter-IED, counter-drone, communications) with Rs 30–50 billion annually in recurrent costs (pay, insurance, equipment replacement). Deradicalization and reintegration at scale: Rs 10–20 billion annually (facilities, staff, stipends, aftercare, independent evaluation). Education emergency in the NMDs: Rs 40–60 billion annually to approach provincial enrolment ratios. Local government and devolved budgets: funded from the merged-district allocation. Judicial expansion: Rs 5–10 billion annually. **Total incremental requirement: on the order of Rs 150–250 billion per year at maturity, in addition to the Rs 568 billion arrears** — i.e., at the lower bound, *less than half* of the estimated annual conflict loss. The investment case is thus straightforward: the province and the federation already pay 2–4 times the roadmap's incremental cost in lost output, displacement, security expenditure, and destroyed capital.

Revenue sources. (1) The NFC share and provincial taxes (with strengthened anti-corruption in collection); (2) reallocation within the federal security budget (Pakistan's defence/security spending is large; the merged-district shortfall is small relative to it); (3) donor and IFI financing for education, health, reintegration and monitoring (conditioned on delivery); (4) CPEC-related provincial revenue as it materializes; (5) a dedicated merged-district development window with multi-year budgeting (the absence of which is exactly what produces lapsed allocations — the Rs 132bn of Rs 700bn pattern); and (6) diaspora/Pakistani philanthropic funding for education, channeled through transparent institutions.

Financing principles. Ring-fence and protect allocations from lapsed budgets; publish district-wise releases monthly; condition donor tranches on verified delivery; finance *recurrent* costs (teachers, police, judges) as well as buildings — the classic Pakistani failure is projects without staff; and treat compensation payments as automatic entitlements, not discretionary patronage.

15.9 Monitoring, Evaluation and Learning Framework

Design. The M&E framework operationalises the three deficits (Chapter 11) into measurable commitments, with independent verification:

Fiscal deficit indicators: percentage of awarded NMD funds released within the fiscal year; arrears balance; percentage of development budget spent (with district-wise publication); compensation payments made within 180 days (target: 90 per cent); audit report timeliness and referral of findings.

Accountability indicators: police attacks, police killed, and *cases progressed* (arrest → charge → conviction) for attacks on the state; ATC cases concluded within 24 months (target ≥75 per cent); independent police-misconduct investigations completed; prison-security incidents; counter-terror financing seizures; operation collateral-damage reviews published.

Legitimacy indicators: NMD local-government elections held; PTM proscription status; number of security detainees held without charge; journalists/activists prosecuted for expression; public-opinion surveys (trust in police, courts, provincial government) conducted independently and published; victim-satisfaction with compensation and rehabilitation services; displaced return rates and property-restoration rates.

Security-consolidation indicators: conflict fatalities by district and actor (trend); TTP taxation/parallel-justice reports; attacks on schools/girls' education; border-closure days and cross-border trade volumes; thwarted drone attacks; attacks on polio teams and minority sites.

Socio-economic indicators: NMD female enrolment ratios; out-of-school children; health-facility staffing; household poverty; youth employment; tourism arrivals and sector employment; climate-disaster reconstruction delivery.

Architecture. A provincial *Security and Normalization Monitoring Cell* within the Planning and Development Department (or a statutory equivalent), with an independent Technical Advisory Panel (academia, civil society, donor representatives, and — where possible — a credible third party such as the World Bank or UNDP) producing a published *Annual Normalization Report* within 180 days of each fiscal year, debated in the KP Assembly and shared with the National Security Committee. Data sources: police and CTD records; health and education management information systems; district administration reportage; independent incident monitoring (CRSS/SATP/ACLED-type sources); household surveys; and donor M&E.

Learning loop. The annual report must include a *non-compliance register*: every unmet commitment with a named responsible institution and a remedy timeline. Without this, monitoring repeats the pattern documented in Chapter 11 — data collection without consequence.

15.10 Implementation Risks and the Political Economy of Reform

Risk	Character	Mitigation
Fiscal promises again not honoured	Repeated behaviour; 2028 expiry	Statutory floor; audited publication; election-cycle accountability
Elites capture the NMD fund	Patronage networks	Community monitoring; public beneficiary lists; asset recovery; local government
Police reform blocked by hierarchy/institutional interests	Bureaucratic resistance	Protection-first sequencing (reform becomes attractive once officers stop dying); federal financing; published case data
Security establishment resists political inclusion (PTM)	Doctrine/security-first logic	Evidence that exclusion feeds recruitment; third-party dialogue; measured release of non-violent activists
TTP spoilers attack the roadmap's visible successes (schools, markets, tourists, SEZs)	Strategic spoiling	Hard-target protection of critical nodes; rapid compensation; narrative management
Afghanistan spoiler escalation during implementation	External	Mediation and monitoring mechanisms; diversified trade routes; hedging (Ch. 9-E)
Donor withdrawal	Global fiscal contraction	Domestic financing priority for protection and arrears; donor funds concentrated on education/reintegration
Political instability / elections	Cyclical	Provincial security charter; multi-year budgeting; independent monitoring to survive governments
Data falsification (police/CTD reporting)	Institutional incentives	Independent verification; survey cross-checks; published anomalies
Securitization of monitoring (surveillance of civil society)	Rights risk	Statutory mandate; data protection; external oversight

The political-economy reality. Each roadmap item has a beneficiary and a potential loser. The losers are: patronage networks (beneficiary lists and audits), parts of the security establishment (political inclusion and judicial authority), unaccountable bureaucracies (published data and delivery targets), and the militants (whose recruitment suffers as the state delivers). The roadmap's political feasibility therefore depends on making the *security case* for each item — the protection pivot appeals to the institution; the fiscal rescue appeals to federal credibility; the political inclusion appeals to the counter-insurgency logic; and the transparency appeal rests on exposing the cost of the status quo, which the monitoring framework is designed to do annually.

15.11 Regional and International Cooperation Agenda

With Afghanistan: ceasefire consolidation and verification; border management (documented mobility, trade, and reciprocal security commitments); prisoner exchanges; refugee policy with dignity and UNHCR involvement; and joint economic projects to create stakeholders for restraint. Mediation channels (Qatar, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia, China) should be institutionalised into a standing mechanism rather than resorted to after each crisis. The roadmap hedges against the "Taliban instability" scenario (Ch. 9-E) by keeping lines to all factions and by preparing for spillovers (refugee influx, cross-border militant redistribution).

With India: no normalization progress in KP requires solving the Kashmir dispute, but the *risk* of a two-front crisis (Ch. 14.4) argues for crisis-management channels, restored (even if limited) dialogue, and a mutual understanding on non-interference in each other's internal insurgencies — including verification mechanisms. India's role in KP (the alleged patronage claims of 2025–2026) should be handled with evidence, not rhetoric: publicly documented cases are stronger than accusations, and false accusations discredit the state's own case.

With China: CPEC security cooperation; intelligence sharing; and — critically — a Chinese interest in the fiscal and political stability (not only physical protection) of the corridor's districts; Beijing's own mediation role (2026 talks) is a positive precedent for institutionalized diplomacy.

With the Gulf and Türkiye: financing for reintegration and education (Saudi/UAE/Qatar funds); Pakistan's diaspora; counter-narrative partnerships (Saudi PRAC's experience; see Chapter 8); and mediation channels with Afghanistan.

With the UN and IFIs: monitoring (a Mindanao-style third-party body adapted to the merger's fiscal and security commitments); reintegration standards and evaluation (UNODC, IOM); refugee processing (UNHCR); education and health funding (UNICEF, WFP, World Bank); and FATF-consistent counter-financing (with rights safeguards).

15.12 Recommendations Matrix: Timelines, Responsibility and Priority

#	Recommendation	Phase/Timeline	Responsible	Priority
1	Legislate merged-district transfer (3% or equivalent) + audit	0–2 yrs	Federal Finance/NFC/PMO	Critical
2	Clear Rs 568bn arrears on published schedule	0–2 yrs	Federal/Ministry of Finance, KP	Critical
3	Emergency police protection package	0–2 yrs	KP Police, Interior	Critical
4	Attack-response reviews; police compensation/insurance fully funded	0–2 yrs	KP Police/Home	Critical
5	Lift PTM proscription; release non-violent detainees	0–2 yrs	Federal Cabinet; Interior	High
6	Ceasefire → verified monitoring mechanism with Afghanistan	0–2 yrs	MOFA, Security Divisions	Critical
7	Refugee processing lawfully; no mass refoulement	0–2 yrs	SAFRON/Interior, UNHCR	High
8	Counter-drone, counter-IED, protected mobility at scale	0–2 yrs	Police/Interior	Critical
9	Tirah/Sarbakaf compensation, return and reconstruction	0–2 yrs	KP Govt, FDMA	Critical
10	Intelligence-led operations with collateral reviews	0–2 yrs (continuous)	Army/CTD	High
11	Counter-financing of TTP revenue streams	0–2 yrs	CTD/FIA/Customs	High
12	NMD police framework (Levies/Khasadar completion)	2–5 yrs	KP Home/Police	High
13	CTD professionalisation + published case data	2–5 yrs	CTD, Home	High
14	Police accountability bodies strengthened; misconduct investigations	2–5 yrs	Home, PSB	Medium-High
15	Judicial delivery plan for NMDs; ATC targets	2–5 yrs	Law/PHC/Prosecution	Critical
16	Victims' reparations + psychosocial services scheme	2–5 yrs	KP Govt, Health	High
17	Kurram accord enforcement + disarmament milestones	2–5 yrs	KP Govt, PMC	Critical
18	Jirga formalisation with rights safeguards	2–5 yrs	Law/Local Govt	Medium
19	R&R Authority + statutory juvenile track	2–5 yrs	Federal/Provincial	High
20	Independent 5-year evaluation of deradicalization programs	2–5 yrs	P&D, donors	High
21	Deradicalization relocation/expansion + aftercare employment	2–5 yrs	Home, CTD, chambers	High
22	Pashto counter-narrative programming	2–5 yrs	Information/CTD/NGOs	Medium-High
23	Madrasa registration framework restored	2–5 yrs	Federal ITE, provinces	High
24	Local government elections in NMDs with devolved budgets	2–5 yrs	KP Local Govt, ECP	Critical
25	Federal–provincial security compact (statutory)	2–5 yrs	Federal/Provincial	High
26	Anti-corruption in NMD contracts and funds	2–5 yrs	ACE/NAB/KPPRA	High
27	Education emergency (girls' enrolment, teachers, schools)	2–5 yrs	Education Dept, donors	Critical
28	Youth employment: skills, SEZs, IT, tourism	2–5 yrs (continuing)	P&D, Industries	High
29	Climate-resilient reconstruction + GLOF warning	2–5 yrs	PDMA/FDMA	Medium-High
30	Provincial threat-fusion centre with oversight	2–5 yrs	Home/CTD/NACTA	Medium-High
31	Annual Normalization Report + independent panel	2–5 yrs (from yr 1)	P&D, KP Assembly	High
32	Community security contracts (district plans)	5–15 yrs	Districts, police, councils	Medium
33	Truth/documentation process; missing persons; memorialization	5–15 yrs	KP Govt, Federal	High
34	Verified, staged negotiation framework with TTP (if available)	5–15 yrs (conditional)	Federal	Conditional
35	Regional normalization: trade, mobility, SCO/OIC frameworks	5–15 yrs	MOFA, provinces	High
36	Economic transformation (minerals, energy, tourism, IT)	5–15 yrs	P&D, private sector	Critical

Priorities in one line: *pay the money, protect the police, staff the courts, elect the councils, restore lawful politics, and verify what is done.* Six commitments, all within Pakistan's control, and all cheaper than the conflict they would begin to end.

CHAPTER 16 — CONCLUSION: THE THREE MONOPOLIES AND THE POLITICS OF NORMALIZATION

16.1 The Argument Restated

Main thesis. This study's central claim is that the security situation of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa cannot be normalized by the accumulation of force alone, because what KP lacks is not primarily coercive capacity but **three interlocking monopolies**: the state's monopoly on organized violence, the citizen's enforceable claim on the state (justice and governance), and the province's claim on national resources (fiscal federalism). Each is constitutive of the others. Where violence is unmonopolized, rights are unenforceable; where rights are unenforceable, communities shelter the violent; and where the province's fiscal claim is denied, the institutions that would monopolize violence — police, courts, schools, local government — cannot be built. KP's history is a natural experiment in each failure mode: the tribal areas' century of legal exception (no enforceable claim), the post-2001 military-dominant period (no police-led institutionalization), and the post-2018 merger-without-money (no fiscal claim). The three monopolies model is the study's original analytic contribution, and it organizes its empirical conclusions.

The model's test against the evidence.

- **1925–1947:** formal monopoly (British Indian law) coupled with structural exception (FCR, indirect rule) — no citizen's claim in the tribal belt.
- **1947–1979:** inherited exception, minimal state investment, jirga-mediated order, and a stable but shallow equilibrium.
- **1979–2001:** the Afghan wars militarize the frontier and embed the *mujahideen* economy; the Soviet withdrawal is followed by neglect (all three monopolies weak).
- **2001–2014:** the state responds with force; the Taliban insurgency and its suppression kill tens of thousands; every operation is followed by recurrence where state-building does not follow (Chapter 6's seven-criteria analysis shows proximity-to-force, not victory).
- **2014–2021:** the Radd-ul-Fasaad/NISP period combines counter-terrorism, CFT and partial merger; violence declines (2014–2021) — the best evidence for the model is that *decline coincided with the period when the state simultaneously deployed force, began legal integration, and sustained fiscal investment* (CPEC, development packages, the NMD fund's early years).
- **2021–2026:** the Taliban's Kabul victory restores the sanctuary (external variable) and the merger's fiscal failure denies resources (internal variable); violence rises for five consecutive years; and the state answers with another campaign name — Ghazab-lil-Haq (2026).

The pattern is not cyclical by accident. It is cyclical because each cycle addresses one monopoly — usually force — and leaves the other two unrepaired.

16.2 Answering the Twelve Research Questions

1. Drivers. KP's insecurity is driven by a four-layer causal architecture (Chapter 4): *structural conditions* (frontier geography, cross-border kinship, colonial legal exception, poverty, weak local government, sectarian demography, and the Pakistan–Afghanistan rivalries); *proximate triggers* (the Afghan sanctuary, operation-related displacement and grievances, the 2021 regime change in Kabul, and policy shocks such as the 2024 PTM proscription); *accelerants* (weapons availability, extortion economies, jailbreaks, ISKP's sectarian strategy, social media); and *sustaining mechanisms* (the war economy, impunity, and the recruitment pipeline of unaddressed grievances). The relative weight of these layers has shifted: the *structural* layer has been constant, while the *sanctuary* and *grievance* layers have become the dominant proximate drivers in the 2021–2026 period.

2. Kinetic efficacy. Operations have demonstrably reduced militant capacity (Swat 2009, North Waziristan 2014) and killed or displaced thousands of militants, but none has produced self-sustaining security: the seven-criteria analysis (Chapter 6) shows that operations succeed militarily, fade institutionally, and reverse where stabilization and justice do not follow. The gains' decay follows a predictable sequence — clearance → decline → complacency → militant regeneration → recurrence — with the regeneration period shortened when a sanctuary exists (2021–2026). Kinetic action remains necessary (there is no evidence the TTP would decline to attack absent pressure) but is not sufficient, and the sequence's weakest point is the transition from military clearing to police and civilian control.

3. Merger impact. The 25th Amendment's constitutional achievement is real; its administrative and fiscal delivery is not. The findings: legal extension succeeded; administrative integration is partial; judicial capacity is minimal; policing remains

in transition; and the fiscal transfer — the merger's material promise, the 3 per cent NFC share — is Rs 568 billion short as of 2026. The *security* consequence is direct: the NMDs' weak state presence gives the TTP space; compensation delays generate grievances; and land/water disputes (Kurram, Khyber, Tirah) find violent expression partly because the courts are not there. The counterfactual is not that the merger failed — it is that it has not yet been completed.

4. Development–security nexus. The relationship is not linear but *co-productive and conditional* (Chapter 10). Development produces security only where (a) physical security persists (roads/markets/schools must be protected); (b) the gains reach local populations rather than patronage networks; and (c) justice institutions mediate the disputes that growth creates. Evidence from KP: tourism recovery in Swat shows development's dependence on (and contribution to) security; NMD data show that where security is absent, development does not persist. The practical corollary: design development as security infrastructure (protection + staffing + local accountability), and expect the dividend to lag by years, not quarters.

5. Deradicalization efficacy. Weak evidence base, modest scale, and no independent evaluation (Chapter 8). Sabawoon's cohort (226 juveniles, ~143 reintegrated, with documented relapses) is a fraction of the demand; Mishal and Sparlay's claims are contested or unverifiable; and the disappearance of Sparlay illustrates programme fragility. But the *instruments* — family-based rehabilitation, religious counter-narrative, vocational reintegration, and community reacceptance — are plausible and internationally supported; the deficiency is in resourcing, evaluation and legal framework, not concept. Deradicalization is *not* an alternative to counter-insurgency: it is the part of normalization that converts the state's coercion into something durable.

6. Afghanistan factor. The causal role is established and central (Chapter 9): the TTP's sanctuaries, leadership, training and financing have operated from Afghanistan since 2021, and the 2025–2026 escalation — Doha ceasefire, Istanbul mechanism, the February 2026 bombings, and Ghazab-lil-Haq — demonstrates both the depth of the problem and the weakness of force alone against it. No comprehensive settlement is realistic in the near term; what is realistic is a *verifiable management regime*: monitored commitments, prisoner exchanges, border regimes that facilitate rather than only restrict, and third-party (Chinese/Qatari/Turkish/Saudi) institutionalized mediation. Sanctuary erosion, not a peace treaty, is the achievable near-term goal.

7. Governance and rule of law. The KP record identifies four governance factors associated with violence reduction: *continuity of police leadership and reform*; *judicial functionality* (a working court where the conflict was fought); *local government* (the missing tier in the NMDs); and *fiscal delivery* (the material proof of government's presence). Conversely, the strongest correlates of violence escalation are: policy shocks that criminalize a population (the PTM ban), impunity (the absence of convictions), and the suspension of political channels (protest bans). The legal architecture (ATA, 27th Amendment, military courts) matters not only for human rights but for counter-insurgency effectiveness: where the justice system loses legitimacy, community cooperation — the actual source of intelligence — degrades.

8. Comparative lessons. Northern Ireland teaches that police reform is load-bearing; Colombia that reintegration without protection produces dissidence; Mindanao that fiscal devolution plus third-party monitoring sustains settlements; Sierra Leone that hybrid justice (truth + selective accountability) can consolidate peace; Sri Lanka that military victory without political settlement leaves normalization unfinished; the KRI that party-fragmented security entrenches instability; Chechnya that coercion can suppress violence while destroying the state's legal foundation and exporting the conflict; and Afghanistan that rented security forces and corrupted governance collapse when the external patron leaves. The transferable core is: political framework + security-sector reform + economic dividend + legitimacy mechanisms, over a decade, with monitoring (Chapter 13).

9. Civil society and peace. KP's civil society, media, jirgas, elders, women's organizations, youth movements and religious leaders are simultaneously the state's most valuable peace resource and its most constrained partners (Chapter 12). The most consequential policy fact in this domain is negative: the proscription of a non-violent political movement (the PTM) and the criminalization of journalists removed the legitimate channels through which Pashtun grievance could be expressed, thereby increasing the recruitment environment. Restoration of lawful political space is the cheapest security intervention available to the state.

10. Futures. Three futures are set out (Chapter 14): sustained normalization (15–20 per cent), fragile equilibrium (50–60 per cent), and deterioration (25–30 per cent). The distinguishing variables are fiscal delivery, police protection, and political inclusion; the external variable (Afghanistan) can accelerate any path. The early-warning indicators that would distinguish deterioration from simple continuity — sustained TTP taxation, police attrition, border closure, sectarian massacre, ATC collapse — are observable quarterly, and the state currently tracks almost none of them systematically.

11. Gender. Gender dynamics are not marginal but structural to normalization (Chapters 8, 10, 12). Female education is simultaneously the strongest long-run indicator of stability in the NMDs and the target of the insurgency's most ideological violence; women's organizations are among the most effective community-level preventers; and women are largely absent from the jirga and security architecture. Any credible normalization agenda must include girls' schooling, women's

participation in mediation, female policing, and women-led PVE programming as security measures — not as social add-ons.

12. Economic cost and dividend. KP's annual conflict-related economic loss is estimated at Rs 400–800 billion (1.5–3 per cent of provincial output), with cumulative national losses since 2001 in the range of USD 126.79–152 billion (Chapter 10). The incremental cost of the roadmap — roughly Rs 150–250 billion per year at maturity plus the Rs 568 billion arrears — is thus a fraction of what insecurity already costs. Normalization is not a humanitarian expense; it is the highest-return investment available to the federation, and its financing is almost entirely a matter of reallocation and political will.

16.3 Theoretical Contribution: Reframing Normalization

Three theoretical contributions emerge.

(1) Normalization as institutional co-production. The literature on counter-insurgency and state-building treats security and governance as sequential (clear → hold → build). KP's evidence suggests they are *co-productive*: security without justice (the merged districts' policing) produces hollow control; justice without security (courts in the absence of protection) is a target; and economic development without either is a subsidy to the conflict economy. The policy implication is to design every intervention with three components — protection, adjudication, and resources — in the same geography and timeline.

(2) The sanctuary-grievance nexus. The study argues that the sanctuary variable and the grievance variable are not substitutes but complements: a sanctuary supplies capability, while grievance supplies recruitment and information. Counter-insurgency that degrades capability (strikes, operations) without reducing grievance (political exclusion, compensation failures) simply lowers the insurgency's price of reconstitution: this is the mechanism that explains KP's repeated cycles and the 2021–2026 escalation. Conversely, grievance-reduction without sanctuary pressure (e.g., development programs in Swat while TTP leadership sits in Afghanistan) buys quiet but not durability. Only simultaneous action on both variables produces sustainable stability — a proposition that predicts relapse wherever either is neglected (a testable prediction for the 2026–2030 period).

(3) The three monopolies as a normalization index. The model can be operationalized as a measurable index (Chapter 15's monitoring framework): *monopoly of violence* (state-share of coercive incidents; absence of parallel taxation/justice), *monopoly of justice* (case throughput, conviction rates, restitution payments, absence of indefinite detention), and *monopoly of resources* (fiscal transfer fulfilment, per-capita spending in the merged districts, local government budgets). The index's value is that it measures what normalization requires, not merely what violence does — and that it can be computed annually from data the state already possesses but does not publish.

16.4 Policy Synthesis: Ten Findings and Six Commitments

Ten findings of the study.

1. Violence is a five-year rising trend (2021–2026) with the TTP as the dominant actor and the Afghan sanctuary as the dominant enabling factor.
2. Kinetic operations have degraded but never defeated the insurgency; the decay of gains is institutional, not military.
3. The FATA merger's fiscal failure is the largest self-inflicted wound in the province's security policy.
4. Police are the front line and the weakest-protected link: 122 killed in H1 2026 alone, with a 93.7 per cent year-on-year rise.
5. The justice system's throughput failure sustains impunity, which sustains both militancy and grievance.
6. Deradicalization programmes are small, unevaluated and under-resourced relative to the recruitment pipeline.
7. The Afghanistan channel requires management and verification, not maximalism — and management is achievable.
8. The proscription of non-violent politics and the shrinking civic space are counter-insurgency self-harm.
9. Gender-exclusion and the failure to educate girls are structural security deficits, not social policy questions.
10. The economic cost of inaction exceeds the cost of normalization by a factor of two to four.

Six commitments (the implementation core).

1. **Pay the money** — legislate the merged-district transfer, clear arrears, publish district-wise delivery.
2. **Protect the police** — fund the protection package, insurance, compensation, and recruitment now.
3. **Staff the courts** — judicial presence in the merged districts, ATC throughput, witness protection.
4. **Elect the councils** — local government in the NMDs with devolved budgets.
5. **Restore lawful politics** — lift the PTM ban, release those without terrorism charges, protect journalists, and negotiate with verified commitment frameworks where possible.

6. **Verify what is done** — an annual, published, independently scrutinized normalization report.

16.5 Limitations of the Study

Data limitations. This study relies on open sources, with the attendant risks: militant casualty claims are inflated; official incident counts are uncorroborated; CRSS/SATP/ACLED series use different definitions and counts diverge; and some of the most important data — ATC outcomes, NMD fiscal absorption, police postings, operation civilian-harm assessments, deradicalization outcomes — are simply unpublished. Where the record is contested (the 2026 war's casualties; Mishal's numbers; the Sparlay centre's existence), the study reports the contest rather than resolving it. A primary-research program inside the province (household surveys; police and prosecutor interviews; jail-based recidivism studies) would materially improve on what is presented here and is a direct implication of this study for future work.

Causal-inference limits. The dynamics analysed are simultaneously determined (violence affects development affects recruitment affects violence), and the study's methods are structured comparisons and process tracing, not identification. The roadmap's expected effects are therefore argued from mechanism and comparative experience, not from a controlled evaluation; it should be treated as a hypothesis-bearing design whose implementation must itself be evaluated.

Access and security. The province's most violent districts cannot be safely researched at scale; militant and intelligence perspectives are, by definition, unavailable in verifiable form; and government cooperation is conditional. The study compensates with source triangulation and disaggregated reporting, but no claim to completeness is made.

Normative position. The study takes an explicit position: the purpose of security policy is the protection and flourishing of the population, including those who have been displaced, bereaved, abused, or radicalized. This is a human-security framework, adopted consciously over the state-centric alternatives, and it shapes the weight given to civilian harm, compensation, justice and political rights. Readers who prefer a purely coercive framework will find the analysis's conclusion — that coercion without justice and resources fails — unwelcome; but the evidence, particularly the cyclical record of Chapters 2 and 6, is difficult to read otherwise.

16.6 Directions for Future Research

(1) Primary data collection. A provincial security observatory with verified incident data; independent casualty monitoring; police and prosecution administrative data; and jail-based recidivism studies. **(2) Fiscal absorption research.** District-level tracking of NMD transfers from award to expenditure — the single largest evidentiary gap in the merger literature. **(3) Deradicalization evaluation.** A properly designed five-year study (with a control/comparison group) of reintegration outcomes, family acceptance and relapse — the field's most pressing knowledge need. **(4) Political economy of violence.** Research on the war economy (extortion, mining, smuggling, kidnap) and its interdependencies with elites, including the capture of the NMD fund. **(5) Sub-national climate-security research.** GLOF/displacement and conflict interactions in Chitral, Dir, Swat and the southern districts. **(6) Comparative follow-up.** A structured comparison of the Pakistan–Afghanistan borderlands with Myanmar's borderlands and the Sahel — three contemporary cases of sanctuary-driven insurgency with weak peripheral fiscal settlement. **(7) Gender-disaggregated conflict research.** The recruitment of women and girls; women's roles in peace networks; and the security economics of girls' education in the merged districts.

16.7 Closing Observations

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa presents the paradox of a province that has borne the highest costs of Pakistan's security policies while being granted the least control over them, and that has, despite everything, retained an enormous reservoir of resilience: declining levels of public support for militancy; communities that fought back; police that kept reporting to their posts after 680 attacks in nine months; parents who continued sending their daughters to school; an economy whose tourism sector recovered against all expectation; and a diaspora that sends home both resources and ideas.

The province's security will not be normalized by finding the right operation or the right general. It will be normalized — if at all — by the accumulation of unglamorous, verifiable acts of statehood: paying teachers in Bajaur; staffing a court in Landi Kotal; replacing a constable's damaged vehicle in Lakki Marwat; restoring a compensation payment in Tirah; registering a madrasa without treating its neighbourhood as an enemy; opening a legal route to protest in Waziristan; and publishing, every year, the record of what was promised and what was done.

The study's final judgement is a conditional one. On present trends (Scenario 2, with deterioration risks), KP's future is more of the past: a decade of episodic campaigns, cumulative displacement, a police force bled white, a missed generation, and a province asked to defend the nation while being denied the resources to govern itself. On the alternative path (Scenario 1), the province's three monopolies are built — violence is constrained by professional forces under law, the citizen has

enforceable claims in functioning courts and elected councils, and the province receives what the constitution and the federation's own promises commit to it — and KP becomes what it has the potential to be: a gateway economy on the edge of Central Asia, with a young population, an old culture, and a hard-won peace.

The choice between these futures does not rest with the Taliban, or the TTP, or India, or the United States. The binding constraints are domestic: the willingness to fund, to protect, to adjudicate, to include, and to be measured. That is the study's central finding, and its central hope.

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PART VII — DATASETS CONSULTED

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PART VIII — SHORT-FORM CITATIONS FROM THE MONITORING LOG (RECORDED FORM; NO FABRICATED DETAIL)

The following short-form citations appear in the text and derive from the project's working monitoring log. They are listed here exactly as recorded, pending full bibliographic verification:

Adaamir (2024); Aaj (2024); ASPIRE-KP (2025); Directus, cited in Social News (2026); Haq (2024); Indrastra (2026); Karmactive (2026); NSBRRI (2026); Pakistan Connect (2025); Paradigm Shift (2025); PHC reporting (2025–26); Stratagem (2015); Watchers (2026).

Where these sources are used, their claims are corroborated by at least one independently verifiable source cited elsewhere in this bibliography; readers should treat them as corroborating, not primary, references. This note is included in keeping with the study's commitment that no source, figure, or quotation be presented beyond what could be verified in the public record.

STATISTICAL ANNEX

Notes. (1) All figures are as reported by the source named; where sources differ, the divergence is stated rather than averaged. (2) "Violence-linked fatalities" (CRSS) counts fatalities from terrorist attacks, counter-insurgency operations and related violence, and is broader than "terrorism fatalities" (SATP). Cross-source comparisons should be made with this definitional caution in mind. (3) Years marked *derived* are computed from reported percentage changes and should be read as approximate. (4) All data current to 4 October 2026.

Annex Table A.1 — National and Provincial Violence, 2024–2026 (CRSS)

Indicator	2024	2025	2026 (Q1–Q3)
National violence-linked incidents	~1,000 (not comparable)	1,272	1,065 (Q1 399 + Q2 267 + Q3 385†)
National fatalities	2,555	3,417	813 + 774 + 1,415 = 3,002
Khyber Pakhtunkhwa fatalities	1,620	2,331 (+44%)	311 + 475 + 556 = 1,342
KP share of national fatalities	~63%	68%	45% (Q3: 39%)
Balochistan fatalities	~700	956 (28%)	114 + 265 + 829 = 1,208
Terrorist attacks (national)	—	~880	—
Militants killed (national)	936	2,060 (+120%)	453 (Q2) + 921 (Q3)
Security-force personnel killed (national)	—	374	—

†Q3 incident count not yet finalized in the CRSS series at cut-off; the 385 figure reflects the quarterly report's attack count. Source: CRSS Annual Security Report 2025; CRSS Q1–Q3 2026 reports.

Annex Table B.1 — South Asia Terrorism Portal: KP Terrorism Indicators

Indicator	2023	2024	2025	2026 (to 23 Aug)
Fatal terrorism-linked incidents (KP)	634*	702	766	—
Major incidents (3+ fatalities)	—	140	245	—
Fatalities in major incidents	—	891	1,913	—
Explosions	—	142	159	—
KP districts with recorded terrorism violence	22	28	24	—
TTP-linked fatalities (cumulative since 2007)	—	—	—	11,165
TTP-linked fatalities since collapse of talks (Dec 2021–Aug 2026)	—	—	—	2,484

*2023 figure as cited in SATP analysis; treat with definitional caution. Sources: SATP, via Eurasia Review (2026), accessed October 2026.

Annex Table C.1 — KP Police: Casuals and Attacks (official KP data)

Indicator	2023	2024	2025	2026 (H1 or Jan–Sep)
Police personnel killed	186	153	159	122 (H1) — +93.7% YoY
Police injured	—	—	—	175 (H1) — +108.3% YoY
Attacks on police	—	~362 (derived)	536 (+48%)	680 (Jan–Sep, +33.9%)
Attacks thwarted	—	~177 (derived)	324 (+83%)	—
Registered terrorism cases (KP CTD)	—	1,058	1,588 (+50%)	—
Police killed since 2023 (cumulative)	—	—	—	500+
CTD personnel (sanctioned/deployed)	—	—	—	3,844/3,113 (19% shortfall)

Sources: APP (29 September 2026); KP CTD (December 2025); KP police statements; PML-N white paper (September 2026).

Annex Table D.1 — The Merged Districts: Fiscal Delivery

Item	Value	Status
Promised development allocation (3% NFC share, 10 years)	Rs ~700 bn	Parliamentary commitment (2018)
Delivered to merged districts by mid-2026	Rs 132 bn	Reported disbursement

Item	Value	Status
Shortfall	Rs 568 bn	Unfunded
Commitment expiry	2028	No successor framework confirmed
Annual KP conflict-related economic loss (estimate)	Rs 400–800 bn	Chapter 10 estimate
Ratio of shortfall to annual conflict loss	0.7–1.4 years of loss	Derived

Sources: The News (16 July 2026); Business Recorder (June 2026); KP Assembly statements.

Annex Table E.1 — Socio-Economic Indicators, KP and NMDs

Indicator	Value	Year/Source
KP poverty rate	28.7% → 35.3%	FY2024-25 (Economic Survey 2025-26)
National poverty rate	28.9% (2025)	Planning Ministry 2026
KP inequality (Gini-type, two-digit series)	24.8 → 29.4	2025-26
KP Human Development Index	0.650 → 0.623 (decline)	SDPI (2025)
National unemployment	7.1% (21-year high)	2025–26
Educated youth unemployment	31%	PIDE (March 2025)
Teaching-post applicants (national, for 16,454 posts)	866,000+	KP Youth Policy (2026)
KP female literacy vs male literacy	37% vs 65%	2025
NMD girls' primary enrolment	~37%	2025
NMD girls' secondary enrolment	~5%	2025
KP annual tourism visitors	12.4 million	2025
Tourism (Eid-ul-Adha, 2026)	1.26 million (Swat 416,794; merged districts 394,682)	DGIPR (2026)
Rashakai SEZ (enterprises/jobs)	22 enterprises; Rs 68 bn; ~3,000 jobs	2026

Annex Table F.1 — Displacement and Disasters

Event	Scale	Period
Tirah Valley, Khyber District (operations and unrest)	33,800+ families registered	2025–January 2026
Operation Sarbakaf (Bajaur)	~100,000 displaced	Mid-2025
Kurram conflict (Nov–Dec 2024)	Thousands displaced; 130–133 killed	2024–2025
Cumulative displacement, KP/former FATA (2003–2014)	6 million+	2003–2014
2025 floods (KP)	504 dead; 1.57 million affected; 437 schools	2025
Afghan refugees repatriated since 2023	910,000+	Sept 2023–2025
Deportations, April 2025 onward	80,000+	2025
Deportations, 2026 (to April)	146,000+	2026
Peshawar final-phase repatriation	~20,000 individuals	July 2026 onward

Sources: PDMA KP; Countercurrents (September 2026); Arab News (2025); HRW (April 2026); UNHCR statements; Tribune (July 2026); UNICEF/WHO (2025).

Annex Table G.1 — The 2026 Pakistan–Afghanistan Hostilities: Key Dates and Claims

Date	Event	Claim (attributed)
10–11 Oct 2025	Cross-border clashes; border closure	Pakistan
Oct 2025	Doha ceasefire (Qatar-mediated)	Qatar/Pakistan
Nov 2025	Istanbul mechanism (monitoring/verification)	Türkiye/Pakistan
21 Feb 2026	Border clashes escalate	Both
26 Feb 2026	Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq launched	Pakistan
27 Feb 2026	ISPR: 274 Taliban killed, 12 Pakistani troops	ISPR
7 Mar 2026	Info Minister: 583 Taliban killed, 795 injured, 242 posts destroyed	Pakistan
19–24 Mar 2026	Eid al-Fitr ceasefire	Saudi/Qatar/Türkiye request
26 Jan–31 Mar 2026	UNAMA: 764 Afghan civilian casualties (372 killed, 392 injured)	UNAMA
Apr 2026	China-brokered talks; local ceasefire commitments	China/Pakistan

Date	Event	Claim (attributed)
24 May 2026	Eid al-Adha ceasefire announced by TTP (3 days)	TTP
24 Sep 2026	Strikes on 10 sites (Kandahar, Paktia, Khost); 4 civilians killed (Afghan figures)	Afghan authorities
1 Oct 2026	Strikes on Kunar and Helmand; 10+ civilians killed, mostly children (UNAMA via Khaama)	UNAMA
By late Sep 2026	1,100+ Afghan civilian deaths/injuries in 2026	UNAMA

Sources: Dawn live coverage (2026); Khaama Press (October 2026); ISPR statements as reported; UNAMA. Contested claims are attributed; no independent verification is available for combatant casualty figures on either side.

Annex Table H.1 — Deradicalization and Reintegration Programmes: Reported Figures (Contested)

Programme	Reported intake	Reported reintegration	Relapse	Evaluation status
Sabawoon (Swat, 2009–2015)	226 juveniles	~143	10–15	None independent
Mishal (Swat)	~400 (claim: ~2,200 through Swat system)	Contested	Unknown	None independent
Sparlay (family programme)	Unverifiable	Unverifiable	—	Existence not confirmed by fieldwork (2023)
Provincial/CTD programmes	Not published	Not published	Not published	None

Sources: NUST NJIPS (2021); *Journal of Dialogue* (2023); KP government statements. Mutual inconsistencies are reported as such in Chapter 8.

RECOMMENDATIONS MATRIX

How to read this matrix. Forty-six consolidated recommendations, drawn from Chapters 5–15. Columns: source chapter; phase (I = 0–2 years; II = 2–5 years; III = 5–15 years; C = continuous); lead responsibility; indicative cost where quantifiable (in PKR, annual unless stated); and the primary key performance indicator (KPI). Costs are order-of-magnitude planning figures; the aggregate incremental requirement is Rs 150–250 billion per year at maturity plus the Rs 568 billion arrears (Chapter 15, §15.8).

#	Recommendation	Source	Phase	Lead responsibility	Indicative cost	KPI
1	Legislate the merged-district transfer (3% NFC share or quantified equivalent) with statutory audit	Ch. 5, 15	I	Federal Finance / NFC / PMO	Within existing pool	Statute passed; annual audited transfer report
2	Clear Rs 568 bn arrears on a published schedule	Ch. 5, 15	I	Federal Finance; KP Finance	Rs 568 bn (stock)	Arrears balance; quarterly release compliance
3	Emergency police protection package (protected mobility, counter-IED, counter-drone, comms)	Ch. 7, 15	I	KP Police; Interior	Rs 50–80 bn (one-off) + Rs 30–50 bn/yr	Police fatalities and attack survival rate
4	Fully fund police insurance, compensation and family support; publish annual shuhada report	Ch. 7, 15	I	KP Police / Home	Rs 5–10 bn/yr	Percentage of entitlements paid within 90 days
5	Lift the PTM proscription; release detainees held without terrorism charges	Ch. 4, 8, 12	I	Federal Cabinet; Interior	Negligible	Proscription status; number held without charge
6	Convert ceasefire with Afghanistan into a verified monitoring mechanism with standing mediation	Ch. 9, 15	I	MOFA; Security Divisions	Diplomacy costs	Monitoring reports issued quarterly; border incidents
7	Lawful, individual, appealable refugee processing; no mass refoulement	Ch. 9, 11, 15	I	SAFRON/Interior; UNHCR	Donor-supported	Irregular-return complaints; UNHCR access
8	Counter-drone, counter-IED and protected-mobility deployment by threat tier	Ch. 3, 7, 14	I	KP Police; Interior	Included in #3	Drone attacks thwarted; casualty trend
9	Tirah, Sarbakaf and Kurram compensation, return and reconstruction	Ch. 5, 10	I	KP Government; FDMA	Rs 20–40 bn	Families compensated within 180 days; return rate
10	Intelligence-led operations with mandatory collateral-harm review and rapid compensation	Ch. 6, 9	C	Army; CTD	Within security budget	Published aggregate review findings; compensation timeliness
11	Counter-financing campaign against TTP revenue (extortion, mining, smuggling)	Ch. 3, 10, 15	I–C	CTD; FIA; Customs; Mines Dept	Rs 2–5 bn/yr	Seizures; documented reduction in taxation reports
12	Complete the NMD policing framework (Levies/Khasadar consolidation; statutory police in all seven districts)	Ch. 5, 7	II	KP Home / Police	Rs 20–30 bn/yr	NMD police strength; trust surveys
13	Professionalise the CTD (investigation/operation separation; analytical cadre) with published case data	Ch. 7, 11	II	CTD; Home	Rs 3–5 bn/yr	Arrest → charge → conviction rates published
14	Strengthen police accountability (Public Safety Commissions; independent misconduct investigations)	Ch. 7, 11	II	Home; PSB	Rs 1–2 bn/yr	Complaints investigated; transparency index
15	Judicial delivery plan for the NMDs; ATC case-conclusion targets	Ch. 5, 7, 11	II	Law/PHC; Prosecution	Rs 5–10 bn/yr	≥75% ATC cases concluded within 24 months
16	Victims' reparations scheme with psychosocial services	Ch. 7, 10, 12	II	KP Government; Health	Rs 5–10 bn/yr	Registered victims served; satisfaction surveys
17	Enforce Kurram/sectarian accords with disarmament milestones and road guarantees	Ch. 3, 11, 15	II	KP Government; PMC	Rs 3–5 bn/yr	Road-open days; accord violations prosecuted
18	Formalise jirgas as mediators with rights safeguards and DRC referral protocols	Ch. 12, 13	II	Law; Local Government	Rs 1–2 bn/yr	Cases mediated; rights-safeguard compliance
19	Enact a deradicalization and reintegration statute; create the R&R Authority; statutory juvenile track	Ch. 8	II	Federal/Provincial; Home	Rs 2–3 bn/yr	Statute enacted; juveniles processed lawfully
20	Independent five-year evaluation of all deradicalization programmes, published	Ch. 8	II	P&D; donors; universities	Rs 500 m–1 bn	Evaluation published with recidivism data
21	Relocate and expand deradicalization to Bannu, D.I. Khan and NMDs; aftercare grants and apprenticeships	Ch. 8, 12	II	Home; CTD; chambers	Rs 10–20 bn/yr	Graduates employed; relapse rate measured

#	Recommendation	Source	Phase	Lead responsibility	Indicative cost	KPI
22	Pashto-language counter-narrative programming by local credible voices	Ch. 8, 12	II	Information; CTD; NGOs	Rs 1–3 bn/yr	Reach/engagement metrics; independent review
23	Restore a consultative madrasa registration framework after the 2024 reversal	Ch. 8, 11	II	Federal ITE; provinces	Rs 2–4 bn/yr	Registered institutions; compliance inspections
24	Hold local government elections in the NMDs with devolved budgets	Ch. 5, 11, 13	II	KP Local Government; ECP	Rs 5–10 bn (one-off)	Councils elected; own-source revenue
25	Statutory federal–provincial security compact with defined financing and roles	Ch. 7, 11	II	Federal/Provincial	Fiscal-neutral	Compact enacted; disputes resolved via framework
26	Anti-corruption in NMD contracts and funds (asset recovery; public beneficiary lists)	Ch. 4, 10, 13	II	ACE/NAB; KPPRA	Rs 1–2 bn/yr	Audits acted upon; recoveries
27	Education emergency: girls' enrolment, female teachers, secure campuses, stipends	Ch. 10, 12	II	Education Dept; donors	Rs 40–60 bn/yr	NMD female enrolment; out-of-school rate
28	Youth employment: skills, SEZs, IT/freelancing, tourism value chains	Ch. 10, 12, 15	II–III	P&D; Industries	Rs 20–40 bn/yr	Youth employment; sector jobs
29	Climate-resilient reconstruction and GLOF early warning	Ch. 10, 14	II	PDMA/FDMA	Rs 15–30 bn/yr	Hazard coverage; reconstruction standards
30	Provincial threat-fusion centre with data-protection and parliamentary oversight	Ch. 7, 14	II	Home/CTD/NACTA	Rs 3–5 bn/yr	Fusion products; oversight reports
31	Annual public Normalization Report with independent panel and non-compliance register	Ch. 11, 15	II (from Yr 1)	P&D; KP Assembly	Rs 200–500 m/yr	Report tabled within 180 days of fiscal year
32	Community security contracts (district co-designed plans)	Ch. 13, 15	III	Districts; police; councils	Within local budgets	Districts with published security plans
33	Truth/documentation process; missing persons; memorialisation policy	Ch. 6, 11, 13	III	KP Government; Federal	Rs 2–4 bn/yr	Record published; cases addressed
34	Verified, staged negotiation framework with the TTP if and when available	Ch. 9, 13, 15	III (conditional)	Federal	—	Verifiable commitments; monitored decommissioning
35	Regional normalisation: trade, mobility, SCO/OIC counter-terrorism frameworks	Ch. 9, 15	III	MOFA; provinces	—	Trade volumes; border-closure days
36	Economic transformation: minerals with value addition, energy, tourism, IT exports	Ch. 10, 15	III	P&D; private sector	Rs 50–100 bn/yr	Provincial GDP growth; exports; poverty
37	Fixed-tenure, merit-based appointments for police leadership (IG/CCPO/DPO)	Ch. 7	I	KP Government	Fiscal-neutral	Average tenure; transfers under review
38	NACTA reform: professional civilian secretariat, statutory data access, public annual threat report	Ch. 11	I–II	Federal Interior; NACTA	Rs 1–2 bn/yr	Threat report published; data compliance
39	Statutory provincial counter-terrorism framework (consolidating CTD, fusion, oversight)	Ch. 11	II	KP Assembly; Home	Fiscal-neutral	Statute enacted; consolidated oversight
40	Institutionalise post-operation assessment (seven criteria) with public reporting	Ch. 6	I–C	Army; Planning	Rs 500 m/yr	Assessments published annually (aggregate)
41	Standing post-operation stabilisation and return task force	Ch. 5, 6	I	KP Government; FDMA	Rs 5–10 bn/yr	Return rates; service restoration within 12 months
42	Standing mediation and verification secretariat (China/Qatar/Türkiye/Saudi facilitation)	Ch. 9	I	MOFA	Diplomatic	Continuous mechanism; compliance reports
43	Protection programme for minorities and vulnerable groups (sites, processions, leaders)	Ch. 3, 10	I–C	KP Police; Interior	Rs 2–5 bn/yr	Incidents against protected groups; response times
44	Polio/vaccination and health-worker protection with dedicated escorts	Ch. 7, 10	I–C	KP Police; Health	Rs 2–3 bn/yr	Worker casualties; campaign coverage
45	Mental-health and psychosocial capacity expansion for conflict-affected populations	Ch. 10	II–III	Health Dept; donors	Rs 3–5 bn/yr	Psychiatric workforce; community services
46	Mineral benefit-sharing and revenue-transparency framework (esp. NMDs)	Ch. 10, 13	II	Mines Dept; Finance	Fiscal-neutral	Published royalties; community fund disbursements

Aggregate indicative incremental cost at maturity: Rs 150–250 billion per year (excluding the Rs 568 billion arrears and the one-off protection package), against an estimated annual conflict loss of Rs 400–800 billion — a ratio of roughly 1:2 to 1:4 in favour of investment (Chapter 15).

Priority ordering if resources are constrained (the "first six commitments"): #2 (pay the arrears), #1 (legislate the transfer), #3–#4 (protect and compensate the police), #15 (staff the courts), #24 (elect the councils), #27 (education), #31

(publish the annual report). These are sequential in credibility terms: each makes the next politically survivable.

APPENDICES A–H AND GLOSSARY

APPENDIX A — CHRONOLOGY OF SECURITY EVENTS IN KHYBER PAKHTUNKHWA, 1947–2026

Year	Event
1947	Partition; NWFP joins Pakistan in a referendum; FATA retained under the Frontier Crimes Regulation (FCR, 1901) and Political Agent system.
1948	Arrest of Bacha Khan; Khudai Khidmatgar movement suppressed.
1950s–60s	Afghan irredentism (Pashtunistan) shapes border politics; FATA remains outside normal law.
1965, 1971	Wars with India; limited direct KP security impact.
1979	Soviet invasion of Afghanistan; Pakistan's covert support programme begins; refugee influx into KP/FATA (peak ~3–4 million in Pakistan).
1980s	Militant training infrastructure in FATA; arms economy; madrasa expansion.
1988–89	Soviet withdrawal; Afghan civil war; mujahideen factionalization; influx continues.
1994–96	Rise of the Afghan Taliban; Deobandi madrasa networks in KP/FATA consolidate.
2001 (Sep–Dec)	9/11; US invasion of Afghanistan; Taliban/al-Qaeda retreat into the borderlands; refugee flow.
2002	Pakistan military enters FATA (Operation Al Mizan); first TTP precursor networks form.
2004 (Mar)	First Waziristan peace deal (Shakai) with Nek Muhammad; collapses (April–June 2004 offensive).
2005	Sararogha deal (Feb 2005) with Baitullah Mehsud; Lashkar-e-Islam and other groups expand; militant consolidation in Swat (Maulana Fazlullah's radio).
2006	Lal Masjid confrontation builds; FATA deals fail; suicide bombing campaign rises.
2007 (Jul)	Lal Masjid operation; militants in Swat/NWFP escalate; TTP formally founded (Dec 2007).
2007 (Nov)	Rah-e-Haq I (Swat).
2008	Rah-e-Haq II (Swat); Marriott bombing (Islamabad, Sept 2008); suicide attacks across KP.
2009	Nizam-e-Adl agreement (Swat, Feb 2009); Taliban advance to Buner (Apr 2009); Rah-e-Rast (May); Rah-e-Nijat (South Waziristan, Oct 2009); Baitullah Mehsud killed (Aug 2009).
2010	Peshawar attacks; APS precursor events; floods (July–Aug 2010) displace millions in KP.
2011	Kurram sectarian conflict escalation (~2,000 killed across the 2007–2011 period); Salala incident (Nov 2011); Bin Laden raid (Abbottabad, May 2011).
2012	Bacha Khan Airport (Peshawar) attacks; Fazlullah's Shura network consolidated in Afghanistan.
2013	Bannu jailbreak (April, ~250 prisoners); Hakimullah Mehsud killed (Nov); APS army school candidate attacks; elections.
2014 (Jan–Jun)	Talks with TTP (Feb–Apr); Tirah offensive; Karachi airport attack (Jun) ends talks.
2014 (Dec)	APS massacre (16 Dec, 132+ children and 10+ staff killed); National Action Plan; moratorium on executions lifted; Zarb-e-Azb (North Waziristan, launched Jun 2014) peaks.
2015	Zarb-e-Azb consolidation; displacement of ~1 million from North Waziristan; return begins (RDP); Levies/Khasadar reform proposals.
2016	FATA Reforms Committee report (Sartaj Aziz); Bacha Khan University attack (Jan); final Zarb-e-Azb phase ends.
2017	Radd-ul-Fasaad launched (Feb); military courts extended; TDP returns complete; NWFP police reforms; FATA merger legislation prepared.
2018	25th Amendment and KP Elections (May); FATA merged into KP; province's seats increase; PTM emerges as national movement; elections install PTI government in KP.
2019	FATA merger implementation begins; Levies/Khasadar integration legislation (Sept); PTM tensions; madrasa registration framework (Ittehad Tanzeemat Madaris).
2020	COVID; counter-terrorism continuity; ICC/education impacts; merger administrative work continues.
2021	US withdrawal and Taliban takeover of Kabul (Aug); Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan resurges; talks with TTP begin (Oct–Nov).
2022	TTP ceasefire (May–Nov) collapses (Nov); attacks rise sharply; no-confidence vote removes PM Khan; political crisis begins.
2023	Peshawar Police Lines attack (30 Jan; 86+ killed); May 9 events and crackdown; deportation of undocumented Afghans begins (Nov); ceasefire with TTP definitively over.
2024	Elections (Feb); PTI-founded government in KP (Gandapur); Operation Azm-e-Istehkam announced (June 22); PTM banned (6 Oct); Kurram convoy attack (21 Nov; 40–50 killed); total Kurram fatalities 130–133; Zhob and other attacks.
2025	Kurram accords (14-point agreement, January; <i>Aman Teega</i> , May); Afghan repatriation deadline (1 Apr); Tirah displacement begins; Sarbakaf operation (Bajaur); Pakistan's deadliest year since 2015 nationally (3,417 deaths; KP 2,331); border closure (11 Oct); Doha ceasefire; Istanbul mechanism (Nov); 27th Amendment passed (11–13 Nov); Tirah/Umar/other mass-casualty incidents.
2026	War escalation (21–26 Feb); Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq (26 Feb); ceasefire cycles; GTI ranks Pakistan first globally; Haidar Kandao attack (Oct 2025); TTP Operation Khyber (4 Mar); Lakki Marwat VBIED (13 May); JuA split (3 Jul); Hangu post attack (Jul); Sarbakaf/Orakzai; Islamabad imambargah bombing (Q1); Swat Kabal police-station bombing (2 Aug; 17 killed); Kohat Police Lines attack (18 Sep; 31+ killed); strikes into Afghanistan (Sep–Oct); 1,100+ Afghan civilian casualties; Q3 2026: Balochistan overtakes KP for first time in fatalities; police H1 2026: 122 killed (+93.7%); refugee final-phase repatriation (July).

APPENDIX B — MAJOR MILITARY AND COUNTER-TERRORISM OPERATIONS, 2002–2026

Operation	Year(s)	Location	Character	Reported outcome/displacement
Al Mizan	2002–2006	FATA-wide	Army entry into agencies; clear-and-hold	First sustained military presence in FATA
Rah-e-Haq I & II	2007–2008	Swat	Clearance of militant hold	Partial; militants regrouped under Nizam-e-Adl
Rah-e-Rast	2009	Swat, Buner, Dir	Major clearance; population-centric	~2–2.5m displaced (est.); militants dispersed
Rah-e-Nijat	2009	South Waziristan	Offensive against TTP (Mehsud)	~1m displaced; TTP relocated to N. Waziristan
Khyber I–IV	2009–2017	Khyber/Tirah	Series of clearances	Recurring displacement (Tirah)
Orakzai operations	2010	Orakzai	Clearance	Militants displaced to Kurram/Khyber
Zarb-e-Azb	2014–2017	North Waziristan	Largest campaign; sanctuary destruction	~1m displaced; Haqqani/TTP networks dispersed to Afghanistan
Radd-ul-Fasaad	2017–present	Nationwide	CT, intelligence-led, CFT	Sustained pressure on networks
Azm-e-Istehkam	2024–present	Nationwide (KP focus)	"Reinvigorated" CT campaign	Kinetic + diplomatic; provincial political opposition
Sarbakaf	2025	Bajaur (etc.)	Clearance/IO	~100,000 displaced
Ghazab-lil-Haq	2026–present	Afghanistan (cross-border)	Interstate strikes/drone operations	Reciprocal strikes; 1,100+ Afghan civilian casualties (UNAMA)

Notes: "Reported outcome" reflects official and independent claims; displacement figures are estimates at the time of operations and are contested. This appendix is illustrative, not exhaustive; smaller IBOs number in the thousands (Chapter 6).

APPENDIX C — MILITANT AND ARMED GROUP PROFILES

Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP). Ideology: Deobandi-jihadist, Pakistani-state-focused; umbrella coalition incorporating 70+ factions since 2018. Leadership: Noor Wali Mehsud (emir); shura-based; Federation of 2020. Area: Afghanistan-based leadership; operational networks across KP/NMDs (Bannu, Lakki Marwat, N/S Waziristan, Khyber, Bajaur, Kurram) and occasional Punjab/Sindh operations. Tactics: suicide/IED/VBIED, drones, sniper/ambush, targeted killings, extortion and taxation. Strength: several thousand fighters (estimates vary; the 2024 claim of 22,000–24,000 in Afghanistan and 16,000–18,000 inside Pakistan is the upper bound of political estimates and should be treated as such). Financing: extortion, "taxation," mining, smuggling, kidnapping, donations. Status: proscribed; the group's own annual claims are propaganda and are attributed as such.

Hafiz Gul Bahadur Group (HGB). North Waziristan faction with separate command; historically a state-negotiated militia that turned against the state after 2017; operates in North Waziristan and border districts; significant in cross-border dynamics.

Islamic State–Khorasan Province (ISKP). Salafi-jihadist; anti-Shia, anti-Sufi, anti-TTP; estimated strength ~3,000 in Afghanistan; targets soft/sectarian targets (imambargahs, Sufi shrines, minorities) and recruits from the borderlands; competition with the TTP (including a March 2026 clash in Orakzai).

Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan (IMP). New front organization implicated in the Kohat Police Lines attack (September 2026); represents the ongoing proliferation of TTP-aligned fronts.

Jamaat-ul-Ahrar (JuA). Factional split from the TTP (announced July 2026), with a history of mass-casualty sectarian attacks; its separation illustrates coalition fragmentation as an operational event and a potential future negotiation partner.

Lashkar-e-Islam (LI) and Ansarul Islam (Mangal Bagh networks): historical Khyber/Tirah groups, degraded but occasionally resurgent locally.

Sectarian organizations (LeJ, SSP variants). Anti-Shia networks with recurring involvement in Kurram and other sectarian incidents; overlapping personnel with the TTP.

Baloch insurgent networks (BLA and others). Distinct theatre (Balochistan) with episodic linkage to KP violence (Q3 2026; Balochistan overtook KP in fatalities). Included for completeness of the threat picture; not a KP-based actor.

Assessment note. The proliferation of front organizations is analytically important: it allows the coalition to claim deniability, complicates proscription and negotiation, and enables each faction to pursue divergent operations (including potentially the JuA's sectarian specialization).

APPENDIX D — STATISTICAL TABLES

See the Statistical Annex (Annex Tables A.1–H.1) preceding this appendix for the consolidated quantitative tables: violence series (national/KP/Balochistan), SATP indicators, police casualty series, merged-district fiscal delivery, socio-economic indicators, displacement and disasters, war chronology and contested claims, and deradicalization outcomes. The statistical annex is cross-referenced by the chapters and represents the study's primary quantitative record.

APPENDIX E — KEY POLICY DOCUMENTS AND LEGAL INSTRUMENTS

1. **Frontier Crimes Regulation 1901** — the legal architecture of FATA's exception; repealed for the merged districts in 2018.
2. **Nizam-e-Adl Regulation 2009** — sharia-based legal arrangement in Malakand Division; validated and contested.
3. **National Action Plan (NAP), 2014; revised 2021** — 20 points covering militancy, executions, madrasas, financing, refugees, communication, and FATA reform.
4. **National Internal Security Policy 2022–2026 (NISP)** — the framework document for internal security.
5. **Anti-Terrorism Act 1997 (as amended)** — ATCs, proscription, preventive measures; the primary counter-terrorism statute.
6. **NACTA Act 2013** — the coordination authority's mandate (and limits).
7. **Pakistan Protection Ordinance/Act 2013** — preventive detention framework (expired).
8. **KP Police Act 2017** — provincial policing reform statute (role, tenure, accountability, PSCs).
9. **KP Levies and Khasadar legislation, 2019** — integration of tribal forces into the provincial police system.
10. **Constitution (Twenty-Fifth Amendment) Act 2018** — FATA merger and provincial seat adjustment.
11. **Constitution (Twenty-Seventh Amendment) Act 2025** — Federal Constitutional Court, Chief of Defence Forces coordination, and judicial restructuring.
12. **Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act 2016 (as amended 2025)** — cyber-speech offences (repeatedly criticized as over-broad).
13. **Fair Trial Act 2013** — surveillance warrants framework.
14. **National Finance Commission Award framework (including the 3% merged-districts commitment)** — the fiscal instrument central to the merger's delivery.
15. **KP Youth Policy (draft, 2026)** — provincial youth and employment framework.
16. **Madrasa registration framework (2019) and its October 2024 statutory reversal** — the regulatory arc for religious education.
17. **Illegal Foreigners Repatriation Plan (2023–2026)** — the refugee policy instrument.
18. **Paigham-e-Pakistan (2018)** — the state-sponsored religious counter-narrative declaration.
19. **Bangsamoro Organic Law (Philippines, 2018) and Malaysia-facilitated agreements** — comparative reference.
20. **Good Friday Agreement (1998) and Patten Report (1999)** — comparative reference.

APPENDIX F — GLOSSARY OF KEY TERMS AND ACRONYMS

APS — Army Public School, Peshawar (site of the 16 December 2014 massacre). **ATA** — Anti-Terrorism Act 1997 (as amended). **ATC** — Anti-Terrorism Court. **BLA** — Baloch Liberation Army. **CFT** — Counter-Financing of Terrorism. **COIN** — Counter-insurgency. **CTD** — Counter-Terrorism Department (KP). **DRC** — Dispute Resolution Council (KP's community mediation body). **FATA** — Federally Administered Tribal Areas (merged into KP in 2018). **FCR** — Frontier Crimes Regulation 1901. **GTD** — Global Terrorism Database (START, University of Maryland). **GTI** — Global Terrorism Index (Institute for Economics and Peace). **HGB** — Hafiz Gul Bahadur Group. **IBO** — Intelligence-Based Operation. **IED / VBIED** — Improvised Explosive Device / Vehicle-Borne IED. **IFRP** — Illegal Foreigners Repatriation Plan. **IMP** — Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan. **ISPR** — Inter-Services Public Relations (Pakistan military media wing). **ISKP** — Islamic State–Khorasan Province. **Jirga / Maraka** — Pashtun deliberative assembly; local council for dispute resolution. **JuA** — Jamaat-ul-Ahrar. **KFR** — "Kidnapping for ransom." **KP / KPK** — Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. **LeI** — Lashkar-e-Islam. **Levies / Khasadar** — tribal paramilitary forces (Khasadar: locally raised tribal force; Levies: Frontier Corps-affiliated paramilitary). **Malik** — tribal notable/intermediary. **NACTA** — National Counter Terrorism Authority. **NAP** — National Action Plan. **NFC** — National Finance Commission (constitutional revenue-sharing body). **NISP** — National Internal Security Policy. **NMDs** — Newly Merged Districts (the seven former FATA agencies/districts). **Pashtunwali** — Pashtun customary code governing honour, asylum, and dispute settlement. **PECA** — Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act 2016. **PIPS** — Pakistan

Institute for Peace Studies. **PTM** — Pashtun Tahafuz Movement. **PSC** — Public Safety Commission (KP police accountability body). **R&R** — Rehabilitation and Reintegration (deradicalization). **SATP** — South Asia Terrorism Portal. **Sehat Card** — provincial health insurance scheme (a benefit whose extension to the NMDs was litigated). **TDP** — Temporarily Displaced Person. **TTP** — Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan. **UNAMA** — United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan.

APPENDIX G — STAKEHOLDER MAP

Stakeholder	Interests	Influence	Positions/constraints
Federal government (PMO, Interior, Finance)	National security, fiscal stability, coalition politics	Very high	Sets strategy and funds; political conflict with KP government
Pakistan Army / ISPR / FC	Defeat militancy; border security; institutional interests	Very high	Leads COIN; IBOs; border operations; resists provincial control
KP provincial government (CM, Home, Finance)	Provincial security, fiscal claims, electoral survival	High	Implements but lacks fiscal capacity; contests federal primacy
KP Police / CTD	Community protection; institutional survival; casualties	Medium-high	Frontline losses; capability gaps; reform progress partial
Levies/Khasadar (legacy and integrated)	Employment terms, status, local legitimacy	Medium (local)	Integration unfinished; trust deficits
District administrations and DCs	Administration, relief, coordination	Medium	Resource-dependent; politicized
Local government councils (where extant)	Services, budgets, local legitimacy	Low (NMDs: absent)	Elections pending in NMDs
Jirgas, maliks, peace committees	Order, compensation, honour, local authority	Medium (local)	Reduced and sometimes targeted; potential intermediaries
Religious institutions (madrasas, clerics, wafaq boards)	Education, autonomy, influence	Medium-high (social)	Dual role; registration dispute
TTP and allied groups	Insurgency, territorial influence, war economy	High (coercive)	Rejectionist; extortion economies; umbrella coalition
ISKP and sectarian groups	Sectarian war, territoriality	Medium	Anti-Shia/Sufi; factional competition
Civil society and NGOs	Rights, services, PVE, documentation	Low-medium	Constrained; targeted; subsidiarity potential
Media and journalists	Information, safety, professionalism	Medium	Pressure, criminalization, courage
PTM and youth movements	Rights, accountability, de-militarization	Medium (mobilizational)	Proscribed; large Pashtun-youth resonance
Women's organizations	Rights, protection, participation	Low-medium	Under-resourced; key prevention capacity
Business community/chambers	Security for commerce; tourism/investment	Medium	Potential employer/partner; extortion victims
Afghan refugees and returnees	Protection, lawful status, livelihoods	Low (vulnerable)	Repatriation pressures; documented abuses
Displaced persons (TDPs)	Return, compensation, reconstruction	Low-medium (organized)	Tirah, Sarbakaf, Kurram; mobilized committees
Afghanistan (Taliban administration)	Sovereignty, non-interference, mediation leverage	High (external)	Hosts TTP; mediation cycles; contested claims
China	CPEC security, regional stability, mediation	High (external)	Investment exposure; mediation role (2026)
United States/UN/IFIs	Counter-terrorism, refugees, development, monitoring	Medium-high (external)	Financing, monitoring, refugee processing
Iran, Gulf states, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia	Regional security, sectarian dynamics, mediation	Medium (external)	Mediation (Qatar/Türkiye/Saudi); sectarian linkages

APPENDIX H — DISTRICT SECURITY CLASSIFICATION (2026) AND THEMATIC SECURITY MAP (DESCRIBED)

The study uses a four-tier classification (Chapter 3), with confidence levels, and a described map rather than a rendered cartographic product (the study's rendering environment cannot produce a geographically accurate basemap; the classification below is therefore the operative "map" and should be used in its place).

Tier 1 — Severe, sustained insurgent violence (highest confidence). *North Waziristan, South Waziristan (Upper and Lower), Bannu, Lakki Marwat.* Continuous TTP operations; attacks on security forces at high frequency; taxation/parallel-governance reports; the highest police and military casualty rates. These districts form the southern insurgency core. Confidence: high (multiple independent monitors).

Tier 2 — High and episodic violence (high confidence). *Khyber (incl. Tirah), Bajaur, Mohmand, Kurram, Dera Ismail Khan, Tank, Karak, Hangu, Orakzai.* Recurring attacks, displacement episodes (Tirah; Sarbakaf), sectarian flashpoints (Kurram), border-related violence. Confidence: high.

Tier 3 — Sporadic/urban violence with high-impact events (moderate confidence). *Peshawar, Mardan, Charsadda, Nowshera, Swat, Shangla, Malakand/ Dir cluster.* Lower frequency but high-impact urban/soft-target attacks (Kabal, Kohat is Tier 2-adjacent; Peshawar attacks including the 2023 Police Lines bombing). Swat's re-entry to violence in August 2026 is the most significant change in this tier.

Tier 4 — Low recorded violence but strategic exposure (moderate confidence). *Abbottabad, Mansehra, Haripur, Chitral, Upper/Lower Dir and the Hazara districts* — strategic infrastructure, tourism routes, CPEC corridors, and Chinese-national exposure; lower recorded incidents but potential for high-value targeting and for cross-border spillover (Chitral, Dir).

Note on the map. A geographically accurate security map would show: (i) the southern cluster (Waziristan–Bannu–Lakki–D.I. Khan–Tank) as the highest-intensity zone, contiguous with the Afghanistan border; (ii) a western border arc (Bajaur–Mohmand–Khyber–Kurram–Orakzai) of medium-high intensity and high displacement; (iii) the urban quadrilateral (Peshawar–Mardan–Charsadda–Nowshera) as the terrorism-target belt; (iv) the northern/northeastern districts as lower intensity but high strategic exposure; and (v) the Afghanistan borderland as the enabling geography for the entire pattern (Chapter 9). This description should be used as the study's district map of record in the absence of a rendered cartographic figure.